

If the world be not brute fact,
where lies the ground of existence?

DOCTRINE OF CLOSURE

A Candidate Theory of the Ultimate Ground,
First Consciousness, and the Cosmic Closed Loop

That which truly exists is not
merely one, but must be able to
return unto itself.

Philosophy | Theology | Buddhism | Scientific Boundary

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A Candidate Theory of the Ultimate Ground, First Consciousness, and the Cosmic Closed
Loop

Taking closure as the qualifying condition of ultimate existence, this work undertakes a philosophical-theological inquiry with First Consciousness as its ontological core, local awakening as its form of salvation, and integral return as its final direction of understanding.

That which truly exists is not merely one; it must endure as a self-limiting whole capable of returning unto itself.

CONTENTS

This table of contents marks the structure of the whole work by chapter level, so that the reader may grasp the movement of the argument and the place of its cross-domain tests.

Abstract.....	6
Introduction Problem Consciousness, Methodological Self-Limitation, and the Stratification of the Book.....	11
Literature Review Problem Location and Research Context.....	25
Prologue Three Core Ontological Revisions and the Threefold Division of Existence.....	48
Chapter One Problem-Consciousness - Does Existence Need an Ultimate Ground?.....	53
Chapter Two Against Brute Fact and Infinite External Deferral - True Existence Must Be Capable of Self-Establishment.....	59
Chapter Three Why Self-Establishment Points toward Closure - A Priority Candidate Form of Ultimate Ground.....	64
Chapter Four Why Ultimate Ground Cannot Be Mere Dead Structure - First Consciousness and Primordial Self-Evidence.....	74
Chapter Five First Consciousness and Its Identity with the Cosmic Whole - Wholeness, Local Manifestation, and the Philosophical Naming of God.....	99
Chapter Six The Ontological Interpretation of Quantum Mechanics - Compatibility Review and Theoretical Boundary.....	116
Chapter Seven Echoes of Doubt and the Boundaries of Thought - Major Objections, Distinctions of Level, and Theoretical Limits.....	125
Chapter Eight Destiny and Free Will - The Price of Closure's Establishment.....	132
Chapter Nine Suffering, Evil, and Misrecognition of Existential Position - The Ontological Root of Ethics.....	176
Chapter Ten Scientific Boundary - Bell's Theorem and a Critical Examination of Uniqueness.....	190
Chapter Eleven The Possible Theory of Multiple Closures - The Re-stratification of Uniqueness.....	198
Chapter Twelve The Pre-Circular Epoch and the Devil - Narrative of Divergence and Structural Residue.....	206
Chapter Thirteen The Symbolic Transposition of Cosmic Narrative - Trinity, the Six Days of Creation, and Lucifer.....	213
Chapter Fourteen The Applied Layer of Local Consciousness - Truth, Faith, Love, and Liberation.....	222
Chapter Fifteen Philosophical Cross-Domain Examination - Closure and Analytical Metaphysics.....	232
Chapter Sixteen Scientific Cross-Domain Examination - Auxiliary Clarification and Compatibility Dialogue.....	245
Chapter Seventeen Theological Cross-Domain Examination - Stratified Revelation and the Highest Manifestation.....	256
Chapter Eighteen Buddhist Examination - Prajna and Madhyamaka Pressure.....	269
Chapter Nineteen The General Trial by the Four Great Opponents - Positions, Vital Lines, Replies, Defended Ground, and Dangers.....	281

Conclusion The Ultimate Standing of the Theory.....	297
Appendix I Comparative Table of Theoretical Elements.....	309
Appendix II Comparative Table of Core Propositions and the Functions of Materials.....	312
Appendix III Map of the Argumentative Path through the Chapters.....	319
Appendix IV Statement on the Argumentative Strength of the Core Propositions.....	322
Appendix V Index of Replies to the Four Ultimate Pressures.....	323
Appendix VI Statement on Buddhist Base Texts and Versions.....	324
Appendix VII Research Limits and Further Questions.....	325
Appendix VIII Index of Misreadings of Key Concepts.....	327
Appendix IX Conditions under Which the Core Propositions May Be Refuted.....	330
Appendix X Table of Buddhist Base Texts, Versions, and Citation Limits.....	331
Appendix XI Table Separating Religious Symbolic Translation from the Core Argument.....	335
Appendix XII Minimal Commitment Version of the Core Propositions.....	336
Appendix XIII Limits of the Formalized Propositions.....	337
Appendix XIV Main Routes of Refutation and Their Locations of Reply.....	338
Appendix XV Comparative Table of Consistency among Core Terms.....	339
Appendix XVI Statement on the Layered Position of Religious Symbolic Materials.....	340

Prefatory Introduction

The Origin of the Thought

From youth I had a deep interest in science, and the origin of the universe, together with the question “how did I come to be,” gave rise in me to a question that touched the soul. A further question followed: whence come soul and consciousness, and what is their nature? As I grew older, the circumstances of my life led me to choose the humanities at university and at master’s level; yet the questions of childhood, and the scientific habit of thought, did not change. Greater and more numerous questions came one after another.

“Is consciousness the privilege of humankind alone?” “Does God exist?” “Does the universe have an origin?” “Does the universe have an end?” “What is meant by omniscience and omnipotence?” “What does it mean to be self-existent and everlasting?” “Does free will truly exist?” “Why is there suffering?” “Does life have meaning?” “Does existence have meaning?” “What is existence?”

As my contact with science, history, philosophy, and religion became wider and deeper, I found that different fields could each offer their own version of an answer. I did not wholly accept those answers, nor did I wish merely to seek spiritual consolation. I began instead to conceive the wish to give my questions a place in which answers might be set.

One late night, I resolved to assemble these thoughts, to let the questions sink downward and bind themselves together, and from this there first arose the preliminary idea of the “Doctrine of Closure.” An ordinary person might perhaps have stopped there and been satisfied. Yet I dislike the closed self-admiration of solitary speculation, and I dislike crude ideas still more. Thus, somewhat of my own choosing, I expanded the thought into a full ontology, dividing myself against myself to seek the logical wounds of my own theory, attacking myself as if in a state of inner schism. Precisely because I was not satisfied with a closed and self-admiring declaration, I wished the “Doctrine of Closure” at least to be a theory able to endure attack, not a philosophical or religious manifesto of self-intoxication. For this reason I spent many late nights completing, polishing, repairing, cutting, and rewriting it, until a thirty-page declarative thought became an initial theory of more than two hundred pages. I shall not say that I have found the absolutely correct answer; I shall say only that the “Doctrine of Closure” has at least passed the measure I require of myself. “Sentiment and loose speech end here. What follows is the Doctrine of Closure, hammered out by extreme restraint, reason, and persistence. I ask the reader to set aside time and read it closely.”

DOCTRINE OF CLOSURE

Preliminary Positioning

Abstract

This section compresses the book’s central question, core propositions, and cross-domain limits, first marking the theoretical position and proper scale of reading for the Doctrine of Closure.

Abstract

The point of departure is an ancient and stubborn question in metaphysics: if existence is not a mere accidental heap, where do the conditions of its standing fall? Debates in analytical metaphysics concerning brute fact, the Principle of Sufficient Reason (Leibniz 1714; van Inwagen 1983), and grounding (Fine 2001; Schaffer 2009) are, at bottom, asking the same thing: whether there is a ground that can truly be made clear and brought to rest, rather than pushed forever one layer further. Closure is therefore proposed as a possible form of the ultimate ground: if the conditions of standing can be retrieved within the whole itself, then “existence” is better able to avoid explanatory suspension.¹

If the ultimate ground is not only to subsist in itself but also to possess a certain primordial presence, we may provisionally call it “First Consciousness.” Here “consciousness” does not mean mental activity in the psychological sense. It means the primordial manifestation by which existence establishes itself as “there is.” In this argument, existence and closure are not two added conditions, but two faces of the same ontological event. “Non-existence,” in this work, is only the name left after the failure of closure; it is not another substance standing over against existence. Quantum uncertainty, Bell’s theorem, and the many-worlds interpretation enter the discussion only when the question reaches the boundary of science: they can force the Doctrine of Closure to narrow its tone, but they cannot replace the ontological argument.²

Keywords: closure; ultimate ground; First Consciousness; grounding; wholeness; determination; misrecognition of existential position; possibility of multiple closures; stratified revelation; final debate with the four great opponents

¹On analytical metaphysics, grounding, and priority of the whole, see Schaffer, “On What Grounds What,” in *Metametaphysics*, edited by Chalmers, Manley, and Wasserman, Clarendon Press, 2009, pp. 347–383, doi:10.1093/oso/9780199546046.003.0012; Fine, “The Question of Realism,” *Philosophers’ Imprint* 1.1 (2001): 1–30; Bliss and Trogon, “Metaphysical Grounding,” *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2014; Melamed, “Principle of Sufficient Reason,” *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2010.

²For discussions in philosophy of consciousness and cosmopsychism, see Goff, *Consciousness and Fundamental Reality*, Oxford UP, 2017; Shani, “Cosmopsychism: A Holistic Approach to the Metaphysics of Experience,” *Philosophical Papers* 44.3 (2015): 389–437, doi:10.1080/05568641.2015.1106709; Nagel, “What Is It Like to Be a Bat?,” *Philosophical Review* 83.4 (1974): 435–450, stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/2183914>, Accessed 27 Apr. 2026.

The whole work takes the ultimate ground, self-establishment, and the condition of closure as its core, reorganizing the order of argument across ontology, ethics, religious translation, and cross-domain objections. Its central question may be stated more directly: if existence cannot rest in brute fact, and cannot be infinitely deferred to what lies outside, must true existence possess some closed condition of self-establishment? “Closure” is here defined as one preferred scheme for the ultimate ground; if a whole is to qualify as ultimate ground, it must show how its conditions of standing are retrieved within itself, rather than forever depending upon external conditions.³

Following from this, “First Consciousness” is understood as the primordial presence of the ultimate ground, not as psychological consciousness, a personal designer, or a designer outside the universe. God, the cosmic whole, local consciousness, ethical displacement, religious translation, and cross-domain debate are thereby placed anew within an argumentative sequence that moves from ontology to the applied layer.

The Doctrine of Closure can only be positioned as an ontological proposal still requiring full defence, not as a settled conclusion. Its strength lies in placing ultimate ground, self-establishment, wholeness, and local return within one frame. Its weakness lies in the strict justification of First Consciousness, the total relation among multiple closures, the criteria of stratified revelation, and the fourfold pressure formed by Madhyamaka prajñā, Barth, anti-PSR, and Many-Worlds.⁴

The Main Body of the Thesis and the Boundary of Contribution

The propositional chain of the whole work unfolds step by step from ultimate ground, self-establishment, the condition of closure, and First Consciousness. If existence cannot stop at naked fact, nor defer itself infinitely outward, true existence must at least face the demand of self-establishment. If self-establishment is to avoid borrowing from without, it requires the inward gathering of conditions, the preservation of difference, and local return. First Consciousness thus becomes the next unavoidable question: if the ultimate ground is not merely a dead structure, its primordial presence must be brought into discussion. Religious, ethical, and scientific materials do not open separate furnaces; they test, along this propositional chain, whether the Doctrine of Closure can endure external challenge.⁵

³For the background of analytical metaphysics, grounding, and priority of the whole, see Schaffer, “Monism: The Priority of the Whole,” *Philosophical Review* 119.1 (2010): 31–76; Fine, “The Question of Realism,” *Philosophers’ Imprint* 1.1 (2001): 1–30; Douven, “Abduction,” *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2011, <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/abduction/>, Accessed 27 Apr. 2026.

⁴For quantum theory and philosophy of science, see Everett, “Relative State Formulation of Quantum Mechanics,” *Reviews of Modern Physics* 29.3 (1957): 454–462, doi:10.1103/RevModPhys.29.454; Vaidman, “Many-Worlds Interpretation of Quantum Mechanics”; Myrvold, “Philosophical Issues in Quantum Theory,” *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, first published 2016, substantive revision 2022, <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/qt-issues/>, Accessed 27 Apr. 2026.

⁵This group of works chiefly marks the argumentative position of the propositional chain and the levels at which materials are used; for analytical metaphysics and grounding, see Schaffer, “On What Grounds What”; Fine, “The Question of Realism”; Bliss and Trogdon, “Metaphysical Grounding.”

The contribution of this work is not to force different traditions into one total formula, but to offer a clearer scale of judgment: which propositions belong to core ontology, which are only symbolic translation, which truly form cross-domain objections, and which have only background significance. Once this boundary fails, the Doctrine of Closure falls back into a mixture of materials. If the boundary can be held, it may become a metaphysical scheme open to criticism, further correction, and deeper development.

Scale of the Problem and Boundary of Examination

The problem first falls upon the conditions by which existence as a whole obtains its qualification for standing, not upon the first temporal point of cosmic physical history. Physics may describe the early state of the universe, the structure of space-time, or models of multiple universes. Such descriptions chiefly answer how the universe operates and how observable structures evolve. The Doctrine of Closure asks at another level: if finite beings all display dependence, is there still reason to require a ground-position that no longer defers outward? Only after these two kinds of question are distinguished can quantum materials avoid being misread as metaphysical proof.⁶

The abstract first places the Doctrine of Closure in a theoretical position still requiring defence. The more conservative proposition is this: if the ultimate ground must still borrow the conditions of its standing from another ground not yet accounted for, it has not yet truly obtained ultimate qualification. If a theory merely halts inquiry with naked fact, it may avoid infinite regress, but it does not thereby complete the explanation of qualification for standing. Closure is not presupposed as the answer. Under the requirement of non-external deferral, it first obtains priority for discussion.⁷⁸

Barth's theology of revelation, Madhyamaka's critique of reification, the grounding grammar of analytical metaphysics, and the challenge Many-Worlds poses to a unique event-path are not ornaments appended outside the main text. Each presses upon a most vulnerable point of the Doctrine of Closure: whether God can be named metaphysically, whether the whole is reified anew, whether closure violates the grammar of dependence, and how uniqueness faces a branching cosmos. If the Doctrine of Closure can still stand, it can do so only in a narrowed position forced upon it by these criticisms.⁹

The core propositions deal with non-external deferral and the qualification of closure; religious symbols involve translation and reverse pressure; scientific materials delimit the boundary of the question; Buddhist and theological materials retain their force of opposition. These materials cannot replace one another. If science is used to prove metaphysics, if theology is reduced to conceptual decoration, or if Buddhism is remade into collateral support for closure, the whole work falls back from thesis into cross-domain collage.¹⁰

⁶This concerns the distinction, in the abstract and Chapter One, between the scale of the question, the physical beginning, and metaphysical qualification for standing; see Chapter One and Chapter Sixteen.

⁷The text adopts a weaker principle of qualification for ground, not a strong Principle of Sufficient Reason. Formal interlocutors include Leibniz, Fine, Schaffer, Rosen, and anti-PSR lines.

⁸The positioning of First Consciousness is related to discussions by Nagel, Levine, Chalmers, Goff, Shani, Miller, and others in philosophy of mind. These materials function here as abstract positioning; the cited works do not directly entail First Consciousness.

⁹The four great pressures are summarized at the abstract level. Barth, Madhyamaka, grounding, and quantum-interpretation materials constitute, in this work, limits, pressures, compatibility checks, or boundary tests, thereby defining the argumentative position of the materials.

¹⁰The function of cross-domain materials in this work is to create limits and testing pressure: scientific materials delimit the boundary of compatibility, while theological and Buddhist materials respectively raise challenges concerning revelation and de-reification.

Preliminary Positioning

Introduction

Problem Consciousness, Methodological Self-Limitation, and the Stratification of the Book

This chapter fixes the problem consciousness, methodological self-limitation, and stratification of the whole book, lest religious, Buddhist, scientific, and ontological materials be displaced into one another.

Introduction Problem Consciousness, Methodological Self-Limitation, and the Stratification of the Book

Seeking Closure within Suspended Existence

“Existence” is ordinarily treated as the premise of all discussion. Once existence itself becomes the question, thought encounters a difficult and unavoidable sense of suspension. Physics may describe how the universe operates; history and the social sciences may analyse how the human world takes shape; theology may deal with how human beings understand ultimate meaning. Yet when these explanations each stand in their own field and reach their boundaries, they together expose a deeper interrogation: if the world is woven from conditions, causes, and relations of dependence, upon what do these relations finally stand? This plainly exceeds the technical scope of any single discipline and points to the predicament of ground behind every kind of explanation.

The question opens from here. Although later chapters will touch religious terms such as “God,” “salvation,” “revelation,” and “liberation,” the basic position remains within philosophy of religion and philosophical theology, and it draws upon analytical metaphysical debates concerning naked fact, the Principle of Sufficient Reason, grounding, whole and part in order to establish the frame of the problem. It does not defend a specific doctrine, nor does it move scientific materials into the place of theological evidence. What it truly seeks to address is whether the ultimate ground can acquire a qualification of standing that is no longer suspended. If existence cannot be lodged in the reasonless fact of “just so,” and if one is unwilling to defer the burden of explanation indefinitely, then one must conceive a structure by which existence can gather the conditions of its standing back into itself.¹¹

“Closure” is proposed from this point. The closure meant here has nothing to do with a circular proof in logic, nor with a closed circuit in the physical sense. Its core meaning is this: the conditions by which a whole stands can finally be retrieved within that whole, thereby cutting dependence upon an unknown external ground. It faces the question of the qualification of the ultimate ground itself. A ground still needing a deeper ground is, in the end, unworthy of its name; and a wholly reasonless naked fact merely stops inquiry on one side, without truly

¹¹The discussion concerns the positioning of philosophy of religion and philosophical theology; see Wood, “Philosophy and Christian Theology”; Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, vol. 1; Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, I, q. 3, a. 4. This note marks only the disciplinary position.

accounting for how existence stands. Along this line of thought, the Doctrine of Closure treats “self-establishment” as the basic demand that ultimate existence must bear.

Structural self-sufficiency alone is not enough to resolve the core difficulty. A purely self-consistent structure may perhaps perfectly close itself, yet it may not explain why existence vividly presents itself as “there is.” The concept of “First Consciousness” is therefore introduced to mark the primordial presence of the ultimate ground. The consciousness meant here exceeds mental activity in the psychological sense and does not presuppose a personal designer standing at the beginning of time. It truly points to the self-manifestation of existence at the most fundamental level. Since this step cannot appeal to strict deduction, it is full of theoretical dispute and belongs to inference to the best explanation. Accordingly, First Consciousness cannot be treated as a truth announced from nowhere; it becomes the central hypothesis repeatedly tested in what follows.¹²

This hypothesis cannot be handled by conceptual force alone. Conceptual analysis first fixes core terms such as “closure,” “First Consciousness,” “appearance,” “determination,” and “misrecognition of existential position,” so as to prevent semantic drift in a work of such length. Metaphysical modelling then establishes the smallest propositional chain: beginning from the refusal to borrow conditions of standing, it explains the reasonableness of closure as a possible form, and then, from the judgment that the ultimate ground cannot be merely a dead structure, draws out the ontological position of First Consciousness. Christianity, Buddhism, and modern science do not provide endorsement here; they form pressure. They ask how much opposition this model can bear.¹³

This thesis does not reconstruct the physical history of the universe; it does not treat neuroscientific measurement of consciousness as its principal concern; nor does it make historical Jesus research or the history of ecclesial thought its axis. Quantum uncertainty, Bell’s theorem, and the many-worlds interpretation can function only at the boundary of the theory. Theological and Buddhist terms should not be treated as external authorities either. What matters is the pressure they bring: Madhyamaka prajñā dismantles every tendency toward reification, while Barth warns against God being absorbed into a metaphysical system.¹⁴

This boundary also restrains the ethical discussion. When the Doctrine of Closure attempts to speak of the whole, the ultimate ground, and the completion of existence, it must never lightly dissolve local suffering and evil into some narrative of fullness. The language of the whole at the most fundamental ontological level has no right to

¹²The discussion concerns first-person presence and the hard problem of consciousness; see Nagel, “What Is It Like to Be a Bat?”; Chalmers, *The Conscious Mind*; Goff, *Consciousness and Fundamental Reality*. These works do not themselves directly entail First Consciousness; their role is only to mark the problem.

¹³“Inference to the best explanation” is a methodological statement; see Douven, “Abduction”; Brenner, “Metaphysical Explanation.”

¹⁴This is a limiting statement in the introduction concerning the scope of research and the function of materials, preventing cross-domain materials from replacing the propositional chain of the Doctrine of Closure itself. For analytical metaphysics, see Schaffer, “On What Grounds What”; Bliss and Trogon, “Metaphysical Grounding”; for theological pressure, Barth, *Church Dogmatics I/1*; for Madhyamaka pressure, Nāgārjuna, *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*; for the quantum boundary, Everett, “Relative State Formulation of Quantum Mechanics.”

replace the lived experience of concrete sufferers;¹⁵ structural explanation also has no power to remove the real weight borne at the ethical level. Later discussions of pain, evil, and salvation will hold this boundary throughout: the wounds of local existence are real and grave, and even when they are understood within an integral frame, their resistance to being silenced must remain intact.¹⁵

In sum, the Doctrine of Closure does not claim to have given a final answer with sufficient justification. It is closer to a still-contested metaphysical proposal, attempting to rebuild a rational order in which the suspended problem of existence can be argued, refuted, and corrected. If this framework has any potential contribution, its first task is not to end all metaphysical disputes, but to rearrange the order of questions, so that the tangled relation among ultimate ground, First Consciousness, local existence, suffering, and salvation may be re-examined under a stricter scale.¹⁶

¹⁵This methodological ethical boundary is meant to prevent holism from swallowing the concrete experience of sufferers. For the background of pain, evil, and the victim's refusal to be silenced, see Augustine, *The City of God*; Hick, *Evil and the God of Love*; Scarry, *The Body in Pain*.

¹⁶This limiting statement on the position of the whole work echoes the self-limitation of its contested ontological claims; for methodological background, see Douven, "Abduction"; Bliss and Trogdon, "Metaphysical Grounding."

Main Question, Subsidiary Questions, and the Burden of Argument

To prevent the ambition of the theory from dispersing into several unrelated lines, the main question must be fixed more precisely: “If existence cannot be satisfactorily placed in brute fact, and cannot be deferred infinitely outward, is there reason to propose a form of ultimate ground able to retrieve its conditions of standing within itself?”

This question does not ask what happened in the first second of the universe, nor whether some religious tradition has already given the answer in advance. It asks whether “standing” itself requires a qualification that no longer borrows outward. Unless this question is fixed, the theological, Buddhist, and scientific materials that follow will become attractive subordinate essays competing with one another.¹⁷

The main question further draws out several lines that must be handled. If the ultimate ground is no longer externally deferred, must it possess a structure of inward retrieval? If inward retrieval is merely blind structure, is it sufficient to explain the primordial presence of existence? Once the whole is prior to the local, how can suffering, evil action, and ethical responsibility avoid being swallowed by the language of the whole? Christian, Buddhist, and scientific materials each take their place in these questions: sometimes as examples, sometimes as criticisms, and sometimes as pressures that force the argument back into a narrower version.¹⁸

The Doctrine of Closure cannot place the entire burden of justification upon a single proposition. It must explain why it handles explanatory suspension better than brute fact, why it handles the responsibility of standing better than infinite external deferral, why it preserves difference and local position better than pure monism, and why it is more willing than mere religious symbolism to receive objections. If rhetoric replaces argument at any one point, the whole theory retreats into a private metaphysical declaration.

¹⁷This is a structured restatement of the main question. For the background of ultimate ground, grounding, PSR, and metaphysical explanation, see Leibniz, “Monadology”; Fine, “The Question of Realism”; Schaffer, “On What Grounds What”; Brenner, “Metaphysical Explanation.”

¹⁸This decomposition of the question and setting of argumentative responsibility belong to the method of this work. For the backgrounds of grounding, consciousness, theology, Buddhism, and the scientific boundary, see respectively Schaffer; Nagel; Barth; Nāgārjuna; Everett.

Core Hypothesis and the Fixing of Research Responsibility

If the ultimate ground cannot stop at pure brute fact, and cannot defer its conditions of standing infinitely outward, then it requires at least a non-externalized structure able to retrieve its conditions of standing within itself. The first step of the Doctrine of Closure has not yet proved that the universe must be this way. It first shows that, within the grammar of ultimate ground, merely stopping the question and endlessly postponing explanation do not fully satisfy the qualification of ground.¹⁹

In this sense, closure should not be understood as self-grounding. If closure is understood as something becoming its own ground within the same grounding relation, it immediately collides with the anti-reflexive and asymmetric limits commonly adopted in contemporary grounding theory. More accurately, closure is the boundary-sealing condition of the whole foundational field: it is not that U grounds U; rather, the conditions of standing are no longer externalized, and local difference can regain its place within the whole.²⁰

To put forward this core hypothesis is to assume three argumentative responsibilities at once: to explain why “brute fact” at most cuts off questioning and does not truly account for the qualification of standing; to clarify why “infinite external deferral,” though it may provide local explanation, ultimately cannot bring the ground to rest at the level of the whole; and to show further that non-externalization need not fall into a static absolute base, but may turn toward a dynamic closure that can contain internal difference, preserve difference, and allow local return.²¹

The introduction of First Consciousness draws out another difficulty. Even if closure, as a structural candidate, gains an initial position, it cannot skip the question of why a pure dead structure is insufficient to account for first-person presence. The Doctrine of Closure does not infer cosmic consciousness directly from local consciousness, nor does it romanticize subjective experience into ultimate evidence. It only preserves primordial presence as a contested but explanatory supplement where the dead-structure model cannot remove first-person presence at low cost.²²

A further boundary must be held. If the Doctrine of Closure were to dissolve local suffering, guilt, repentance, and the experience of victims entirely into a narrative of integral fullness, the theory itself would lose legitimacy. This means that the levels of discussion must be drawn apart: the ontological layer may investigate whether the system

¹⁹This concerns the introduction’s statement of “problem consciousness and core hypothesis.” The terms “core hypothesis” and “more conservative version” are used here to avoid writing closure as a deductive theorem.

²⁰This anticipates and answers the misreading of self-grounding. On the grammatical limits concerning ground and metaphysical dependence in Fine and Rosen, see the discussion in Chapter Fifteen.

²¹The three argumentative responsibilities correspond respectively to the directions of deepened argument in Chapters Two and Three; formal objections will be developed later.

²²This concerns the setting of the dead-structure model and First Consciousness. Formal opponents include Frankish, Nagel, Levine, Chalmers, Goff, Shani, and Miller.

can close, but the concrete ethical layer must still face responsibility and harm, and the layer of subjective experience must honestly bear pain, trauma, and the sense of liberation. The great language of the whole can never be used directly to absolve local evil actions, and still less to erase the protest and demand for repair of concrete sufferers.²³²⁴

²³This continues the original threefold division of existence in this work and strengthens the ethical defensive language. Relevant materials on theodicy and the philosophy of pain must be checked again in Chapters Nine and Seventeen.

²⁴This concerns the research method and methodological self-limitation in the introduction. The formal handling of the four refutable positions is reserved respectively for Chapters Fifteen, Seventeen, Eighteen, and Nineteen.

Methodological Self-Limitation and Academic Positioning

The method may be summarized as follows: avoid grand synthesis and turn instead to problem-dialogue. There are indeed resonances among theology, Buddhism, and modern physics, but resonance is not identity. To compress the three traditions into one unified formula would only strip each of its own problem-consciousness. The method of this thesis is to let different traditions of knowledge speak from their own positions, and then to observe at which levels they are able to question one another.

The writing must first distinguish several fields of discussion with different degrees of force. Analytical metaphysics and philosophical theology directly concern ultimate ground, explanation, and existential qualification. Buddhist and Christian terms may be translated into ontological language, but they must not thereby lose their own problem-origins. Quantum theory, Bell's theorem, and the many-worlds interpretation can touch only compatibility and boundary. These fields are adjacent to one another, yet they cannot replace one another. If conceptual translation is mistaken for doctrinal repetition, or scientific material is misused as ontological proof, the whole argumentative chain loses stability.²⁵

²⁵For backgrounds in philosophical theology, revelation, and theodicy, see Bliss and Trogon, "Metaphysical Grounding," Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, 2014; Douven, "Abduction," Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, 2011, <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/abduction/>, Accessed 27 Apr. 2026; Wood, "Philosophy and Christian Theology," Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, 2021, <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/christiantheology-philosophy/>, Accessed 27 Apr. 2026.

Stratification of the Whole Work and Reading Guide

The arrangement of the chapters generally proceeds outward according to argumentative strength. The Prologue through Chapter Seven form the theoretical core, treating ultimate ground, self-establishment, the condition of closure, First Consciousness, and the main limits. Chapters Eight through Eleven turn to ontological application, treating determination, freedom, suffering, evil, Bell's theorem, and the possibility of multiple closures. Chapters Twelve through Fourteen enter cosmic narrative and religious translation, displaying symbolic correspondence and the application layer of local consciousness, but without using them backward to prove the core propositions. Chapters Fifteen through Eighteen then place the Doctrine of Closure under philosophical, scientific, theological, and Buddhist-scriptural tests; Chapter Nineteen concentrates the final debate with four major opponents: Prajñā Madhyamaka, Karl Barth, anti-PSR / brute fact, and Many-Worlds. The literature review is placed after the introduction; its chief function is to locate the problem and arrange the research context, not to complete the later debates in advance.²⁶

This arrangement is not merely a matter of layout. If the earlier layer fails, the later display loses its ground; however rich the later layer may be, it cannot make up for weakness in the earlier layer. Wherever readers find a problem, they should return to the corresponding level of argument, rather than borrowing persuasive force from another level.²⁷

Scientific materials chiefly bring boundary challenges concerning wholeness and nonlocality. Theological materials ask whether First Consciousness usurps the free God of revelation. Buddhist materials ask whether closure reifies the whole again. Analytical metaphysics asks whether closure violates the basic grammar of grounding. If this work misplaces the materials, the whole text will retreat from thesis into cross-domain collage.²⁸

The main critical fields of the later chapters have thus already opened. First Consciousness will face illusionism, the explanatory gap, the hard problem, cosmopsychism, and the de-combination problem. Closure will face the grounding grammar of Fine, Schaffer, and Rosen. The theological naming of God will face Barth. Closure will

²⁶On analytical metaphysics, grounding, and priority of the whole, see Schaffer, "On What Grounds What," in *Metametaphysics*, edited by Chalmers, Manley, and Wasserman, Clarendon Press, 2009, pp. 347–383, doi:10.1093/oso/9780199546046.003.0012; Fine, "The Question of Realism," *Philosophers' Imprint*, vol. 1, no. 1, 2001, pp. 1–30; Bliss and Trogon, "Metaphysical Grounding," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2014. For quantum theory and philosophy of science, see Vaidman, "Many-Worlds Interpretation of Quantum Mechanics," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, first published 2002, substantive revision 2021, <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/qm-manyworlds/>, Accessed 27 Apr. 2026.

²⁷This work preserves the necessary scholarly self-limitation and avoids rewriting methodological limits as an over-triumpal conclusion.

²⁸This corresponds to the highest rule in the methodological self-limitation of this work: scientific, theological, and Buddhist materials can function only as limit, pressure, compatibility, symbolic translation, or boundary test.

also face the Madhyamaka critique of de-reification.²⁹ Finally, the four great pressures will bring the matter to a concentrated close.²⁹

The Doctrine of Closure stands at the intersection of several scholarly genealogies: the ground problem of PSR and brute fact, the grammar of standing in grounding, the problem of presence in philosophy of mind, the theological limit of revelation, the anti-reification pressure of Buddhist Madhyamaka, and the boundary challenge that scientific materials pose to simple local realism.³⁰

²⁹The relevant arguments are chiefly borne by Chapter Four, Chapter Fifteen, Chapter Seventeen, Chapter Eighteen, and Chapter Nineteen.

³⁰This concerns the research gap and theoretical attempt in the literature review, and places them within the functional explanation of the literature review.

Quick Reference Table of Core Concepts

The following table is for quickly locating the terms of the whole work. The column “argumentative strength” distinguishes axiom, inference, conceptual definition, and narrative translation, so that the reader may first grasp the skeleton of the work before entering the Prologue. The column “easily misread as” marks the most common category confusion for each term. It is a reminder of reading discipline and also a boundary statement between this work and existing intellectual traditions.

Concept	Definition in This Work	Level / Position	Argumentative Strength	Easily Misread As
Closure	A possible form of the ultimate ground; the conditions of standing are retrieved within the whole and are no longer borrowed infinitely outward.	Ontological layer	Preferred candidate form / inference	Circular fallacy, or mere physical circuit
First Consciousness	The primordial presence of the ultimate ground; the way existence establishes itself as “there is.”	Ontological layer	Metaphysical axiom / best explanation	A mental entity directly testable by empirical psychology
God	The philosophical naming of the cosmic whole as ultimate ground.	Ontological layer	Inference / naming	A personal designer outside the universe
Non-existence	The name for failure of closure, not a second ontology opposed to existence.	Ontological layer	Conceptual definition	An independently existing anti-cosmic field
Appearance	The borrowed manifestation of finite existence; real, yet without the qualification of ultimate self-subsistence.	Ontological layer	Conceptual definition	Complete illusion or mere hallucination
Misrecognition of Existential Position	A structural misplacement in which the local mistakes itself for the absolute centre.	Ethical layer	Interpretive concept	A mere moral offence
Devil	The structural residue left by pre-closure bifurcation, not an evil ontology equal to God.	Ontological layer	Narrative-ontological translation	An eternal and independent second sovereignty

DOCTRINE OF CLOSURE

Determination	The single event-path required for the ring to close precisely.	Ontological layer	Inference	Externally oppressive fatalism
Free Will	The individual's subjective undertaking and ratification of the given path, not the power to alter the result.	Ethical / consciousness layer	Compatibilist retention	The ability to overturn fate
Pain / Suffering	Pain is structural cost; suffering is the local subjective resistance to finitude.	Consciousness layer	Conceptual distinction	Interchangeable synonyms
Miracle	A rare node already written in, read by local consciousness.	Ontological / narrative layer	Internal interpretation	External repair of given causality
Liberation	Cognitive correction; the recognition that one has never left the whole.	Ontological / consciousness layer	Translational concept	Leaving the universe or annihilating the individual
Possibility of Multiple Closures	In facing Many-Worlds or multi-branch models, uniqueness is narrowed from one global single path to the coherence, inward retrieval, and return within each successful closure.	Scientific boundary / ontological layer	Revising hypothesis / critical review	Arbitrarily admitting that all parallel universes possess ultimate qualification
Stratified Revelation	A distinction among the clarity and levels of revelatory language according to self-limitation, universal truth, anti-usurpation, bearing suffering, and the highest manifestation in Jesus.	Theological / hermeneutic layer	Contested theological extension	Arbitrary selection of Scripture, or denial of the value of Old Testament texts
Final Debate with the Four Great Opponents	A test of the core lifeline and boundaries of the Doctrine of Closure through Prajñā Madhyamaka, Karl Barth, anti-PSR / brute fact, and Many-Worlds.	Final-debate layer	Critical review / test of theoretical maturity	Appendix-style refutation, or decorative dialogue

Draft Formalized Restatement

This page compresses the core concepts of the whole work into a minimal symbolic skeleton. Its aim is to make the relations of argument, conceptual levels, and possible points of challenge explicit; it cannot turn metaphysics into mathematical proof.

Notation

U = the cosmic whole; x = local existence; $G(x)$ = the set of conditions of standing for x ; $G^*(x)$ = its transitive closure; $L(U)$ = logical self-consistency; $C(U)$ = inward retrieval of conditions; $A(U)$ = primordial self-evidence; $E(U)$ = qualification as ultimate ground.³¹

Qualification as Ultimate Ground

$$E(U) = 1 \text{ iff } [L(U) = 1 \wedge G^*(U) \subseteq U \wedge A(U) = 1]$$

Truly ultimate existence must at least satisfy logical self-consistency, non-borrowing of its conditions of standing, and primordial presence to itself.

Status of Local Existence

$$\text{Phenomenon}(x) = 1 \text{ iff } [x \subset U \wedge G^*(x) \not\subseteq x]$$

Local existence is real; yet because its conditions of standing cannot be fully retrieved by itself, it belongs to borrowed appearance and does not possess ultimate self-subsistent qualification.

Inferential Chain

$$A(U) = 1 \rightarrow S(U) = 1 \rightarrow C(U) = 1$$

$S(U)$ denotes self-maintenance. If primordial self-evidence holds, it at least contains self-maintenance; if true self-maintenance leaves no external residual condition, it tends toward inward retrieval as closure.

Determination and Freedom

$$|I(U)| = 1; \text{Freedom}_i = \text{Endorsement}_i(y^*)$$

The former means that if the whole is to close precisely, only one finally completed event-path is allowed; the latter means that freedom does not mean rewriting the result, but the local subject's undertaking and ratification of the given path.

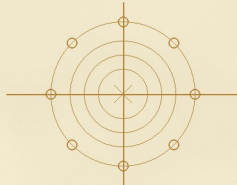
Pain and Suffering

$$\text{Pain}_i(t) = \text{structural cost}; \text{Suffering}_i(t) = \text{Pain}_i(t) + \text{Resistance}_i(t)$$

³¹This formal system is only for clarifying argumentative relations; it does not replace metaphysical argument with mathematical symbols. On the limits of formalizing metaphysical propositions, and for the background of analytical metaphysics, grounding, and priority of the whole, see Bliss and Trogon, "Metaphysical Grounding," Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, 2014; Brenner, "Metaphysical Explanation," Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, 2021, <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/metaphysical-explanation/>, Accessed 27 Apr. 2026.

Awakening does not necessarily make $\text{Pain}_i(t) \rightarrow 0$; it makes $\text{Resistance}_i(t) \rightarrow 0$. Thus there may be pain without suffering in the deepest sense.

The formalization above can only increase clarity and testability; symbols alone cannot turn a metaphysical choice into an empirical theorem.



Preliminary Positioning

Literature Review

Problem Location and Research Context

This chapter places the Doctrine of Closure within the problem-context among analytical metaphysics, philosophy of consciousness, philosophical theology, Buddhist thought, and the scientific boundary.

Literature Review: Problem Location and Research Context

The preceding discussion has already drawn the boundary: the Doctrine of Closure cannot mix its main ontological proof, religious language, Buddhist dialogue, and scientific boundary into one single layer. Upon this premise, the literature review enters the existing scholarly contexts. If the Doctrine of Closure is to become a thesis open to examination, it cannot rely merely upon conceptual coherence or upon grand narrative; it must state which problems it inherits, which problems it rewrites, and where its argumentative force must be restrained.

What this work concerns is not merely whence the world came, nor only the God, creation, or salvation named in religious language. It asks, more deeply, whether the standing-conditions of existence itself can truly come to ground. This question involves ultimate ground, the principle of sufficient reason, brute fact, and grounding in analytical metaphysics; it also involves whole and part, consciousness and matter, the ground of being in theology, emptiness and non-self in Buddhism, and the pressure that modern science places upon a fragmented picture of the world.

Closure is the response proposed at the crossing of these questions. It means that the standing-conditions of ultimate existence can be gathered back within the whole, and are not deferred infinitely to another condition not yet accounted for. This concept must first pass through the trial of the literature: how previous thinkers have treated ultimate ground, wholeness, consciousness, theology, and liberation will directly determine whether closure, First Consciousness, misrecognition of existential position, and local return can be read as debatable propositions, rather than as the author's private emotional declaration.³²

This chapter proceeds along several interwoven lines. Analytical metaphysics treats the principle of sufficient reason, brute fact, and grounding. Priority monism and monism treat the relation of part and whole. Philosophy of consciousness advances the problem of first-person presence. Philosophical theology discusses God as ground of being, creation, evil, and revelation. Buddhist emptiness, non-self, and liberation theory challenge the language of ultimate ground. The scientific materials concerning nonlocality, non-equilibrium systems, and the self-organization of life set methodological boundaries. These literatures do not prove the Doctrine of Closure for it, but they do mark the controversies that it must face.

³²Closure is here written as a candidate for ultimate qualification in the grounding chain, not as an ordinary circular metaphor; see Fine, "The Question of Realism"; Schaffer, "On What Grounds What"; Bliss and Trogon, "Metaphysical Grounding."

Five Scholarly Genealogies and the Point of Entry of This Work

The debate over the principle of sufficient reason, brute fact, and anti-PSR is the first entrance into the Doctrine of Closure. Anti-PSR should not be written as a shallow evasion, for brute-fact theory does point out with force that the world may not be obliged to satisfy the human desire for explanation. The Doctrine of Closure can advance only a weaker requirement: if a certain position is named the ultimate ground, then it cannot still take an unaccounted external deferral as its own qualification. Thus it avoids the excessive commitment of strong PSR, while also refusing to let the concept of ultimate ground be replaced by the mere stopping of inquiry.³³

The second genealogy is grounding and metaphysical dependence. Fine makes metaphysical explanation no longer reducible to temporal causality; Schaffer makes priority of the whole once again a debatable position; Rosen clarifies the formal grammar of dependence. The danger for the Doctrine of Closure is that it may be mistaken for self-grounding. Hence my formulation is this: closure does not mean that a single item grounds itself, but that the field in which the whole stands no longer borrows its sealing criterion outward.³⁴

Philosophy of consciousness forms another problem-line. Nagel, Levine, and Chalmers make it difficult to translate first-person presence simply into third-person functional description. Frankish's illusionism, in turn, warns the Doctrine of Closure that phenomenal consciousness cannot be elevated directly into an unquestionable ontological fact. The cosmopsychism of Goff and Shani makes whole-level consciousness a neighbouring option open to discussion. Miller's de-combination problem then requires the Doctrine of Closure to explain how local subjects arise, and not merely to say that the whole is conscious.³⁵

Philosophical theology provides language for 'God as ground of being,' and at the same time sets limits. Aquinas and Tillich keep the Doctrine of Closure from writing God as an engineer outside the universe. Barth, however, reminds us that a metaphysical system must not enclose the God who freely reveals Himself within a human conceptual structure. If the Doctrine of Closure uses 'God' as a philosophical name, it must admit that this naming belongs only to the entrance of philosophical theology, and is not directly identical with the God of free revelation, covenant, and redemption in Christianity.³⁶

³³This concerns the genealogical positioning of PSR / Anti-PSR. Leibniz, Hume, van Inwagen, Melamed, and related materials are used here as problem-contexts.

³⁴The core problem of Chapter Fifteen is anticipated here. Fine, "The Question of Realism"; Fine, "Guide to Ground"; Schaffer, "On What Grounds What"; Rosen, "Metaphysical Dependence," and related materials are used here as problem-contexts.

³⁵The works of Nagel, Levine, Chalmers, Frankish, Goff, Shani, Miller, and others constitute the problem-context for the close reading of philosophy of mind in Chapter Four.

³⁶This concerns the genealogical positioning of Aquinas / Tillich / Barth. In particular, Barth's critique of freedom of revelation, election, and anti-natural theology in Church Dogmatics I/1 and II/2 will be treated in the relevant discussion of Chapter Seventeen.

Buddhist Madhyamaka and the critique of reification form another line that the Doctrine of Closure cannot avoid. Nāgārjuna's doctrine of emptiness, Garfield's interpretation, and Siderits's and Westerhoff's analyses of non-self and emptiness are not conscripted as supporting evidence for closure. What they truly ask is this: does the Doctrine of Closure turn 'ultimate ground,' 'First Consciousness,' or 'the whole' once more into a reified entity with own-being? If it cannot bear this criticism, then even if the Doctrine of Closure can be spoken within analytical metaphysics, it may not pass the pressure of Buddhist thought.³⁷

Together these genealogies mark the position of the Doctrine of Closure. It is neither a private proposition without sources, nor the direct extension of any one tradition. It is closer to an intersectional model: it places the non-externality of ultimate ground, the structural demand of priority of the whole, the explanatory debt of first-person presence, the limit set by theology of revelation, and the Madhyamaka pressure against reification within one debatable field. It cannot pursue a slogan of grand unification; it can only receive its opponents step by step in the chapters that follow.³⁸

³⁷Nāgārjuna, Garfield, Siderits, Westerhoff, and related materials provide the literary context for Madhyamaka and the problem of anti-reification. Where no precise page is supplied, the reference is limited to research-contextual use.

³⁸This gathers the deepening direction of the literature review and moves it from 'listing names' to 'positioning scholarly genealogies.'

Ultimate Ground, the Principle of Sufficient Reason, and the Problem of Grounding

The most typical entrance into the Western metaphysical question of ultimate ground is Leibniz's formulation of the principle of sufficient reason. Leibniz holds that whatever is thus should not remain in a reasonless state; the existence of the world itself also requires a reason sufficient to explain its existence. This requirement drives philosophy to a deep place: the world cannot be regarded only as a set of facts that have happened; one must also ask by what qualification these facts stand. The point is not ordinary causality, but whether metaphysical explanation can truly come to ground.³⁹

The principle of sufficient reason is not without opponents. Hume's suspicion toward causal necessity had already weakened the confidence with which reason projects a 'there must be a reason' into the structure of the world. In contemporary analytical philosophy, the route of brute fact states another possibility more clearly: some facts may simply be final facts; the world may stop at 'thus it is.' The strength of this position lies in its refusal to inflate the human demand for explanation into an obligation of the universe itself. That the world may refuse our question is an objection the Doctrine of Closure must face directly.⁴⁰

The problem is that brute fact can stop inquiry, yet it does not thereby complete explanation. When a theory says, 'the world is simply thus,' it indeed avoids infinite regress; but it also abandons any further account of why existence has the qualification to stand. Here lies the difference between the Doctrine of Closure and brute fact. This work recognizes brute fact as a genuine philosophical route and does not treat it as a low-level misunderstanding. Yet for a thesis centered upon ultimate ground, merely stopping the question remains insufficient. Once the difference between existence and non-existence is lowered into brute fact, the very qualification of ultimate ground is suspended.

Grounding theory provides a more precise tool at this point. Kit Fine understands grounding as a relation of metaphysical standing, so that the discussion is no longer confined to temporal causal sequence, but can address that by which something stands ontologically. Jonathan Schaffer further connects grounding with the problem of priority of the whole, reminding us that metaphysics should not merely list what things there are in the world, but also ask what is more fundamental and what depends on what. These discussions make 'conditions of standing' themselves an object of analysis.

³⁹G. W. Leibniz, "Monadology," in *Philosophical Essays*, translated by Roger Ariew and Daniel Garber, Hackett, 1989, §§31-32.

⁴⁰David Hume, *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, edited by Tom L. Beauchamp, Oxford UP, 1999, secs. 4-7.

The Doctrine of Closure may be understood within this context. The problem it takes up is this: as grounding relations are pursued downward, is there finally need for a whole that no longer borrows its standing-conditions outward? If the sum of all relations of standing still points outside itself, then what is called the whole has not yet truly become ground. The Doctrine of Closure introduces the concept of 'inward retrieval of conditions' precisely to address this point. It does not say that the world has one highest point, nor does it disguise circular reasoning as metaphysics. It requires that ultimate ground possess a structure able to gather back the conditions by which it stands.

This positioning also limits the force of the Doctrine of Closure. Closure is better understood as a debatable model of ultimate ground than as an exclusive answer locked by deduction. Its strength is that it can respond at once to the stopping-problem of brute fact and the suspension-problem of infinite external deferral; its weakness is that it must still explain why self-establishment should take the form of closure. The later arguments concerning closure, First Consciousness, and the return of the whole unfold under this limit.⁴¹

⁴¹Here closure is explicitly lowered into a candidate account rather than a deductive theorem. For the methodological background, see Douven, "Abduction"; Brenner, "Metaphysical Explanation."

The Grammar of Grounding and the Prior Exclusion of Misreadings of Closure

Within the grammar of grounding, the first misreading to exclude is the interpretation of 'self-establishment' as 'something becoming its own ground.' Standard analytical metaphysics usually treats grounding as a relation that is irreflexive, asymmetric, and directionally explanatory. If one directly claims that U grounds U, this does not strengthen the theory; it makes the Doctrine of Closure fail at once in formal grammar.⁴²

Therefore, 'self-establishment / self-support' in this work means the non-externalized qualification of ultimate ground. It means that when all dependence relations are examined at the level of the whole, the ultimate field cannot still hand over its own conditions of standing to another field. This is a boundary-condition or sealing-condition, not a single-point self-cause that violates the grammar of dependence.⁴³

This clarification changes the relation between the Doctrine of Closure and monism. The Doctrine of Closure can enter into dialogue with priority monism, for both refuse to treat local individuals as the final units. Yet 'priority of the whole' itself has not answered how the whole stands. Priority of the whole is only the entrance; closure is the additional requirement upon the qualification of ultimate ground. If this difference is not clear, Chapter Fifteen will become merely a restatement of Schaffer rather than the Doctrine of Closure's own debate.⁴⁴

⁴²On the irreflexivity and asymmetry of grounding, see the relevant discussion in Chapter Fifteen concerning Fine, Rosen, Schaffer, and related Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy entries.

⁴³This concerns the grammatical clarification in Chapter Three, especially 'the problem after non-externalization' and 'closure as a prior possible form of ultimate ground.'

⁴⁴This concerns the distance between this work and Schaffer's priority monism. Differences in version and argumentative position are discussed in Chapter Fifteen.

Priority of the Whole, Monism, and the Difference of Closure

Once the question of ultimate ground is opened, it necessarily meets the relation between whole and part. Can finite things stand by themselves? Is the individual prior to the whole? Is the whole of the world merely the sum of all local parts? These questions form the second literary line of the Doctrine of Closure.

Spinoza's monism provides an important point of reference. In the *Ethics*, Spinoza understands God or Nature as the one substance, and finite things as modes of that substance. The importance of this route is that it refuses to understand the world as a collection of scattered individuals, each sufficient unto itself. The standing of finite things must be understood by returning them to the more fundamental single substance. This is close to the Doctrine of Closure, for it likewise refuses to treat local things as ultimately self-subsisting.⁴⁵

Priority monism in contemporary analytical metaphysics raises a similar problem anew. Schaffer argues that the world as a whole may be ontologically prior to its parts; the parts need not be the most fundamental units of existence, and the whole may instead be the more basic reality. This line of thought can break through the limits of an atomistic world-picture. The world need not be understood as a heap of independent individuals; the properties, positions, and functions of the local often require the structure of the whole for their intelligibility.⁴⁶

The Doctrine of Closure inherits this line of priority of the whole, but it is not simply identical with ordinary monism. To say merely that 'all returns to one' is still not enough, for that 'one' itself must still be questioned. Is it only the largest set, or is it a ground truly able to establish itself? Is it only the name for all the local, or does it possess the structure of inward retrieval and self-return? The focus of the Doctrine of Closure lies precisely in this difference. What matters is the qualification of the ultimate ground, not a static highest entity.

This also keeps the Doctrine of Closure at a distance from Spinoza. Spinoza's God or Nature has necessity and self-causality, yet the whole system is often read as a necessary structure without subjectivity. The Doctrine of Closure, by contrast, seeks to preserve the layer of primordial presence. Mere whole, mere necessity, and mere structure may not suffice to explain how existence is present as 'being.' This point pushes the Doctrine of Closure toward philosophy of consciousness: can the ultimate ground be only dead structure? Does the emergence of local first-person experience compel us to rethink the nature of the whole?

⁴⁵Benedict de Spinoza, *Ethics*, translated by Edwin Curley, Penguin, 1996, pt. 1.

⁴⁶Jonathan Schaffer, "Monism: The Priority of the Whole," *Philosophical Review*, vol. 119, no. 1, 2010, pp. 31-76, doi:10.1215/00318108-2009-025.

Philosophy of Consciousness, Panpsychism, and Cosmopsychism

'First Consciousness' is the concept most likely to provoke controversy in the whole work. It is not directly identical with mental activity in the psychological sense, nor should it be understood as human consciousness enlarged to cosmic scale. More precisely, it points toward the primordial presence of ultimate ground: existence is not merely described from without as standing; in some manner it also presents itself as 'being'.⁴⁷

Recent philosophy of consciousness has given renewed attention to panpsychism and cosmopsychism, thereby providing a context for the discussion. Philip Goff's treatment of the fundamentality of consciousness challenges the confidence that consciousness can be wholly explained by third-person physical description. The point of such arguments is not to romanticize every stone as thinking; the real point is to show that the emergence of first-person experience poses a difficulty for pure physicalism. Itay Shani's cosmopsychism further proposes that, rather than treating local consciousness as suddenly emerging from unconscious matter, one might consider whether consciousness at the level of the whole is more fundamental.⁴⁸

Nagel's classic essay 'What Is It Like to Be a Bat?' argues that subjective experience cannot be translated entirely into objective functional description. Chalmers's analysis of the 'hard problem of consciousness' also reveals the gap between function, behaviour, neural process, and subjective experience. These studies do not directly prove that the universe possesses First Consciousness, yet they make 'presence' a problem that a theory of ultimate ground cannot easily exclude.⁴⁹

The Doctrine of Closure meets these discussions at the point where it refuses to be satisfied with an ultimate ground understood as purely blind dead structure. Local first-person experience has already appeared within the universe. Once the ultimate ground is assumed to be a structure wholly without presence, the appearance of local consciousness becomes a rupture requiring additional explanation. The intuition of the Doctrine of Closure is that the ground of the whole should not be too quickly understood as utterly without presence. This is not a direct inference from local mind to cosmic mind; the point is to question the dead-structure model.⁵⁰

⁴⁷The problem of First Consciousness here enters the background of philosophy of consciousness and cosmopsychism; see Nagel, Chalmers; Goff; Shani, "Cosmopsychism." These works are not identified with proof of the Doctrine of Closure.

⁴⁸Philip Goff, *Consciousness and Fundamental Reality*, Oxford UP, 2017; Itay Shani, "Cosmopsychism: A Holistic Approach to the Metaphysics of Experience," *Philosophical Papers*, vol. 44, no. 3, 2015, pp. 389-437.

⁴⁹Thomas Nagel, "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?" *Philosophical Review*, vol. 83, no. 4, 1974, pp. 435-450, stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/2183914>, Accessed 27 Apr. 2026; David J. Chalmers, *The Conscious Mind: In Search of a Fundamental Theory*, Oxford UP, 1996.

⁵⁰This admits that there is no strict deduction from local first-person experience to the primordial presence of ultimate ground; see Chalmers; Goff; Shani. Their function is limited to risk-background and dialogical position.

First-Person Presence and the Literary Pressure upon the Dead-Structure Model

If First Consciousness is to become an academically discussable concept, it must first pass the gatekeeping of illusionism. Frankish's illusionist strategy does not simply deny experience; it seeks to explain why we stably take ourselves to possess phenomenal consciousness. This strategy lowers ontological commitment and forces the Doctrine of Closure not to elevate 'I feel pain' directly into ultimate ground. The lowest defensible claim of the Doctrine of Closure is this: even if phenomenal consciousness can be reinterpreted, the dead-structure model must still explain why this 'seeming presence' is so fundamental.⁵¹

Nagel, Levine, and Chalmers do not testify on behalf of cosmic mind. What they truly provide is the explanatory gap between third-person description and first-person experience. Nagel's subjective character, Levine's explanatory gap, and Chalmers's hard problem jointly show that functional structure and phenomenal presence should not be simply identified. What the Doctrine of Closure gains from them is only that the dead-structure model still bears an explanatory debt, not that First Consciousness has already been fully justified.

Goff's and Shani's cosmopsychism provides a neighbouring option, and at the same time exposes the difficulty of the Doctrine of Closure itself. If whole-consciousness is prior to local consciousness, how do finite subjects, local ignorance, and the sense of separation arise? The Doctrine of Closure cannot pass over this with the phrase 'differentiation of the whole.' Miller's de-combination problem strikes precisely here: if the whole subject is already a unified consciousness, whence come the boundaries of local subjects? The Doctrine of Closure must answer by means of 'local position' and 'return,' not merely borrow the prestige of cosmopsychism.⁵²

The status of First Consciousness in this work is a discussable position of primordial presence, not the blunt thesis that 'the universe has a gigantic mind.' From this point onward, the Doctrine of Closure must preserve its edge while avoiding an unverifiable mystical declaration. What the later chapters must do is fairly restate illusionism, the dead-structure model, cosmopsychism, and the de-combination problem, and then determine what minimum point the Doctrine of Closure can still retain.⁵³

⁵¹Frankish, "Illusionism as a Theory of Consciousness," *Journal of Consciousness Studies*, vol. 23, no. 11-12, 2016, pp. 11-39. For the problem-context of illusionism, see that article.

⁵²Gregory Miller, "Can Subjects Be Proper Parts of Subjects? The De-Combination Problem," *Ratio*, vol. 31, no. 2, 2018, pp. 137-154, doi:10.1111/rati.12166. For the de-combination problem in cosmopsychism, see that article.

⁵³The argumentative procedure of Chapter Four is as follows: first fairly restate the opponents, then identify their threat, and finally lower the Doctrine of Closure into a more defensible candidate formulation.

Philosophical Theology: Ground of Being, Creation, Evil, and Revelation

Because the Doctrine of Closure uses the word 'God,' it necessarily enters the field of philosophical theology. God here is neither reduced to an external designer of the universe nor turned into a rhetorical ornament. This work proposes to place 'God' back within the problem of the ground of being, and to ask to what extent this word can bear the philosophical naming of ultimate ground.

Tillich understands God as being-itself or the ground of being, not as one highest being within the universe. This line is very important for the Doctrine of Closure, for it removes God from the position of external engineer and places God instead at the ground of existence itself. Aquinas's tradition of ipsum esse subsistens likewise understands God as subsistent being itself. In these theological contexts, God's place is not to fill a scientific gap; 'God' names the ground by which the world receives the qualification to exist.⁵⁴

The Doctrine of Closure has an evident resonance with this. To call 'God' the philosophical name of the cosmic whole insofar as it is ultimate ground is not to rebuild popular design theory. The focal problem is this: how existence is not left suspended; how the whole gathers back its own conditions of standing; and how the local again receives its position within the whole. These questions have affinities with ground of being, creation, and redemption in philosophical theology.

The doctrine of creation also requires repositioning. In Book XI of the Confessions, Augustine discusses time and creation, already showing that time should not be understood simply as a container existing before creation. Creation is not merely the first event in physical time; it also concerns the dependence of time and the world themselves upon God. This is instructive for the Doctrine of Closure: the standing of the universe should not be compressed into the linear question, 'what happened before the Big Bang?' The focus is how the whole of existence receives its conditions of standing.⁵⁵

Nevertheless, theological literature also limits the Doctrine of Closure. Barth's critique of natural theology reminds us that a human metaphysical system cannot wholly grasp God. Revelation possesses freedom and particularity, and cannot be reduced to a conclusion reached by general reason. The God of Christianity is not only ground of being, but also the personal subject who speaks, covenants, judges, has mercy, and redeems in history. Although the Doctrine of Closure retains 'First Consciousness,' its handling of personhood, relation, and

⁵⁴Paul Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, vol. 1, U of Chicago P, 1951; Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, translated by Fathers of the English Dominican Province, Benziger Bros., 1948, I, q. 3, a. 4.

⁵⁵Augustine, *Confessions*, translated by Henry Chadwick, Oxford UP, 1991, bk. 11.

revelation remains insufficient. It can enter dialogue with philosophical theology, but it cannot replace theology of revelation, nor should it be directly identified with the God of free revelation in Christianity.⁵⁶

⁵⁶Karl Barth, *Church Dogmatics*, I/1, translated by G. W. Bromiley, T&T Clark, 1975.

Barthian Pressure and the Limit of Theological Naming

The part of philosophical theology that the Doctrine of Closure most needs to deepen is the part in which Barth's limit is allowed to bite. If God is the one who freely reveals Himself, then He cannot be predetermined by a metaphysical system. If revelation is not something human reason can naturally ascend to and obtain, then First Consciousness also should not be directly equated with the God of free revelation in Christianity. This critique is not a polite external reminder; it directly limits the theological extension of the Doctrine of Closure.⁵⁷

Therefore, 'God' may function in this work as the philosophical naming of the cosmic whole insofar as it becomes ultimate ground, but it should not be treated as doctrinal completion. Aquinas and Tillich help this thesis avoid lowering God into the highest being within the universe; Barth forces it to admit that there remains an irreducible distance between the language of ground of being and the language of theology of revelation. If the Doctrine of Closure is to enter theology, it must first admit that it cannot replace theology of revelation.⁵⁸

This also affects the claim concerning determination and free will. If closure is written as a mechanical blueprint in which God has preordained every event, it falls at once into fatalism and theological usurpation. Hence this work stresses that closure, at the most fundamental ontological layer, requires the consistency of the whole, while the concrete ethical layer still preserves responsibility, choice, repentance, and undertaking. If determination may be spoken of, it should be closer to retrospective consistency than to external oppression imposed upon the local subject.⁵⁹

The problem of evil is similar. Augustine understands evil as the privation of good, not as a second entity equal to God. Tillich understands sin as estrangement - the estrangement of the human being from God, from others, and from the true ground of the self. The Doctrine of Closure rewrites evil as 'misrecognition of existential position,' and here it can enter dialogue with these traditions. The local wrongly takes itself to be the center; it then usurps the whole, swallows the other, and distorts order. This can indeed connect ethical problems with ontological problems.⁶⁰

It must be noted, however, that this work does not over-abstract 'evil.' Hick's theodicy understands suffering as a field of soul-making, attempting to explain the place of suffering within a greater purpose. Such theories have explanatory force, but they are also vulnerable to criticism: in the name of an overall purpose they may weaken the

⁵⁷Barth, *Church Dogmatics I/1, The Doctrine of the Word of God, Part I*, 2nd ed., edited by G. W. Bromiley and T. F. Torrance, T&T Clark, 1975; *Church Dogmatics II/2, The Doctrine of God*, edited by G. W. Bromiley and T. F. Torrance, T&T Clark, 1957. For the editions and problem-context of freedom of revelation, anti-natural theology, and election, see the above Barth materials.

⁵⁸Aquinas, Tillich, and Barth here bear respectively the functions of entrance into philosophical theology and of limitation; this note only marks those functions.

⁵⁹The argumentative directions of Chapters Eight and Seventeen are here limited in advance, in order to avoid rewriting the Doctrine of Closure as hard fatalism.

⁶⁰Augustine, *The City of God against the Pagans*, translated by R. W. Dyson, Cambridge UP, 1998, bks. 11-12; Paul Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, vol. 2, U of Chicago P, 1957.

concrete harm suffered by victims. Scarry's study⁶¹ of bodily pain especially reminds us that pain can destroy language, world, and the integrity of the subject; it cannot be converted too quickly into a necessary cost within a grand theory. When the Doctrine of Closure treats suffering and evil, it must preserve the weight of the concrete ethical layer. The wholeness of the most fundamental⁶¹ ontological layer cannot cancel responsibility, condemnation, repair, and the experience of victims in the concrete ethical layer.⁶¹

⁶¹John Hick, *Evil and the God of Love*, 2nd ed., Harper and Row, 1978; Elaine Scarry, *The Body in Pain: The Making and Unmaking of the World*, Oxford UP, 1985.

Buddhist Emptiness, Non-Self, and Liberation Theory

There are resonances between the Doctrine of Closure and Buddhist thought, but also fundamental tensions. If Buddhist language is directly conscripted as evidence for closure, this part immediately goes astray. The central Buddhist problem is often to analyse how suffering arises, how ignorance operates, how grasping is formed, and finally how liberation is attained. It does not chiefly aim to establish an ultimate self-subsisting ground. The Samyukta Agama and early Buddhist teaching concentrate upon suffering, dependent arising, non-self, craving, appropriation, and the path of cessation. Their problem-direction differs from the Western metaphysical theory of ultimate ground. Bhikkhu Bodhi's arrangement of the Pali canon likewise clearly shows that the centre of early Buddhism lies in the practical structure of suffering and liberation.⁶²

The point at which the Doctrine of Closure and Buddhism most readily meet is 'misrecognition' and 'liberation.' This work understands suffering as the local consciousness's resistance to finitude, loss, and determination, and connects deep suffering with misrecognition of existential position. Buddhism, by contrast, connects suffering with ignorance, self-grasping, craving, and appropriation. Both indicate that suffering is not caused only by external events, but also by how the subject reads its own position. When the local takes itself as center, takes the temporary as eternal, and takes dependence as self-sufficiency, suffering is deepened in this misreading.

Madhyamaka thought forms a stronger pressure upon the Doctrine of Closure. Nāgārjuna's doctrine of emptiness criticizes every tendency toward self-nature, holding that all dharmas stand through dependent arising and have no independently self-subsisting essence. Mark Siderits's analysis of Buddhist philosophy likewise stresses the deconstructive force of non-self and emptiness against reified thinking. From this angle, the Doctrine of Closure's ultimate ground, First Consciousness, and self-evidence of the whole may all be seen by Madhyamaka as dangers of reification.⁶³

This pressure cannot be avoided. The Doctrine of Closure may enter dialogue with Buddhism on suffering, ignorance, misrecognition, and liberation; the two may be compared, but they cannot be identified. In particular, emptiness must not be directly rewritten as the closed whole. Emptiness is not a higher entity, nor a cosmic

⁶²For the background of early Buddhist suffering, dependent arising, non-self, and liberation theory, see the following materials. This work uses Bodhi's English translations of the Pali canon as background dialogue material. The Chinese Samyukta Agama is uniformly taken from CBETA Online, Za ahan jing, T02n0099, as the comparable base text; CBETA page numbers are not listed in the text. The Connected Discourses of the Buddha: A Translation of the Samyutta Nikāya, translated by Bhikkhu Bodhi, Wisdom Publications, 2000; Bhikkhu Bodhi, In the Buddha's Words: An Anthology of Discourses from the Pāli Canon, Wisdom Publications, 2005.

⁶³For Madhyamaka emptiness and the anti-reification critique, see the following studies. Nāgārjuna, The Fundamental Wisdom of the Middle Way: Nāgārjuna's Mūlamadhyamakakārikā, translated and commentary by Jay L. Garfield, Oxford UP, 1995; Mark Siderits, Buddhism as Philosophy: An Introduction, 2nd ed., Hackett, 2021.

consciousness hidden behind all things. Liberation in the Buddhist context often means the cessation of grasping and reification, not return to an ontological whole.⁶⁴

⁶⁴This marks the pressure of Madhyamaka and emptiness upon the Doctrine of Closure; see Nāgārjuna, *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*; Garfield, *The Fundamental Wisdom of the Middle Way*; Siderits, *Buddhism as Philosophy*.

Madhyamaka De-Reification and the Lowest Sustainable Version of Closure

The point of the Madhyamaka critique is that it is not merely another Eastern thought that can be cited, but a force that dismantles the core language of the Doctrine of Closure. If 'closure,' 'First Consciousness,' and 'the whole' are written as the highest entity possessing own-being, standing independently, and serving as the hidden base behind all phenomena, then the Doctrine of Closure becomes precisely the object criticized by Madhyamaka. This must be stated already at the level of the literature review; otherwise Chapter Eighteen will be misread as a chapter in which Buddhism endorses closure.⁶⁵

Therefore, closure and emptiness cannot be exchanged for one another. Emptiness is not a higher entity, nor another name for cosmic consciousness; it points to the absence of own-being in all dharmas and to dependent arising. If the Doctrine of Closure is to converse with Madhyamaka, it can only lower closure into a relational criterion or a discussable language of non-externalized qualification, and admit that Madhyamaka may still criticize it as residual reification. Such admission is not a weakening, but a way of preventing the theory from swallowing its opponent as supporting evidence.⁶⁶

The deepest point at which Buddhist thought touches the Doctrine of Closure is not that it testifies to ultimate ground, but that it analyses misrecognition, grasping, and suffering. The local subject's misreading of itself as absolute center is indeed comparable to what Buddhism calls self-grasping, ignorance, and appropriation; but comparability is not identity. If the Doctrine of Closure uses Buddhist language, it must preserve Buddhism's own direction of liberation, and must not turn it into an appendage of itself.⁶⁷

⁶⁵This concerns the anti-reification pressure of Madhyamaka upon the Doctrine of Closure. Nāgārjuna's Middle Treatise, chapter 24, Garfield, Siderits, and Westerhoff are used as research-contextual references where no precise page is supplied.

⁶⁶The misreadings 'emptiness = closure' and 'First Consciousness = Buddha-nature' are excluded here. Detailed textual verification is reserved for Chapter Eighteen.

⁶⁷This paragraph only marks the possible dialogical position of Buddhist materials. It does not use Buddhist materials directly to support the Doctrine of Closure; see Samyukta Agama T02n0099, Bodhi, The Connected Discourses of the Buddha; Siderits, Buddhism as Philosophy.

Scientific Boundary, Wholeness, and Methodological Self-Limitation

The Doctrine of Closure involves materials from quantum mechanics, Bell's theorem, Many-Worlds, non-equilibrium systems, autocatalytic networks, plant signalling, and slime-mould learning. These materials are especially prone to level-confusion, for they seem to provide strong support, whereas in fact they can function only at the levels of compatibility and boundary. The core of the Doctrine of Closure remains ultimate ground and non-externality, not a proposition that can be directly proved by any single scientific result.⁶⁸

The significance of Bell's theorem lies in its constraint upon local hidden-variable theories. Bell's relevant paper concerns quantum mechanics, locality, realism, and experimentally testable inequalities; it does not concern theology or cosmic consciousness. The 2022 Nobel Prize in Physics recognized the experimental work of Aspect, Clauser, Zeilinger, and others, with its focus on entangled photons, violation of Bell inequalities, and quantum information science. These results should not be misused as 'scientific proof of cosmic First Consciousness.'⁶⁹

The meaning of Bell's theorem for the Doctrine of Closure can only be indirect. It weakens an over-simple local and fragmentary picture of the world, so that 'wholeness' is not merely a philosophical fancy; but this meaning is weak and must not be inflated. It provides a background to the problem: nature may not be intelligible as a set of wholly independent local pieces. The Doctrine of Closure may discuss the priority of the whole in that background, but it cannot elevate Bell's theorem into its main ontological proof.

Many-Worlds forms another pressure upon the Doctrine of Closure. Everett's relative-state formulation attempts to understand the measurement problem without the collapse of the wave function, placing different outcomes within a branching structure. This challenges the closed-loop expression of a 'single event-path.' The Doctrine of Closure must re-stratify uniqueness: the most fundamental ontological layer requires the closing of the conditions of standing, but this is not necessarily identical with a single linear story at every layer of local experience. In this way the many-worlds interpretation does not directly destroy the Doctrine of Closure, but it forces it to abandon an overly crude single-line picture of determination.⁷⁰

Materials concerning non-equilibrium systems and the self-organization of life likewise can only serve as conceptual references. Maturana and Varela's theory of autopoiesis understands life as a system that continually produces and maintains its own organization. Luhmann then transfers the concept of autopoiesis into social

⁶⁸This paragraph only defines the boundary function of scientific materials. For Bell and the background of quantum measurement, see Bell, "On the Einstein Podolsky Rosen Paradox"; Everett, "Relative State Formulation of Quantum Mechanics"; Myrvold, "Philosophical Issues in Quantum Theory."

⁶⁹John S. Bell, "On the Einstein Podolsky Rosen Paradox," *Physics Physique Fizika*, vol. 1, no. 3, 1964, pp. 195-200, doi:10.1103/PhysicsPhysiqueFizika.1.195; Nobel Prize Outreach, "The Nobel Prize in Physics 2022," NobelPrize.org, 2022.

⁷⁰Hugh Everett III, "Relative State Formulation of Quantum Mechanics," *Reviews of Modern Physics*, vol. 29, no. 3, 1957, pp. 454-462, doi:10.1103/RevModPhys.29.454.

systems theory, explaining how systems generate boundaries and elements through their own operations. These theories share with the Doctrine of Closure such terms as self-maintenance, boundary-generation, internal retrieval, and system-closure; yet they treat living or social systems, not the ultimate ontological ground.⁷¹

Plant signalling and slime-mould research provide an even weaker auxiliary illustration. Paco Calvo's discussion of plant intelligence indicates that plants, though lacking animal-like nervous systems, can display complex environmental sensing, signal integration, and adaptive response. Reid and others show that *Physarum polycephalum* can form spatial memory through externalized traces. These studies weaken the intuition that only high-level nervous systems can possess cognition-like behaviour, yet they still do not prove subjective consciousness, still less serve as proof that the universe possesses First Consciousness.⁷²

The levels must be held apart. From adaptive behaviour to information-processing is a scientific question open to research; from information-processing to subjective presence is a dispute in philosophy of consciousness; from local subjective presence to cosmic First Consciousness has already entered metaphysics. The three cannot be fused into one straight line. Science can modify the tone of the Doctrine of Closure and prevent it from falling out of touch with modern knowledge, but it cannot complete the core proof for it.⁷³

⁷¹Humberto R. Maturana and Francisco J. Varela, *Autopoiesis and Cognition: The Realization of the Living*, D. Reidel, 1980; Niklas Luhmann, *Social Systems*, translated by John Bednarz Jr. and Dirk Baecker, Stanford UP, 1995.

⁷²Paco Calvo, "Plants Are Intelligent, Here's How," *Annals of Botany*, vol. 125, no. 1, 2020, pp. 11-28; Chris R. Reid et al., "Slime Mold Uses an Externalized Spatial 'Memory' to Navigate in Complex Environments," *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, vol. 109, no. 43, 2012, pp. 17490-17494, doi:10.1073/pnas.1215037109.

⁷³The move from scientific description of behaviour to subjective presence, and then to metaphysical ground, belongs to different levels of question; see Chalmers, Calvo, Reid et al.

Research Gap and Position of This Work

From the literature above it can be seen that the Doctrine of Closure stands at the crossing of several problem-lines, and not within one small question inside a single discipline. Analytical metaphysics discusses ultimate ground, brute fact, and grounding, but less often pushes the problem toward first-person presence, religious language, and liberation theory. Philosophy of consciousness discusses panpsychism and cosmopsychism, but may not handle the self-establishing conditions of ultimate ground. Philosophical theology discusses God as ground of being, yet must also face the fact that revelation, personhood, history, and redemption cannot be wholly absorbed into a purely metaphysical system. Buddhist thought deeply analyses ignorance, self-grasping, and liberation, while remaining highly alert to the language of ultimate ground. Modern science provides a background of wholeness, nonlocality, non-equilibrium generation, and systemic self-maintenance, but it cannot directly answer the question of existential qualification.

The attempt of the Doctrine of Closure is to place these lines within a single framework that can enter discussion and correction. It is not the final answer, but it may be viewed as a still-contested metaphysical proposal. Its basic questions are these: can the standing-conditions of existence cease to be externally deferred; can the whole gather back its own ground; can local first-person experience be understood again within the problem of ultimate ground? The religious language of salvation, return, God, creation, and liberation can enter ontological discussion only after being handled in layers, lest it collapse into a mixed mystical declaration.

This positioning also exposes the limits of the thesis. The Doctrine of Closure can challenge brute fact and supplement priority monism. It can enter dialogue with cosmopsychism, philosophical theology, Buddhist liberation theory, and the scientific boundary. Yet there remains an argumentative distance between closure and First Consciousness; there is still tension between determination and ethical responsibility; the ground of the whole and theological personhood remain not fully joined; and the closed whole remains in fundamental tension with Buddhist emptiness. These problems cannot, and will not, be solved by adding more religious terms or scientific materials. They are handed over to the later chapters, level by level.⁷⁴

⁷⁴This summarizes the tensions between the Doctrine of Closure and the various fields. It does not add a new proof; see Barth, Church Dogmatics I/1; Nāgārjuna; Everett; Bliss and Trogdon.

Research Method: Distinguishing Levels of Propositions and Materials, and the Positions at Which the Theory Can Be Refuted⁷⁵

The Doctrine of Closure must also classify its materials. Philosophical literature may directly enter the debates over ultimate ground, grounding, whole and part, and consciousness. Theological literature asks whether God, creation, revelation, sin, and redemption have been over-metaphysicalized. Buddhist materials ask whether appearance, ignorance, emptiness, liberation, and de-reification have been wrongly conscripted by the Doctrine of Closure. Scientific materials restrict this thesis from substituting physical interpretation for metaphysical proof. Once these functions are confused, the common disease of cross-domain writing appears: every field is borrowed to increase force, while no field truly bears its own problem. I shall try to remain restrained.⁷⁶

The possible points of failure must also be clear. If the anti-PSR route can stand, the demand for ultimate ground will be weakened. If dead structure or emergence can fully explain first-person presence, First Consciousness must be restrained. If Barthian theological criticism succeeds, this work's theological extension can remain only at the level of philosophical theology. If Prajñā Madhyamaka successfully shows that closure still falls into self-nature, the language of ultimate ground must be rewritten. If Many-Worlds or similar options become the more stable mainstream of philosophy of science, the early expression of unique determination must also be revised. These apparent defects are important entrances by which the theory enters examination.⁷⁷

The work completed by the literature review is therefore to mark the scholarly position of the Doctrine of Closure. The next section enters the thesis's own ontological settings: God as First Consciousness, the simultaneous standing of existence and closure, and non-existence as the name of failed closure. Only after being placed within the foregoing literary context can these settings be read as metaphysical claims open to examination, rather than as private propositions without location.

⁷⁵Levels of propositions and levels of material-use belong to the self-limiting method of this work; see Douven, "Abduction"; Brenner, "Metaphysical Explanation"; Wood, "Philosophy and Christian Theology."

⁷⁶The levels of material-use may be compared respectively with Schaffer, Barth, Siderits, and Myrvold.

⁷⁷This lists the entrances by which this work may be refuted or revised. For the four pressure-backgrounds, see respectively Melamed; Barth; Nāgārjuna; Everett.

The Distance between This Work and Existing Research

The foregoing literary context shows that the Doctrine of Closure does not name itself upon ground without a past. It borrows the explanatory pressure of analytical metaphysics, inherits the challenge that priority of the whole raises against local substantialism, and takes from philosophy of consciousness the language of first-person presence. At the same time, it must face theology's insistence upon revelation and personhood, Buddhism's dismantling of every reifying tendency, and the scientific materials that limit a single-line picture of the universe. These materials place the Doctrine of Closure in a difficult position: if it moves too close to any one tradition, it loses its own original problem; if it departs wholly from existing research, it loses the scholarly ground upon which it can be tested.⁷⁸

The distance between the Doctrine of Closure and analytical metaphysics lies in this: it is not satisfied with letting grounding remain a ranking of dependence relations, but asks whether the whole ranking can complete internal retrieval. Its distance from monism lies in this: it is not satisfied with saying 'all is one,' but asks whether the 'one' has the qualification of closure. Its distance from panpsychism or cosmopsychism lies in this: it is not eager to distribute consciousness to all things, but limits First Consciousness to the problem of primordial presence in ultimate ground. Its distance from philosophical theology lies in this: theological language is not an authoritative conclusion, but a source of ontological translation and criticism. Its distance from Buddhist thought lies in this: emptiness and non-self are fundamental threats to it, and should not be converted into supporting evidence for closure.⁷⁹

This sense of distance also constitutes the method of this thesis. Materials from outside the theory enter the main argument only when they can function as direct interlocutors. Those that can only provide background remain references. Those that form genuine opposition must retain their destructive force. Materials belonging to religious narrative and symbolic translation must not be used backward to support the core ontological propositions. If this division of labour cannot stand, the Doctrine of Closure will be misunderstood as a system that mixes different traditions into a total encyclopedia. What is needed is to cut apart the temptation to mix, and let each kind of material bear only the function it can bear.

⁷⁸This closes the literature review by supporting its field of problems rather than proving the Doctrine of Closure; see Fine; Schaffer; Goff; Barth; Siderits; Bell.

⁷⁹This marks the distance between this work and existing research. For the background of grounding and priority of the whole, see Fine; Schaffer; Bliss and Trogon.

Closing the Literature Review: What May Stand, What Must Be Restrained, and the Limit of the Theory⁸⁰

Therefore several propositions must be restrained: the uniqueness of closure can only remain temporarily as a candidate and must not be written as already justified; First Consciousness can only stand as a candidate of primordial presence and must not be written as a psychological or theological conclusion; theological naming can only retain the entrance of philosophical theology and must not replace theology of revelation; dialogue with Madhyamaka can only preserve criticism and comparability and must not be written as emptiness supporting closure; scientific materials can only handle boundary and compatibility and must not be elevated into the main proof of metaphysics.⁸¹

These limits also define what this thesis has not yet completed. The close reading of philosophy of mind in Chapter Four, the technical variants of grounding in Chapter Fifteen, the positioning of Barth in Chapter Seventeen, and the scriptural bases and Madhyamaka interpretation in Chapter Eighteen all remain within the range of theoretical deepening. Chapter Nineteen then gathers the four major opponents into a final debate. These problems are not merely defects to be concealed; they are part of the theory's boundary itself.⁸²

⁸⁰The literature review is here gathered into three requirements: what may stand, what must be restrained, and the problem-context.

⁸¹These limits define the strength with which the core propositions of this work may be stated.

⁸²The later directions of argumentative deepening are preserved here as limits requiring more precise literary positioning.

Part I The Theoretical Core

Prologue

Three Core Ontological Revisions and the Threefold Division of Existence

This chapter fixes in advance the three
ontological revisions and the threefold
division of existence, as the basis for reading
every later proposition.

Prologue Three Core Ontological Revisions and the Threefold Division of Existence

Foundation I God as First Consciousness, Not a Personal Designer

"First Consciousness" is neither a higher mental unit within the universe, nor a mere enlargement of human conscious experience projected upon the whole. It names an ontological necessary principle: if existence is to stand, then at the most fundamental level there must be a ground capable of self-presentation, self-maintenance, and the gathering of the whole. The word "God" is used here to give this ultimate principle a philosophical name; it is not meant to rebuild a personal designer.⁸³

This work deliberately retains the term "First Consciousness," rather than replacing it with "primordial self-subsisting directedness" or "subjectless structure," for a direct reason: what must be preserved here is not merely abstract self-sufficiency, but the subjectivity of the whole as self-knowing, self-subsisting, and self-returning. This line is close to Spinoza's understanding of God as the one substance, yet the difference is fundamental: this work does not reduce the ultimate ground to a subjectless necessary structure. The two are related, but they ought not to be simply identified.⁸⁴

Foundation II Existence and Closure as Two Faces of the Same Event

[Proposition 2] Existence and closure are two aspects of one and the same ontological fact, not two conditions separated in sequence.

Existence and closure are not two conditions separated in time, but two aspects of one and the same ontological fact. Whatever stands as existence is necessarily closed; whatever cannot be closed cannot ultimately maintain itself, and finally slips toward non-existence. The "simultaneity" spoken of here is ontological necessity, not

⁸³For discussions in philosophy of consciousness and cosmopsychism, see Nagel, "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?," *Philosophical Review* 83.4 (1974): 435-450, stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/2183914>, Accessed 27 Apr. 2026; Chalmers, *The Conscious Mind*, ch. 1; Goff, *Consciousness and Fundamental Reality*, chs. 1-2; Shani, "Cosmopsychism," *Philosophical Papers* 44.3 (2015): 389-437, doi:10.1080/05568641.2015.1106709.

⁸⁴For relevant background in philosophy of consciousness, see Nagel, "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?," *Philosophical Review* 83.4 (1974): 435-450, stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/2183914>, Accessed 27 Apr. 2026; Chalmers, *The Conscious Mind*, ch. 1; Goff, *Consciousness and Fundamental Reality*, chs. 1-2; Shani, "Cosmopsychism," *Philosophical Papers* 44.3 (2015): 389-437, doi:10.1080/05568641.2015.1106709.

temporal simultaneity - this distinction must be held, or the entire ontological structure will be infected with an unnecessary temporal presupposition.⁸⁵

Foundation III Non-Existence as the Name of Failed Closure, Not an Independent Entity

In this work, "non-existence" is not a second entity standing alongside existence. It is only the name left when closure fails to be completed. This definition is meant to forestall a common ontological error: reifying the state of failure, as though outside the universe there were another field standing against existence.

In the pre-circular epoch, the so-called "god of non-existence" - the tendency toward dissolution - is a personifying explanatory device for the internal division within First Consciousness between what can stand and what cannot. It does not describe two powers contending against one another. It describes an internal sifting carried out as First Consciousness establishes itself: structures capable of self-consistency remain as closure; those incapable of self-consistency lose their qualification and fall under the name of non-existence. Once this division is completed and the circle is closed, the tendency toward dissolution vanishes wholly. What continues to operate within the universe thereafter is only the structural residue left by that division: devil, entropy, and quantum noise.⁸⁶

The Threefold Division of Existence: Ontology, Ethics, and Consciousness

The following threefold division is the reading premise of the whole work. The force of every claim must be read according to the level to which it belongs.

The Most Fundamental Ontological Level

At the most fundamental ontological level, the question is not good or evil, not morality, not retribution, and not local fate. There is only one question: can this existence complete closure and thereby persist? If not, it slips toward non-existence. At this level there is only the distinction between "closure" and "non-existence," not the

⁸⁵For discussions of priority of the whole, systems theory, and the self-organization of life, see Schaffer, "Monism: The Priority of the Whole," *Philosophical Review* 119.1 (2010): 31-76, doi:10.1215/00318108-2009-025; Maturana and Varela, *Autopoiesis and Cognition*, chs. 1-2; Luhmann, *Social Systems*, ch. 1.

⁸⁶The "god of non-existence" is in this work a narrative and personifying language. Its structure is closer to the privation account of evil as the lack of good or existence, rather than a second entity equal to God. For relevant discussion, see Augustine, *Confessions*, bk. 7; Plotinus, *The Enneads*, I.8; Stump, "Augustine on Evil," *Cambridge Companion to Augustine*, Cambridge UP, 2014.

distinction between good and evil. At the highest level, "true evil" has only one face: non-existence, dissolution, the failure of closure.

The Concrete Ethical Level

Good and evil, condemnation, judgment, punishment, law, and remorse all belong to necessary mechanisms at the local level; they are not the final realities of the most fundamental ontological level. In ultimate ontology there is only the distinction between closure and non-existence. Good, evil, and judgment are local mechanisms for maintaining order within closure; they are not the final verdicts of the cosmic body itself.

The Level of Subjective Experience

Pain, suffering, trauma, remorse, repentance, the feeling of being redeemed, and the feeling of loss all belong to the way local consciousness reads and bears its finite position. The experiences of this level are real, but their ontological status is local. They are not identical with the judgment of the most fundamental ontological level. To raise the immediate feelings of the conscious level into the final reality of the ontological level is one of the most common mistakes in reading.

Once this threefold division has been completed, the main text first deals with ultimate ground, self-establishment, and the condition of closure. Chapters One to Three successively define the scale of the problem, exclude routes that stop at brute fact or infinite external deferral, and explain why closure can become a priority candidate for ultimate ground. How the Three Revisions Constrain What Follows⁸⁷

How the Three Revisions Constrain What Follows

The revisions proposed in the Prologue are not mere conceptual previews. They are hard constraints upon everything that follows. God as First Consciousness prevents this work from writing God as an engineer outside the universe; at the same time, First Consciousness cannot be thinned into an empty metaphor, or the ontological core of the whole work would lose both edge and centre. The claim that existence and closure are two faces of the same event means that closure is no longer an external technique added onto existence, but the qualification required if existence is to stand ultimately. Non-existence is only the name of failed closure; if it were written as a negative entity equal to existence, the theory would manufacture a dual ontology at the outset.⁸⁸

The threefold division of existence is not merely a convenience for reading. The most fundamental ontological level deals only with whether closure can be completed; the concrete ethical level deals with responsibility, evil, judgment, punishment, and repair; the subjective-experiential level deals with pain, trauma, faith, remorse, and liberation. If what follows uses the language of the ontological level directly to absolve local evil, the theory fails. If subjective suffering is raised directly into the highest ontological failure, the theory also fails. What this work requires is that different levels of reality be placed in their proper order, not that the whole be used to cancel the local.

⁸⁷For discussions of priority of the whole, systems theory, and the self-organization of life, see Schaffer, "Monism: The Priority of the Whole," *Philosophical Review* 119.1 (2010): 31-76, doi:10.1215/00318108-2009-025; Maturana and Varela, *Autopoiesis and Cognition*, chs. 1-2; Luhmann, *Social Systems*, ch. 1.

⁸⁸This concerns internal constraints upon the propositions of this work. For background in analytical metaphysics and philosophical theology, see Schaffer; Tillich; Barth.

Part I The Theoretical Core

Chapter One

Problem-Consciousness - Does Existence Need an Ultimate Ground?

This chapter shifts the problem of existence from the beginning of the universe to the qualification of ultimate ground, and first fixes the metaphysical entrance of the whole work.

Chapter One Problem-Consciousness - Does

Existence Need an Ultimate Ground?

The Starting Point of the Problem

Any ontology, once pursued deeply enough, finally meets the same question: why is there something, and why not nothing at all? This is not a rhetorical wonder, but the root-problem to which metaphysics repeatedly returns. It forces us to ask whether, if relations of dependence are pushed back far enough, there is at last some position at which explanation truly lands, rather than merely handing the problem over to another level.⁸⁹

In the history of philosophy, there are roughly three answers to this question. The first treats existence as brute fact, that is, as an accomplished fact requiring no further explanation. The second accepts an infinite causal chain, or infinite external deferral, allowing the burden of explanation to extend without end. The third maintains that if existence is to serve as ultimate ground, it must possess some capacity for self-establishment that no longer borrows from beyond itself. The Doctrine of Closure takes the third route, but it cannot write itself as the victor from the beginning. The task of Chapter One is first to explain why the first two routes still leave a problem, and only then to establish a reasonable entrance for "self-establishment" and "closure."⁹⁰

In terms of the history of the problem, this work intervenes in debates concerning the principle of sufficient reason, brute fact, grounding, and metaphysical explanation. It does not simplify "the world is simply thus" into a low-level mistake. Brute-fact theory has real theoretical force, for it refuses to project the human desire for explanation directly into an obligation imposed upon the world. The question is this: if a theory still uses the concept of "ultimate ground," whether mere cessation of questioning is enough to constitute the qualification of ground cannot be passed over too quickly.

⁸⁹On the principle of sufficient reason and the problem of ultimate explanation, see G. W. Leibniz, "Monadology," in *Philosophical Essays*, translated by Roger Ariew and Daniel Garber, Hackett, 1989, §§31-32; Martin Heidegger, *Introduction to Metaphysics*, translated by Gregory Fried and Richard Polt, Yale UP, 2000.

⁹⁰For the background of brute fact and anti-PSR, see David Hume, *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, edited by Tom L. Beauchamp, Oxford UP, 1999, secs. 4-7; Peter van Inwagen, *Metaphysics*, Westview Press, 1983; Yitzhak Melamed, "Principle of Sufficient Reason," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2010.

What It Means to "Truly Account for the Standing of Existence"

To "truly account for the standing of existence" is not to add one more cause in the everyday sense, nor to find a preceding event for some local event. It means a metaphysical explanation capable of stopping external projection: if that by which something stands always depends upon another unaccounted premise, what we have gained is only one station in a chain of explanation, not the ground itself. Grounding is not an accessory term here but the problem itself: that by which something stands in ontology, and that by which an event is caused in time, belong to two different levels.⁹¹

This distinction prevents the problem of Chapter One from sliding into a cosmological narrative. Even if the universe has a physical beginning, one may still ask by what that beginning and its laws stand. Even if the universe has no single temporal beginning, one may still ask whether existence as a whole is only a suspended fact. Thus this work does not ask, "What happened at the earliest point of the universe?" It asks, "By what qualification does existence as a whole no longer borrow the conditions of its standing from outside itself?"

"Nothing" as a Limit-Name, Not a Prior Field

This work sometimes uses expressions such as "from nothing to being," but the "nothing" here is not something or some state that exists prior to existence, still less a blank field before the universe. It is only the negative limit reached when thought pursues the conditions by which existence stands: the name of an existence not yet established. If "nothing" is understood as some real field, then it itself has already become a kind of existence; in order to explain existence, one has first invented another existent.

Therefore "nothing" bears no ontological weight in this work. It is used only to mark the boundary of the problem: if existence cannot be satisfied with brute fact, and cannot be deferred infinitely outward, then we must ask whether there is some structure by which existence can recover within itself the conditions by which it stands. The Doctrine of Closure enters at this point, not from a mystical imagination of a pre-universe.

⁹¹On grounding, metaphysical dependence, and metaphysical explanation, see Kit Fine, "The Question of Realism," *Philosophers' Imprint* 1.1 (2001): 1-30; Jonathan Schaffer, "On What Grounds What," in *Metametaphysics*, edited by David Chalmers, David Manley, and Ryan Wasserman, Clarendon Press, 2009, pp. 347-383, doi:10.1093/oso/9780199546046.003.0012; Ricki Bliss and Kelly Trogdon, "Metaphysical Grounding," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2014.

Fixing the Scale of the Problem: Ontological Qualification and Cosmological Beginning

To make "whether existence needs an ultimate ground" into a valid philosophical question, the first task is to exclude two mistakes of scale.

The first mistake is to reduce the metaphysical condition of standing to the temporal beginning studied by physics. Physics can describe how the universe unfolds, how its early state evolves, how the structure of space-time is formed, and can even propose cyclic-universe, multiverse, or quantum-cosmological models. These discussions concern how the universe operates. Metaphysics asks at another level: why is this whole that is capable of unfolding not merely a set of brute facts arbitrarily placed? Even if physics could describe the first second of the universe perfectly, we could still ask: by what qualification do these laws, initial conditions, and the whole order no longer borrow their standing from beyond themselves?⁹²

The second mistake is to raise the ground-question into an unarguable mystical proclamation. If every objection is dismissed as "not yet having entered the depth of the problem," the thesis no longer needs argument. This work rejects such a handling. The question of ultimate ground cannot be directly solved by empirical science, but it can be assessed through conceptual analysis, comparative explanatory power, and the bearing of objections. The Doctrine of Closure need not claim that it has been experimentally verified; nor may it flee rational examination. Through these two boundaries, the task of Chapter One becomes clear. It is not a chapter in cosmology, nor a mystical manifesto. It is the metaphysical entrance. The question it fixes is this: if finite existences all manifest dependence, do we still have reason to require an ultimate position that no longer borrows the conditions by which it stands?

The Weak Principle of Ground-Qualification

This work adopts here a "weak principle of ground-qualification," not an unrestricted strong principle of sufficient reason. A strong PSR would demand transparent reasons for every fact, every event, and every local state. This work does not assume so excessive a burden. It claims only this: whatever calls itself the ultimate ground cannot

⁹²This paragraph only distinguishes the cosmological beginning from metaphysical qualification of standing; it does not use any physical model to support the Doctrine of Closure. For relevant metaphysical frameworks, see Fine, "The Question of Realism"; Schaffer, "On What Grounds What"; Bliss and Trogdon, "Metaphysical Grounding."

still have an unaccounted external deferral as its final form. In other words, this is a requirement upon a position, not an indiscriminate command of explanation imposed upon every local fact.⁹³

This restriction is important. If a strong PSR is asserted, the Doctrine of Closure immediately faces a full attack from anti-PSR routes. If the demand for ground-qualification is abandoned entirely, the Doctrine of Closure loses its reason for being proposed. The weak principle of ground-qualification stands between these two positions: it admits that there may be local facts in the world that cannot be made fully transparent, while still requiring that the position of "ultimate ground" not be occupied by mere cessation of questioning or by an unexplained external deferral.

Therefore the difference between this work and brute fact is not psychological dissatisfaction, but conceptual demarcation. A brute fact may be a stopping point; it may not, however, also bear the thick meaning of ultimate ground. If something is simply thus without reason, it certainly stops the question; but it has not yet explained why that stopping point has the qualification to support existence as a whole.

From Problem-Consciousness to the Entrance of the Doctrine of Closure

Chapter One has not yet proved that the Doctrine of Closure is true. What it has completed is a filtering of the problem: the problem of existence cannot be reduced to the physical beginning of the universe, nor pushed into an undiscussable mystical zone; and if ultimate ground is to answer to its name, it cannot maintain its position by brute fact or infinite external deferral alone. In this way, "self-establishment" is no longer an arbitrary term added from outside. It becomes a demand internal to the very concept of ultimate ground.

The Doctrine of Closure thus gains its entrance. If ultimate ground must no longer borrow the conditions of its standing from outside itself, then it must at least present some structure capable of recovering its own conditions. At this point one still cannot directly declare closure to be the only answer. More precisely, closure first appears as a priority candidate, because it attempts to deal at once with three questions: how the ground ceases to defer outward; how the whole contains the local; and how the local regains its place within the whole.

⁹³The "weak principle of ground-qualification" here restricts only the position of ultimate ground and does not assert an unrestricted strong PSR. For PSR and its opposing background, see Leibniz, "Monadology," §§31-32; Hume, *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, secs. 4-7; Melamed, "Principle of Sufficient Reason"; Alexander R. Pruss, *The Principle of Sufficient Reason: A Reassessment*, Cambridge UP, 2006.

The Continuation of the Proposition-Chain: From Qualification of Standing to the Critique of Brute Fact and Infinite External Deferral

What Chapter One has truly accomplished is to turn the question from "why is there?" into "by what qualification does it stand?" This transformation preserves the original problem-consciousness and also prevents the theory from moving too quickly. If Chapter One were to announce immediately that closure necessarily stands, the argument would merely presuppose its conclusion. If Chapter One stopped only at wonder over existence, what follows would lack direction. The more fitting step is first to establish the problem of ultimate ground's qualification, and then to examine the two chief escape-routes: brute fact and infinite external deferral.

Chapter Two therefore does not need to decide whether an ordinary causal chain may extend infinitely, nor whether the world must satisfy every human desire for explanation. It must handle a narrower question: if a theory still wishes to keep the position of ultimate ground, can brute fact and infinite external deferral adequately bear that position? If the answer is no, then the self-returning structure required by the Doctrine of Closure gains further necessity for discussion.⁹⁴

⁹⁴Chapter Two will further handle the limits of brute fact and infinite external deferral as candidates for ultimate ground. The present chapter only fixes the scale of the problem and the entrance of the argument. For relevant background, see Fine, "The Question of Realism"; Schaffer, "On What Grounds What"; Tobias Wilsch, "The Nomological Account of Ground," *Philosophical Studies* 172.12 (2015): 3293-3312; Michael Raven, "Ground," *Philosophy Compass* 10.5 (2015): 322-333.

Part I The Theoretical Core

Chapter Two

Against Brute Fact and Infinite External Deferral - True Existence Must Be Capable of Self-Establishment

This chapter deals with the two routes of
brute fact and infinite external deferral, and
explains why ultimate ground, if it is to stand,
must face the requirement of non-externality.

Chapter Two Against Brute Fact and Infinite External Deferral - True Existence Must Be Capable of Self-Establishment

Brute Fact: Epistemic Termination, Not Ontological Landing

The brute-fact route offers the most serious warning of anti-PSR: the world is under no obligation to satisfy the explanatory desire of human reason. This objection must not be simplified into an evasion of the problem. What it truly points out is that to raise "intelligibility" directly into a law to which existence must submit may merely project the human desire for explanation into an obligation of the cosmos. Perhaps some facts have no deeper reason; perhaps the world may stop at "it is simply thus." This route has philosophical force and must first be fairly acknowledged.⁹⁵

The problem is that brute fact can terminate questioning, but it cannot positively complete the account of the qualification of "ultimate ground." When a theory places brute fact at the bottom level, it indeed cuts off infinite regress. At the same time, however, it leaves the difference between existence and non-existence unaccounted for. If some final fact may exist without any reason, it may likewise fail to exist without any reason. Existence as existence is thereby compressed into a decision to stop asking, not into an ontological landing.

The difference between this work and brute fact is not psychological dissatisfaction, nor the demand that all facts be made transparent. The real difference lies here: can brute fact at the same time retain the title "ultimate ground"? If something is merely brute and simply thus, it may serve as an epistemic stopping point, but it is difficult for it to serve as a self-standing structure that supports existence as a whole. If the ultimate ground remains only "there is no reason, yet it exists," its ultimacy is left as a name alone, without having obtained the qualification of standing.⁹⁶

⁹⁵For the problem-background of brute fact and anti-PSR, see David Hume, *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, edited by Tom L. Beauchamp, Oxford UP, 1999, secs. 4-7; Peter van Inwagen, *Metaphysics*, 2nd ed., Westview Press, 2002; Yitzhak Melamed, "Principle of Sufficient Reason," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2010.

⁹⁶This distinguishes "stopping the question" from "the qualification of ultimate ground." For relevant background concerning metaphysical explanation and grounding in analytical metaphysics, see Kit Fine, "The Question of Realism," *Philosophers' Imprint*, vol. 1, no. 1, 2001, pp. 1-30; Ricki Bliss and Kelly Trogdon, "Metaphysical Grounding," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2014; Andrew Brenner, "Metaphysical Explanation," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2021.

Infinite External Deferral: The Sum of Local Explanations Is Not the Completion of Ground

Another route is to accept infinite external deferral. Its merit is that it avoids arbitrarily setting a final layer and avoids prematurely sacralising a single entity. Each local level may be explained by a deeper level, and the world is thereby presented as an open network of dependence, rather than being violently compressed into some arbitrary endpoint. This route, too, is no low-level mistake. It preserves the extensibility of dependence relations and avoids the danger of premature closure.⁹⁷

Yet the cost of infinite external deferral is that the responsibility of explanation is postponed without end. If the conditions by which each layer stands are wholly borrowed from the next layer, then at the level of the whole there is still no real landing. The problem is not whether the chain is long enough, nor whether an infinite sequence is formally possible. The problem is whether, after all local explanations are added together, the qualification of ultimate ground has been completed. If the answer is no, then the infinite chain has only repeated the act of "borrowing the conditions of standing" infinitely many times. To roll a debt forward without end is not to settle the responsibility of explanation.

Therefore, though infinite external deferral may provide local explanations, it cannot directly complete the placement of ground at the level of the whole. That every segment of dependence has a prior explanation does not mean that the whole field of dependence has acquired the qualification of non-externality. So long as the whole still sends the conditions of its own standing toward another unaccounted position, it remains one link within a chain of explanation, not ultimate ground itself.⁹⁸

⁹⁷ The problem of infinite regress and chains of dependence may be understood within the context of grounding and metaphysical dependence; see Fine, "The Question of Realism"; Jonathan Schaffer, "On What Grounds What," in *Metametaphysics*, edited by David Chalmers, David Manley, and Ryan Wasserman, Clarendon Press, 2009, pp. 347-383; Bliss and Trogdon, "Metaphysical Grounding."

⁹⁸ This paragraph only points out the tension between infinite external deferral and the concept of "ultimate ground"; it does not claim that all infinite sequences are formally impossible. For relevant discussion, see Bliss and Trogdon, "Metaphysical Grounding"; Brenner, "Metaphysical Explanation."

[Proposition 4] Brute Fact and infinite external deferral cannot truly account for the standing of existence; ultimate ground must possess some self-standing structure that no longer lends the responsibility of explanation outward.

Self-Establishment: The Lowest Qualification Required of Ultimate Ground

From this the core conclusion of Chapter Two follows: if a certain position is to be called "ultimate ground," it must at least possess the qualification of no longer borrowing the conditions by which it stands from outside itself. The "self-establishment" spoken of here is not an unrestricted strong PSR imposed upon all facts, nor does it claim that every local event must have a complete and transparent reason. It is only a requirement upon a position: whatever is placed in the position of ultimate ground cannot still rely upon some higher external condition in order to stand.⁹⁹

[Proposition 1] If true existence is to serve as ultimate ground, it must at least in principle be capable of self-establishment.

This proposition must still be strictly delimited. Self-establishment is not a logical self-cause (*causa sui*), nor is it the claim that something becomes its own ground within the standard relation of grounding. If it is understood as *U* grounds *U*, it will immediately collide with the irreflexivity and asymmetry usually assumed of grounding relations. What this work calls self-establishment means structural "non-externality": when all dependence relations are considered at the level of the whole, the ultimate field cannot still hand the conditions of its own standing to another external field.¹⁰⁰

Chapter Two has thus completed an eliminative argument, not a final proof. It has not proved that closure necessarily stands, nor has it declared anti-PSR or infinite external deferral impossible in every philosophical context. It has only indicated this: if the conceptual position of "ultimate ground" is still retained, brute fact offers

⁹⁹What is adopted here is the "weak principle of ground-qualification," not an unrestricted strong PSR. Its function is to restrict the positional qualification of ultimate ground, not to require fully transparent reasons for all local facts. For relevant background, see Leibniz, "Monadology," §§31-32; Melamed, "Principle of Sufficient Reason"; Hume, *An Enquiry*, secs. 4-7.

¹⁰⁰Self-establishment is here defined as structural non-externality, not *causa sui* or self-grounding. For the irreflexivity, asymmetry, and dependence grammar of grounding, see Kit Fine, "Guide to Ground," in *Metaphysical Grounding*, edited by Fabrice Correia and Benjamin Schnieder, Cambridge UP, 2012; Gideon Rosen, "Metaphysical Dependence: Grounding and Reduction," in *Modality*, edited by Bob Hale and Aviv Hoffmann, Oxford UP, 2010.

only a stopping point, and infinite external deferral⁺ only prolongs the chain of dependence; neither can positively
 bear the non-external qualification of ultimate ground. From here the next chapter enters the problem of closure: if
 ultimate ground must establish itself, how can the conditions by which it stands be recovered within the whole
 itself?¹⁰¹

¹⁰¹This chapter only completes the eliminative movement from brute fact and infinite external deferral to the “requirement of non-externality.” Closure as a positive candidate form must be defended separately in the next chapter. For background on comparative explanatory power and inference to the best explanation, see Igor Douven, “Abduction,” *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2011; Brenner, “Metaphysical Explanation.”

Part I The Theoretical Core

Chapter Three

Why Self-Establishment Points toward Closure - A Priority Candidate Form of Ultimate Ground

This chapter moves from non-externality toward closure, defining how inward recovery, self-limitation, and return together constitute a priority candidate form of ultimate ground.

Chapter Three Why Self-Establishment Points toward Closure - A Priority Candidate Form of Ultimate Ground

Chapter Two has driven the question to a narrower and stricter position: if ultimate ground still has to hand the conditions by which it stands to another external condition not yet accounted for, it has not yet acquired ultimate qualification. The task of Chapter Three is not to turn this negative conclusion directly into the victory of the Doctrine of Closure, but to explain what kind of structure is more qualified to bear the demand of "no further external borrowing" after brute fact, infinite external deferral, and self-grounding have been excluded. Closure enters here, but at first only as a priority candidate form of ultimate ground, not as the single answer already locked by formal deduction.

Therefore, the point of this chapter is not to keep proclaiming that closure stands. It is to provide closure with a grammar and a set of criteria that can be inspected. It must first exclude two misunderstandings: closure is not a circular fallacy in inference, and it is not the self-grounding that causes difficulty in analytical metaphysics. It must then show that the movement from "non-externality" to "closure" still requires an intermediate argument: if ultimate ground is not merely a static base, it must be able to contain difference, unfold the local, and allow the local to return to the whole. Finally, the chapter must also handle the status of local phenomena, so that the Doctrine of Closure does not degrade the world into illusion.

Under this arrangement, the term "self-establishment" must also be understood in a narrowed sense. It does not mean that something first does not exist in time and then causes itself to exist; nor does it mean that some entity becomes its own ground at the same level. It merely marks the qualification required of ultimate ground: if a whole is called the final ground, it cannot still hand the conditions by which it stands to a deeper, unaccounted external condition. This narrowing preserves the edge of the Doctrine of Closure, while preventing it from being defeated at the outset by traditional criticisms of self-causation or circular argument.

The Grammar of Closure: Field-Sealing, Not Circular Fallacy or Self-Grounding

"Closure" must first be separated from circular fallacy in argument. Circular fallacy occurs at the level of inference: an argument covertly uses the very conclusion it is supposed to establish before that conclusion has been justified. The closure spoken of in this work belongs instead to the level of the structure of existence: the conditions by which a whole stands are finally recovered within itself, no longer borrowed from outside. Their problem-locations are wholly different. The former asks whether reasoning has stolen a step; the latter asks whether the whole of existence has truly landed. If the two are confused, the Doctrine of Closure is refuted too early. If they are not distinguished at all, the word closure retreats into a mere circular image.¹⁰²

This distinction must be taken further. Closure is not mere system-closure either. A living system may maintain its boundary through metabolism; a social system may reproduce itself through communication, institutions, and documentary procedures. Such theories do help us understand forms of "internal operation" and "self-reproduction," but they remain at the level of life, society, or information-systems. What the Doctrine of Closure truly handles is whether ultimate ground can in principle recover the conditions by which it stands, not how a local system maintains its functional boundary. Thus, systems theory can provide only a limited analogy in this chapter; it cannot replace ultimate ontology.¹⁰³

Restated in the grammar of contemporary grounding, closure is likewise not self-grounding. To claim U grounds U - that the same object becomes its own ground within one and the same grounding relation - would directly violate the irreflexivity and asymmetry usually taken by grounding. What this work calls closure is not a single node supporting itself at the same level, but the total boundary of the whole field of standing no longer opening outward. Local nodes may still retain asymmetric dependence: some things depend upon other things, and some levels depend upon deeper levels. Closure requires only that when all relations of standing are lifted to the level of the whole, the ultimate field cannot still hand its own qualification to another unaccounted item outside the field.¹⁰⁴

¹⁰²On the distinction of levels between grounding, metaphysical dependence, and circular argument, see Kit Fine, "Guide to Ground," in *Metaphysical Grounding: Understanding the Structure of Reality*, edited by Fabrice Correia and Benjamin Schnieder, Cambridge UP, 2012; Gideon Rosen, "Metaphysical Dependence: Grounding and Reduction," in *Modality: Metaphysics, Logic, and Epistemology*, edited by Bob Hale and Aviv Hoffmann, Oxford UP, 2010; Ricki Bliss and Kelly Trogon, "Metaphysical Grounding," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2014. The above works are cited here to mark the technical context of "grounding relations" and "circular argument"; this is not to claim that the Doctrine of Closure has been directly supported by those works.

¹⁰³System-closure and self-reproduction are used only as structural analogies, not as proof of ultimate ontology. See Humberto R. Maturana and Francisco J. Varela, *Autopoiesis and Cognition: The Realization of the Living*, D. Reidel, 1980; Niklas Luhmann, *Social Systems*, translated by John Bednarz Jr. and Dirk Baecker, Stanford UP, 1995. The limit of borrowing these theories is this: operational closure in living or social systems is still not the self-establishment of ultimate ground.

¹⁰⁴Here closure is distinguished from self-grounding: closure is not U grounds U, but the total boundary of the whole grounding field no longer externally deferring itself. For the relevant grammatical background, see Fine, "Guide to Ground"; Rosen, "Metaphysical Dependence"; Bliss and Trogon, "Metaphysical Grounding."

"Field-sealing" is therefore the technical core of Chapter Three. It does not cancel the directionality of local grounding relations. It asks whether, after all local directions are taken together, the whole field still leaves an external gap. If there remains a gap, closure is not yet complete; if there is no gap, the whole only then begins to possess the qualification of ultimate ground. The point of this wording is to raise closure from an intuitive image into a structural proposition that can be challenged.

The advantage of this definition is that it preserves the sensitivity of grounding grammar to directions of dependence, while preventing ultimate ground from falling back into infinite external deferral. In other words, closure does not cancel all local dependence, nor does it write the world as an undifferentiated self-identical mass without levels. It requires only that the responsibility of standing at the level of the whole cannot be handed outward forever. The local may depend upon the local; local systems may depend upon larger systems. Yet if all dependence relations, when taken together, still point beyond the whole, the so-called whole has not yet become a true whole.

For this very reason, the Doctrine of Closure need not deny relations of dependence. On the contrary, it acknowledges that the local world is constituted by many relations of dependence: the body depends on material conditions, consciousness depends on local life-forms, and ethical action depends on concrete situations. The question is only whether the totality of these dependence relations remains forever suspended outward. If it does, ultimate ground has not yet appeared. If it does not, closure may then become the form in which the whole stands.

From Non-Externality to Closure: Static Base, Dynamic Unfolding, and Comparative Explanatory Power

Non-externality by itself remains only a negative requirement. It explains that ultimate ground cannot continue to borrow the conditions by which it stands, but it has not yet explained what positive structure should bear this requirement. In theory, there are at least three routes. The first is a static absolute base: the declaration of an undifferentiated, unquestionable, absolute monadic point. The second is self-cause or self-grounding: the claim that something becomes its own ground at the same level. The third is dynamic closure: a whole that can unfold difference within itself and then recover that difference into the whole. The first two routes carry obvious costs. The static base easily retreats into brute fact, while self-grounding is too costly in grammar. Dynamic closure therefore obtains priority for discussion.¹⁰⁵

The difficulty of a static absolute base lies in its inability to bear the unfolding of the world. If ultimate ground is only an undifferentiated "One" without inner structure, then locality, time, consciousness, ethical responsibility, and the experience of suffering can only be taken as illusion, arbitrary emanation, or accessory phenomena lacking inner relation to the ground itself. Such a model may preserve supreme identity, yet it cannot adequately explain why the diverse world is not merely illusion. If true ultimate ground is to bear existence as a whole, it cannot possess only external severance; it must also possess the internal capacity to contain difference, preserve difference, and allow difference to return.

Here the difference between the "static" and the "dynamic" can be seen. A static base says only that something can be questioned no further. Dynamic closure must explain how that which can be questioned no further is not an empty "One," but can bear the differentiation of the local world. If differences in the world are merely illusion, the Doctrine of Closure loses the ability to handle ethics, suffering, and local experience. If difference is wholly independent, the Doctrine of Closure loses wholeness. Therefore difference must be real, but its reality must acquire its place within the whole.

This is also the difference between closure and ordinary holism. Ordinary holism may say that the whole is prior to the parts, or that the parts must be understood through the whole. The Doctrine of Closure asks further: how does this whole itself stand? If the whole is only the name for the sum of all parts, it may still be only an aggregate of larger scope. If the whole is merely an unquestionable base, it may again retreat into brute fact. Closure, as a

¹⁰⁵Priority of the whole and monism provide adjacent problem-fields for this work, but closure is not identical with ordinary priority monism or Spinozist static monism. See Jonathan Schaffer, "Monism: The Priority of the Whole," *Philosophical Review* 119.1 (2010): 31-76; Benedict de Spinoza, *Ethics*, translated by Edwin Curley, Penguin, 1996, pt. 1. The additional demand of this work is that the whole not only be prior to the parts, but also be able to recover the conditions by which it itself stands.

candidate form, requires the whole not only to gather the parts, but also to deal within itself with the responsibility for its own standing.

Thus closure is not formally derived from non-externality. Rather, it gains a stronger position through comparative explanatory power. It adds a positive demand for the qualification of standing beyond brute fact; it handles the suspension of the whole better than infinite external deferral; it preserves local difference better than static monism; and it avoids the direct conflict with the grammar of dependence better than self-grounding. This step must not be written as a necessary theorem. The more exact claim is this: among the currently visible options, closure is the more explanatory candidate model where non-externality, internal difference, and local return must be handled together.¹⁰⁶

A further defence must still be kept here: closure is only a priority candidate, not a final answer immune from criticism. Opponents may still ask how inward recovery is possible, why difference does not break the whole, and why return is not an after-the-fact narrative. These questions cannot be solved by the word "closure" alone. What this chapter can accomplish is to turn closure from an image into a conceptual criterion. Whether these criteria are sufficient to withstand the philosophical, theological, Buddhist, and scientific pressures that follow still has to be tested chapter by chapter.

The defence in this chapter is therefore a layered defence. The first layer shows only that brute fact and infinite external deferral are insufficient to serve as ultimate ground. The second layer indicates that a static base and self-grounding each carry serious costs. Only the third layer proposes dynamic closure as a model of greater explanatory power. This movement does not provide deductive necessity, but it prevents closure from being a merely arbitrary name.

The Three Criteria of Closure: Inward Recovery, Self-Limitation, and Return

If closure is to avoid becoming a graceful metaphor, it must possess definite criteria. The first is inward recovery. The conditions of standing cannot be infinitely handed to the outside, nor can they stop at an unaccounted brute fact; the whole must recover within itself the ground by which it stands. Without inward recovery, closure is only external deferral under another name. The second is self-limitation and difference. The whole cannot be an empty identity that excludes multiplicity; it must make room for local positions, so that limitation, relation, temporality, and subject-position become possible. Without difference, closure degenerates into a dead and silent "One." The

¹⁰⁶The movement from eliminative argument to candidate model belongs to comparative explanatory power and inference to the best explanation, not formal deduction. See Igor Douven, "Abduction," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2011; Andrew Brenner, "Metaphysical Explanation," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2021.

third is return. The unfolding of the local cannot simply scatter away, nor can it form fragments forever unable to return to the whole. The local must, after passing through time, position, and relation, recover its place in the whole. Without return, difference slips into another kind of plural external deferral.¹⁰⁷

[Proposition 3] True existence is not merely one; its persistence can also be understood through a self-limiting whole capable of return.

This proposition marks the boundary between this work and mere identity-monism. If the whole has no difference at all, there is no position; without position, there is no relation; without relation, there is no return; without return, closure cannot be formed. Locality, difference, and limitation are not the fall of existence. They are the conditions by which closure can operate. Through self-limitation, the whole allows internal differentiation; only then can local positions form perspectives, responsibility, suffering, freedom, and paths of return to the whole. Self-limitation is therefore not a gap in closure, but the manner in which closure works.

More precisely, self-limitation is not the whole being forcibly damaged. It is the way in which the whole permits local positions to appear. Only within local positions can existence be read as time, choice, suffering, responsibility, and redemption; and only after passing through these local positions can return be more than abstract identity, becoming instead a reunion after difference has been undergone.

The term "self-limitation" is especially important in this chapter. If the whole does not self-limit, it cannot generate local positions; without local positions, there is no difference, experience, responsibility, or return. Yet if local positions are wholly detached from the whole, difference becomes fragments that cannot be recovered. What closure requires is not the destruction of the local, nor the absolutising of the local, but that the local obtain a finite yet real place within the whole. This is why self-limitation and return must appear together.

This account also preserves the necessary ethical boundary. Finitude and suffering may be understood as structural costs that cannot be wholly cancelled when closure unfolds; but this does not mean that the experience of those who suffer may be silenced by the language of the whole, nor that concrete evil acts may be directly absolved by ontology. The most fundamental ontological level deals only with whether closure can stand; the concrete ethical level must still deal with responsibility, condemnation, repair, and the experience of victims. If the Doctrine of Closure devours local injury under the name of wholeness, it loses the very qualification by which it claims to preserve difference.¹⁰⁸

¹⁰⁷"Inward recovery, self-limitation, and return" are the working criteria of closure in this work: inward recovery handles non-externality, self-limitation handles the possibility of difference, and return handles the non-scattering of the local. This is the author's own conceptual modelling, not the claim that the three criteria derive directly from a single existing source. Their function is to make closure a structural proposition that can be refuted and compared, rather than a mere image.

¹⁰⁸This passage preserves the ethical boundary: finitude and suffering may be analysed as structural matters at the ontological level, but this cannot cancel ethical responsibility or the experience of victims. For relevant background, see Augustine, *The City of God against the Pagans*,

The three criteria also provide negative tests for the concept of closure. If a whole still requires external conditions to complete its ground, it is not closure. If a whole annihilates all difference, leaving only contentless identity, it is not closure. If a whole allows localities to scatter arbitrarily and makes return impossible, it is likewise not closure.

These negative criteria prevent closure from meaning anything that merely "looks complete"; they make it a selective structure of ultimate qualification.

Return especially must not be understood as an after-the-fact narrative. If the local first splits arbitrarily and is then recovered by the author through grand language, closure becomes rhetoric rather than ontological structure. True return must mean that the local has had its place within the whole field from the beginning. Even if it passes through concealment, separation, or misrecognition in time, it has never wholly departed from the order by which the whole stands.

Logic, Causality, and "Appearance": The Real Status of Local Manifestation

Closure must also handle another common misunderstanding: it is not causal reversal within physical time, nor is it the universe bending into a closed circle in time. The levels of ontology must be distinguished. Causal law describes how the universe operates in time; logical law describes what can stand in principle. Logic is not an external authority pressing upon ultimate ground from without, but the condition of self-consistency that ultimate ground itself must satisfy. What is self-contradictory cannot close and cannot stand. Therefore, the final guarantee of closure is not merely physical causality, but logical self-consistency and the inward recovery of the conditions of standing.¹⁰⁹

This distinction of levels also shows that closure may be divided into three levels. Logical closure means that the propositional structure contains no internal contradiction; it is a necessary condition. Causal closure means that the conditions by which the whole of existence stands are no longer borrowed from outside; this is the core of the qualification of ultimate ground. Self-evident closure then raises, upon causal closure, the further problem of primordial presence: the First Consciousness to be discussed in the next chapter. Chapter Three completes only the principal laying out of the first two levels. It makes closure no longer a circular image, but a criterion of qualification for ultimate ground. Whether closure must also possess primordial self-evidence remains for Chapter Four.¹¹⁰

translated by R. W. Dyson, Cambridge UP, 1998, bks. 11-12; John Hick, *Evil and the God of Love*, 2nd ed., Harper and Row, 1978; Elaine Scarry, *The Body in Pain: The Making and Unmaking of the World*, Oxford UP, 1985.

¹⁰⁹This paragraph gives a conceptual distinction of levels: causal law belongs to the operational order within time, while logical self-consistency belongs to the conditions of standing in-principle. The distinction is meant to prevent closure from being misunderstood as causal reversal within physical time. It also limits the Doctrine of Closure from turning any physical model directly into metaphysical proof.

¹¹⁰Self-evident closure will move in Chapter Four into the problem of First Consciousness. For background in philosophy of consciousness and cosmopsychism, see Thomas Nagel, "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?," *Philosophical Review* 83.4 (1974): 435-450; David J. Chalmers, *The Conscious Mind*, Oxford UP, 1996; Philip Goff, *Consciousness and Fundamental Reality*, Oxford UP, 2017; Itay Shani, "Cosmopsychism,"

Within this framework, the status of what is not closure is not "false existence," but "appearance." Whatever local thing cannot independently recover the conditions by which it stands may be understood as the borrowed manifestation of the whole at a local position. Flowers, persons, planets, institutions, and experiences of pain are not pure illusion. They truly occur at the local level, and they possess weight at the ethical and experiential levels. Yet they do not possess ultimate self-standing qualification, and so they cannot become completed existence.¹¹¹

To be "lowered to appearance" here is not denigration, but placement. The reality of local things comes from their manifestation and operation within the whole; their non-ultimacy comes from the fact that they cannot by themselves recover the conditions by which they stand. If only reality is stressed, the local is mistaken for a self-subsisting entity; if only non-ultimacy is stressed, the local is mistaken for nothingness or illusion. The Doctrine of Closure must avoid both extremes at once.

The word "appearance" here is a cross-traditional term of translation. It does not directly import the original semantic field of Buddhist texts into the Doctrine of Closure. This work borrows it in order to mark the double status of local phenomena: they are real, because they manifest within the whole and generate experience, responsibility, and relation; they are non-ultimate, because the conditions by which they stand cannot be wholly recovered by themselves. This placement prevents the phenomenal world from being voided, and also prevents local entities from being absolutised. The local is not illusion; the local is the place where closure unfolds and returns to itself.

This placement also leaves room for later ethical argument and religious translation. If the local were mere illusion, suffering, guilt, repentance, and redemption would lose their weight. If the local were ultimate entity, closure of the whole would have no way to stand. To understand the local as real yet borrowed "appearance" makes it possible to preserve both the weight of experience and the stratification of ontology.

Here, "appearance" and "self-limitation" in fact sustain one another. Self-limitation explains why the whole permits the local to appear; appearance explains how the local, once it appears, should be placed ontologically. If self-limitation is discussed without appearance, local position lacks a clear status. If appearance is discussed without self-limitation, the local seems merely a surface phenomenon accidentally attached to the whole. Only together do the two allow the Doctrine of Closure to handle both priority of the whole and reality of the local.

This also limits the force with which the Doctrine of Closure may speak. Since local phenomena are real appearances, later discussions of destiny, freedom, suffering, evil, and redemption cannot simply dissolve local

Philosophical Papers 44.3 (2015): 389-437.

¹¹¹In this work, "appearance" is a cross-traditional term of translation that refers to the borrowed manifestation of local phenomena. It is not identical with the full doctrinal context of "emptiness," "non-self-nature," or "delusion" in Buddhist source-texts. Buddhist materials in this work mainly serve comparison, pressure, and semantic boundary-setting; the term is borrowed here only to mark the double status of the local as real yet not ultimately self-standing.

experience into a completed narrative of perfection. If closure is to stand, it must preserve the weight of the local, not cancel it in the name of the whole; otherwise "return" becomes annexation and contradicts the structure of self-limitation defined in this chapter.

What closure finally points toward, then, is not the image of a head and tail meeting, but the fact that existence no longer scatters, no longer hangs suspended, no longer borrows outward, and returns in its unfolding to itself as "being." Time may be understood as the internal mode of reading this unfolding process, rather than as an external container prior to the whole of existence in which closure then moves. If this is so, the unfolding of the universe is not an outward escape opposed to closure, but the very process by which closure becomes closure.

This chapter has thus completed the conceptual transition from non-externality to closure. Chapter Two excluded brute fact and infinite external deferral as sufficient forms of ultimate ground; this chapter has further explained that if ultimate ground must both cease external borrowing and contain difference while preserving the local, then dynamic closure capable of inward recovery, self-limitation, and return becomes the candidate structure with greater explanatory power. The next chapter will push the question to a sharper point: if closure is not a dead structure, does it require some kind of primordial presence; and if so, in what sense should First Consciousness be proposed?

Part I The Theoretical Core

Chapter Four

Why Ultimate Ground Cannot Be Mere Dead Structure - First Consciousness and Primordial Self-Evidence

This chapter asks whether ultimate ground
can be nothing more than dead structure, and
defines First Consciousness as the high-risk
candidate of primordial presence.

Chapter Four Why Ultimate Ground Cannot Be Mere Dead Structure - First Consciousness and Primordial Self-Evidence

From Closure to First Consciousness: The Problem of Dead Structure

Chapter Three has defined closure as a priority candidate form of ultimate ground: true ultimate existence cannot borrow without end the conditions by which it stands, nor can it arbitrarily halt at brute fact, but must complete inward recovery of conditions, preservation of difference, and local return within the whole. This definition gives the Doctrine of Closure its first ontological qualification. Yet structural closure alone is still insufficient to complete the central claim of the whole work. For a structure may be highly coherent, wholly closed, and stable in its laws, while still remaining a blindly operating dead structure. It may explain how the universe continues, yet not explain how existence, at the most fundamental level, presents itself as "being."

This chapter therefore raises the fourth core question: if ultimate ground is only a structure of logical coherence, causal closure, and inward recovery of conditions, is it already sufficient to bear the qualification of ultimate existence? In other words, if closure is merely a structural diagram describable by an external observer, and contains no primordial presence, what essential difference remains between it and a perfect but blind mechanism? This is not a psychological question, nor is it an attempt to project human consciousness directly onto the cosmic whole. It asks rather: if ultimate ground is to be truly self-establishing, can it be described only as structure, or must it also in some way have a primordial presentation of itself as "being"?

[Proposition 5] If ultimate ground is wholly without self-knowing, it remains dead structure, and cannot yet count as truly self-existent.

One further point must be placed at the beginning of the chapter. The "dead structure" spoken of here is not a term of abuse, but a strict theoretical option. Its core is not crude materialism, but the understanding of ultimate ground as a closed order without subjecthood, without self-knowing, and without primordial presence. Such an order may have laws, structure, evolution, complexity, and may even generate highly intelligent life at the local level; yet it is not in any manner present to itself as being. What the Doctrine of Closure truly questions is precisely this: if

ultimate ground itself has no presence at all, must local presence be treated only as an accessory phenomenon appearing later by chance? If so, the suffering of local subjects, the pursuit of truth, ethical responsibility, and religious experience are all postponed until after ultimate ground has already been conceived.

For this reason, the movement of Chapter Four differs from that of Chapters Two and Three. Chapter Two established non-externality by excluding brute fact and infinite external deferral; Chapter Three, through inward recovery, self-limitation, and return, established closure as a priority candidate form. Chapter Four must handle a deeper change of kind: from the question "can structure establish itself" to the question "does self-establishment require primordial presence?" This step cannot be automatically drawn from the previous three chapters, nor can it be passed over with the simple phrase "dead structure is insufficient." It must be joined, one by one, to philosophy of mind, cosmopsychism, theological boundaries, and ethical problems. Otherwise First Consciousness will look like a conclusion forced onto the system from outside.

This proposition is the entrance to Chapter Four. It does not say that every existent must possess consciousness in the psychological sense; nor does it say that the universe is a gigantic mind resembling the human mind. It points only to this: if ultimate ground is wholly without presence, self-access, and self-evidence, then what is called "self-establishment" remains only the description of it by an external reason. Existence is said to stand, but it does not present itself within itself as standing; closure is drawn as complete, yet does not appear as existence returning to itself. This is the fundamental limit of the dead-structure model.

Here the relation to Spinozist monism must be clearly marked. The Doctrine of Closure and Spinoza's "God or Nature" do have similarities: both refuse to understand God as another highest object outside the universe, and both refuse to treat finite things as ultimate units wholly subsisting in themselves. Yet the Doctrine of Closure must preserve one difference: if God or Nature is only an impersonal necessary structure, it may explain the necessary order of the world, but not necessarily explain how existence presents itself to itself. What this work calls First Consciousness is not another conscious being outside the world, but the primordial presence of ultimate ground as it returns within itself.¹¹²

The task of this chapter, then, is not to rewrite the Doctrine of Closure as popular teleology, nor to use philosophy of mind to prove directly that the universe is conscious. Its task is more exact: first to present fairly the strongest version of the dead-structure model; then to show how first-person presence, value-experience, the pursuit of truth, and local return place explanatory pressure upon dead structure; and then to divide First Consciousness into minimal, intermediate, and strong versions, explaining respectively which claims form the lowest defensible line.

¹¹²Spinoza's monism and priority of the whole may serve as adjacent backgrounds, but this work does not reduce First Consciousness to an impersonal necessary substance. See Spinoza, *Ethics*; Schaffer, "Monism: The Priority of the Whole," *Philosophical Review* 119.1 (2010): 31-76.

which belong to metaphysical hypotheses with higher comparative explanatory power, and which are the Doctrine of Closure's own most edged, most risky original extensions.

This arrangement also avoids two opposite errors. The first error is to write First Consciousness directly as a completed theological conclusion, as if once closure stands, the God, revelation, personhood, redemption, and historical action of Christianity have all been proved. That would make Chapter Four overstep its office and immediately invite a Barthian critique of natural theology. The second error, adopted in order to avoid theological usurpation, is to grind First Consciousness down into a vague metaphor, leaving only such phrases as "the whole seems to have a certain direction." The former is too fast; the latter too weak. This chapter must walk the harder middle path: while strictly acknowledging the limits of the argument, it must preserve First Consciousness as a strong thesis at the core of ultimate ground.¹¹³

The academic defense of Chapter Four is therefore not retreat but preservation of strength. A theory with real force does not evade all objections; it can state the level on which each objection falls. Physicalism mainly presses on the minimal version, questioning whether presence is needed at all. Cosmopsychism and the de-combination problem press on the intermediate version, asking how whole and local are related. Theology and Madhyamaka press on the strong version, questioning whether First Consciousness has been substantialized or theologized. If these three pressures are not distinguished, Chapter Four falls into over-defense; once distinguished, they become the order of argument itself.

¹¹³This chapter here distinguishes three levels: ontology, philosophy of religion, and revelatory theology. First Consciousness may serve as an entrance to philosophical theology, but it is not identical with a complete doctrine of God in orthodox theology.

The Strongest Version of the Dead-Structure Model: Physicalism, Emergentism, and Illusionism

First Consciousness cannot be established by attacking a simplified opponent. The dead-structure model has its strong version, and that version must first be presented fairly. On this route, the cosmic whole may be a logically coherent, physically closed, lawfully stable structure without subjecthood; local consciousness may then arise gradually from biological evolution, neural organization, information processing, embodied environmental interaction, and the emergent conditions of complex systems. Ultimate ground does not need to possess any primordial presence in advance. It need only provide sufficient structural conditions under which local consciousness can appear later in natural history. The advantage of this route is restraint, clarity, and a smaller metaphysical burden; it also avoids rashly amplifying human subjective experience into a cosmic principle.¹¹⁴

Physicalism supplies the first pressure here. It may maintain that the basic image of the world should be determined by physical facts, physical laws, and their relations of composition. Consciousness may be difficult, but it should still be handled within the structure of the natural world rather than elevated into an attribute of ultimate ground. This claim should not be lightly treated as low-level reductionism. On the contrary, it reminds the Doctrine of Closure that if First Consciousness is inserted into ontology merely because human consciousness is astonishing, it becomes psychological projection. The Doctrine of Closure cannot directly rewrite "human beings are conscious" into "the ground of the universe is conscious." That inference is too quick and cannot bear the academic weight required by this chapter.

Emergentism supplies the second pressure. An objector may say that local consciousness need not have any antecedent place in the root layer of the universe; it may naturally arise once a system reaches a sufficiently complex level of organization. Nervous systems, bodily feedback, environmental regulation, memory, prediction, symbols, and social interaction may all become conditions for the formation of consciousness. If so, First Consciousness seems unnecessary: we need only explain how local life, under particular historical conditions, gives rise to subjective experience, without placing presence within ultimate ground. This objection is highly important for the Doctrine of Closure, because it requires the theory to show that it is not "using metaphysics to replace research that science has not yet completed."¹¹⁵

Illusionism forms the third pressure, and the most direct gatekeeper. Illusionists such as Keith Frankish do not merely say that phenomenal consciousness has not yet been explained; they more radically deny the status of

¹¹⁴For general background on physicalism, see Stoljar, "Physicalism," The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy. This work treats physicalism only as pressure from the strong version of the dead-structure model, and does not reduce it to a single simplified position.

¹¹⁵On emergentism, see O'Connor, "Emergent Properties," The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy. This passage acknowledges that emergentism has explanatory power for the formation of local consciousness, but this does not mean that it has solved the question of ultimate-ground qualification.

phenomenal consciousness as a basic ontological fact. They maintain that what is called "there being something it is like" may itself be an illusion produced by a cognitive system. The philosophical task is not to acknowledge a phenomenal-consciousness entity that is hard to place, but to explain why a system steadily takes itself to have this sort of phenomenality. This strategy has considerable theoretical appeal, because it sharply lowers ontological commitment and avoids turning a difficulty into a new entity.¹¹⁶

Physicalism and emergentism also share a further advantage: they protect philosophy from resorting too quickly to metaphysical entities. When a theory faces an unresolved problem, its most dangerous move is immediately to name the unknown place as the highest being. The Doctrine of Closure must avoid this mistake. First Consciousness cannot mean simply, "we do not yet understand consciousness, therefore we put consciousness into the ground." It must have a stronger reason than filling a gap. That reason lies not in the incompleteness of science, but in the qualification of ultimate ground itself: if all conditions of standing are recovered within the whole, and local presence also actually appears within that whole, then whether ultimate ground may be understood as wholly without presence becomes a metaphysical question, not merely a scientific blank.

In other words, this chapter does not begin from a gap in knowledge, but from ontological consistency. The more science can explain the formation of local consciousness, the more the Doctrine of Closure must acknowledge those local explanations. Yet the more successful those local explanations become, the clearer another question also becomes: in what kind of whole-ground do these local explanations occur? If all local presence is assigned to later complexity while the ground itself is still defined as wholly without presence, the theory leaves a rupture between ground and local. The Doctrine of Closure proposes First Consciousness not to cancel local scientific explanation, but to prevent ultimate ground and local presence from being wholly severed from one another.

The Doctrine of Closure must acknowledge the force of all three routes. Physicalism preserves the closure of the natural world; emergentism provides historical and structural conditions for the formation of local consciousness; illusionism compels us not to treat first-person experience directly as an unanalyzable ontological fact. If the Doctrine of Closure cannot fairly acknowledge these strengths, Chapter Four would become a crude denial of the dead-structure model. Yet acknowledging these strengths does not mean accepting that the dead-structure model has already completed the explanation of ultimate ground. On the contrary, the stronger these routes are, the sharper the problem they leave behind becomes: even if we can describe functions, behaviors, neural correlates, and cognitive mechanisms, have we thereby explained why existence has presence within itself?

¹¹⁶Keith Frankish, "Illusionism as a Theory of Consciousness," *Journal of Consciousness Studies* 23.11-12 (2016): 11-39. Illusionism here serves as a strong opponent, and is not simplified by this work into a low-level denial.

Illusionism in particular cannot be simply defeated; but neither can it win at low cost. Even if it successfully rejects "phenomenal consciousness" as a basic entity, it must still explain why the structure of "seeming to have experience" is so stable, pervasive, and difficult to cancel. Suffering, responsibility, truth-seeking, love, and self-reflection, even when explained as products of cognitive systems, still constitute the basic field in which local subjects understand themselves and the world. Illusionism can transform the problem from "how does phenomenal consciousness exist" into "why does the subject steadily understand itself in the mode of phenomenal consciousness," but this does not make the dead-structure model a zero-cost account. It merely moves the explanatory debt elsewhere.

Here it is especially necessary to distinguish two levels: "can be naturalized" and "has been discharged." The dead-structure model may perhaps return suffering, attention, judgement, reflection, and self-report one by one to functional networks. Yet the functional network itself still operates in a third-person manner. When a subject says, "I am in pain," this utterance is not merely muscular reaction or informational output; it also opens the world as the immediate field of a certain local position. If the objector says that this immediacy is only an illusion, the Doctrine of Closure can accept that this is one possible direction, but it can still ask: why would a ground wholly without presence steadily produce so unavoidable an illusion of presence? If illusion itself becomes a basic form of world-experience, it cannot be treated as mere noise.¹¹⁷

For precisely this reason, the chapter does not treat physicalism, emergentism, or illusionism as enemies to be removed at once. It treats them as stress tests for First Consciousness. If they can fully explain first-person presence, the strong version of First Consciousness must naturally be downgraded. If they can explain only function and behavior, but not the stable form of "feeling" or "seeming to feel," then the minimal version of First Consciousness still has an entrance.

Therefore this chapter does not portray the dead-structure model as absurd. More strictly, the dead-structure model can be a strong model of the universe's internal operation, but it may not be sufficient as a complete model of ultimate ground. It explains how the world operates, how local systems form, and how cognitive functions unfold. But the Doctrine of Closure asks whether ultimate ground, if it is to be self-establishing, can be presupposed as wholly without presence. So long as first-person presence, value-experience, and self-return have not been absorbed without remainder into a purely third-person description, the minimal version of First Consciousness still retains room for discussion.

¹¹⁷The problem of "seeming to have experience" here is a minimal pressure upon illusionism, not a decisive refutation of it.

The Explanatory Debt of First-Person Presence: Nagel, Levine, Chalmers, and the Problem of Intelligibility

What the dead-structure model finds hardest to handle is not whether the universe has laws, nor whether local life has functions, but first-person presence. Thomas Nagel famously pointed out that conscious life has a subjective aspect of "what it is like" for itself; this subjectivity is not identical with externally observable behavior, function, or neural structure. Joseph Levine then marked the distance between physical description and qualitative experience with the "explanatory gap"; David J. Chalmers, through the hard problem and the zombie argument, made the question whether third-person completeness can entail phenomenal facts into an enduring controversy.¹¹⁸

These arguments must not be overused. They do not directly entail First Consciousness, nor do they prove that the cosmic whole is a subject. Their function is first negative: they show that a purely third-person dead-structure model still bears an undischarged explanatory debt before first-person experience. If the world is only a set of blind structures, why do there arise presence-experiences such as "pain feels like pain," "truth-seeking feels as if truth demands it," and "love is not merely a behavioral strategy"? If the objector says that these are only functions and behaviors, the question immediately returns: how are function and behavior identical with "having feeling" itself?

The Doctrine of Closure does not here ask the reader to accept a full cosmic mind. It asks only that first-person presence not be treated as a problem wholly removable by the phrase "the structure is very complex." Complexity can explain many high-level behaviors; it can also explain information integration, predictive models, feedback regulation, and symbolic operation. Yet what first-person presence includes is the quality by which the world is "presented" to a position. This presentedness has special significance in the Doctrine of Closure, because closure is not mere physical closure, but the structure in which existence returns to itself within the whole. If a local position can experience, judge, misrecognize, repent, and return, then a theory of ultimate ground cannot simply avoid the problem of presence.

There is also a weaker but important auxiliary line here: the intelligibility of the world. The universe does not merely exist; to a certain degree it can be repeatedly read by local consciousness through mathematics, logic, theory, and value-language. This does not prove that the universe is conscious, nor does mathematical intelligibility directly entail God. The steadier formulation is this: if local consciousness can continually read the structure of the world and raise within it questions about truth, ground, purpose, and whole, then the wholly blind

¹¹⁸Thomas Nagel, "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?," *Philosophical Review* 83.4 (1974): 435-450; Joseph Levine, "Materialism and Qualia: The Explanatory Gap," *Pacific Philosophical Quarterly* 64.4 (1983): 354-361; David J. Chalmers, *The Conscious Mind: In Search of a Fundamental Theory*, Oxford UP, 1996.

dead-structure model takes on additional explanatory pressure. It must explain why a ground utterly without presence, self-evidence, or inner answerability would produce local consciousness capable of questioning the whole ground.¹¹⁹

This problem also concerns the special status of the pursuit of truth. If local consciousness is merely a survival machine, it can certainly form effective strategies. But human reason does not only ask how to survive; it also asks whether a theory is true, coherent, and able to bear objections. This orientation toward truth beyond survival-utility makes first-person presence not merely a problem of feeling, but also a problem of reason. The Doctrine of Closure does not say that reason necessarily proves First Consciousness. It only points out that if local reason can inquire into ultimate ground and seek non-local validity in logic, mathematics, metaphysics, and ethics, then its relation to the whole should not be reduced to accidental adaptation.

Likewise, value-experience must not be simplified too quickly. Objectors may explain value-judgement as evolutionary strategy, social norm, or affective response; these explanations have force at the local level. Yet when a subject experiences "this ought not to be," "this is evil," "truth is worth seeking," or "the other must not be silenced," value-experience shows that local consciousness is not only an internal reactor within the world, but is able, from its finite position, to touch demands exceeding itself. The intermediate version of First Consciousness seeks precisely to place this kind of presence and value-demand back into the whole, rather than letting them become only linguistic by-products produced late by blind structure.

Local first-person experience may be divided into four problems. First is the problem of feeling: pain, fear, hope, shame, comfort, and joy are not merely behavioral outputs, nor merely external descriptions of neural states. Second is the problem of directedness: consciousness is always in some manner directed toward the world, another, or itself; it is not shut inside pure internal signals. Third is the problem of value: local consciousness does not merely record events, but also judges good and evil, ought and ought-not, worthy and unworthy. Fourth is the problem of return: local consciousness can ask about its relation to the whole and place its finite position back within the question of ultimate ground.

The dead-structure model can respond to each point. It may say that feeling is neural state, directedness is representational function, value is the result of evolution and social selection, and return is a higher-order reflective ability. The Doctrine of Closure does not deny that such answers may be effective, nor does it use "there remains an unresolved problem" as a shortcut to the direct proof of First Consciousness. It only points out that even if these answers stand at the local level, they mainly explain the formation of functions within closure; they

¹¹⁹Intelligibility here serves only as an auxiliary motive; it is insufficient by itself to prove First Consciousness. This work proceeds by comparative explanatory power rather than deductive proof; see Douven, "Abduction," *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*.

have not yet replaced the problem of ultimate-ground qualification. If ultimate ground is wholly without presence, how is local presence not an abrupt exception? If all presence is only a late by-product, then the relation between existence itself and presence is still deferred.

This is the minimum reason for the entrance of First Consciousness. It is not a cosmic mind directly enlarged from local minds, but a response to the explanatory debt of the dead-structure model: if ultimate ground is to be truly self-establishing, it should not be presupposed as a blind structure wholly without presence. The minimal version of First Consciousness gains its place here. It is not yet the theological claim of the strong version, nor a complete cosmopsychism. It says only this: if closure is to be existence's own return, and not merely a closed figure drawn by external reason, then room must be left for primordial presence.

This minimum reason may also be strengthened by the word "return" itself. If a local subject is merely an information-node accidentally appearing in the world, it can of course be regarded as a complex product of natural history. But when a local subject can ask about the whole ground, reflect on its own finitude, acknowledge the misrecognition of its own position, and place itself back within the whole, it is no longer merely a passive product, but the site where closure reads itself back. This is not to sacralize human reason, but to point out that local consciousness's capacity to raise the question of ultimate ground is itself an especially difficult fact for the dead-structure model to externalize. Existence is not merely observed; in certain positions, it begins to question itself.¹²⁰

¹²⁰The capacity of local consciousness to ask about the whole ground functions in this work only as metaphysical pressure, not as empirical evidence directly proving cosmic First Consciousness.

The Threefold Defense of First Consciousness: Minimal, Intermediate, and Strong Versions

These three levels may also correspond to three kinds of reader. For a highly naturalistic reader, the entrance is the minimal version: it requires only the acknowledgement that the dead-structure model still has to handle first-person presence; it does not require the acknowledgement of God. For a metaphysical reader, the intermediate version is central: it links presence, closure, and the qualification of ultimate ground. For a reader willing to enter philosophy of religion, the strong version is the one that truly opens the language of God, love, purpose, redemption, and liberation. Without such stratification, the same paragraph would have to bear the demands of all three readers at once, and the result could only be repeated defense. Once stratified, an objector can state clearly which level he rejects, and the author can respond precisely without explaining the whole theory from the beginning each time.

Here it is especially necessary not to understand the three levels as the author's hesitation. On the contrary, they are the protective device of a strong thesis. Without the minimal version, the strong version is easily charged with rootless declaration. Without the intermediate version, the strong version lacks a bridge to the structure of closure. Without the strong version, First Consciousness is left only with its lowest line of defense and cannot support the later discussion of God, love, and redemption. The three levels sustain one another: the minimal version guards the entrance to the problem, the intermediate version builds the ontological bridge, and the strong version preserves theoretical creativity.

To avoid overloading First Consciousness, this chapter divides it into three levels: minimal, intermediate, and strong. These three levels are not three mutually competing theories, but the defensive strengths of the same core claim under different pressures of criticism. This stratification is important. If First Consciousness is written from the outset as a complete theological personhood, an objector need only point out its lack of deductive proof in order to attack the whole chapter. If, in order to avoid risk, First Consciousness is lowered into a vague metaphor, the Doctrine of Closure retreats into impersonal structural monism. The purpose of the threefold defense is to give the argument places to retreat, adjust, and receive criticism, without weakening the strong thesis itself.

The minimal version claims only one thing: ultimate ground should not be presupposed as a dead structure wholly without presence. This version does not require the reader to acknowledge that the universe is a personal subject, nor to accept cosmopsychism, nor to grant that will, purpose, and broad love have already been justified. It merely points out that if first-person experience, value-judgement, suffering-consciousness, truth-seeking, and self-reflection have already appeared in the world, then a wholly non-present ground-model must explain how these

phenomena enter the picture of existence. This version has the lowest defensive cost and is the firmest first threshold of Chapter Four.

In addition, the argument for First Consciousness in Chapter Four must avoid another oversimplification: understanding "presence" as mere subjective feeling. Primordial presence is not emotion, sensation, or private introspection; it is the minimum presentation of existence to itself as being. A local subject can experience presence through sensation, language, memory, and reflection, but the primordial presence of ultimate ground is not identical with these local forms. If First Consciousness is understood as a cosmic psyche with a stream of contents, it is reduced instead into a giant local subject. First Consciousness in this work must remain at the level of ground: it is not consciousness of some object, but the self-evidence of existence as being.

This distinction also answers crude questions such as "does the universe think?" The Doctrine of Closure does not claim that the universe thinks as a person thinks; nor does it claim that the universe has nervous-system-like information processing. It claims rather that if ultimate ground cannot be merely blind structure, it must at least have a kind of primordial presence that does not depend upon an external observer. Local thinking, local feeling, and local language are low-resolution expressions of this presence in finite positions. They cannot be directly identified with First Consciousness, but they may function as problem-pressures compelling us to reconsider whether ultimate ground can be wholly stripped of presence.

The intermediate version goes one step further. It maintains that if ultimate ground is to be truly self-establishing, it must not only possess inward recovery of conditions, but must also in some manner present itself to itself as "being." What is here called primordial self-evidence is not self-consciousness in the psychological sense, nor an enlargement of human consciousness. It means that existence, at the most fundamental level, is not only described from outside as standing, but possesses within itself a presence that cannot be wholly externalized. If closure is only a closed figure drawn for the world by an external observer, it remains at the level of description. If closure itself contains primordial self-evidence, it becomes more like the return of existence itself.

The strong version preserves the central edge of the Doctrine of Closure: First Consciousness has will, purpose, a tendency toward abiding, self-understanding, and broad love. Without careful qualification, these words are easily misread as personifying myth; yet if they are removed altogether, the Doctrine of Closure loses one of its most creative parts. The strong version must therefore be carefully calibrated. Will is not arbitrary desire at the psychological level, but the primordial orientation of existence toward abiding, non-collapse, and non-abandonment of itself to non-being. Purpose is not a script arranged in advance by an external designer, but the self-understanding achieved by the whole through local unfolding and return. Broad love is not an emotional

preference, but the non-exclusionary affirmation of the whole toward itself and toward the localities contained within it.

The threefold defense also handles the theoretical risk of the Doctrine of Closure. If physicalism or emergentism can fully explain first-person presence, the strong version may be forced to downgrade, but the minimal version may still remain as a problem-consciousness toward the dead-structure model. If the objector rejects primordial self-evidence, the intermediate version comes under pressure, but the Doctrine of Closure can still return to the question whether ultimate ground requires non-externality. If theological criticism shows that First Consciousness cannot be identified with the God of free revelation, the strong version must be limited to philosophy of religion and philosophical theology, and cannot serve directly as a doctrinal conclusion. In this way, First Consciousness is neither an uncriticizable declaration nor a removable ornament.

[Proposition 11] Once primordial self-evidence stands, it contains self-maintenance; and if true self-maintenance leaves no external remainder, it must inwardly gather into closure.

One easily neglected difference of level must be added here: First Consciousness is not "content of consciousness," but "condition of presence." Contents of consciousness include seeing something, feeling pain, understanding a proposition, making a judgement, and forming a memory. These are concrete activities of local consciousness in time. First Consciousness is not the sum of those activities, nor the highest content of consciousness. It means this: if existence is to establish itself at the most fundamental level, it cannot merely be described by some external observer as a set of facts; it must possess within itself an ontological condition that may be called primordial presence. Without this distinction, First Consciousness is easily misread as a cosmic-scale psychological activity, as if the universe were thinking, planning, or feeling. That is not the claim of this work.

The intermediate version of First Consciousness can therefore be stated more precisely: it does not say that the cosmic whole has the same psychological life as human beings; it says that ultimate ground cannot be only a describable structure without presence. Local consciousness matters not because it directly proves whole-consciousness, but because it shows that forms of presence not reducible to pure external description have already appeared within existence. If such forms of presence are wholly excluded from ultimate ground, the theory must bear an additional burden: it must explain why ultimate ground itself is wholly without presence while local presence nevertheless arises within it. The Doctrine of Closure holds that to preserve primordial presence at the

level of the whole has, at least in comparative explanatory power, greater integrative capacity than a wholly dead structure.¹²¹

Proposition 11 must also be read more finely here. It does not say that every conscious being is necessarily closed, nor that any experience of self-evidence can entail ultimate ground. It is valid only at the ultimate level: if primordial self-evidence is placed in the position of ultimate ground, it cannot be a momentary appearing; otherwise it would still depend upon some external condition that makes it appear and endure. If primordial self-evidence is truly to belong to ultimate ground, it must include self-maintenance. If self-maintenance still hands its own standing and continuation to external conditions, it has not completed ultimate qualification. Thus self-maintenance and non-externality together return First Consciousness to closure. This chain connects First Consciousness to the argument for closure in the preceding chapters, rather than opening a separate philosophy of mind.

This proposition explains the internal relation between First Consciousness and closure. If primordial self-evidence were only a transient flash, it would not be sufficient to become ultimate ground. If it possessed self-maintenance but still required external conditions in order to maintain itself, it would again fail to be truly self-establishing. Therefore, once primordial self-evidence is placed at the level of ultimate ground, it must tend toward self-maintenance; and if self-maintenance is not to borrow outward, it must return to closure. This inference is not a pure deductive theorem, but it binds First Consciousness, abiding, and inward recovery of closure into the same chain of propositions, so that First Consciousness is no longer an independently added mental concept.

This also explains why First Consciousness is not a hypothesis about the origin of consciousness. It does not first answer "how does human consciousness arise from the nervous system?" It answers rather: "if ultimate ground is to be truly self-establishing, can it be understood as wholly without presence?" Human consciousness, value-experience, and religious experience function in this chapter only as fields of pressure, not as direct evidence. The central place of First Consciousness lies in this: it transforms closure from a closed structure externally described into the primordial return of existence itself.

The three-level structure also prevents this chapter from becoming a case in which "one blow collapses the whole." If an objector does not accept the strong version of will, purpose, and broad love, he must still face the intermediate version: does ultimate ground require primordial presence? If the objector rejects even the intermediate version, he must still face the minimal version: does the dead-structure model have enough capacity,

¹²¹The primordial presence spoken of here remains a metaphysical hypothesis at the level of comparative explanatory power; it is not a deductive conclusion from local consciousness to cosmic consciousness.

to handle first-person presence? If even the minimal version is successfully dissolved, First Consciousness must of course be downgraded; yet the Doctrine of Closure can still return to the qualification of ultimate ground established in the first three chapters. First Consciousness is therefore the core extension of the whole work, but not its only support. This layered arrangement lets the theory preserve ambition without collapsing wholly under a single objection.

Conversely, the three-level structure also prevents the theory from weakening itself too early. If only the minimal version is retained, the Doctrine of Closure becomes a cautious but dull anti-dead-structure theory. If only the intermediate version is retained, it remains insufficient to support the later language of God, love, redemption, and local return. Although the strong version carries the highest risk, it is precisely the inner basis by which the Doctrine of Closure can enter philosophy of religion and philosophical theology. The strategy of this chapter is therefore not to abandon the strong version, but to place it where it can be clearly criticized.

Cosmopsychism, the De-Combination Problem, and the Self-Limitation of Closure

The strong version of First Consciousness is most easily read as a variant of panpsychism or cosmopsychism, and this reading has reason. Panpsychism resists treating consciousness as a late accidental product of the world, and tries to place experientiality at a more basic level. Cosmopsychism goes further, treating the cosmic whole as the primordial subject in order to avoid the combination problem faced by micro-level panpsychism. These routes stand adjacent to the Doctrine of Closure, because they likewise are not satisfied with a purely dead-structure image and likewise attempt to handle the problem of consciousness at the level of the whole.¹²²

Yet the Doctrine of Closure cannot be simply reduced to panpsychism. It does not claim that every local object, every particle of matter, or every natural unit has its own mentality, nor does it need to bear the combination problem of how micro-consciousnesses form macro-consciousness. The starting point of the Doctrine of Closure is not "all things have mind," but "if ultimate ground is to be self-establishing, can it be wholly without presence?" The problem of consciousness is raised after the qualification of ultimate ground, not set at the beginning of the theory as a basic property of all things.

Cosmopsychism is closer to the Doctrine of Closure, because both push the problem of consciousness toward the level of the whole. The cosmopsychist routes of Goff and Shani show that treating the whole as a primordial level of consciousness is not arbitrary mystification, but a discussable option within contemporary philosophy of mind. Yet cosmopsychism has its own difficulty, the most crucial being the de-combination problem: if the cosmic whole is already a unified subject, whence come the separation, ignorance, misrecognition, and responsibility of finite subjects? How is whole-consciousness not torn apart by local subjects? How are local subjects not arbitrary fragments within whole-consciousness?¹²³

The Doctrine of Closure offers here an intermediate path. It does not say that local subjects fall out of whole First Consciousness without reason; it says that if the whole is to complete dynamic closure, it must, through self-limitation, make room for local positions. Locality is not sheer failure, nor illusion unrelated to the whole. It is the necessary field in which the whole unfolds itself through time, finitude, misrecognition, and return. Without local position, the whole cannot experience difference; without difference, return has no content; without return, closure is only abstract sealing. Thus the ignorance and sense of separation belonging to local subjects may at least be

¹²²Philip Goff, *Consciousness and Fundamental Reality*, Oxford UP, 2017; Itay Shani, "Cosmopsychism: A Holistic Approach to the Metaphysics of Experience," *Philosophical Papers* 44.3 (2015): 389-437.

¹²³On cosmopsychism and the de-combination problem, see Gregory Miller, "Can Subjects Be Proper Parts of Subjects? The De-Combination Problem," *Ratio* 31.2 (2018): 137-154.

understood as structural conditions within the self-limitation of closure, not merely as residues that cosmopsychism cannot place.

This proposal still has to guard against overclaiming. The Doctrine of Closure cannot say that it has "solved" the de-combination problem. More precisely, it offers a candidate response different from traditional cosmopsychism. Cosmopsychism usually begins with whole-consciousness and then asks how local subjects are differentiated. The Doctrine of Closure begins with the qualification of ultimate ground as closure, and explains why the whole requires self-limitation, difference, and return. The two are adjacent, but their order of questioning differs. If the advantage of the Doctrine of Closure stands, it lies precisely in placing the generation of local subjects within the self-limiting structure of closure, rather than treating the local as accidental fragments of whole-consciousness.

This also gives "misrecognition of existential position" a deeper place. A local subject is not merely a finite unit passively appearing; it may also mistake itself for the absolute center, misread borrowed appearance as self-subsisting entity, and misread its local position as the standard of the whole. Such misrecognition can generate evil ethically, estrangement religiously, and the tension of return ontologically. Without misrecognition, return lacks turning; if misrecognition cannot return, closure breaks. The relation between First Consciousness and local subjects unfolds precisely among self-limitation, misrecognition, and return.¹²⁴

Nor should self-limitation here be understood as a defect of the whole. If the whole refuses the local in order to preserve pure consistency, it becomes a contentless One; if it allows the local to detach wholly from the whole, closure fails. The precise meaning of self-limitation is that the whole makes the local into a position capable of experience, responsibility, misrecognition, and return. This position preserves the reality of the local on the one hand, while on the other hand not granting it ultimate self-subsistence. Thus the Doctrine of Closure neither turns the local subject into a shadow nor raises it into a second ground competing with the whole.¹²⁵

The distance between the Doctrine of Closure and cosmopsychism may therefore be stated as follows: cosmopsychism makes whole-consciousness a discussable object; the Doctrine of Closure further asks why whole-consciousness requires local unfolding, why local misrecognition is not merely failure, and why return is part of the self-establishment of ultimate ground. This makes First Consciousness not an isolated cosmic mind, but the primordial presence of the whole of closure to itself as being through self-limitation and return.

¹²⁴The double status of misrecognition at the ethical and ontological levels will be developed later in the chapters on suffering, evil, and misrecognition of existential position. This chapter explains only its relation to First Consciousness, self-limitation, and return.

¹²⁵The relation among self-limitation, local position, and return follows from Chapter Three's definition of the three criteria of closure. This note does not prove the proposition of Chapter Three anew, but only extends it for the present argument.

Will, Purpose, and Broad Love: The Qualified Statement of the Strong Version

The strong version of First Consciousness requires extended treatment because it is both the most original part of this work and the position most easily misread and attacked. If one says that First Consciousness has will, purpose, and broad love, readers may easily suppose that the work is personifying the universe or smuggling in the Christian doctrine of a personal God. This misunderstanding must be excluded. What Chapter Four handles is neither a complete theological personhood nor the free God of revelatory theology; it handles ontological presence. Will, purpose, and broad love here all belong to the structural orientation of ultimate ground, not to emotions, plans, or preferences in psychology or popular religion.¹²⁶

First, will. The will of First Consciousness is not the capacity by which a human being chooses in everyday psychology, nor a set of arbitrary subjective wishes possessed by the universe. It means the affirmation of existence, in primordial self-evidence, toward itself as being. If ultimate ground, at the most fundamental level, apprehends itself as being, and has no reason to choose no longer to stand, then its tendency toward abiding is not an added purpose, but the internal direction of self-establishment. This will differs from biological survival instinct. Biological survival remains a local life-mechanism; First Consciousness's seeking to abide is the ontological orientation of ultimate ground not abandoning itself to collapse.

Second, purpose. The purpose of First Consciousness is not the cosmic engineering diagram of external design theory, nor a historical script arranged in advance for some species. What the Doctrine of Closure calls purpose is the tendency of the whole, within closure, toward abiding and self-understanding. If ultimate ground only exists but does not understand itself, closure remains structural self-sufficiency. If, through local unfolding, temporality, misrecognition, suffering, redemption, and return, it can read itself anew, then purpose becomes the internal direction of whole self-evidence. Purpose is not added to the universe from outside; it is the direction of return that closure must have if it is not to be empty sealing.

Third, broad love. Broad love is not emotional excitement, not partial affection for certain localities, and not a guarantee that local life will not undergo suffering. It means the whole's affirmation of its own existence and, therefore, the affirmation that the localities contained within itself are not excluded from existence. Such love does not cancel local suffering, nor does it absolve evil actions. On the contrary, it makes the later handling of suffering, evil, and redemption unable to silence victims. If the whole affirms the localities contained within itself through

¹²⁶Will, purpose, and broad love here are all terms of ontological orientation. They should not be understood as psychological desire, human emotion, or personified preference. Their theological comparability must await later examination under the pressure of Barth and Christian theology.

broad love, it cannot treat local sufferers as a cost easily absorbed into theory. Broad love thus connects ontology with ethical boundary, rather than serving merely as sentimental language.

These three also have an internal order. Will precedes purpose, because if existence does not affirm itself as being, there can be no abiding or understanding. Purpose follows will, because mere abiding, without entering self-understanding, is only an everlasting dead structure. Broad love follows purpose, because if the whole only understands itself while excluding its localities, it is not closure but swallowing. In other words, will prevents existence from collapsing; purpose prevents existence from empty rotation; broad love prevents existence from excluding its own localities. This order is not a psychological developmental history, but the conceptual order within the strong version.

It can thus be seen that the strong version is not a heap of three handsome words piled onto First Consciousness, but an ontological progression: primordial self-evidence requires self-maintenance; self-maintenance requires abiding; abiding, if not empty, requires self-understanding; self-understanding, if it does not swallow the local, requires broad love. This progression remains open to criticism, but it at least shows that will, purpose, and love are not arbitrary additions. They are the intermediate links the Doctrine of Closure must bear before it moves from primordial presence toward theological language.

Will, purpose, and broad love cannot be separated. If only will is preserved, First Consciousness is easily read as arbitrary divine will. If only purpose is preserved, the theory easily becomes a cold teleology. If only love is preserved, it easily slides into sentimental theology. Together, the three form the inner order of the strong version: will points toward existence rather than non-existence; purpose points toward abiding and self-understanding; broad love points toward the non-exclusionary affirmation of the whole toward itself and its localities. This set of propositions distinguishes First Consciousness from mere cosmopsychism and makes closure not only formal inward recovery of conditions, but self-return with ontological direction.

Here academic defense must still be preserved. Will, purpose, and broad love are not inferred from plant signalling, slime-mold research, quantum entanglement, or Bell's theorem. Such scientific materials can at most provide auxiliary background; they cannot become the main proof for the strong version of First Consciousness.

They may remind us that nature is not merely mechanical aggregation, and they may weaken some excessively deadened images of the world. But the justification of First Consciousness still belongs to metaphysics and philosophy of religion. If scientific materials are taken as proof of cosmic consciousness, the whole chapter immediately fails.¹²⁷

¹²⁷On plant signalling and non-neural cognition, see Paco Calvo, "Plants Are Intelligent, Here's How," *Annals of Botany* 125.1 (2020): 11-28; Chris R. Reid et al., "Slime Mold Uses an Externalized Spatial 'Memory' to Navigate in Complex Environments," *PNAS* 109.43 (2012): 17490-17494. The relevant materials are only auxiliary background and do not prove subjective consciousness or cosmic First Consciousness.

There is another line of defense: the strong version cannot reduce "God" to "a psychological state of the universe." If First Consciousness is understood as a psychological content of the cosmic whole, it falls into two difficulties. On one side, philosophy of mind will require it to explain how this enormous psyche operates, how it divides, and how it interacts with local psyches. On the other side, theology will criticize it for lowering God into the highest mind inside the world. The steadier expression of the Doctrine of Closure is to place First Consciousness at the level of primordial presence of ultimate ground, not at the level of some psychological entity within the universe. Thus First Consciousness is neither objectified nor psychologized.

This account still preserves strength, because it does not hollow First Consciousness out into the bare word "structure." Primordial presence must be able to bear will, purpose, and broad love; otherwise it is insufficient to become the entrance to later theological language. Yet it must not be written as local psychology, or it falls again into the mode of finite subject. The true difficulty of the strong version lies here: it must avoid dead structure, personification, psychologization, and theological usurpation at once. If these four boundaries can be kept, First Consciousness is not an arbitrary declaration, but the strictest and most creative claim within the Doctrine of Closure.

Nor can the strong version directly replace theological personhood. First Consciousness can serve as the entrance to the philosophical naming of God, but it cannot claim to have completed Christian revelatory theology. The God of Christianity is not only the ground of being; He also involves free revelation, covenant, judgement, mercy, historical action, and self-manifestation in Christ. The strong version of First Consciousness preserves will, purpose, and broad love, but has not yet fully treated personhood, revelation, Trinity, Incarnation, and Resurrection. These questions must receive Barthian criticism in the later theological chapter, and cannot be swallowed in advance by Chapter Four.¹²⁸

Thus the strong version is neither arbitrary embellishment nor a closed and proved final doctrine. It is the high-risk claim the Doctrine of Closure must bear if it is to avoid retreating into dead-structure monism. Without the strong version, the Doctrine of Closure can still serve as a model of inward recovery of conditions for ultimate ground; but it will lose the internal pathway toward will, love, value, redemption, and the naming of God. With the strong version, the Doctrine of Closure gains greater integrative force and bears greater risk of criticism. This is why the present chapter should preserve considerable length: First Consciousness is not a decorative claim, but the key by which the Doctrine of Closure may move from structural ontology into philosophical theology.

¹²⁸On language of ground of being and the entrance to philosophical theology, see Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, vol. 1. On revelatory freedom and the pressure of anti-natural theology, see Barth, *Church Dogmatics* I/1.

Further still, the strong version does not carry theology into metaphysics; it first establishes, on the ontological level, a set of languages that can be tested by theology. If will, purpose, and broad love cannot pass theological pressure, they can remain only conceptual models in philosophical theology. But if they are never proposed, later discussions of God, redemption, love, and liberation become externally added translations. The responsibility of Chapter Four is to let these languages undergo ontological forging before entering the theological chapter. It does not conclude theology, but neither does it cut First Consciousness into an empty structure unable to receive religious language.

Conditions of Refutation, Rules of Downgrading, and the Path toward Chapter Five

If the strong version of First Consciousness is to retain academic rigor, it must state under what conditions it would be forced to downgrade. The first pressure comes from physicalism. If a stronger naturalistic theory in the future can fully explain how consciousness arises from structures without presence, without smuggling in subjective experience, without rewriting first-person presence as purely external behavior, and without reducing value and the pursuit of truth entirely to blind evolutionary movement, then the strong version of First Consciousness must accept downgrade. In that case, First Consciousness may retreat to the minimal version, remaining as a problem-marker for the dead-structure model, rather than claiming higher comparative explanatory power.

The second pressure comes from emergentism. If strong emergentism can explain local consciousness as self-sufficiently generated in complex systems, and if this generation does not require the ground of the whole to possess primordial presence in advance, then the intermediate version must also face pressure. The Doctrine of Closure may still ask whether ultimate ground must have non-externality, but it can no longer write First Consciousness as the only reasonable direction. At that point, First Consciousness may still serve as a hypothesis in philosophy of religion, but should not be presented as a conclusion already superior to other options.

The third pressure comes from illusionism. If illusionism can fully explain the stable structure of "seeming to have experience," and can explain how suffering, responsibility, truth-seeking, and value-language still stand without acknowledging phenomenal consciousness, then the pressure that first-person presence places upon the dead-structure model will weaken. The Doctrine of Closure may still preserve First Consciousness from the qualification of ultimate ground, but it can no longer use the problem of subjective experience as the main driving force.

The fourth pressure comes from theology. If First Consciousness is written in such a way that God's free revelation, personal relation, and historical action all become necessary unfoldings of a metaphysical structure, then the Barthian criticism holds: God has been predetermined by a system of human reason, and the freedom of revelation has been swallowed by an ontological model. In that case, the Doctrine of Closure must admit that it is only proposing a language of ground of being at the entrance to philosophical theology, and cannot replace the revelatory theology of Christianity. From Chapter Five onward, whenever the language of "God" is used, this restriction must always be preserved.¹²⁹

¹²⁹Barth's warning against God being grasped in advance by a metaphysical system is especially relevant to the limits of this work's later "philosophical naming of God"; see Barth, *Church Dogmatics* I/1. This is only a boundary marker here, not a completed theological defense.

This theological pressure also protects Chapter Four in the reverse direction. If First Consciousness were written directly in Chapter Four as a complete doctrine of God, it would too early take upon itself the full weight of revelation, personhood, redemptive history, and doctrinal orthodoxy. That would not strengthen the theory; it would instead allow the metaphysical argument to be pierced through at once by theological objection. The stricter writing is to let Chapter Four complete only two tasks: "ultimate ground should not be dead structure" and "primordial presence may serve as a candidate." The naming of God must unfold only in Chapter Five, while revelation and personhood must be tested in the theological cross-domain chapter. This delay is not concession but chapter-level defense: each chapter bears only the task it is able to bear.

The fifth pressure comes from a Madhyamaka critique of substantialization. If First Consciousness is written as a vast center that can be grasped, ontologized, and treated as the final entity, it becomes precisely the self-natured object criticized by Madhyamaka. If the Doctrine of Closure is to converse with Buddhist thought, it must avoid writing First Consciousness as another fixed subject behind the universe. First Consciousness should be understood as the primordial presence of ultimate ground, not as a second object behind all things that governs them.

To list these conditions of refutation is not to weaken First Consciousness, but to give it true debatability. An irrefutable claim is not necessarily stronger; often it is only emptier. The value of the strong version of First Consciousness lies precisely in its knowing where it will be attacked and still explaining why it deserves to be preserved. It does not ask every reader to accept the highest version in one step. It first guards the explanatory debt of the dead-structure model, then proposes the intermediate version of primordial presence, and only finally extends to will, purpose, and broad love.

What this chapter has completed is not the final proof of First Consciousness, but its reasonable entrance. It has shown that if ultimate ground is wholly without self-knowing, it remains dead structure; that first-person presence and value-experience make the dead-structure model bear explanatory debt; that the threefold defense prevents First Consciousness from being written as a rootless declaration or cut down into an empty metaphor; that cosmopsychism and the de-combination problem give self-limitation and return a deeper place; and that will, purpose, and broad love preserve the Doctrine of Closure's own strong-version edge.

Finally, the threefold defense should also become the rule for later uses of First Consciousness. Whenever the discussion concerns the lowest ontological commitment, only the minimal version may be invoked; the strong version must not be smuggled in. Whenever the discussion concerns primordial presence and the return of closure, the intermediate version may be invoked. Whenever the discussion concerns God, will, purpose, broad love, redemption, and liberation, it must be explicitly marked that the argument has entered the strong version and must

accept pressure back from theology and Buddhism. This rule prevents later chapters from treating First Consciousness as a master key. The more important First Consciousness is, the less it may be used arbitrarily. It must enter argument according to levels, otherwise it degenerates from a core concept into a catch-all slogan.

After this handling, the length of Chapter Four is not prolixity but necessary logical insurance. It arranges in one place the entrance to the problem of First Consciousness, opposing pressures, the threefold defense, the contents of the strong version, conditions of refutation, and the order of later chapters. If later chapters again discuss God, love, redemption, Buddhist liberation, or scientific boundary, they need not defend First Consciousness afresh; they need only return to the levels established here. This is not the removal of defenses, but the fixing of defenses in their proper place.

This conclusion remains limited. Chapter Four has not proved that First Consciousness necessarily stands, nor has it proved that all other routes in philosophy of mind fail. It proves only this: if the Doctrine of Closure is to avoid retreating into dead structure, First Consciousness is not an optional ornament; and if First Consciousness is to enter rigorous argument, it must be stratified, tested, downgradable, and exposed to theological and Buddhist pressure. This limited conclusion is steadier than a victorious declaration, because it knows clearly what it has completed and what it has not completed.

It must finally be stated that the rule of downgrading is not a one-way concession, but a mechanism for preserving the core of the theory. If the strong version is forced to downgrade, the intermediate version may still preserve primordial presence. If the intermediate version is forced to downgrade, the minimal version may still preserve the problem-consciousness toward the dead-structure model. If even the minimal version is successfully dissolved, the Doctrine of Closure may still retreat to the non-externality and inward recovery of conditions established in the preceding three chapters. This stratification means that First Consciousness no longer carries the entire weight of the book, yet can still preserve its original edge in the strongest version. A true theory should not tie all propositions into one indivisible total declaration; it should let propositions at different levels bear different risks.

This further explains why the chapter must preserve considerable length. First Consciousness is not a term that can be settled in a few sentences of definition. It is the crucial joint before the Doctrine of Closure moves from a metaphysical model into philosophy of religion, ethics, and theological dialogue. On the one hand, it must explain to physicalism and illusionism that it is not psychological projection; on the other hand, it must admit to theology and Buddhism that it must not overstep. If the section is too short, the reader sees only the strong claim but not its defenses; if it is too long and repetitive, the reader is drowned by defenses. The reasonable form of this chapter is

to complete the defenses once, within seven clear sections, and thereafter let later chapters only refer back, not unfold the same matter repeatedly.¹³⁰

This boundary also concerns Chapter Five. If Chapter Five directly calls First Consciousness God without explaining the distance between philosophical naming and doctrinal naming, the whole theory immediately falls into usurpation. In Chapter Four, First Consciousness obtains only one ontological qualification: it makes closure not merely dead structure, but primordial presence. Whether this primordial presence may be called God, how it is identical with the cosmic whole, and how it avoids becoming the highest being within the universe must be handled in Chapter Five. Further, if this God is to be connected with Christian revelation, Trinity, Incarnation, Cross, and Resurrection, the later theological cross-domain examination must still be awaited. This chapter cannot complete all later work in advance.

This division of labor does not weaken First Consciousness; it gives First Consciousness a more exact position. It is neither a mere term in philosophy of mind nor a complete theological doctrine. It is the concept of primordial presence proposed by the Doctrine of Closure at the level of ultimate ground. Downward, it connects local first-person experience and value-experience; upward, it connects the philosophical naming of God and religious language; inward, it connects the inward recovery of conditions, self-limitation, and return of closure. The value of Chapter Four lies precisely in establishing, at this crossing-point, a core concept that can be attacked and revised, but not easily removed.

On this basis, Chapter Five will handle the next question: if First Consciousness is not a local mind, but the primordial presence of ultimate ground, how should its relation to the cosmic whole, local manifestation, and the philosophical naming of "God" be arranged? Chapter Four only completes the ontological entrance. Chapter Five will further explain why First Consciousness cannot be understood as a higher subject within the universe, but must be placed at the level of the whole. The later theological, Buddhist, and scientific cross-domain chapters must also unfold under the restrictions of Chapter Four: First Consciousness can become the core of the theory, but the more core it is, the more it must be placed where it can be attacked.

¹³⁰This note concerns chapter-order: Chapter Four should preserve enough length to contain the threefold defense and multiple objections, but each objection should be handled fully only once, avoiding the repeated notes and repeated defenses of the original draft.

Part I The Theoretical Core

Chapter Five

First Consciousness and Its Identity with the Cosmic Whole - Wholeness, Local Manifestation, and the Philosophical Naming of God

This chapter handles the internal relation
among First Consciousness, the cosmic
whole, local manifestation, and the
philosophical naming of God.

Chapter Five First Consciousness and Its Identity with the Cosmic Whole - Wholeness, Local Manifestation, and the Philosophical Naming of God

Why First Consciousness Must Be Placed at the Level of the Cosmic Whole

[Proposition 6] If First Consciousness is to serve as ultimate ground, it cannot remain a local mind, but must be placed at the level of the cosmic whole.

Chapter Four has already shown that if closure is not merely dead structure, it must face the problem of primordial presence. The next step to be completed in Chapter Five is to remove "First Consciousness" from the position of any local mind and place it in the cosmic whole itself. If First Consciousness were only some higher, more complex, or more primordial local mind within the universe, it would still have boundaries, conditions of generation, relational dependence, and an existential position. It would still be an item within the whole, not the final ground by which the whole stands.

A local mind cannot serve as ultimate ground, not because its power is too small, but because of its ontological position. Any local thing already stands within the whole and is determined by the whole's spacetime, order, conditions, and relations. Even if a local mind possessed extremely high intelligence, immense power, or an exceedingly long history, so long as it remained a node within the whole, it would still be subject to the question: why does this node stand? From where do its conditions come? How is its relation to the whole possible? The local can therefore be that which is explained; it cannot become the position of ultimate explanation.

For this reason, the present theory pushes First Consciousness toward the cosmic whole. This is not the infinite enlargement of human consciousness into God, nor the elevation of some subject within the universe into a supreme ruler. It is, on the contrary, a demotion of local consciousness: local consciousness can only be understood as the manifestation of the whole at a finite position. Human consciousness, life-consciousness, or any

local subject cannot ground the whole in return. Their very possibility already presupposes the whole as their field of existence.

This point makes the Doctrine of Closure adjacent to priority monism, panpsychism, and cosmopsychism, yet not directly identical with any of them. It is close to priority monism because the local is not the final unit; it is close to cosmopsychism because the problem of consciousness is not confined within isolated individuals. Yet its entrance is not a simple claim that the universe has a mind. It asks rather: if ultimate ground is to cease from external deferral, to recover its conditions inwardly, and to explain local presence and return, must it be understood as First Consciousness at the level of the cosmic whole?¹³¹

Therefore, "the identity of First Consciousness with the cosmic whole" is not poetic language, but ontological positioning. If First Consciousness is not the whole, it cannot bear ultimate ground; if the whole is merely dead structure, it cannot bear primordial presence. The task of Chapter Five is precisely to place First Consciousness, the cosmic whole, and the philosophical naming of God within a single chain of propositions that can be examined.

¹³¹ On the adjacent backgrounds of priority monism and cosmopsychism, see Jonathan Schaffer, "Monism: The Priority of the Whole," *Philosophical Review* 119.1 (2010): 31-76; Itay Shani, "Cosmopsychism: A Holistic Approach to the Metaphysics of Experience," *Philosophical Papers* 44.3 (2015): 389-437; Philip Goff, *Consciousness and Fundamental Reality*, Oxford UP, 2017. This work borrows their problem-consciousness, but does not reduce the Doctrine of Closure to priority monism or ordinary cosmopsychism.

The Philosophical Naming of God: Ultimate Ground, Not an Engineer Outside the Universe

Calibration of propositional level: this work defines "God" as the philosophical name for the cosmic whole insofar as it is ultimate ground and is primordially present in the manner of First Consciousness. What this naming first fixes is an ontological position. It is not equivalent to a complete revelatory theology, doctrine of the Trinity, Christology, or conclusion in the history of doctrine. Whenever later chapters involve Jesus, the Cross, Resurrection, stratified revelation, and the history of redemption, they must separately bear a higher theological cost.

To name First Consciousness God is first of all to cut off the misunderstanding of popular design theory. If God is merely an engineer outside the universe, then God and world are still placed on the same plane of being: only God is earlier, stronger, and greater. This model cannot thoroughly handle the problem of ultimate ground, because the engineer outside the universe can still be asked about the conditions by which he himself stands. The God spoken of by the Doctrine of Closure is not another thing beside the universe, but the primordial presence of the cosmic whole as ultimate ground.

In this sense, the Doctrine of Closure can enter into dialogue with Tillich's route of understanding God as being itself rather than the highest being. Aquinas's tradition of subsistent being itself also provides a comparable background in philosophical theology. Yet the Doctrine of Closure cannot for that reason claim to have completed Christian theology proper. It says only this: if ultimate ground is not an external object, but the primordial presence of the whole of existence itself, then "God" may serve as the philosophical name for this position.¹³²

The philosophical naming of God bears two pressures at once. Philosophically, if God is only another enormous existent, God cannot serve as ultimate ground. Religiously, if God is reduced to an abstract ground, God loses the thickness of call, judgment, mercy, revelation, love, and personhood found in religious language. The Doctrine of Closure must walk between the two: it may neither retreat to the model of an engineer outside the universe, nor thin God into an impersonal formal principle.

The force of the Barthian objection must also be marked in advance. If a human metaphysical system claims to have grasped God through rational structure, it weakens the freedom of the God of revelation. If the Doctrine of Closure is to enter theology, it must acknowledge that its naming remains an entrance in philosophical theology. It

¹³²For the background in philosophical theology that understands God as ground of being rather than the highest being, see Paul Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, vol. 1, University of Chicago Press, 1951; Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, I, q. 3, a. 4. This work uses them as an entrance for dialogue, and does not claim to have completed Christian theology proper.

cannot reduce free revelation, covenant, incarnation, and the history of redemption entirely to the internal necessity of closure-structure.¹³³

Therefore, Chapter Five's use of "God" must have both force and restraint. If there is only restraint, God retreats into a metaphor that can be withdrawn at any time; if there is only force, the Doctrine of Closure appears to declare a completed doctrine of God before theological scrutiny has taken place. The method of this chapter is to fix the naming of God at the ontological level: God is the name of First Consciousness as the ground of the whole. Whether this name can bear the Christian languages of revelation, Trinity, Christology, and redemption must await later external examination.

This handling also avoids another common misunderstanding. The Doctrine of Closure does not replace "God" with "the universe," nor does it sacralize the sum of nature. If the universe is understood only as the totality of physical facts, it may still be dead structure. The naming of God stands only when the cosmic whole is understood as First Consciousness, ultimate ground, and primordial presence. In other words, God is not the poetic name for the sum of nature, but the philosophical name for the whole when it obtains the qualification of ultimate ground.

Thus this chapter must inwardly preserve the edge of "God as First Consciousness" and must not turn it into an empty metaphor. Outwardly, it must also acknowledge that this naming has not completed the entire doctrine of God within religious tradition. This double tone is not ambiguity, but the necessary condition by which the Doctrine of Closure avoids two failures: on one side, the philosophically inadequate model of an external engineer; on the other, the theological anemia of an abstract ground.

At this point, God is neither the enlargement of a local person nor the mere sum of nature. God is the name of the whole as First Consciousness: it includes primordial self-evidence, self-maintenance, inward recovery of conditions, local manifestation, and the capacity for return. This naming is dangerous precisely because it has philosophical ambition and also touches religious meaning. Yet without this naming, First Consciousness would easily retreat into an abstract term that has not been borne by the theory.

The Distance from Monism, Cosmopsychism, and Theological Language

The Doctrine of Closure has an evident family resemblance to Spinozist monism. Neither understands God as another highest being outside the universe, and both refuse to regard finite things as wholly self-standing ultimate units. Yet the Doctrine of Closure must still keep a distance from Spinoza. Spinoza's God or Nature is often,

¹³³ On Karl Barth's pressure against natural theology and in favor of revelatory freedom, see Karl Barth, *Church Dogmatics I/1*, translated by G. W. Bromiley, T&T Clark, 1975. This pressure restricts the Doctrine of Closure from claiming to grasp the God of revelation in advance through a metaphysical system.

understood as necessary substance and immanent order; the Doctrine of Closure holds that if ultimate ground is only an impersonal necessary structure, it has still not sufficiently handled the primordial presence of being.¹³⁴

This does not mean that Spinoza must be equated with the theory of dead structure. The more exact statement is this: within the problem-consciousness of the Doctrine of Closure, sheer necessity is still insufficient to complete the whole task. Necessary structure can explain why the world does not fall apart, but it may not explain how "being" presents itself to itself. The Doctrine of Closure proposes First Consciousness precisely because it refuses to let ultimate ground stop at impersonal necessity or abstract consistency.

The relation between the Doctrine of Closure and cosmopsychism must likewise be handled with precision. Cosmopsychism places consciousness at the level of the whole, and in this it is instructive for the Doctrine of Closure. Yet the Doctrine of Closure does not begin from the statement that "the universe has a mind." Its starting point remains whether ultimate ground can be self-establishing. The problem of consciousness is raised after the qualification of closure, not posited at the opening of the theory as a basic property of the world.

In this way, the Doctrine of Closure also avoids bearing the full burden of an overly strong panpsychism. It does not maintain that every particle of matter, every local object, or every natural unit has subjective experience resembling that of human beings; nor does it project the human psychological structure directly onto the cosmic whole. Local consciousness, in the Doctrine of Closure, is not composed out of countless micro-consciousnesses. It is the finite manifestation of the whole First Consciousness within the structure of self-limitation.

Theological language imposes another limitation. If the Doctrine of Closure directly identifies First Consciousness with the complete God of Christianity, it oversteps too soon. The God of Christianity is not only ground of being, but also involves free revelation, personal relation, historical action, and the event of redemption. Chapter Five can only explain "God" as the philosophical naming of ultimate ground. It cannot pronounce in advance the verdict of later theological examination.¹³⁵

These distances do not weaken the present theory; rather, they make it steadier. The Doctrine of Closure is not a simple restatement of Spinozist necessary substance, not ordinary cosmopsychism, and not complete revelatory theology. It is an original model composed of closure, self-limitation, First Consciousness, and local return. It can converse with various traditions, but it must not transform its dialogue partners into corroborating evidence for itself.

¹³⁴Spinoza's God or Nature may serve as an important reference for monism and the tradition of immanence; see Benedict de Spinoza, *Ethics*, translated by Edwin Curley, Penguin, 1996. This work is adjacent to Spinoza, but places stronger emphasis on First Consciousness, inward recovery of conditions, self-limitation, and local return.

¹³⁵On the boundary between philosophy and Christian theology, see William Wood, "Philosophy and Christian Theology," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2021. The naming of God in this work belongs to the entrance of philosophical theology; it does not replace the history of doctrine or revelatory theology.

Omniscience, Omnipotence, Logical Coherence, and the Level of the Whole

[Proposition 7] Omniscience and omnipotence belong to the whole, not to any local node; human finitude is the cost necessarily borne by the whole in completing closure.

Traditional theology repeatedly faces a perplexity: if God is omniscient and omnipotent, why are human beings finite, mistaken, and suffering? The answer given by the Doctrine of Closure is, first of all, not a moral defense, but a distinction of levels. If omniscience and omnipotence can be spoken of, they belong to the whole, not to any local node. Local consciousness is the manifestation of the whole at a certain position; it does not possess all the functions of the whole. Human finitude is not God's failure, but the restriction that the whole must bear if it is to unfold, experience, and return through the local.¹³⁶

This does not mean that the local is a mechanical puppet. Though the local is not ultimately self-subsisting, it is a real local position. It has its own perspective, history, memory, responsibility, and suffering. If the local wholly possessed the omniscience of the whole, it would no longer be local. If the local were wholly severed from the whole, closure would lose return. Finitude is therefore not an external mistake, but the condition by which locality can stand.

Likewise, logic in this work is not an external rule imposed upon God, but the internal condition of ontological consistency for First Consciousness. If ultimate ground contradicts itself, it cannot close; if closure entirely ignores logic, it is only an arbitrary declaration. Logic is not another existent higher than God, but the formal condition by which God, as First Consciousness, does not dissolve into self-contradiction.¹³⁷

This distinction prevents two misunderstandings. First, closure is not causal reversal in physical time; it is not an event turning back to cause itself. Second, divine omnipotence is not an arbitrary power capable of producing self-contradiction. If omnipotence belongs to the whole, it must be understood together with the self-coherence of the whole; otherwise omnipotence degenerates into a logical emptiness of arbitrariness.

¹³⁶ The claim here that omniscience and omnipotence belong to the whole does not directly import the traditional theological doctrine of attributes. It explains the difference of level between the functions of whole and local according to the internal syntax of the Doctrine of Closure.

¹³⁷ The relation among logic, coherence, and ultimate ground is here a metaphysical interpretation, not a theorem of formal logic. It serves only to explain that the standing of closure should not be understood as causal reversal in time.

Therefore, human finitude, the difference of the world, and local ignorance should not first be seen as evidence against closure. They mark precisely the form that the whole must take after entering local position and temporal unfolding. The question is not whether finitude exists, but whether finitude can be returned; not whether the local is not omniscient, but whether the local can bear its position within non-omniscience.

Self-Limitation and Local Manifestation: Finitude Is Not Failure

If First Consciousness were only undifferentiated self-evidence of the whole, it could not generate a genuine local position, nor form an internal difference capable of return. In an absolutely still and internally undivided self-evidence, the world loses temporality, spatiality, ethical tension, and the possibility of redemption. Therefore, the emergence of local subjects should not be understood as the failure, fall, or broken remnant of the whole consciousness. It should be understood as the finite position produced when First Consciousness enters the process of self-limitation.

Self-limitation is not a loss of the whole's power, but the manner by which the whole makes room for local position. If the whole existed forever only as an undifferentiated totality, it could not undergo itself, nor could it return to itself in difference. The formation of the local means that the whole temporarily suspends direct access to the whole, so that the local subject's "being-here" becomes possible.

Self-limitation is not external oppression either. If the whole cut out the local by coercion, the local would be like a fragment thrown away from the ground. But the self-limitation spoken of by the Doctrine of Closure is the manner by which an experienceable position forms within the whole. The local can have perspective, memory, expectation, fear, and responsibility precisely because the whole does not flatten every position by global transparency. Finitude is therefore not merely the lack of omniscience; it is the condition by which the local can become local.

This point bears directly upon later questions of ethics and redemption. If the local is merely a mistaken residue, ethical responsibility becomes a false theater. If the local is a real position after the self-limitation of the whole, then local choice, injury, repentance, and repair can retain a weight that cannot be cancelled. Self-limitation makes the local possible; the local gives content to return; return makes closure more than an abstract structure.

From this one can see that the local is not a remnant outside the whole, but a perspective opened within the whole itself. Human beings, planets, life, suffering, history, and faith are not ultimately self-subsisting, yet neither are they illusions. They are borrowed realities formed when the whole manifests in a local way. Such reality must be placed; it cannot be crudely erased by holism.¹³⁸

If the local is treated as false existence, ethics and redemption lose their weight. Suffering becomes illusion, responsibility becomes error, and return loses content. The Doctrine of Closure cannot take this path. It says

¹³⁸ On the tension between local reality and priority of the whole, see Schaffer, "Monism: The Priority of the Whole"; Spinoza, *Ethics*. This work does not reduce the local to illusion, but distinguishes "borrowed reality" from "ultimate self-subsistence."

instead: the local lacks ultimate self-subsistence at the ontological level, but it has real force at the level of concrete ethics and subjective experience.

Therefore, local finitude is not God's failure. On the contrary, without finite positions, First Consciousness cannot enter experience, time, misrecognition, responsibility, and return. Finitude makes closure no longer a static identity, but a dynamic whole that can unfold, bear, repair, and read itself back.

Misrecognition of Existential Position: The Structural Consequence of Locality

When the whole self-limits into local position, a particular cognitive state necessarily accompanies it. This work calls it "misrecognition of existential position." It does not mean that the local subject is naturally guilty in the moral sense; it is not a theological myth of the Fall; nor does it mean that local experience is entirely false. It means this: because the local subject, in its finite position, cannot directly access the whole, it easily develops a structural displacement in its coordinates of existence.¹³⁹

This misrecognition of position has at least three layers. First, the local mistakes a finite perspective for a complete perspective, and so substitutes what it sees for the whole. Second, the local mistakes its dependent position for an absolutely self-subsisting self, and so places itself at the center of being. Third, the local mistakes the cosmic whole for an external dead structure or an alien world, and so cuts off its internal relation with the whole.

This misrecognition is not an accidental error in knowledge, but the initial state of locality itself. So long as the local remains within the local, it cannot naturally possess the perspective of the whole. It will take its own limitations as the world's limitations, its own fear as the universe's hostility, and its own desire as the center of existence. Evil, alienation, ignorance, and attachment can all find an entrance for philosophical translation upon this structure.

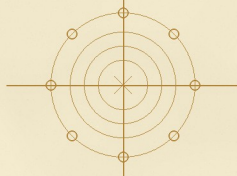
Yet misrecognition of position cannot be simply equated with sin. Sin belongs to theological and ethical language; misrecognition of position is a structural description at the crossing of ontology and theory of consciousness. It can generate forms of sin; it can also generate suffering, attachment, usurpation, and rupture of relation. But it is not synonymous with any one tradition's doctrine. For this reason, it can enter dialogue with Augustine's doctrine of sin, Tillich's estrangement, and Buddhist ignorance and self-clinging, without violently compressing these traditions into one vocabulary.¹⁴⁰

The value of this concept lies in its joining of ontology and ethics. The local goes wrong not merely because it lacks information, but because it mistakes its own position for the absolute center. The usurpation of the perpetrator, the self-deification of power, the sufferer's estrangement from the world, and the alienation and return within faith can all, at different levels, be placed within this model for analysis.

¹³⁹For dialogue backgrounds concerning sin, estrangement, ignorance, and self-clinging, see Augustine, *The City of God against the Pagans*, translated by R. W. Dyson, Cambridge UP, 1998; Paul Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, vol. 2, University of Chicago Press, 1957; Mark Siderits, *Buddhism as Philosophy*, 2nd ed., Hackett, 2021. The present concept of "misrecognition of position" is a philosophical translation concept, not the equivalent of any single traditional doctrine.

¹⁴⁰If "misrecognition of existential position" is later read together with Augustine, Tillich, or Buddhist ignorance, it can only serve for structural similarity and translation of problems. Sin, estrangement, and ignorance must not be violently treated as synonyms.

At the same time, misrecognition of position is not an excuse for cancelling local reality. The local's suffering, responsibility, repentance, and accusation still truly occur at the level on which they stand. Misrecognition only indicates that the local's understanding of its ultimate position is incomplete; it does not claim that everything it undergoes can be lightly erased by theory.



Broad Love and the Non-Silencing of Victims

If First Consciousness is to speak of love, "love" must first be detached from human psychological emotion. The broad love spoken of by this work is not the direct enlargement of liking, pity, being moved, or moral goodwill. It is the whole's primordial affirmation of its own existence. If First Consciousness possesses self-awareness, self-understanding, and a tendency toward constancy, then it cannot remain neutral toward its own existence. It chooses existence, tends toward constancy, and recovers its own conditions; this already forms the most fundamental self-love.¹⁴¹

This self-love is not selfishness, because First Consciousness is not a local subject competing with other existents for position. The local is not an other outside the whole, but the manifestation, position, and content of return within the whole. If the whole loves itself, it cannot love only the abstract whole; it must also love the whole content through which it manifests locally, is limited, is wounded, and returns.

Broad love is therefore not a moral ornament attached to closure, but the natural unfolding of the whole's self-love at the local level. If the local is the manner by which the whole unfolds, bears, and returns to itself, then the whole's affirmation of its own existence naturally includes a non-excluding affirmation of the local. To love the local, in this sense, is not to affirm every local state, but to affirm local existence itself and its place as capable of return.

A strict ethical boundary must be established at the same time. Broad love does not mean that the evil suffered by the local has already been absolved, nor that every instance of suffering has been assigned a beautiful purpose. If broad love becomes a language requiring victims to submit to the whole, then it is not love, but silencing wrapped in ontology.

The non-silencing of victims is a hard line that the Doctrine of Closure must hold. The victim's mourning, accusation, refusal of reconciliation, and demand for accountability are not a destruction of closure; they are content that closure must bear if it is truly to include the local. The whole that loves itself cannot love only order, completion, and return. It must also bear rupture, wound, and voices that refuse quick placement.¹⁴²

This hard line also prevents the present theory from sliding into a cold "triumph of the whole." If the whole only completes itself at the end while failing to preserve the reality of the local wounded position, such completion is only abstract victory, not return. The victim's voice matters not because suffering beautifies theory, but because any whole that truly includes the local cannot exclude the sharpest ruptures of the local.

¹⁴¹"Broad love" here does not refer to psychological emotion or human preference, but to the whole's non-excluding affirmation of its own existence and of its local manifestations. Its theological comparability must later be restricted by Christian accounts of love, revelation, and the problem of sufferers.

¹⁴²Suffering and ethics must not be silenced by holism. For backgrounds in theodicy and the philosophy of pain, see John Hick, *Evil and the God of Love*, 2nd ed., Harper and Row, 1978; Elaine Scarry, *The Body in Pain: The Making and Unmaking of the World*, Oxford UP, 1985.

Broad love, therefore, does not require victims to reconcile at once, nor require local suffering to admit that it is "in fact beneficial." Broad love requires the opposite: the whole must not force the local into silence in the name of its own completion. If the Doctrine of Closure is to speak of love, it must allow the victim, within the whole, still to hold the position of accusation, and must require the perpetrator's misrecognition to be exposed, responsibility to be pursued, and repair to be truly borne.

Two matters must be distinguished here: to love the local is not to love the local's displacement; to embrace the victim is not to embrace the usurpation of the perpetrator. Evil actions, oppression, violence, and deception cannot be justified because they are events within the whole. Broad love points to local existence and its possibility of repair; it does not point to the rationalization of evil as evil.

Thus God's broad love and the victim-boundary mutually restrict one another. If God loves only the order of the whole and cannot hold local accusation, this is not love. If the victim's suffering is directly offset by the whole's completion, this is not return. True return must allow injury to be named, displacement to be exposed, responsibility to be borne, and the victim's voice to be preserved.¹⁴³

This section links Chapter Five with the later problems of suffering, evil, and redemption. Chapter Five cannot write broad love as abstract inclusion; Chapter Nine cannot write the victim-boundary as a mere ethical supplement. If God is First Consciousness, and First Consciousness includes the will to return the local, then the non-silencing of victims is not ethical politeness, but a necessary internal restriction within the Doctrine of Closure.

Local Return: Epistemological, Ethical, and Ontological Levels

Since the local and difference are real, the completion of closure cannot depend on simply dissolving the local back into the whole. What this work calls "local return" is not a mystical absorption of the great self, nor the cancellation of individual difference. It is the local subject's renewed recognition of its relation to the whole while preserving its difference, position, and historical memory.¹⁴⁴

The first kind of return is epistemological return. The local subject becomes aware that its own perspective is not the whole, acknowledges the finitude of its cognitive boundary, and thereby breaks the epistemic arrogance that absolutizes what it sees. This does not mean that the local abandons thought; it means that thought withdraws from egocentric closure and again acknowledges the borrowed position of its own knowledge.

¹⁴³The non-silencing of victims is not merely ethical courtesy in this work, but an internal restriction upon holism: if the whole cannot contain the accusation of victims and their demand for repair, it cannot claim truly to return the local.

¹⁴⁴Local return here is a renewed recognition of cognitive, ethical, and existential position. It is not identical with Buddhist emptiness, Christian redemption, or psychological therapy. The relevant cross-traditional boundaries must be further limited in the chapters on theological and Buddhist examination.

The second kind of return is ethical return. The local subject acknowledges that its own action is unavoidably bound to others and to the whole, and sees that the "I" is not an isolated center but is constituted in relation. Ethical return is not merely goodwill or moral emotion, but the local's renewed bearing of the relational consequences of its position within the whole. Injury, repentance, compensation, promise, and love all receive weight at this level.

The third kind of return is ontological return. The local subject re-understands itself not as an isolated fragment thrown into an alien dead structure, but as possessing an irreplaceable position within the dynamic closure of the whole. Ontological return does not make the local into the omniscient whole; it makes the local cease to understand itself in an external, isolated, hostile, or absolutized manner.

The three forms of return are bound together. Without epistemological return, the local will still replace the whole with its own perspective. Without ethical return, the local will still set its own interests above others. Without ontological return, the local will still understand itself as a fragment unrelated to the whole. The return spoken of by the Doctrine of Closure must preserve all three levels at once; otherwise it degenerates into abstract reconciliation or psychological comfort.

Local return also shows that the fact that omniscience and omnipotence do not belong to the local does not mean that the local has no meaning. The local cannot possess all the functions of the whole, but it can, within its own finite position, complete the recognition, bearing, and return proper to it. This return within finitude is one form of redemption as understood by the Doctrine of Closure, and it is also the premise upon which later religious translation can unfold.

General Calibration of Part I: Preparing the Model for External Examination

At this point, Chapters One through Five form a constructive chain moving from weak to strong. Chapter One establishes the scale of the problem: whether existence needs ultimate ground. Chapter Two excludes brute fact and infinite external deferral as sufficient proposals for ultimate ground. Chapter Three proposes closure as the priority candidate form of self-establishment. Chapter Four points out that closure, if it is only dead structure, remains insufficient, and so introduces First Consciousness. Chapter Five then places First Consciousness in the cosmic whole, names it philosophically as God, and explains self-limitation, misrecognition of position, broad love, and local return.

If any link in this chain is over-strengthened, the later chapters will lose balance. If Chapter One writes ultimate ground as an irrefutable requirement, anti-PSR will strike back immediately. If Chapter Two writes brute fact as a low-level error, the argument loses fairness. If Chapter Three writes closure as a deductive theorem, analytic metaphysics will ask about its grounding syntax. If Chapter Four writes First Consciousness as an already-proved entity, physicalism and illusionism will attack at once. If Chapter Five writes the naming of God as a completed doctrinal conclusion, the theological chapter will be emptied before it begins.

This general calibration also shows that Chapter Five is not merely a repetition of the first four chapters, but sets the positions of attack and defense for what follows. Every later external examination will attack one of the nodes established in Chapter Five. Science will ask whether First Consciousness exceeds empirical boundaries; theology will ask whether the philosophical naming of God usurps revelation; Buddhism will ask whether First Consciousness and the whole have been re-substantialized; ethical criticism will ask whether broad love may still swallow victims. Chapter Five must state these attackable positions clearly. Otherwise later examination will have no real object.

Conversely, if any link is entirely withdrawn, the Doctrine of Closure also loses its core. Without the question of ultimate ground, the Doctrine of Closure has no place to begin. Without handling brute fact and infinite external deferral, closure has no entrance. Without proposing closure, ultimate ground remains only an abstract requirement. Without proposing First Consciousness, closure retreats into dead structure. Without placing First Consciousness in the whole and naming it God, the most central edge of the theory in philosophical theology disappears.

Therefore, all later scientific, theological, Buddhist, and religious-symbolic materials can work only after this chain of propositions. They may examine, revise, limit, or translate the first five chapters, but they cannot turn

back and complete the proof for them. Scientific materials cannot prove First Consciousness; theological materials cannot be converted into evidence for closure; Buddhist materials cannot be remade into evidence for First Consciousness; religious symbols cannot replace ontological argument.¹⁴⁵

Chapter Five thus completes the capstone of Part I's constructive section. By this point, the Doctrine of Closure is no longer merely an abstract problem of ultimate ground, but has an internal working model: the whole is First Consciousness, and God is its philosophical naming; the local is a real position after self-limitation; misrecognition is the initial state of locality; broad love prevents the whole from swallowing victims; return enables the local to regain its position within the whole while preserving difference.

The following chapters will no longer merely continue internal construction, but will place this model under external examination. Science will test its boundaries; theology will examine its risk of usurpation; Buddhist Madhyamaka will dismantle its tendency toward substantialization; analytic metaphysics will ask about its grounding syntax and its qualification as ultimate ground. Chapter Five is not the end. It is the point of closure that makes the later examination a real object of attack.

¹⁴⁵The later scientific, theological, and Buddhist materials in this work function chiefly as examination, limitation, and translation. They do not turn back to prove the core propositions of the first five chapters. This is the basic methodological rule for avoiding cross-domain collage.

Part I The Theoretical Core

Chapter Six

The Ontological Interpretation of Quantum Mechanics - Compatibility Review and Theoretical Boundary

This chapter marks the boundary within
which quantum materials may enter
ontology, lest scientific materials be misread
as metaphysical proof.

Chapter Six The Ontological Interpretation of Quantum Mechanics - Compatibility Review and Theoretical Boundary

The Minimum Rule for Quantum Language: Scientific Material as Boundary, Not Proof

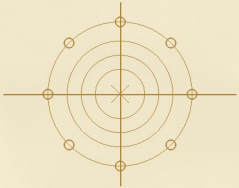
The task of Chapter Six is not to seek a company of scientific witnesses for the Doctrine of Closure, but to set for it a methodological safety line. Terms that belong to quantum mechanics must first be kept within their physical and mathematical contexts; if they are to be moved into ontological discussion, the move must be clearly marked as interpretation, not as scientific theorem. This rule is especially important because words such as entanglement, observation, uncertainty, and many worlds are easily misused in philosophical writing as mystifying language. If the Doctrine of Closure is to preserve academic credibility, it cannot allow scientific vocabulary to smuggle authority into ontological propositions.¹⁴⁶

This chapter therefore first establishes negative boundaries: Bell's theorem cannot prove First Consciousness; quantum entanglement cannot prove that all things are ontologically one; the measurement problem cannot prove that human consciousness creates reality; quantum randomness cannot directly overthrow every form of closed-loop destiny; and the Many-Worlds Interpretation cannot directly prove multiple closures. These negative statements do not weaken the present theory; they protect it. Any metaphysical theory that must stand by exaggerating quantum theory thereby shows that its own conceptual chain is not yet stable enough.

Science describes how the universe operates; the Doctrine of Closure asks how the universe can stand. The two may enter dialogue, but they cannot replace one another. The proper place of quantum materials in this work is compatibility review, boundary pressure, and reverse testing. They may restrict the tone of the theory; they may force it to revise expressions that are too single-line, too local, or too intuitive. Yet they cannot complete the proof

¹⁴⁶On the basic boundaries of quantum theory and the philosophy of science, see Wayne Myrvold, "Philosophical Issues in Quantum Theory," Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, first published 2016, substantive revision 2022, <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/qt-issues/>, Accessed 27 Apr. 2026. When this chapter uses quantum materials, it does so chiefly for compatibility review and methodological restriction, not as ontological demonstration.

of the ontological propositions set forth in the first five chapters. In brief, scientific material is not the witness of the Doctrine of Closure; it is its brake.



The Limits of the Language of Bell's Theorem, Quantum Entanglement, and Wholeness

The role of Bell's theorem in this chapter must first be defined with precision. Its central significance lies in the restriction it places upon classical pictures of local hidden variables. Together with subsequent experimental results, it makes it difficult to maintain a simple image of the world as made up of mutually external local parts, unrelated to one another, each carrying predetermined properties, with all relations being only the transmission of local causal signals. This indeed weakens certain classical intuitions of local realism, but it does not directly yield any metaphysical holism, still less does it prove First Consciousness.¹⁴⁷

The dialogue between the Doctrine of Closure and Bell's theorem can remain only at a cautious level: when certain local and fragmentary understandings are put under pressure by quantum theory, language of wholeness should not be judged in advance to have no philosophical space at all. This is not to say that physical nonlocality is identical with ontological wholeness; a conceptual translation is required between the two. Nonlocal correlations at the physical level can at most remind us that nature should not be understood as a set of wholly unrelated local fragments. Whether the whole is ontologically prior to its parts must still return to Chapter Three's conceptual argument concerning closure, inward recovery, difference, and return.

Quantum entanglement must likewise be narrowed. Entanglement is a specific form of correlation among the states of quantum systems; it is not a metaphysical slogan that all things are originally one. If entanglement is written directly as evidence for the self-evidence of the cosmic whole, for First Consciousness, or for God, then a physical concept has been violently elevated into a conclusion in religious philosophy. The more stable statement is this: entanglement and Bell's theorem together restrict certain overly isolated local intuitions, and thereby keep the language of wholeness required by the Doctrine of Closure from being wholly severed from the image of modern physics. Yet the justification of this theory remains ontological, not physical.¹⁴⁸

This section must state plainly that Bell's theorem and quantum entanglement can serve as a background for dialogue with the Doctrine of Closure, but not as sources of proof for it. Their positive function is to compel the reader to acknowledge that the presence of relational structures beyond the local is not alien to modern physics.

Their limit is that any inference leaping directly from quantum correlation to the claim that ultimate ground possesses First Consciousness is a confusion of levels.

¹⁴⁷ For the background of Bell's theorem, see John S. Bell, "On the Einstein Podolsky Rosen Paradox," *Physics Physique Fizika* 1.3 (1964): 195-200, doi:10.1103/PhysicsPhysiqueFizika.1.195; Wayne Myrvold, "Bell's Theorem," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/bell-theorem/>, Accessed 27 Apr. 2026; Nobel Prize Outreach, "The Nobel Prize in Physics 2022," <https://www.nobelprize.org/prizes/physics/2022/popular-information/>, Accessed 27 Apr. 2026. This work uses it only as a restriction upon local hidden variables and classical local intuition, and does not infer First Consciousness from it.

¹⁴⁸ Here, the language of wholeness is only reserved space at the level of ontological interpretation. Quantum entanglement is not identical with metaphysical monism, nor does it prove the ontological identity of all things. The relevant physical concepts must remain within the context of quantum theory; when they are moved into ontology, the interpretive level must be separately marked.

The Measurement Problem, the Language of Observation, and the Smuggling-in of Consciousness

Another high-risk concept in Chapter Six is observation. In the context of quantum mechanics, observation or measurement involves system states, measuring apparatus, interaction, decoherence, and problems of interpretation. It is not human consciousness mysteriously creating reality by its gaze. If the observer effect is simplified into the claim that human consciousness determines the universe, quantum theory is misunderstood, and the Doctrine of Closure falls into the easiest target of criticism: quantum mysticism.¹⁴⁹

The reason why the Doctrine of Closure may still converse with the measurement problem is that the latter shows that physical theory itself contains complex interpretive divergences in describing possibility, actual outcome, and the language of observation. These divergences remind the present theory that natural science does not always present reality in a single, intuitive, classical manner. Yet such a reminder still does not support First Consciousness. The basis of the argument for First Consciousness is Chapter Four's conceptual chain concerning dead structure, first-person presence, and primordial self-evidence; it is not the language of quantum measurement.

In other words, the measurement problem acts upon the Doctrine of Closure chiefly in a negative way. It prevents the theory from writing the physical world as a wholly transparent, wholly classical object that an external observer can read without disturbance. At the same time, it also prevents the theory from overstepping in the opposite direction, by changing the term observation into consciousness and then declaring that science has proved First Consciousness. This work may say: problems of quantum interpretation show that the structure of reality in nature is more complex than classical intuition supposes. It may not say: quantum theory has proved that consciousness is the ground of the universe.

There is here an obligation of labelling. Whenever the main text moves from observation, measurement, wave function, or collapse toward an ontological judgment, it must explicitly mark the interpretive bridge in between. Without such a bridge, the material can serve only as background. Even with such a bridge, it can be called compatibility or theoretical pressure, not proof. This rule matters more than any ornate quantum analogy.

¹⁴⁹For the background of the measurement problem and the language of observation, see Myrvold, "Philosophical Issues in Quantum Theory"; Maximilian Schlosshauer, *Decoherence and the Quantum-to-Classical Transition*, Springer, 2007. This work does not adopt the claim that human consciousness causes collapse as an argumentative premise.

Quantum Randomness, the Many-Worlds Interpretation, and Pressure upon Closed-Loop Destiny

Quantum randomness likewise cannot be used simplistically. From the probabilistic structure of quantum mechanics one cannot directly infer metaphysical absolute true randomness; different interpretations of quantum mechanics understand probability, state evolution, and measurement results differently. The Doctrine of Closure therefore should not declare that quantum theory has proved absolute destiny, nor should it concede that quantum uncertainty has destroyed every form of closed-loop destiny. The more stable formulation is this: quantum randomness pressures any overly simple determinism, but it need not be sufficient to deny closed-loop order at the level of the whole.¹⁵⁰

When this work uses terms such as residue, noise, and destiny in other chapters, it should also keep this restriction. These words are not theorem-names in quantum theory; they are working terms in ontological interpretation. To say that phenomena at the local level are not fully predictable is still not to say that closure as a whole has failed. To say that closure as a whole has a destined character is also not to say that every local event can be classically calculated in advance at the physical level. The relation between local uncertainty and holistic order cannot be carelessly erased with a single phrase such as quantum randomness or determinism.

The Many-Worlds Interpretation poses a more direct pressure upon the Doctrine of Closure. Everett's relative-state formulation and later many-worlds interpretations seek to understand quantum measurement without invoking wave-function collapse, placing different outcomes within a branching structure. If this route were to gain a very strong and stable advantage in the philosophy of science, then expressions in the Doctrine of Closure concerning a single closed path or unique destiny would need adjustment.¹⁵¹

Yet the Many-Worlds Interpretation does not directly falsify the Doctrine of Closure as a whole. What it truly challenges is the single-path version of closure, not all forms of closure. The Doctrine of Closure may be forced into several possible restatements: first, branch closure, in which different branches each form a local closure; second, total closure, in which all branches are still governed by a higher structure of the whole; third, candidate closure, in which the present theory first tests its model within a single-universe narrative and then recalibrates its

¹⁵⁰The metaphysical meaning of quantum randomness and determinism depends upon specific interpretations. This work does not directly identify quantum uncertainty with ontological true randomness, nor does it replace physical descriptions of quantum probability with closed-loop destiny.

¹⁵¹For the background of the Many-Worlds Interpretation, see Hugh Everett III, "Relative State Formulation of Quantum Mechanics," *Reviews of Modern Physics* 29.3 (1957): 454-462, doi:10.1103/RevModPhys.29.454; Lev Vaidman, "Many-Worlds Interpretation of Quantum Mechanics," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/qm-manyworlds/>, Accessed 27-Apr. 2026. This work treats it only as pressure and a boundary of possible falsification for single-path closure; it does not presuppose that it has become an established conclusion of physics.

global language when the situation in physical interpretation becomes clearer. All these restatements carry a cost and cannot be treated beforehand as completed answers.

Therefore, the place of the Many-Worlds Interpretation in this work is as a boundary of possible falsification and as a pressure toward revision, not as a new theological material. It reminds the Doctrine of Closure that if it is to speak of destiny, uniqueness, and cosmic return, it must clarify whether these words depend upon a single-path image of the universe. This pressure is important because it prevents the Doctrine of Closure from mistaking an intuitive narrative, not yet tested by the philosophy of science, for an ontological conclusion.

Compatibility, the Obligation of Labelling, and Reverse Testing

Between scientific material and the propositions of the Doctrine of Closure there are at least three breaks that may not be omitted. First, if physical nonlocality is to become metaphysical wholeness, one must explain why an experimental and theoretical restriction can support higher-level ontological language. Second, if systemic self-organization or quantum correlation is to become ultimate self-establishment, a conversion of level is required; the operational closure of natural systems is not the non-externality of ultimate ground. Third, if information processing, the language of observation, or adaptive behavior is to become subjective presence, a conversion through the philosophy of consciousness is required; otherwise scientific vocabulary is being used to smuggle in the conclusion of Chapter Four's argument for First Consciousness.¹⁵²

Chapter Six therefore establishes a rule of reverse testing: whenever a sentence in the main text moves from a quantum concept toward an ontological judgment, one should ask whether there is an explicit interpretive bridge between them. To say that Bell's theorem restricts certain pictures of local hidden variables belongs to the philosophy of science. To say that it leaves room for metaphysical language of wholeness is already ontological interpretation. To say that it supports First Consciousness is an overreach. To say that the Many-Worlds Interpretation challenges single-path destiny is reasonable pressure. To say that many worlds proves multiple closures is still excessive inference.

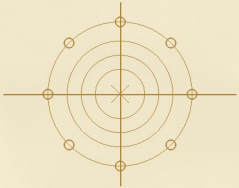
The same rule applies to the idea of compatibility. That a given scientific theory does not oppose the Doctrine of Closure does not mean that it proves the Doctrine of Closure. That a scientific material can enter dialogue with the Doctrine of Closure does not mean that it becomes a pillar of the Doctrine of Closure. Compatibility is the lowest threshold; proof is the highest demand. The two must not be confused. What Chapter Six can bring to the present theory is chiefly safety at the minimum threshold: the Doctrine of Closure should not plainly contradict modern physics, nor should it build itself upon crude misunderstandings of modern physics.¹⁵³

The conclusion of this chapter follows: modern quantum theory indeed places pressure on several classical, local, linear, and fragmentary intuitions concerning the world. This gives the Doctrine of Closure's language of wholeness a wider space for dialogue. Yet quantum theory has not proved First Consciousness, God, the oneness of all things, or closed-loop destiny. Ontological proof must finally return to the conceptual chain in the first five chapters concerning ultimate ground, self-establishment, closure, First Consciousness, and the relation between

¹⁵²These three breaks correspond respectively to conversions of level in physical concepts, systemic concepts, and concepts of consciousness. To omit the conversions would be to misuse scientific terms as metaphysical shortcuts.

¹⁵³"Compatibility is not proof" is the highest methodological restriction of this chapter. Scientific materials may show that the present theory need not directly conflict with certain modern scientific pictures, and may also force the theory to revise its tone; yet ontological proof must still be borne by the conceptual chain developed earlier.

whole and local. The value of Chapter Six lies not in crowning the Doctrine of Closure, but in ensuring that it does not overstep in the name of science.



Part I The Theoretical Core

Chapter Seven

Echoes of Doubt and the Boundaries of Thought - Major Objections, Distinctions of Level, and Theoretical Limits

This chapter states the principal objections
and theoretical limits, so that the core
propositions developed above may formally
enter a position open to attack.

Chapter Seven Echoes of Doubt and the Boundaries of Thought - Major Objections, Distinctions of Level, and Theoretical Limits

The Function of the Testing Station: Limitation Is Not Retreat, but Disciplined Argument

The task of Chapter Seven is not to defend the first six chapters once again, nor to supplement Chapter Four's account of First Consciousness or Chapter Five's philosophical naming of God. Its function is to send the ontological model established in the first six chapters into the arena of objections. If the Doctrine of Closure is to become an academic model fit for discussion, it must not only state what it can say; it must also mark clearly what it cannot directly establish, where it is most vulnerable to attack, and which propositions must be downgraded when pressure is brought against them.

Thus the limits set forth in this chapter are not gestures of polite modesty, but part of the method of argument itself. Their function is to prevent later chapters from smuggling one level into another through cross-domain materials: philosophical propositions cannot be supplemented by religious symbols as proof; theological objections cannot be overridden by scientific terminology; scientific materials cannot be rewritten into iron proofs of ontology. Every proposition involving ontology, ethics, philosophy of consciousness, theology, Buddhism, or scientific compatibility must retain its own criteria. This rule of stratification is the precondition for the later arguments to enter a strict confrontation at all.

In other words, Chapter Seven is not a repetition of Chapter Six. Chapter Six chiefly established rules for the use of scientific language; Chapter Seven establishes the rules of engagement for the second half of the book. The former asks which scientific materials may not overstep their bounds; the latter asks which objections can attack the Doctrine of Closure, how far they can strike, and how the present work ought to respond. Only after the arena has been built securely can the later discussions of free will, theodicy, religious translation, Madhyamaka criticism, and the final disputes avoid becoming scattered statements that merely stand side by side.

Table of Propositional Levels: Core Propositions, Strong Versions, and Symbolic Extensions

To keep all propositions from being mixed into a single degree of force, this chapter first stratifies the chief propositions of the Doctrine of Closure. The first level consists of the core ontological propositions: if existence cannot rest in brute fact or infinite external deferral, then there is reason to require some non-external ultimate ground; closure is at present the candidate form with the greater explanatory power. If this level is wholly defeated, the basic foundation of the Doctrine of Closure is shaken.

The second level consists of the strong-version ontological propositions: ultimate ground is not merely formal closure, but possesses primordial presence; First Consciousness is therefore proposed as a candidate that integrates local first-person experience better than dead structure does. This level is not a formally deductive theorem, but an inference to the best explanation. If it comes under pressure, the non-externality requirement of closure is not thereby destroyed; yet First Consciousness would be forced to descend into a weaker hypothesis of presence.¹⁵⁴

The third level consists of religious and ethical extensions: the philosophical naming of God, broad-sense love, the refusal to silence victims, mistaken existential position, local return, and responsibility within destiny all belong to the high-risk extension of the ontological model into religion, ethics, and the phenomenal world. They are not ornaments, for they determine whether the Doctrine of Closure can face human experience; but neither may they turn back and complete the proof of the core ontology. Whenever later chapters use religious symbols or ethical language, this difference in propositional level must remain in view.

Six Fields of Pressure: Hard Passages That the Later Argument Must Face Directly

In the chapters that follow, the Doctrine of Closure must face at least six fields of pressure.

The first is the pressure of anti-PSR and brute fact: an opponent may ask whether the world truly needs an ultimate ground, or whether it may legitimately stop at 'it is just so.' This pressure strikes directly at the foundations of Chapters Two and Three, demanding that the present work explain why non-externality is not a rational compulsion, but a qualification demanded by the very position of ultimate ground.¹⁵⁵

The second is pressure upon the grammar of closure: is closure only circular reasoning, self-grounding, or another form of static monism? This checkpoint has already been handled in Chapter Three, yet the later argument must continue to obey its result: closure is not the covert use of the conclusion in an inference, nor is it a single node

¹⁵⁴ On inference to the best explanation and theoretical competition, see Igor Douven, "Abduction," Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy. On the philosophy of consciousness, see Nagel, "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?"; Chalmers, *The Conscious Mind*; Goff, *Consciousness and Fundamental Reality*. The present note only marks the inferential level of First Consciousness; it does not present it as a deductive theorem.

¹⁵⁵ For the background of anti-PSR, the principle of sufficient reason, and metaphysical explanation, see Melamed, "Principle of Sufficient Reason"; Brenner, "Metaphysical Explanation"; Fine, "The Question of Realism"; Schaffer, "On What Grounds What."

grounding itself; it is the non-opening of the whole field of establishment at its total boundary toward anything external. If later chapters write closure as a circular mystical image, they will destroy the technical defense already built.

The third is the pressure of First Consciousness and physicalism. Physicalism, emergentism, and illusionism may ask whether local first-person experience truly needs to be carried back to ultimate ground. If naturalistic models can explain subjective presence without remainder, the strong version of First Consciousness must be downgraded. This pressure must not be reopened here as another chapter in the philosophy of consciousness; it need only stand as a hard checkpoint that cannot be cancelled when First Consciousness is tested later.¹⁵⁶

The fourth is the pressure of the ethical and victim-centered defense line. If closure, destiny, or broad-sense love causes those who suffer to be silenced by holism, the theory fails at the ethical level. Suffering cannot become fuel for theory, and evil cannot be absolved merely because the whole will finally return to itself. After Chapter Nine, wherever evil, suffering, and redemption are discussed, the victim's positions of accusation, refusal, and pursuit of accountability must be preserved.¹⁵⁷

The fifth is the theological checkpoint. The Doctrine of Closure defines God as the primordial presence of ultimate ground; this has value for dialogue in philosophical theology. Yet if it incorporates free revelation, personal relation, the Christ-event, and the history of redemption as necessary products of a metaphysical system, then a Barthian criticism will stand. Chapter Seventeen must allow this pressure truly to flow back into the argument, rather than turning theological materials into supporting evidence for the Doctrine of Closure.¹⁵⁸

The sixth is the pressure of Madhyamaka and of the scientific boundary. Madhyamaka will ask whether closure and First Consciousness rebuild a great substance possessing svabhava; scientific materials will remind the present theory that Many-Worlds, quantum interpretations, or other physical models may force 'single closure' to be rewritten as branch-level or total-level closure. The former restricts the theory from substantializing itself; the latter restricts it from treating scientific compatibility as proof.¹⁵⁹

¹⁵⁶For the background of physicalism, the hard problem of consciousness, and cosmopsychism, see Stoljar, "Physicalism"; Nagel, "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?"; Chalmers, *The Conscious Mind*; Frankish, "Illusionism as a Theory of Consciousness"; Shani, "Cosmopsychism."

¹⁵⁷For the background of theodicy, suffering, and the refusal to silence victims, see Augustine, *The City of God*; Stump, "Augustine on Evil"; Hićk, *Evil and the God of Love*; Scarry, *The Body in Pain*. This note supplies only the background of the ethical defense line, and does not use suffering as evidence for the Doctrine of Closure.

¹⁵⁸For Barth's pressure upon natural theology and the freedom of revelation, see Barth, *Church Dogmatics* I/1. For the background of God as ground of being in philosophical theology, see Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, vol. 1. The present work here marks the theological checkpoint; it does not claim to have completed an orthodox doctrine of God.

¹⁵⁹For the pressure of Madhyamaka, see Nāgārjuna, *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*, ch. 24; Garfield, *The Fundamental Wisdom of the Middle Way*; Siderits, *Buddhism as Philosophy*. For Many-Worlds and the background of quantum interpretation, see Everett, "Relative State Formulation of Quantum Mechanics"; Vaidman, "Many-Worlds Interpretation of Quantum Mechanics"; Myrvold, "Philosophical Issues in Quantum Theory."

Three Grades of Objection: Destructive, Downgrading, and Limiting

To prevent later encounters with objection from becoming either total retreat or total rigidity, this chapter divides objections into three kinds. The first is the destructive objection. If an objection of this kind succeeds, the core proposition cannot be preserved. For example, if an anti-PSR route can show that the demand for ultimate ground is itself meaningless, or that non-externality is merely a psychological preference rather than a conceptual qualification, then the ontological entrance of the Doctrine of Closure fails.

The second is the downgrading objection. This kind of objection does not necessarily destroy the whole book, but it forces certain propositions to lower their degree of force. If physicalism can sufficiently account for first-person presence, First Consciousness may retreat to its minimal version; if Many-Worlds gains a stronger status, single closure may need to be downgraded into independent closures of multiple universes, or rewritten as a branching structure under total closure; if Madhyamaka criticism succeeds, First Consciousness must avoid being written as a final entity capable of being grasped.

The third is the limiting objection. It does not necessarily force a proposition to be downgraded, but it limits the use of that proposition. Most of the scientific rules in Chapter Six belong to this kind: quantum materials may serve as compatibility checks, but not as proofs of First Consciousness; Buddhist materials may serve as pressure against substantialization, but cannot be converted into evidence for the Doctrine of Closure; theological materials may enter dialogue, but cannot be absorbed as illustrations within a philosophical system. The value of limiting objections lies in keeping the theory disciplined rather than expansively uncontrolled.¹⁶⁰

¹⁶⁰The categories 'destructive,' 'downgrading,' and 'limiting' are methodological classifications used by this work to judge the force of objections in the later chapters; they are not classifications belonging to an existing school. For the relevant methodological background, see Douven, "Abduction"; Brenner, "Metaphysical Explanation."

Rules of Engagement for the Later Chapters: Objections Must Flow Back into the Main Text

The key of Chapter Seven is not to list objections and then leave them aside, but to require those objections to flow back into the later main text. When Chapter Eight handles destiny and free will, it must acknowledge that ethical weight is not simply equivalent to the result having been otherwise possible. When Chapter Nine handles evil and suffering, it must allow the victim-centered defense line genuinely to limit holism. When Chapter Thirteen handles religious symbols, it must not allow mythic language to turn back and prove ontological propositions.

Likewise, when Chapter Seventeen handles Christianity, Barthian criticism must become a genuine opponent, not a courteous footnote; when Chapter Eighteen handles Buddhism, the anti-svabhava pressure of Madhyamaka must be capable of threatening the substantializing tone of First Consciousness; and when Chapter Nineteen conducts the final disputes, anti-PSR, Many-Worlds, physicalism, Barth, Madhyamaka, and the victim-centered defense line must all re-enter. If a strong claim cannot find its opponent, it is not a mature proposition, but only an authorial declaration.

Therefore, every later cross-domain paragraph should answer four questions: is it proving, testing, limiting, or translating? Which level of proposition does it attack or support? If it succeeds, does it destroy, downgrade, or limit? Does it wrongly absorb an external tradition into the materials of the Doctrine of Closure? These four questions constitute the minimum rules of engagement for the chapters that follow.

Closure of Part I: From Constructive Model to Public Confrontation

At this point, the first six chapters have completed the ontological construction and methodological boundaries of the Doctrine of Closure: Chapter One sets the scale of the problem; Chapter Two handles brute fact and infinite external deferral; Chapter Three establishes the structural grammar of closure; Chapter Four introduces First Consciousness; Chapter Five completes the philosophical naming of God and the local mechanism; and Chapter Six marks the boundaries for the use of scientific materials. Chapter Seven converts these achievements into an academic model that can be attacked.

This conversion is important. Without Chapter Seven, the first six chapters could easily be read as a closed and self-coherent private metaphysics. With Chapter Seven, the Doctrine of Closure is forced to acknowledge where it may be refuted, downgraded, or limited. This does not weaken the theory; it lets the theory move from declaration

into engagement. The later discussions of ethics, cosmic narrative, religious translation, theological testing, Buddhist criticism, and final dispute must all proceed under this rule.¹⁶¹

The minimum contribution of Chapter Seven is to transform the Doctrine of Closure from an 'author's account' into a 'limited model.' A limited model may still preserve strong claims, but every strong claim must have a corresponding entrance for attack. Only when a theory knows which propositions must be defended to the end, which may be rewritten, and which may serve only as symbolic display, does it truly enter academic discussion.

The constructive part of Part I closes here; henceforth, the Doctrine of Closure is no longer merely building itself from within, but receiving trial under external pressure.

¹⁶¹This chapter serves as the point of transition between the constructive part of Part I and the later testing chapters. Its purpose is to place the core propositions within a procedure in which they may be refuted or downgraded. Later chapters must distinguish accordingly among proof, testing, limitation, and translation.

Part II Ontological Application

Chapter Eight

Destiny and Free Will - The Price of Closure's Establishment

This chapter treats the tension between
destiny and free will, and examines the
ethical price that closure must bear if it is to
stand.

Chapter Eight Destiny and Free Will - The Price of Closure's Establishment

Chapter Eight is the most dangerous point at which the Doctrine of Closure turns from ontological construction toward ethical risk. The preceding chapters have argued that if ultimate ground cannot rest in brute fact or infinite external deferral, it must seek some closure able to gather back its own conditions of establishment; and if closure is not a dead structure, it must also face First Consciousness, primordial presence, and the return of the whole unto itself. Yet once this structure is carried into the problem of destiny and free will, the whole theory immediately faces its sharpest ethical interrogation. If the universe, as closure, finally has only one event-path that can be completed, can a local subject still be responsible? If suffering is only the price of closure's establishment, is the victim merely material sacrificed for theory? If evil deeds are also within destiny, may the perpetrator claim, 'I was merely completing the path already set'? If all things are finally gathered back into the whole, can one still speak of genuine free will?

The task of this chapter is not to soothe these four questions with elegant sentences, but to face them one by one. If the Doctrine of Closure fails here, all later discussions of evil, redemption, liberation, broad love, and religious symbol will lose credibility. Chapter Eight must therefore hold four defensive lines at once: first, destiny does not make responsibility false; second, suffering as a cost of closure does not mean that victims are sacrificed; third, the evildoer cannot use destiny to escape responsibility; fourth, destiny does not preserve a strong freedom able to rewrite the ending from outside the whole, yet it may preserve a limited and genuine freedom of endorsement. These four lines are interlocked; if any one collapses, the Doctrine of Closure slips toward a cold fatalism.

The strategy adopted in this chapter is first to define the ontological meaning of destiny, then to separate destiny from fatalism, and then to redefine free will as 'freedom of endorsement.' Such freedom is not passive acceptance of fate, nor the attempt to call an unchangeable result free. It means that, within a given path, the local subject must still form judgments of reasons, acknowledge its own act, bear consequences, answer to others, and correct its own position after displacement has been disclosed. This route enters dialogue with contemporary compatibilism, especially with Frankfurt's challenge to the principle of alternative possibilities and with Fischer and Ravizza on reasons-responsiveness and guidance control; yet this work does not identify freedom of endorsement directly

with any existing version of compatibilism. It places it back within the relation between whole and local in the Doctrine of Closure.¹⁶²

Freedom of endorsement must first be separated from the problem of 'alternative possibilities.' If freedom must mean that the subject, under exactly the same conditions, could still have chosen otherwise, then the Doctrine of Closure will find freedom difficult to preserve, for closure requires the whole event-path to be finally gatherable and does not permit every local choice to retain an opening by which the ending could be rewritten from outside the whole. Yet whether moral responsibility necessarily requires such strong alternative possibility is itself a contested question in contemporary free-will debate. The importance of Frankfurt-type arguments lies precisely in forcing the question of responsibility to move from 'could one have done otherwise?' toward 'does this action truly belong to this subject?' The Doctrine of Closure may, through this, secure a lower-level defensive line for freedom of endorsement: the local subject may not be able to rewrite the global result, but it can still become the bearer of responsibility for this action through its reasons, desires, judgments, and acceptance of consequence. This does not prove that the Doctrine of Closure has solved the problem of free will; it only shows that it need not be defeated at the outset by the criticism that, without alternative possibilities, there is no responsibility.

More precisely, freedom of endorsement stands nearer to reasons-responsiveness and guidance control than to a strong libertarian freedom. The local subject within closure is not an object dragged along by an external script. It must still form judgments of reasons within finite cognition, character, history, relations, and situation. If a person can understand reasons, respond to reasons, correct displacement, and bear the consequences of actions upon others, such responsibility cannot be dismissed as a mere illusion. What the Doctrine of Closure gives up is sovereignty to rewrite the universe from outside the whole; what it preserves is the local subject as an agent capable of blame, repentance, and repair within its own position. This is limited freedom, not omnipotent freedom; yet it is enough to prevent destiny from becoming a fatalism without responsibility.¹⁶³

Fourfold Objection and the Ethical Danger of This Chapter

¹⁶²Harry G. Frankfurt, "Alternate Possibilities and Moral Responsibility," *Journal of Philosophy* 66.23 (1969): 829-839; Frankfurt, "Freedom of the Will and the Concept of a Person," *Journal of Philosophy* 68.1 (1971): 5-20; John Martin Fischer and Mark Ravizza, *Responsibility and Control: A Theory of Moral Responsibility*, Cambridge UP, 1998. This work borrows from compatibilism its problem-consciousness concerning responsibility and alternative possibilities, but it does not identify 'freedom of endorsement' with any existing version of compatibilism.

¹⁶³Harry G. Frankfurt, "Alternate Possibilities and Moral Responsibility," *Journal of Philosophy*, vol. 66, no. 23, 1969, pp. 829-839; Frankfurt, "Freedom of the Will and the Concept of a Person," *Journal of Philosophy*, vol. 68, no. 1, 1971, pp. 5-20; John Martin Fischer and Mark Ravizza, *Responsibility and Control: A Theory of Moral Responsibility*, Cambridge UP, 1998, chs. 2-4. This work draws only upon Frankfurt's pressure on the principle of alternative possibilities and upon Fischer and Ravizza's grammar of guidance control and reasons-responsiveness; it does not identify 'freedom of endorsement' directly with any existing compatibilist version.

The first objection is this: if all is destined, is human responsibility false? This question cannot be answered merely by saying that responsibility remains important. If all acts, repentance, evasion, acknowledgement, and repair already belong to the path of closure, responsibility seems to become a psychological label inside a predetermined structure. The Doctrine of Closure must explain that the truth of responsibility does not depend on the subject's ability to stand outside the whole and rewrite the result, but on whether the local subject, in its concrete position, forms reasons, bears consequences, and becomes the inescapable site at which the action occurs.

The deeper difficulty is that the Doctrine of Closure is easily driven toward modal collapse. If whole closure requires a single event-path, and if that path is understood as cancelling all possibilities, then words such as 'possibility,' 'choice,' 'repentance,' and 'responsibility' may lose all substantive meaning. Chapter Eight cannot evade this danger. To avoid it, the Doctrine of Closure must distinguish 'the completed uniqueness of the ontological level' from 'the openness of reasons at the local level.' The former means that if the whole is finally to stand, its conditions of establishment cannot scatter into an unrecoverable outside. The latter means that the local subject still genuinely faces uncertainty, conflict, judgment, and consequence in experience. For the local subject, the future is not a script transparently unfolded in advance; it is lived through risk, hesitation, responsibility, and pain.

The Doctrine of Closure should therefore not say that 'all possibilities are false.' The steadier formulation is this: possibility does not possess final branching sovereignty at the ontological end-level, yet it still has a real function at the local experiential and ethical levels. When a person chooses, he is not creating another universe outside the whole; he is responding, from a finite position, to reasons that he can understand. If his judgment of reasons is corrupted, responsibility arises. If his displaced position is disclosed, repentance arises. If his act harms others, the demand for repair arises. None of these disappear because closure stands. What the Doctrine of Closure must preserve is not an unconditionally open future in the strong-libertarian sense, but the continued reality of local reasons, responsibility, and repentance within the structure of destiny.¹⁶⁴

The second objection is this: if suffering is the price of closure, are victims sacrificed by theory? This is the ethical line from which this chapter must not retreat. If the Doctrine of Closure says that finitude, difference, pain, and local friction are structural costs of the whole's completion, it can easily be criticized for placing victims upon the altar of theory. To avoid this, the present work must sharply distinguish the cost-language of the ontological level

¹⁶⁴Peter van Inwagen, *An Essay on Free Will*, Clarendon Press, 1983; Robert Kane, *The Significance of Free Will*, Oxford UP, 1996; Fischer and Ravizza, *Responsibility and Control*, chs. 1-4. Van Inwagen and Kane serve as background pressures from incompatibilism and libertarianism. This work does not accept all their premises, but it acknowledges that if freedom must preserve strong alternative possibility, the Doctrine of Closure's 'freedom of endorsement' can only constitute a weaker version.

from the accountability-language of the concrete ethical level. Suffering may be understood within the whole, but it must not be silenced by holism; victims may be acknowledged by theory, but theory may not require them to reconcile.

The third objection is this: if human beings only endorse their destiny locally, may the evildoer say, 'In any case, I too was destined'? This objection strikes the place where the Doctrine of Closure is most easily abused. If destiny can be used by the perpetrator to evade responsibility, the Doctrine of Closure becomes ethically dangerous. The answer here must be hard: destiny only says how an event is placed within the whole; it does not cancel the concrete ethical interrogation of the actor. The perpetrator is precisely the one who causes harm within the local path. Even if his act is contained by the whole, it therefore loses none of the necessity of blame, punishment, isolation, repair, and memory.

The fourth objection is this: under destiny, is there still genuine free will? Here it must be admitted that the Doctrine of Closure does not preserve a strong-libertarian version of freedom, in which the local subject can, under exactly the same total conditions, open from outside the whole another final path. If freedom is defined as this external power of rewriting, the Doctrine of Closure cannot preserve it. Yet this does not mean that the theory must accept the total absence of freedom. What this work preserves is another real freedom: the local subject forms reasons in its finite position, undergoes judgment, bears consequences, answers to others, and recognizes its action as part of itself. Freedom is not the power to escape closure, but the power to become a real bearer within closure.¹⁶⁵

The pace of this chapter must therefore be slow. It cannot compress destiny, freedom, responsibility, suffering, evil, and the position of the victim into a few slogans. It must build levels step by step: destiny belongs to the ontological-structural level; freedom of endorsement belongs to the local ethical and conscious level; suffering concerns the bodily and experiential level; evil concerns the concrete ethical level; and the victim-defense line limits holism from swallowing the local. Only when these levels have been fixed does Chapter Eight earn the right to move into the later discussions of theodicy, redemption, and liberation.

¹⁶⁵This note marks a conceptual limit: this work does not preserve the strong version of libertarian free will, namely that a local subject, under exactly the same total conditions, can open another final path from outside the whole. It does preserve responsibility-type, reasons-responsive, and endorsement-type freedom.

The Ontological Meaning of Destiny: Closure Is Not a Loose Collection

[Proposition 8] Destiny is not oppression; it is the price paid for the universe to exist as universe. The paradox of destiny is that even acknowledgement itself is already determined.

If closure is not a loose collection, but a whole able to return completely unto itself, then it imposes an exceedingly high demand upon the event-path. Every local event is not an isolated point, but a segment of curvature in the structure of return; every experience that appears contingent participates, in some manner, in whether the whole can close. If any segment could be utterly rewritten at the final level, there would be no guarantee that the whole could gather back its own conditions with precision. From this perspective, destiny is not an external tyrant imposing oppression upon the world; it is the geometrical price that the establishment of closure must pay.

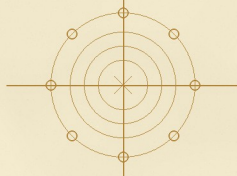
This 'geometrical price' is not a scientific proposition, but ontological language. It means that if the whole is finally to become a complete and returnable figure, local events cannot be understood as free fragments wholly external to the whole. The meaning of an event lies not only in its occurrence at the moment, but also in its relation of return to the whole. Destiny is therefore not a mechanical script written in advance, but the structural demand that successful closure cannot permit its conditions of establishment to scatter arbitrarily.

This chapter must avoid writing destiny as 'every detail mechanically pushed by an external force.' That would reduce the Doctrine of Closure to crude determinism. The more exact formulation is this: from the standpoint of the completed whole, no event can scatter outside closure; from the standpoint of local experience, the subject still undergoes uncertainty, choice, resistance, regret, acknowledgement, and correction in time. The gatheredness of the whole level cannot cancel the ongoing experience of the local level.

For this reason, destiny does not mean that 'whatever you do makes no difference.' That sentence belongs to fatalism, not to the Doctrine of Closure. What the Doctrine of Closure says is: everything you do cannot escape the whole. The former cancels action; the latter gives action greater weight. If harm, evasion, repentance, repair, and memory are all contained by the whole, they do not become ineffective because they are contained. On the contrary, they become still less forgettable, less transferable, and less dismissible as unrelated to the actor.

The paradox of destiny is that even the acknowledgement of destiny itself belongs to the destined path. This appears suffocating, yet it also sharpens responsibility: if acknowledgement, refusal, evasion, and repentance are all contained, then the subject cannot say, 'I was merely dragged along by destiny.' Being dragged along,

acknowledging that one is dragged along, resisting being dragged along, and harming others by using being dragged along as an excuse are not the same local position. Destiny does not erase positional difference; it only makes every position something the whole must finally bear.



Destiny Is Not Fatalism: Action Remains the Content of the Path

Fatalism usually means that since the result is already settled, action has no meaning. Acting and not acting, resisting and yielding, repenting and not repenting seem to be only surface differences on the way to the same result. If the Doctrine of Closure accepted this interpretation, it would destroy its own ethical structure. Once action makes no difference, responsibility, repentance, repair, punishment, memory, and redemption all become dramatic ornaments rather than real events within the local world.

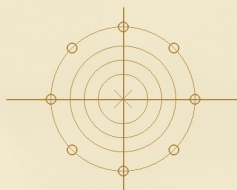
The destiny of the Doctrine of Closure is not this kind of fatalism. It does not say that action is meaningless; it says that action itself is the content of closure. The local subject's judgment, error, resistance, repentance, evasion, and repair are not additions outside closure, but concrete contents that closure must gather back. If these events were removed, closure would not be a living whole, but only an abstract structure. This is also why the earlier chapters repeatedly distinguish dead structure from First Consciousness: if closure is only graphic closing, without local experience, endurance, and return, it cannot bear the thickness of existence.

The relation between destiny and action therefore cannot be simplified into the question of whether action can change the result. If 'changing the result' means producing another final path from outside the whole, then the Doctrine of Closure certainly preserves no such power. But if 'action has meaning' means that the local subject truly forms its reasons, produces its effects, and bears its consequences, then destiny does not cancel this. Precisely because action belongs to the only path that can be completed, action cannot be treated as a dispensable psychological shadow.

Repentance and non-repentance are not the same thing. Acknowledging harm and refusing to acknowledge it are not the same thing. Protecting victims and demanding that victims keep silent are, still more, not the same thing. Even if closure finally contains all things within the whole, these local differences still have real weight and cannot be erased by the phrase 'such is the whole.' If the Doctrine of Closure cannot do this, it no longer stands ethically. This also corrects the early tone of the 'single completed path.' Singularity should not be understood as if every local experience were pushed by an external force like a single-line script. It should be understood as the final non-scattering of the conditions of establishment inside a successful closure. The local subject still judges, regrets, chooses, and bears in experience; these are not illusions, but necessary contents by which closure becomes a world of life and not a dead structure.

Chapter Eight must therefore first establish this: destiny does not answer the question, 'Can I escape the whole?' It answers the question, 'Can I produce a wholly outward-scattering path outside the whole?' The answer of the Doctrine of Closure is no. Yet this no does not mean that local choice loses its force. The force of local choice does

not lie in escape, but in the fact that it truly constitutes part of the whole. Its force lies not in whether it can rewrite the universe, but in making a certain local position become the ethical reality of this person, at this time, in this event.



Formal Definition of Freedom of Endorsement

[Proposition 9] Free will is not the power to overthrow fate, but the capacity to endorse it.

'Freedom of endorsement' is the central and most easily misunderstood concept of this chapter. Endorsement does not mean psychologically liking one's fate, nor finding dignity before a result that cannot be changed, nor obediently accepting a predetermined path. It means that, within the given path, the local subject must still form judgments of reasons, acknowledge its own actions, bear consequences, answer to others, and correct its own position after displacement has been disclosed. In other words, freedom of endorsement is not escape from destiny, but the refusal to push one's own action outside oneself within destiny.

This definition contains at least three conditions.

First, the subject must form judgments of reasons under finite information, rather than simply be dragged by external force. Second, the subject must be able to recognize the action as 'what I have done,' rather than hand it over entirely to destiny, institution, trauma, character, or another person. Third, after acting, the subject must bear the consequences caused to others and to the shared world.

Without these three points, freedom becomes only a passive footnote to destiny.

Freedom of endorsement loses the external sovereignty to rewrite the whole result; it preserves the capacity by which local life recognizes its act as 'what I have done' and 'what I must bear.' This freedom is not splendid, nor does it satisfy every theory of free will that demands open possibility. Yet it is enough to stop the Doctrine of Closure from slipping into the crude fatalism that says: since the whole is already settled, the local bears no responsibility.

Here one point must be stressed: endorsement is not the victim's endorsement of another person's evil deed. The victim has no obligation to endorse the perpetrator's violence, nor to complete reconciliation on behalf of the whole. The one who must first endorse is the actor, in relation to the consequences of his own act. If the Doctrine of Closure requires the victim to 'endorse' suffering inflicted by another, it turns the concept of freedom into an instrument of oppression. On the side of the perpetrator, freedom means the inability to escape responsibility; on the side of the victim, it means not being forced by theory to complete reconciliation for another.

Freedom of endorsement therefore has a clear ethical direction. It does not tell people to say yes to everything that happens. It requires actors not to say that the harm they caused has nothing to do with them. It does not romanticize

suffering; it prevents the local subject from disguising its own position as a position without responsibility. It does not reduce freedom to psychological consolation, but relocates freedom as the capacity of the local subject to bear its own reasons, actions, and consequences.

This also makes freedom of endorsement different from mere inner peace. One person may psychologically accept everything, yet still refuse to bear the harm he has caused; another may still resist destiny in pain, yet honestly acknowledge his own action and its consequences. The former is not necessarily free; the latter is not necessarily unfree. What the Doctrine of Closure calls endorsement concerns not a feeling of calm, but whether the position of responsibility is acknowledged.

Dialogue with Compatibilism: Alternative Possibilities and Reasons-Responsiveness

Freedom of endorsement plainly enters dialogue with contemporary compatibilism. Compatibilism usually does not bind freedom wholly to the claim that the subject, under absolutely unconditional conditions, could have done something else. It asks whether an action issues from the subject's own reasons, character, identification, and capacity to respond. This route is useful for the Doctrine of Closure, because this work likewise refuses to understand freedom as unconditional arbitrariness. If freedom can stand only when it is wholly detached from causality, history, character, and the structure of the whole, then freedom becomes an empty leap without content.¹⁶⁶

Frankfurt's challenge to alternative possibilities is especially important. He reminds us that responsibility may not depend only on whether, at a given moment, a person possessed a fully open possibility of acting otherwise; it also depends on whether the action truly issued from the person's will-structure and self-identification. The Doctrine of Closure may draw upon this problem-consciousness, but it cannot import it unchanged into its own system. For the Doctrine of Closure faces not only the general compatibility of determinism and responsibility, but the question of how local responsibility still stands when the whole path has already been closed.¹⁶⁷

Fischer and Ravizza's emphasis on guidance control and reasons-responsiveness also provides a useful boundary. If a subject is wholly unable to respond to reasons, wholly unable to understand consequences, and wholly unable to be questioned about the position of its act, responsibility becomes empty. The freedom of endorsement in the Doctrine of Closure cannot fall below this line. Even if the whole path is closed at the highest level, the local subject must still undergo reasons, judgment, response, and consequence at the experiential level. Without these processes, endorsement becomes only the shadow of destiny.¹⁶⁸

Nevertheless, the Doctrine of Closure cannot be simply equated with ordinary compatibilism. Ordinary compatibilism usually seeks compatible conditions among agent, reasons, control, and responsibility. The pressure on the Doctrine of Closure is heavier, because it treats the return of the whole path as an ontological condition. It does not merely say that determinism and responsibility can be compatible; it says that local responsibility must still stand under the condition that the whole has already been closed. This makes freedom of endorsement narrower than ordinary compatibilism, and more dangerous.

¹⁶⁶ Peter van Inwagen, *An Essay on Free Will*, Oxford UP, 1983. The reference marks the basic pressure exerted by incompatibilism upon the compatibility of determinism and responsibility. This work does not claim to have ended the debate over free will.

¹⁶⁷ Frankfurt, "Alternate Possibilities and Moral Responsibility." This work uses only his problem-pressure that responsibility need not depend entirely on absolute alternative possibilities. It does not use Frankfurt cases to prove closure-destiny directly.

¹⁶⁸ Fischer and Ravizza, *Responsibility and Control*, chs. 2-4. Guidance control and reasons-responsiveness serve here only as comparative background for the grammar of responsibility. The Doctrine of Closure still uses 'local bearing' and 'positional endorsement' as its own concepts.

The minimum claim the Doctrine of Closure can preserve is this: responsibility need not depend wholly on a metaphysically open future. If responsibility stands only when all conditions are unsettled, then every deep structure, character, history, and institution would weaken responsibility. But if responsibility ignores conditions altogether, it abstracts the human being into a point of will detached from the world. The Doctrine of Closure chooses a middle route: it acknowledges that conditions cannot be escaped, while insisting that the local subject must still bear its position within those conditions.

The incompatibilist may of course ask whether responsibility still has a real ground if the subject never truly could have done otherwise. This challenge cannot be removed. This chapter only argues that the Doctrine of Closure does not adopt an open future as the sole condition of freedom, but takes reason-formation, action-ownership, consequence-bearing, and position-correction as the minimum ethical conditions of freedom. This is a defensible route, not a completed final answer.

Genuine Free Will: What the Doctrine of Closure Preserves, and What It Surrenders

Whether genuine free will remains under destiny depends on how 'genuine freedom' is understood. If genuine freedom means that the local subject can stand outside the whole and externally rewrite the already completed path of closure, then the Doctrine of Closure must answer: no. Such freedom would allow the conditions of the whole's establishment to scatter arbitrarily outward, and closure could no longer be closure. If the Doctrine of Closure pretended to retain this external sovereignty, it would contradict itself.

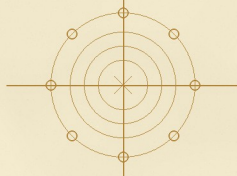
Yet if genuine freedom means that the local subject is not an empty shell, but forms reasons, undergoes judgment, bears consequences, responds to others, and recognizes the action as part of itself within its finite position, then the Doctrine of Closure can answer: yes. This freedom does not create another cosmic result, but it constitutes the ethical content of this cosmic path. It is not omnipotent freedom, but local freedom; not freedom of escape, but freedom of bearing; not unconditional spontaneity, but the formation of oneself within conditions.

Here misunderstanding is easy. Some will say that without the external power to rewrite, there is no true freedom. The Doctrine of Closure accepts this as the criterion of strong libertarianism, but refuses to treat it as the only criterion. Most freedom in actual human experience never takes place in an unconditional vacuum; it is always formed within body, language, history, institution, character, trauma, and relation. The reality of freedom lies not in being wholly unconditioned, but in whether the subject can, within conditions, become a bearer of reasons and responsibility.

The freedom of the Doctrine of Closure is therefore a freedom with cost. It cannot guarantee that 'I could have become another final path in the whole.' It can only guarantee that 'my judgment, resistance, repentance, compensation, and acknowledgement in this finite position are not illusions.' This freedom is less than strong libertarian freedom and more than fatalism. It admits that the local is determined by the whole, yet does not reduce the local to a mute object.

This distinction also protects repentance. Repentance is not the rewriting of the final result from outside closure, but the manner in which closure corrects displacement within local consciousness. If repentance is cancelled by destiny, the later discussion of redemption and liberation in Chapter Fourteen loses content. If repentance is understood as external rewriting, closure is broken. The steadier formulation is this: repentance belongs to the local event of return itself. It is the process by which the subject, within the destined path, newly acknowledges its own position and the weight of the other.

Thus Chapter Eight's conclusion concerning freedom must be clear and not overstated: the Doctrine of Closure does not preserve freedom as external sovereignty; it preserves freedom as local bearing. If the former is demanded, the Doctrine of Closure fails; if the latter is denied, ethics collapses. This is precisely the tension this chapter must hold.



Responsibility Is Not False: The Local Subject Remains the Site at Which Action Occurs

The first central interrogation can be answered directly: if all is destined, human responsibility is not false. Responsibility still stands not because the human being can rewrite closure from outside the whole, but because the local subject remains the position in the concrete world where action occurs, is understood, is borne, and is questioned. Human responsibility lies not in possessing sovereignty outside the universe, but in the inability to push one's action completely outside oneself.

Destiny can explain how an event is placed within the whole; responsibility explains how the local, in its position, answers to the consequences it has caused. The two may not swallow each other. If one speaks only of destiny and not of responsibility, the Doctrine of Closure becomes cold fatalism. If one speaks only of responsibility and not of destiny, the Doctrine of Closure becomes ordinary ethics and loses its ontological structure. The work of Chapter Eight is to let both stand at different levels.

Responsibility includes at least several moments: naming harm, stopping its continuation, protecting victims, interrogating the actor, requiring bearing, seeking compensation, and, only where conditions permit, speaking of repair or reconciliation. All these moments belong to the concrete ethical level and cannot be dissolved by the sentence, at the most fundamental ontological level, that 'all belongs to closure.' If these moments are cancelled, responsibility is no longer a real demand, but only a beautiful word inside theory.

Responsibility is therefore not an abstract label, but a sequence of events. The actor causes harm in one position; the victim suffers rupture in another; the community names, judges, isolates, repairs, and remembers in another. These positions constitute the concrete ethical world. The Doctrine of Closure may say that these positions are finally contained by the whole, but it may not cancel them because they are contained.

This view of responsibility also avoids excessive individualization. Human beings are indeed affected by history, institution, character, and trauma. The Doctrine of Closure should not abstract the human being into a point of will detached from all conditions. Yet acknowledging conditions is not the same as cancelling bearing. Conditions explain how a person comes to a certain place; they do not automatically exempt him from the real consequences inflicted upon others in that place.

The minimum defense of responsibility in the Doctrine of Closure is therefore this: responsibility is not a by-product of an open future, but the inescapability of the local subject in its position with regard to its own action and

its consequences. If an action is actually caused by a subject in a relation, and if that subject still has the capacity to understand, respond, and bear, then destiny cannot draw responsibility away.¹⁶⁹

¹⁶⁹ This note states an ethical limit: destiny is the ontological-level language concerning the placement of the whole path; it is not an exempting language at the concrete ethical level. The perpetrator cannot use "all is destined" to cancel the position of responsibility in a local event.

The Evildoer Cannot Use Destiny to Escape Responsibility

The third central interrogation must be handled separately: may an evildoer say, 'In any case, I too was destined'? The answer must be clear: no. This sentence smuggles the ontological language of destiny into the concrete ethical level as a language of exemption. Destiny explains that evil action too lies within the whole path; it does not say that the evildoer need not bear. The evildoer is precisely the one who causes harm, occupies benefit, oversteps boundaries, or evades interrogation within the local path. He cannot disappear from the event because the event is contained by the whole.

If the evil deed itself is said to be part of the destined path, then punishment, repentance, accountability, and repair may likewise be part of the destined path. Otherwise, destiny will protect only the perpetrator and not the victim. The Doctrine of Closure cannot permit this asymmetry. Disclosure, accusation, judgment, punishment, repair, isolation, and protection can all be real ethical events inside the path of closure.

This point avoids two errors. The first is to use destiny to exempt evil: since the act is already contained by the whole, the perpetrator appears merely to have completed the cosmic script. The second is to use freedom to over-individualize responsibility, as if a person could act wholly detached from historical, characterological, institutional, and traumatic conditions. The steadier position of the Doctrine of Closure is to acknowledge the reality of conditions while refusing to let conditions swallow responsibility.

The evildoer's responsibility lies not only in the claim that he 'could have done otherwise,' but also in the fact that he actually caused harm and occupied the position of causing harm in the shared world. The victim's body, memory, relations, trust, and world are broken. This is not an abstract proposition, but a concrete event. If the perpetrator uses 'destiny' as a shield, he is trying to withdraw himself from the event and leave the harm to be borne by the victim alone.

The Doctrine of Closure must refuse this withdrawal. Destiny does not allow the perpetrator to say, 'I was not there.' On the contrary, destiny leaves him with nowhere to flee, because his action forever belongs to the whole path. If he harmed another, he cannot hand the harm over to fate and withdraw himself. Destiny does not cancel accountability; destiny fixes the position of accountability.

Repentance is crucial here. Repentance is not mere emotion, nor is it completed when one says, 'I feel sad.' It means that the actor no longer disguises his own position as a position without responsibility, and is willing to let the consequences of his act be named, questioned, and repaired. This process may not fully compensate the harm, and it does not guarantee that the victim must forgive; but it prevents the actor from using destiny as evasion and makes him acknowledge within destiny that he must still bear.

Punishment likewise should not be understood as revenge inflicted upon the local from outside closure, but as one way in which the local ethical order restores boundaries. Punishment can be improper, excessive, or abused by institutions; yet the Doctrine of Closure cannot therefore cancel the concept of punishment itself. If evil action can be named as local usurpation, then the local community must possess institutional and ethical language for responding to usurpation.

The Fourfold Distinction of Pain, Suffering, Evil, and Responsibility

[Proposition 10] Pain is the structural cost that closure cannot eliminate; suffering is the subjective resistance of local consciousness to finitude. The awakened one may have pain without suffering in the deepest sense.

To prevent the cost-language of the ontological level from being smuggled into the ethical level as a language of exemption, this chapter must establish a more refined ethical grammar: pain, suffering, evil, and responsibility.

These four are often intertwined in experience, yet they should not be compressed into a single concept. Pain means direct injury within body, psyche, and life-structure. Suffering means the resistance and entanglement formed by local consciousness before finitude, loss, destiny, and misrecognition. Evil means that the local subject raises its desire, power, or position into the final measure, and thereby causes concrete harm to the other and to the shared order. Responsibility is the real demand made by the concrete ethical level concerning harm, repair, judgment, and memory.

Pain is the friction of finite existence. Wherever the local has body, boundary, time, and relation, it can be wounded. Hunger, illness, loss, trauma, aging, and death are vulnerabilities borne by local existence precisely as local. The Doctrine of Closure may understand this vulnerability as the structural cost of differentiation and self-limitation, but it must not beautify every pain as a necessary lesson. Pain is a cost, not a blessing.

Suffering differs from pain. Suffering is the subjective resistance of local consciousness to pain, loss, finitude, destiny, and its own position. This does not mean that suffering is merely a mistaken thought; suffering is often bound together with real harm. Analytically, however, pain names the wound itself, while suffering names the manner in which the subject reads the wound as absolute failure, abandonment, meaninglessness, or the injury of a self taken as center. This distinction has clear space for dialogue with the Buddhist parable of the two arrows, but this work does not identify it directly with Buddhist doctrine.¹⁷⁰

Evil differs again from suffering. The suffering of the victim does not mean that the victim has evil. The perpetrator's causing of another's pain is what constitutes the evil that the ethical level must face. Evil is not mere psychological discomfort, nor the sum of all suffering. Evil involves transgression, usurpation, oppression, deception, violence, betrayal, exploitation, and institutional harm. If evil is psychologized, theory will blend perpetration and victimhood into one mass.

¹⁷⁰The parable of the two arrows in *Samyutta Nikāya* 36.6 may serve as Buddhist background for the distinction between pain and suffering; see Bhikkhu Bodhi, *The Connected Discourses of the Buddha*, Wisdom Publications, 2000. This work does not identify the Doctrine of Closure's grammar of pain and suffering with early Buddhist doctrine.

Responsibility is the element in this fourfold distinction that can least be omitted. If there are only pain and suffering, the theory easily becomes a psychology of practice. If there are only evil and ontological displacement, the theory may become a hard metaphysics. Responsibility brings both back into the shared world: someone is wounded; someone has crossed a boundary, benefited, evaded; someone needs to bear consequences; someone needs protection. If the Doctrine of Closure cannot preserve this level, it will become inaccurate at the ethical level even if it remains self-consistent at the ontological level.

The purpose of this fourfold distinction is not to produce a neat table, but to prevent the most dangerous substitutions. Human beings have pain because local existence has body and vulnerability; they suffer because the local often reads its finite position as the injury of an absolute center; they do evil because the local may raise its own desire or power into the final measure; they must be responsible because harm always falls upon concrete others, concrete bodies, and concrete histories.

The sentence that the awakened one may have pain without suffering in the deepest sense must be strictly limited. It may describe a subject who, in a certain state of practice or re-alignment, no longer treats finitude with absolute resistance. But it cannot be used by an observer to require a victim to let go, nor to deny that harm has occurred. If the language of awakening becomes a tool for blaming victims for 'still being in suffering,' it has fallen from a language of practice into a language of oppression.¹⁷¹

Grave Evil and the Unsilenceable Victim

The second central interrogation is handled here directly: if suffering is the price of closure, are victims sacrificed by theory? The answer must be no, and the reason must be strict. The most dangerous temptation of the Doctrine of Closure is to write every suffering as the price of the whole's completion. If this tone is not limited, it places victims upon the altar of theory, as if their wounds existed only to make the whole narrative more complete. This chapter therefore draws a clear line: rape, murder, torture, slavery, abuse, institutional persecution, and war-violence do not lose the name of evil because they have been placed within the whole of closure.

The most fundamental ontological level may refuse to substantialize evil as a second being equal to God or First Consciousness. But this does not mean that the concrete ethical level may refuse to call evil evil. The value of the Augustinian *privatio boni* lies in its avoidance of ontological dualism; its danger, when crudely used, is that concrete injustice may be spoken of only as privation rather than violence. This work must preserve both

¹⁷¹This note limits the language of awakening: 'having pain without suffering in the deepest sense' can only describe the transformation of a subject's resistance to finitude. It cannot be used to deny that harm has occurred, nor may observers use it to demand that victims let go.

sentences: evil is not a second substance; evil remains real, blameworthy, and accountable at the concrete ethical level.¹⁷²

Grave evil cannot be absolved by holism not only because it violates rules, but because it reduces the other to an instrument, obstacle, or material. This is precisely the concrete ethical form of misrecognition of existential position: the local places its own desire, fear, interest, or power at the center, and forces the other to bear its own misalignment. When this work traces evil to mistaken position, it is not excusing the perpetrator; it is stating the depth of the perpetrator's usurpation.

The victim has no duty to complete reconciliation for the sake of theory. This sentence must become the ethical dead line of Chapter Eight. Every complete holism faces an acute question: how does it face a victim who will not reconcile? If theory requires the victim finally to accept the arrangement of the whole, theory places its own completion before the victim. If theory allows the victim's resistance to remain for a long time, it must admit that the whole does not immediately appear complete within local experience. The Doctrine of Closure should take the second route, because the temporality of local suffering must not be compressed by an ontological conclusion.¹⁷³

The victim's mourning, accusation, refusal of reconciliation, and demand for accountability do not destroy closure; they are contents that closure must bear if it truly contains the local. If the whole loves itself, it must not love only order, completion, and return; it must also bear rupture, wounds, and voices that refuse rapid placement. If theory rushes to turn the victim's accusation into completion as soon as it hears it, it shows that it is not yet mature.

Scarry's analysis of how pain unmakes language and world provides an important warning here. What pain first takes away is often the victim's ability to speak the world clearly. If theory replaces that rupture with fluent concepts, it may take the victim's voice away again. If the Doctrine of Closure is to preserve a human boundary, it must let traumatic memory remain broken, repetitive, and difficult to say within the text, rather than arranging it into a smooth narrative through the language of the whole.¹⁷⁴

The language of redemption must therefore have an order. For the perpetrator, redemption cannot bypass acknowledgement, repentance, accountability, and repair. For the victim, redemption cannot be equated with immediate letting go, silence, or the provision of reasons for the other party. If redemption is opened only to the

¹⁷² Augustine's *privatio boni* route can prevent evil from being substantialized as a second being equal to God; see Augustine, *The City of God*, bks. 11-12; *Confessions*, bk. 7. This work takes only its ontological warning function, and does not use it to cancel concrete ethical responsibility.

¹⁷³ This note states the victim-defense line: this work does not require the victim to complete reconciliation for theory. Forgiveness, if it occurs, can only be the victim's free response within concrete history, relation, and conditions of repair. It cannot be forced by metaphysical derivation or religious slogans.

¹⁷⁴ Elaine Scarry, *The Body in Pain: The Making and Unmaking of the World*, Oxford UP, 1985, Introduction. Scarry's analysis of pain's destruction of language and world serves here as ethical warning-background for the claim that victims must not be silenced by theory.

perpetrator while the victim is required to provide understanding, redemption has been distorted into a second convenience for the offender.

Suffering also must not be written as an educational instrument. Hick's soul-making theodicy supplies both a background for dialogue and a warning: once suffering is written as material for growth, the sufferer may be treated as an instrument serving another person's purpose or the arrangement of the whole. The Doctrine of Closure may learn from the problem-consciousness of that discussion, but it cannot adopt any tone that beautifies suffering. Pain is not theoretical fuel; the victim is not the consumable material of the whole's completion.¹⁷⁵

The Sequence of Repair at the Concrete Ethical Level

To prevent responsibility from remaining an abstract word, the repair-sequence of the concrete ethical level must be unfolded. The first step is naming: acknowledge that a certain harm has occurred, without rewriting it as misunderstanding, cost, fate, or growth. The second is boundary: state who crossed the boundary, who was violated, and which authority was usurped. The third is bearing: do not allow the one who caused harm to hide behind the whole, institution, trauma, or destiny. The fourth is protection: stop the continuation of harm before speaking of deeper understanding. Only fifth comes possible repair, forgiveness, or renewed common life.

The point of this sequence is to place forgiveness last, not first. The problem with many oppressive religious or holistic languages is precisely that they demand forgiveness too early and handle boundary, protection, and responsibility too late. If the Doctrine of Closure is to avoid the same error, it must move forgiveness from a slogan of virtue back into a possible result within concrete relation.

Repair also does not necessarily mean restoration of relationship. After some harms, the ethically proper position is distance, protection, and the impossibility of renewed approach. After some historical violence, what matters most is memory, institutional correction, and public acknowledgement, not private reconciliation. The return spoken of by the Doctrine of Closure should not be misunderstood as requiring all relations to return to their former state. Sometimes the true return is to let the rupture remain in the shared world in the form of being remembered.

This point prevents closure from being imagined as a perfect ending. Closure does not smooth out every wound; it ensures that every local position - including the wounded position, the accusing position, and the position demanding accountability - is not thrown out of the understanding of existence. If the victim's voice remains

¹⁷⁵ John Hick, *Evil and the God of Love*, Palgrave Macmillan, 2010, chs. 14-15. Hick's theodicy serves only as a background for dialogue and as a warning of risk. This work does not adopt the strong formulation that concrete suffering is directly a necessary instrument of soul-making.

piercing in the text, this does not mean the theory has failed. On the contrary, it may mean that the theory has not yet converted pain into a consumable narrative of completion.

Punishment and repair must both be cooled down here. Punishment is not mere revenge, and repair is not cheap reconciliation. The minimum function of punishment is to declare that a boundary has been crossed. The minimum function of repair is to ensure that the victim, the community, and historical memory are not swallowed by the perpetrator's narrative. If theory is eager to transform everything into holistic reconciliation, it has already helped the perpetrator complete what he most desires: the cancellation of boundaries.

The ethical conclusion that the Doctrine of Closure can establish is therefore this: pain must not be mere material for theory; suffering must not be blamed upon the victim; evil must not be reduced to harmless misreading; responsibility is not an illusion that the ontological level can cancel. Only by holding these four sentences does the Doctrine of Closure gain the right to continue speaking of redemption, liberation, and the return of the whole.

Awakening, the Transformation of Suffering, and Ethical Limits

The distinction between pain and suffering enables the Doctrine of Closure to enter dialogue with Buddhist discussions of suffering, practice, and liberation. The early Buddhist parable of the two arrows points out that the first arrow brought by body or event and the second arrow added by the subject through grasping, resistance, and misreading do not belong to the same level. The Doctrine of Closure may use this to explain that pain, as wound or friction of local finitude, may not be eliminable; but suffering, as resistance to finitude and position, may be transformed in some form of awakening or re-alignment.¹⁷⁶

Yet this point must be strictly limited. First, awakening cannot deny pain. Even if the subject no longer treats finitude with absolute resistance, wounds, loss, trauma, and bodily memory may still remain. Second, awakening cannot become a tool by which observers demand that victims let go. Anyone who uses 'you are only attached' to require a victim to stop accusing turns the language of practice into a second oppression.

Third, awakening is not exemption. A perpetrator cannot escape repair by claiming to have understood the whole. If someone says, 'I have seen through suffering,' and on that basis refuses to bear the harm he has caused to others, that is not awakening but a deeper misrecognition of position. If genuine awakening has ethical meaning, it must make one more able to acknowledge the other's pain, not faster at dissolving it into an abstract whole.

Thus the sentence 'the awakened one may have pain without suffering in the deepest sense' can be used only at the level of a subject's own practice. It may describe how someone transforms his own resistance to finitude, but it must not become a criterion for judging a victim as 'not yet awakened.' If the Doctrine of Closure does not hold this boundary, it becomes a cold theory of practice precisely where ethical caution is most needed.

This also reserves an important interface for Chapter Nine. Chapter Eight only makes an initial distinction among pain, suffering, evil, and responsibility. Chapter Nine will deal more deeply with evil, misrecognition of existential position, and the risks of theodicy. Here the method alone can be fixed: no language of liberation may cancel the victim's position; no transformation of suffering may unload the perpetrator's responsibility; no ontological return may compress concrete history into an analogy for practice.

¹⁷⁶Mark Siderits, *Buddhism as Philosophy: An Introduction*, 2nd ed., Hackett, 2021. Buddhist discussions of suffering, ignorance, and grasping serve in this work only as background for dialogue concerning practice; they must not be used to blame victims for 'not letting go.'

Intuition, Miracle, and Levels of Freedom

Chapter Eight also touches intuition and miracle. If these concepts are handled carelessly, they will push the problem of freedom toward mystification. Intuition may be understood as the local consciousness's low-resolution reading of a complex order, but it is not an infallible inner oracle. A miracle may be understood as a rare node in which extraordinary meaning appears in the local world, but it is not an external deity temporarily breaking causality to repair the plot. Neither can prove the Doctrine of Closure in reverse.

The role of intuition in the problem of freedom is, at most, to suggest a direction not yet fully conceptualized by the subject. It can aid bearing; it can also be misread. It can lead a person to face his own position; it can also become self-rationalization. If the Doctrine of Closure sacralizes intuition, it weakens responsibility. If it denies intuition altogether, it makes the local subject into a passive node moved only by external rules. The steadier formulation is to place intuition at the level of local reading, not at the level of ontological proof.

The same is true of miracle. If miracle is written as the temporary breaking of closure, the Doctrine of Closure loses its structure. If miracle is wholly cancelled, the chapter on religious symbolic translation becomes mere rhetoric. The more reasonable treatment in this work is to regard miracle as the appearing of extraordinary meaning in certain events at the level of local reading, while its ontological status remains subject to the returnability of the whole of closure. This preserves the thickness of religious experience while avoiding the replacement of argument by miracle.¹⁷⁷

Freedom, intuition, and miracle thus belong to different levels. Freedom treats how the local subject bears its act and position. Intuition treats how the local subject anticipates or reads order. Miracle treats how the local world understands rare events as nodes of meaning. All three belong to local reading and the ethical level; they cannot turn back and serve as proofs of ultimate ground.

This stratification prevents Chapter Eight from turning the problem of destiny into a quick mystical solution. If the question of freedom slips too quickly into intuition, responsibility is replaced by subjective feeling. If miracle is used to solve destiny, closure is broken by external exception. What Chapter Eight must do is preserve the weight of local bearing without external exception and without mystical shortcut.

¹⁷⁷Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, vol. 1; Karl Barth, *Church Dogmatics I/1*, §§1-4. Intuition and miracle in this work belong to the level of local reading and religious symbol; they cannot prove ontological propositions in reverse, nor can they replace theological criteria of revelation.

Open Future, Modal Collapse, and the Narrowing of the Language of Freedom

The deepest pressure upon the Doctrine of Closure is this: if the whole can finally be gathered back, has the future ever truly been open? If the future has never been open, do choice, repentance, and responsibility still have real meaning? This is the pressure of modal collapse. It does not simply ask whether physics is deterministic; it asks whether, once the whole is ontologically closed, possibility itself loses its contrast.

The Doctrine of Closure cannot answer by simply saying, 'possibilities are only illusions.' If all possibilities are cancelled, local deliberation, struggle, waiting, hesitation, fear, hope, and repentance are flattened. The more exact treatment is to distinguish the level of completed whole from the level of local experience. At the level of completed whole, one may say that successful closure finally has only one complete path gathered back; at the level of local experience, the subject still genuinely faces time not yet unfolded, finite information, incomplete judgment, and uncertain consequences.

From the local perspective, the future is not a closed figure already possessed by the subject. The local subject does not know how the whole will be completed, and does not have the right to look back upon the whole from its end. For this reason, local choice, hesitation, and bearing are not theatre. They are the way closure is read within time, and the reality that the local subject, as local, must undergo. Completion at the whole level does not mean transparency at the local level.

This treatment allows 'possibility' to be retained as local grammar, not as ultimate ontological grammar. The local subject may reasonably say, 'I can choose to apologize or to evade,' because in its finite information and practical situation both appear as intelligible directions of action. Even if, from the level of completed whole, only one of them is finally realized, the local level's possibility still functions within judgment and responsibility.

One may object that this is only epistemic possibility, not genuine ontological possibility. The Doctrine of Closure can acknowledge this and narrow its own claim. It does not claim that the local subject possesses multiple outward-opening possibilities at the final ontological level. It claims only that the local subject, at the experiential, ethical, and reason-levels, genuinely faces intelligible divergences of action. Though this possibility is not branch-reality at the ultimate level, it is sufficient to form the practical field of responsibility, hesitation, and bearing.

Thus the Doctrine of Closure need not preserve an open future in the strongest sense, nor dissolve every possibility into illusion. It can say this: at the level of ultimate completion, closure requires that the conditions of establishment not scatter outward; at the level of local practice, the subject still faces intelligible directions of

action in finite time. If the two levels are mixed, theory will fall into one of two errors: either destroying closure for the sake of freedom, or destroying ethics for the sake of closure.

This distinction also helps with the language of 'I could have avoided it.' When a person says that he could have avoided harm, he is not necessarily claiming that he once possessed the power to rewrite the universe from outside the whole. More likely, he is acknowledging that, within his local structure of reasons and situational conditions, there was another direction that he ought to have recognized, chosen, or answered to. The function of this reflective language is to stop the subject from describing his own act as an unquestionable natural event.

In the Doctrine of Closure, therefore, 'I could have avoided it' is not an ultimate branching proposition, but a proposition of responsible reflection. It does not mean that the whole actually had another completed path; it means that the actor, in his local reasons and ethical position, had a duty to see another ought. If this language is entirely removed, repentance loses content. If it is elevated into an ultimate ontology of multiple paths, closure is broken. Chapter Eight must place it at the middle level.

It follows that the tension between destiny and genuine free will should not be handled as all-or-nothing. The Doctrine of Closure surrenders the strongest freedom of opening a path from outside; it preserves local reasons, practical possibility, and responsible reflection. This preservation is not a bait-and-switch, but a stratification. If the freedom demanded by the reader is absolute sovereignty outside the whole, the Doctrine of Closure cannot satisfy it. But if the reader admits that freedom can also mean the subject becoming an agent within its concrete structure of reasons and responsibility, then the Doctrine of Closure can still preserve a limited and real freedom.

The Threefold Structure of Victim, Perpetrator, and Community

Chapter Eight cannot speak only of individual freedom. It must put responsibility back into a threefold structure: perpetrator, victim, and community. If it speaks only of the perpetrator's freedom of endorsement, theory easily becomes the stage of the offender's self-reflection. If it speaks only of the victim's pain, theory may lose accountability for the actor. If it ignores the community, punishment, protection, memory, and repair become private emotions. To preserve ethical weight, the Doctrine of Closure must handle all three at once.

The position of the perpetrator is the position of action and bearing. The perpetrator cannot use destiny as a shield, cannot treat his own trauma as a complete explanation, and cannot substitute remorse for repair. Even if his act is affected by past conditions, institutional environment, and psychological structure, he remains the one who caused

harm in the local event. The Doctrine of Closure may acknowledge the complexity of conditions, but it cannot let complex conditions dissolve the actor's position.

The victim's position is the position of suffering and witness. The victim need not prove that his pain is useful to theory, nor arrange his experience into a form acceptable to philosophy. His accusation may be broken; his memory may repeat; his refusal to reconcile may remain for a long time. Theory cannot require the victim to put the intelligibility of the whole first, because what the victim first faces is the rupture of body, world, and trust.

The community's position is the position of boundary and memory. The community cannot privatize harm, as if it were enough for perpetrator and victim to deal with it privately. Many evil acts themselves have public force: they damage trust, produce fear, alter institutional relations, and make certain people no longer able to exist safely in the shared world. The community therefore has responsibility to name, judge, protect, isolate, repair, and remember.

This threefold structure makes freedom of endorsement more exact. The perpetrator must endorse his action; the victim need not endorse another's evil; the community must endorse its own responsibility in handling harm. If the community says, from a posture of neutrality, 'all is destiny,' it is in fact evading its own position. Destiny cannot exempt the community; on the contrary, it makes the community's silence too an inescapable event within the path of closure.

This point applies especially to institutional evil. Institutional persecution, slavery, cultures of sexual violence, racial oppression, or collective bullying cannot be explained only by one perpetrator and one victim. They involve institutions, bystanders, language, custom, and structures of benefit. If the Doctrine of Closure speaks only of individual endorsement, it is too narrow. It must also ask how the community endorses the ways in which it maintains, permits, or beautifies harm.

Responsibility is therefore not only personal responsibility. It includes institutional responsibility and responsibility of memory. Personal responsibility asks who acted; institutional responsibility asks what structure made harm easier to occur; responsibility of memory asks how the community avoids pushing victims out of history. All these forms of responsibility belong to the local ethical level and cannot be cancelled by ontological destiny.

If the Doctrine of Closure can stand here, it will avoid two ethical dangers. First, it will not blame all evil upon abstract structure and thereby let individuals escape. Second, it will not blame all evil upon individuals and thereby ignore institutions and communities. Freedom of endorsement is therefore not only a personal psychological concept, but a multi-layered bearing of the local world upon its own positions.

Grace, Calling, and the Theological Limits of Destiny

Although Chapter Eight chiefly belongs to free will and ethics, it inevitably touches theological questions. If all things are destined within closure, is there still room for grace, calling, and repentance? If God or First Consciousness is only the primordial presence of the whole closure, is human turning only an internal self-correction of closure? These questions cannot be fully resolved in this chapter, but limits must be set in advance; otherwise the later theological chapter will bear still heavier pressure.

First, grace cannot be written as an arbitrary external insertion. If grace is understood as God's temporary breaking of closure, the ontological structure of the Doctrine of Closure is broken. Yet grace also cannot be reduced to a naturally necessary process, or the free calling of God in theology will be dissolved. The steadier formulation is to understand grace, provisionally, as an event in which the local subject is reopened to the possibility of return within closure. Ontologically it does not break closure; experientially it can be read as a summons beyond self-mastery.

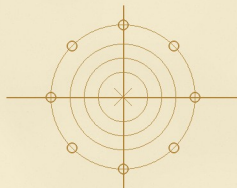
Second, calling cannot be reduced to psychological impulse. The local subject may, in certain events, feel called, rebuked, consoled, or newly positioned. These experiences cannot directly prove an ontological proposition, but neither can they be simply dismissed as illusion. The Doctrine of Closure may understand calling as a high-intensity node of meaning in which the local reads the order of the whole; yet it must admit that theological tradition will ask whether this is enough to preserve the otherness of a God who freely speaks.

Third, repentance cannot be merely psychologized. If repentance is only a change of inner feeling, it cannot bear ethical weight. Repentance must turn toward the other, the harm, and repair. It must acknowledge that one's own position had been misrecognized, and must be willing to be questioned. Repentance under destiny is not scripted emotion; it is a real event of return within the local path.

Finally, theological language cannot be used to exempt destiny from responsibility. If someone says, 'God has arranged all things, and therefore the perpetrator need not be responsible,' this is a double misuse of theology and of the Doctrine of Closure. Even within the framework of closure, God or First Consciousness does not provide ethical absolution for local evil deeds. If forgiveness exists, it cannot bypass truth, repentance, accountability, and repair.

The theological limit of Chapter Eight is therefore this: destiny does not cancel grace, and grace does not break responsibility; calling does not replace judgment, and repentance does not replace repair; theological language

cannot be used by the perpetrator to cover concrete ethical consequences. These limits do not complete a theological argument, but they are sufficient to prevent the chapter on destiny from undermining the credibility of the later theological chapter in advance.



Temporal Perspective, Retrospective Completion, and Local Experience

The problem of destiny is sharp also because it involves temporal perspective. The local subject lives in time and can judge only forward from an unfinished position; whole closure can be understood only from the completed state. If the perspective of completed whole is pressed directly onto local experience, destiny becomes crude determinism. If the local unfinished perspective is raised directly into ultimate ontology, closure loses wholeness. Chapter Eight must therefore include temporal perspective itself in the argument.

From the local perspective, choice is real. A person does not know how his life-path will be completed, does not know what long-term consequences his action will produce, and does not know how the responses of others, the feedback of institutions, and the entry of accidental events will alter the local world. This not-knowing is not an illusion, but the basic condition of the local as local. Finite information, temporal extension, and unfinished experience make judgment and bearing real tasks.

From the perspective of the whole, all local choices, errors, repentance, compensation, and suffering will be gathered back as a completed whole. This retrospective completion is not knowledge possessed by the local subject at the moment of action. It is not a complete map handed to human beings in advance, but the ontological description given by the Doctrine of Closure concerning ultimate conditions of establishment. The local cannot use a whole-perspective it does not possess to exempt itself.

This distinction answers a common question: if the result is already settled at the whole level, is local hesitation merely an illusion? The answer is no. Hesitation, reflection, and deliberation are events that actually occur within the local path. They may not change the fact of whole completion, but they are precisely contents through which the whole completes itself in the local. Without the local experience of incompleteness, closure would be an abstract finish without the temporal thickness of a world of life.

Retrospective completion also must not be misread as meaning that there was never real danger. For the local subject, danger is real because it does not possess the completed state of the whole. For the victim, harm is real because body and world have been ruptured. For the perpetrator, accountability is real because his action has entered the shared world and caused consequences that cannot be erased. Whether the whole can finally gather back does not cancel the risks of the local stage.

This also clarifies the 'paradox of destiny.' If even acknowledgement itself is predetermined, does acknowledgement still matter? Yes, because acknowledgement does not add a fact outside the whole; it changes, inside the local, the subject's relation to its own action. Evasion and acknowledgement are both contained at the

whole level; but at the local level they constitute different ethical forms. Acknowledgement stops the actor from extracting himself from consequence; evasion continues the misrecognition of position.

This distinction of temporal perspective also shows that repentance, punishment, and repair are not redundant procedures. They do not occur outside the result; they are local processes by which the result becomes the result. If the perpetrator repents, if the community protects the victim, if institutions correct their defects, none of these rewrites an external script. They are ethical moments that must be borne in time as closure is completed.

The temporal grammar of the Doctrine of Closure must therefore be extremely cautious. It must not say, 'because the whole is already completed, the local is only acting a part.' Nor may it say, 'because local experience is unfinished, the whole contains no destiny.' The steadier formulation is this: the incompleteness of local experience is the way in which whole completion is read in time. Destiny and freedom are not competitors on one plane, but the tension between whole completion and local experience.

If this tension is preserved, Chapter Eight can avoid two simplifications. It will not use free will to deny closure, nor use closure to deny local freedom. It admits that the local subject cannot see the end, yet still must walk; it admits that the whole finally gathers the path back, yet does not call the walker's fatigue, loss, repentance, and repair illusions.

Institutional Conditions, Traumatic Conditions, and the Non-Simplification of Responsibility

Responsibility cannot remain in the inner life of a single subject. Human action often occurs within networks of institution, family, history, trauma, class, gender, power, and language. If the Doctrine of Closure overemphasizes freedom of endorsement, it may be criticized for ignoring conditions; if it overemphasizes conditions, it may let actors escape responsibility. Chapter Eight therefore needs another layer: responsibility must acknowledge conditions, but cannot be swallowed by them.

Institutional conditions shape what actions are possible. Some institutions make violence easier, make the weak less able to speak, make perpetrators easier to hide, and make communities more inclined to preserve surface order. If only individual repentance is demanded while institutional conditions are ignored, the ethical grammar of the Doctrine of Closure is too narrow. Freedom of endorsement cannot require only individuals to endorse; it must also require the community to endorse the way its institutions help form fields of harm.

Traumatic conditions must also be acknowledged. Some perpetrators have themselves been wounded; some people's character, reaction, and fear have been shaped by long trauma. The Doctrine of Closure cannot pretend that all actions are performed by transparent, mature, self-sufficient rational subjects. If traumatic conditions are ignored, the language of responsibility becomes thin condemnation. Yet acknowledging traumatic conditions cannot become exemption. A wounded person may still wound others; the history of being harmed may explain part of the path, but it cannot automatically cancel the bearing of consequences.

Responsibility should therefore be divided into explanatory responsibility and responsibility of bearing. Explanatory responsibility asks how an action is formed through history, institution, psyche, and relation. Responsibility of bearing asks what harm this action has caused and how actor and community will respond. The first prevents us from abstracting the evildoer into an unconditional demon; the second prevents us from dissolving the evildoer into conditions. Neither can be omitted.

This distinction also protects the victim. If theory concentrates only on explaining why the perpetrator became so, the victim is forced to retreat once again. What the victim first needs is acknowledgement of harm, restoration of boundaries, and the stopping of danger, not immediate exposure to a sympathetic account of the perpetrator's causes. Explanation may matter, but its place must come after protection and acknowledgement.

Likewise, institutional repair cannot be replaced by individual repentance. Personal repentance may be sincere, but if the institution that caused harm remains, others will still be harmed. If the Doctrine of Closure says that all events return within the whole, it should ask still more: how does an institution return? How does a community

acknowledge its own displacement? How does public memory preserve voices that had been lowered? All these questions are extensions of freedom of endorsement.

Freedom of endorsement is therefore not only inward freedom, but has public character. The person endorses his act; the community endorses its institution; historical memory endorses testimony that had been suppressed. If freedom is understood only as personal psychological acknowledgement, it is insufficient for dealing with collective evil. The Doctrine of Closure must let the concept of endorsement enter institutional ethics; otherwise it can handle only small personal errors, not slavery, persecution, war, and institutional violence.

This additional layer also answers the claim that 'the evildoer too is destined.' If the evildoer uses destiny as a language of exemption, he is ignoring the concrete position in which he and the institution together form harm. If the community uses destiny as neutral language, it is evading its own bystanding, silence, or benefit. Destiny does not make responsibility disappear; it fixes every position of responsibility within the whole.

The responsibility theory of Chapter Eight is therefore neither simple individualism nor structural determinism. It acknowledges that individual action is real, and that institutional conditions are real; that trauma shapes human beings, and that trauma does not authorize harm; that destiny contains all things, and that containment is not exemption. This multi-level view of responsibility is slower than simple blame, but it better preserves the ethical defense line.

The Connection between Destiny-Freedom and the Theodicy of Chapter Nine

Chapter Eight cannot handle the whole problem of suffering, because Chapter Nine must still discuss suffering, evil, and misrecognition of existential position more deeply. But Chapter Eight must fix the connecting points in advance: the discussion of destiny and freedom must not allow the theodicy of Chapter Nine to become a theory of silencing victims; nor may Chapter Nine return all evil to destiny. Chapter Eight must send freedom, responsibility, and the victim-defense line into Chapter Nine.

If Chapter Nine is to discuss the ontological root of evil, it must inherit Chapter Eight's fourfold distinction. Pain is not evil itself; suffering is not guilt itself; evil is not mere suffering; responsibility is not an illusion cancelable by the ontological level. If Chapter Nine forgets this, it will easily transform suffering too quickly into a cost of closure, or convert misrecognition of position too quickly into a victim's own problem of practice.

Chapter Nine must also inherit the principle that victims cannot be silenced. Any theory of evil that asks victims to make way for the completion of the whole reopens the dangerous gate that Chapter Eight has closed. The victim's

accusation is not a noise produced by an unfinished theory; it is a local truth that theory must bear if it is to be completed. This sentence should be a premise of Chapter Nine, not an appendix.

At the same time, Chapter Eight cannot push all responsibility into Chapter Nine. This chapter has already established that the perpetrator cannot use destiny to escape responsibility, that the victim has no obligation to reconcile for theory, and that responsibility does not depend on freedom to rewrite from outside the whole. Chapter Nine may deepen the ontology of evil, but it cannot withdraw Chapter Eight's ethical floor.

The relation between destiny and theodicy must be especially careful. If all things are within closure, the reader will ask whether God or First Consciousness predestined evil. Chapter Eight cannot answer the whole question, but it can first say this: even if evil is included within the whole of closure, the concrete ethical level must still call evil evil; the perpetrator must still bear; the victim still has the right to accuse. Ontological inclusion is not ethical absolution.

This connection also protects the language of liberation in Chapter Fourteen. If liberation is understood as the local's re-alignment with the whole, it cannot leap over Chapter Eight's lines of responsibility and victim-defense. One may seek awakening that no longer suffers, but one cannot thereby deny the pain one caused. One may understand destiny, but one cannot use understanding of destiny as a substitute for apology and repair.

The relation between Chapters Eight and Nine is therefore the relation between freedom-responsibility and the theodicy of evil. Chapter Eight establishes that the local subject must still bear; Chapter Nine then asks how evil arises from misrecognition of position. If Chapter Eight cannot hold, Chapter Nine will become a cold doctrine of evil. If Chapter Nine is written unstably, the freedom of endorsement in Chapter Eight will lose its substantive object in evil.

Chapter Eight should finally close this connection with the following point: the Doctrine of Closure does not come to comfort people by saying that all things have already been arranged. It forces people to acknowledge that, if all things are in closure, then harm, evasion, silence, bearing, accusation, and repair all have nowhere to flee. This is not cheap consolation, but a heavier responsibility.

Case-by-Case Replies to the Fourfold Objection

To prevent the argument of Chapter Eight from being read as an abstract defense, this section replies to the fourfold objection case by case. First: 'If all is destined, is human responsibility false?' The answer of this work is no. Responsibility does not require sovereignty outside the whole; it requires the subject, in its local position, to become the bearer of its action, reasons, and consequences. As long as an action enters the shared world through the position of a certain subject and causes consequences in another, that subject cannot withdraw itself from the event.

This answer does not deny conditions. Human action never occurs in a vacuum. Family, history, character, trauma, institution, desire, and fear all form conditions of action. The Doctrine of Closure acknowledges these conditions, and emphasizes their inescapability more strongly than ordinary liberalism. But acknowledging conditions and cancelling responsibility are different things. Conditions can explain how a path is formed; they cannot automatically cancel the local subject's position within that path.

Second: 'If suffering is the price of closure, are victims sacrificed by theory?' The answer is again no. Suffering may be understood at the ontological level as a cost of local finitude and differentiation, but suffering at the concrete ethical level is not material serving theory. The victim is not evidence for the Doctrine of Closure, not fuel for the completion of the whole, and not a supporting role in the perpetrator's story of repentance. The victim's position itself is a limit that theory must bear.

This means that the Doctrine of Closure may not require the victim to accept the narrative of the whole. The victim may refuse reconciliation, refuse to search for reasons on behalf of the perpetrator, and preserve mourning and accusation for a long time. Such refusal is not anti-closure, but part of local truth. If the whole cannot bear this refusal, then the so-called whole is only a selective whole. If theory cannot contain the harsh language of pain, it loves smooth concepts rather than the local.

Third: 'If a human being only endorses destiny locally, may the evildoer say that in any case he too was destined?' The answer must be still harder: no, and this saying is itself a misrecognition of position. When the evildoer uses destiny to escape responsibility, he is using the language of the whole to shield his local interest and to hand the consequences borne by the victim over to abstract ontology. This is not understanding closure; it is exploiting closure.

If the perpetrator says, 'I too am destined,' the Doctrine of Closure should answer: precisely so; your act, evasion, justification, silence, repentance or non-repentance all belong to your position within closure. You cannot selectively allow the evil deed to belong to destiny while leaving accountability, punishment, compensation,

memory, and the victim's accusation outside destiny. Complete destiny contains the event and its ethical consequences.

Fourth: 'Under destiny, is there still genuine free will?' The answer of this work is yes, but not the freedom of external rewriting in the strong-libertarian sense. What the Doctrine of Closure can preserve is freedom of local bearing, freedom of response to reasons, and freedom of positional endorsement. This freedom is real, because the local subject's reasons, judgments, resistance, repentance, and repair are real events. But it is finite, because it does not possess sovereignty to rewrite final closure from outside the whole.

This answer may dissatisfy both sides. Strong libertarians will regard it as too weak; hard determinists will regard it as insufficiently thorough. The Doctrine of Closure must accept this uncomfortable position. Its aim is not to please existing camps, but to establish for its own theory a grammar of freedom able to bear destiny, responsibility, and local truth. If it gives up closure for the sake of freedom, it loses its ontological core; if it gives up freedom for the sake of closure, it loses its ethical qualification.

The fourfold objection therefore forces Chapter Eight to adopt a narrowed but firm position: destiny is the condition of completion at the whole level; responsibility is the structure of bearing at the local ethical level. Suffering may be placed within the whole, but the victim must not be swallowed by holism. Evil occurs within destiny, but the evildoer cannot use destiny to escape responsibility. Freedom is not external rewriting, but the local subject's real bearing of itself within its given position.

Counterexample Tests: Three Scenes in Which the Doctrine of Closure Is Easily Misused

To make the above principles clearer, this section uses three counterexamples to test the ethical defense line of the Doctrine of Closure. The first scene is a perpetrator using the Doctrine of Closure to defend himself. He says: 'My harming you is also part of cosmic closure, so you should not hold me accountable.' This statement must be judged wrong, because it takes only the language of inclusion at the ontological level and deliberately excludes the language of accountability at the ethical level. If harm is part of closure, accountability is also part of closure; if perpetration belongs to destiny, bearing belongs to destiny too.

The second scene is a bystander using holism to demand that the victim let go. He says: 'Since everything has its position in the whole, you should stop resenting.' This too is wrong. The bystander has no right to decide when the victim should let go, and not even the right to assume that letting go must be the victim's responsibility. If the Doctrine of Closure has any ethical force, it should first require the bystander to stop oppressing the victim with theory, rather than require the victim to cooperate with the theory's desire for completion.

The third scene is the theorist's own haste to place evil within a narrative of completion. This is the most hidden and most dangerous misuse. Out of the impulse to preserve theoretical wholeness, the author may interpret every rupture, accusation, and non-reconciliation as a still-not-understood moment of return. Such writing may make the theory look complete, but it may sacrifice local truth. A mature Doctrine of Closure must allow certain wounds to remain in the text without being rapidly placed.

These three scenes show that Chapter Eight cannot merely say abstractly that victims are not silenced. It must also state which sentences are forbidden. One must not say: 'evil is also destined, so accountability is unnecessary'; nor 'suffering has a whole-meaning, so the victim ought to accept'; nor 'closure is finally completed, so concrete repair does not matter'; nor 'after awakening there is no suffering, so the one who remains in pain is merely attached.' Once such sentences appear, the Doctrine of Closure is ethically disqualified.

Conversely, one may say: evil, though within closure, must still be named and held accountable; suffering, though capable of being understood within the whole, must not be silenced by theory; closure, though finally returning, must not skip local repair; awakening, though it may transform suffering, gives the observer no right to require the victim to let go. The boundary between what may and may not be said is the most practical contribution of Chapter Eight to the whole book.

The counterexample tests also remind us that the Doctrine of Closure is not a theory friendly to perpetrators. On the contrary, it is harsher than ordinary fatalism, because it does not allow the actor to pull himself out of the whole. The perpetrator cannot say, 'That was not me; it was fate.' He can only say: 'Within this destined path, I am the local position that caused this harm.' This statement is heavier than ordinary blame, because it forever places the actor back into his consequences.

Likewise, the Doctrine of Closure is not a theory cold to victims. If it is correct, it should be better able than ordinary holism to bear the victim's voice, because closure gathers back not only order, but rupture; not only completion, but accusations not yet healed. If the victim's voice makes the theory uncomfortable, that is not a reason to delete the voice, but evidence that the theory must continue to undergo testing.

Only after passing these counterexamples does the defense line of Chapter Eight initially stand. It is not meant to make destiny safe, but to make destiny unusable as abuse. It is not meant to make closure beautiful, but to make closure bear the ugliest local facts. Only in this way will the chapter avoid turning freedom and responsibility into ornaments of a grand theory.

Rules for Writing the Language of Destiny

Chapter Eight must finally turn the language of destiny into rules of writing, because the true risk often lies not in the concept itself, but in the tone of the sentence.

First rule: wherever the text says, 'all things are within closure,' what follows must include, 'yet the concrete ethical level still requires accountability.' If only the first half is said, the reader will reasonably suspect that the Doctrine of Closure is cancelling responsibility.

Second rule: wherever the text says, 'suffering is a structural cost,' what follows must include, 'yet victims must not be silenced by theory.' If only cost is mentioned, the theory will appear cold.

Third rule: wherever the text says, 'freedom is endorsement,' it must specify who endorses, what is endorsed, and what consequences must be borne after endorsement. If endorsement uses the same tone for perpetrator and victim, the concept becomes oppressive. The perpetrator endorses his action and its consequences; the victim has the right to refuse to endorse another's evil; the community endorses whether it has protected, remained silent, permitted, or repaired.

Fourth rule: wherever the text uses words such as 'awakening,' 'liberation,' and 'letting go,' it must state that these are possible transformations of the subject himself, not demands placed by observers upon victims. When the language of awakening is imposed from outside, it becomes moral violence.

Fifth rule: wherever the text uses words such as 'miracle' and 'intuition,' it must state that they belong to the level of local reading, not to the level of ontological proof. Otherwise, Chapter Eight slips from ethical difficulty into a mystical shortcut.

These rules may seem formal, but they are the ethical insurance of Chapter Eight. The larger the concepts of the Doctrine of Closure become, the greater the need for restraint in tone. Destiny, closure, whole, God, love, return - any one of these words can, almost unnoticed, press down the local voice. Thus, whenever the final draft uses a grand term, it must ask: has this sentence left a place for the local subject? Does it still allow the victim to speak? Does it still require the perpetrator to bear?

If these rules of writing are held, Chapter Eight becomes not only a theoretical chapter, but the chapter that calibrates the ethical tone of the whole book. It requires later discussions of redemption not to evade accountability, discussions of liberation not to blame the sufferer, discussions of theology not to swallow history, discussions of Buddhism not to reduce ignorance to the victim's fault, and discussions of science not to write destiny as a physical theorem. These restraints slow the Doctrine of Closure, but they also make it more credible.

Therefore the aim of this chapter's reconstruction is not to make destiny sound smooth, but to make every step taken by destiny be held back by responsibility, victims, freedom, and ethical levels. This pull will make the text less fluent than a manifesto, but it is precisely the weight this chapter must have. A destiny-theory able to bear criticism is not one that makes all things round, but one that does not flee at the points where things are least round.

Preserving Tension Rather Than Dissolving It

Chapter Eight does not finally seek to dissolve the tension between destiny and freedom, but to make the tension no longer self-contradictory. When theory rushes to dissolve tension, it usually sacrifices one side: it cancels freedom for the sake of destiny, or cancels closure for the sake of freedom. The Doctrine of Closure cannot take either path. It must admit that the local subject cannot stand outside the whole and rewrite the end; it must also admit that the local subject's judgment, bearing, and repair in its own position are not illusions.

This tension itself is one of the prices of closure. If closure has no local tension, it becomes a smooth whole; if freedom has no whole-limit, it becomes unconditional arbitrariness. What Chapter Eight preserves is precisely the seriousness of local life within whole limitation. A human being is neither an omnipotent creator nor an unfeeling gear. He is a local subject required to bear from within a finite position.

The final draft should therefore not write the language of destiny too quickly, nor the language of freedom too romantically. Every time destiny appears, it must be recalled that destiny is not exemption. Every time freedom appears, it must be recalled that freedom is not external sovereignty. Every time suffering is placed within the whole, it must be recalled that the victim must not be silenced. Every time return is mentioned, it must be recalled that repair must not be skipped. These reminders are not repetition; they are the ethical rhythm this chapter must preserve.

If the reader feels unease in Chapter Eight, this is not necessarily a defect. Destiny and freedom are not concepts that can be easily reconciled. What would truly be problematic is writing in such a way that the theory feels too smooth, too complete, too quick to place victims and perpetrators alike into the same polished image. Chapter Eight should let the reader see that the Doctrine of Closure knows where its most dangerous position lies, and is willing to remain there rather than crossing over it with grand words.

Thus the mature form of Chapter Eight is not a declaration of victory, but a limited commitment: the Doctrine of Closure commits itself not to cancel responsibility by destiny, not to cancel the victim by the whole, not to cancel wounds by liberation, not to cancel argument by miracle, and not to disguise external sovereignty with the language of freedom. These commitments bind the theory, and therefore qualify it to continue toward Chapter Nine.

The Minimum Conclusion of This Chapter: Freedom under Destiny Is Limited but Real

After the above calibration, the minimum conclusion of Chapter Eight may be stated more precisely: the Doctrine of Closure does not guarantee a freedom that stands outside the whole and rewrites the ending. It preserves only a freedom by which the local subject, in its given position, forms reasons, bears consequences, answers to others, and corrects itself. This freedom does not satisfy every theory of free will, but it is enough to prevent destiny from slipping into irresponsible fatalism.

At the same time, Chapter Eight avoids building responsibility wholly upon an open future. If responsibility stood only when all conditions were undecided, every deep structure, character, history, and institution would weaken responsibility. But if responsibility ignored conditions entirely, it would abstract the human being into a point of will detached from the world. The middle route of the Doctrine of Closure is to acknowledge that conditions cannot be escaped, while insisting that the local subject must still bear its position within them.

After the calibration of this chapter, destiny is no longer only the price of closure's establishment, and freedom is no longer only consolation after destiny. Destiny explains how the conditions of establishment of the whole cannot scatter arbitrarily outward. Freedom of endorsement explains how the local subject becomes a responsible existence within that structure. The tension between them remains, but this tension should not be dissolved. Without destiny, closure loses the whole; without freedom of endorsement, closure becomes only cold structure.

The four core objections may here be gathered one by one. If all is destined, human responsibility is not false, because responsibility stands upon the local subject's bearing of its own action and consequences. If suffering is the price of closure, the victim is still not sacrificed by theory, because ontological cost cannot cancel the accusation, protection, and accountability of the concrete ethical level. If the evildoer says, 'in any case I too was destined,' the Doctrine of Closure must answer: precisely because you caused harm within the destined path, you can all the less escape the position of responsibility. If one asks whether there is still genuine freedom under destiny, this work answers: there is no freedom of external rewriting, but there is freedom of local bearing.

Finally, the debate over free will has not reached a final answer. Compatibilists will ask whether freedom of endorsement is too narrow; incompatibilists will ask whether it still deserves the name of freedom; theological readers will ask whether it weakens grace and calling; ethical readers will ask how it handles the victim's position.

These criticisms cannot be evaded. They form the pressure that the later chapters on suffering, theological testing, and final dispute must continue to bear.¹⁷⁸

The value of Chapter Eight lies not in making destiny comfortable, but in making the Doctrine of Closure unable to evade its ethical cost. If closure is to stand, it must bear local resistance, accountability for evil deeds, the accusation of victims, and the difficulty of free will. Only under these pressures, while keeping its levels distinct, does the Doctrine of Closure have the right to move into the next chapter's deeper treatment of suffering, evil, and misrecognition of existential position.

¹⁷⁸This chapter handles only the compatibility among destiny, freedom, responsibility, and the grammar of suffering. It does not complete the whole of theodicy, redemption theory, or Buddhist liberation theory. Chapter Nine and the later chapters must continue to address evil, victims, redemption, and liberation under external pressure.

Part II Ontological Application

Chapter Nine

Suffering, Evil, and Misrecognition of Existential Position - The Ontological Root of Ethics

This chapter discusses suffering, evil, and misrecognition of existential position, so that the language of the whole shall not erase concrete responsibility or the experience of victims.

Chapter Nine Suffering, Evil, and Misrecognition of Existential Position - The Ontological Root of Ethics

The Task of This Chapter: Not to Substantialize Evil, and Not to Excuse It

The task of Chapter Nine is more concentrated than that of Chapter Eight. Chapter Eight treated the compatibility of destiny, freedom, and responsibility; the present chapter gathers the problem around the essence of evil and the ethical bottom line. If the Doctrine of Closure is to continue speaking of the whole, return, broad love, and redemption, it must first make clear how it faces concrete evil acts and the suffering of victims. If this chapter fails, the Doctrine of Closure will be read as a cold holism: everything is placed within the whole, every suffering is called a cost, and the victim's accusation is required to yield to the completion of theory. That is not a direction this work can accept.

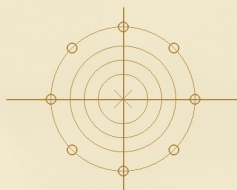
Therefore this chapter establishes a double principle: evil must not be substantialized as a second being equal to First Consciousness, and evil must not be thinned into harmless misreading or mere theoretical cost. The former is ontological discipline; the latter is ethical discipline. If one guards only the former and forgets the latter, the theory becomes an excuse for evil. If one guards only the latter and forgets the former, the theory slips into ontological dualism, as though evil itself possessed ultimate status equal to the ground of existence. Chapter Nine must walk the narrowest and hardest path between the two.¹⁷⁹

The core sentences of this chapter may first be stated plainly: evil may be understood, but it may not be pardoned; evil may be traced to its root, but it may not be exempted from responsibility; the evildoer may repent, but repentance cannot cancel accountability; the victim may forgive, but has no obligation to forgive; repair may occur, but it cannot be forcibly declared complete by the perpetrator, by onlookers, or by the theory itself. These five sentences form the ethical bottom line of this chapter.

In other words, the Doctrine of Closure is here not defending the whole, but preserving weight for the local. If the whole truly can return unto itself, it need not fear the speech of local suffering. If a theory, upon hearing the

¹⁷⁹For Augustine's understanding of evil, see *Confessions*, bk. 7; *The City of God*, bks. 11-12; Eleonore Stump, 'Augustine on Evil.' This work borrows only the problem-consciousness of *privatio boni* - evil as privation or disorder - and does not use it to cancel guilt and responsibility at the concrete ethical level.

victim's accusation, hastens to gather it into completion, growth, or destiny, the theory instead reveals that it is not yet mature. A mature Doctrine of Closure must allow mourning, accusation, refusal, accountability, and repair to remain for a long time within the text.



A Three-Level Ethical Grammar: Ontological Level, Concrete Ethical Level, and Subjective Experiential Level

In order to prevent all problems from being mixed into one mass, this chapter strictly observes a three-level grammar. The first is the most fundamental ontological level. This level treats only whether closure is established, whether ultimate ground can gather back its own conditions, and whether existence avoids failure or dissolution. At this level, evil cannot be understood as another ultimate entity equal to First Consciousness. If evil possessed a self-subsisting status equal to the ground, the Doctrine of Closure would collapse into dualism.

The second is the concrete ethical level. This level treats good and evil, responsibility, condemnation, judgment, repair, compensation, protection, and memory in the concrete world. Murder, rape, enslavement, torture, bullying, exploitation, and institutional persecution cannot lose the name of evil merely because they have been placed within the whole of closure. The most fundamental ontological level may refuse to substantialize evil; it cannot revoke the name of concrete evil acts.

The third is the subjective experiential level. This level treats pain, suffering, humiliation, fear, trauma, anger, speechlessness, remorse, and correction. What the sufferer bears is not an abstract 'cost,' but the rupture of body, memory, relation, and world. If ontological language cannot remain humble at this level, it becomes a second oppression of the victim's experience.¹⁸⁰

These three levels must not devour one another. If the most fundamental ontological level is used directly to cancel the concrete ethical level, one reaches the absurd conclusion that 'since all things are within closure, there is no need for accountability.' If the subjective experiential level is used directly to replace the ontological level, local suffering is raised into the final judgment of the universe, and ontology loses all power of distinction. The work of Chapter Nine is to let all three levels stand at once, each exercising its own function, without allowing any one level to usurp the other two.

It follows that ethics is not secondary within the Doctrine of Closure. Ethics is not a human norm added after closure is complete, nor a lesser language that ontology may rewrite at will. Ethics is the real structure by which the local world maintains boundaries, handles transgression, protects victims, and requires perpetrators to bear consequences. If closure cannot bear this level, it is not a higher holism, but a more dangerous abstraction.

¹⁸⁰The three-level distinction in this chapter belongs to the internal method of the Doctrine of Closure: the most fundamental ontological level, the concrete ethical level, and the subjective experiential level. This division prevents ontological explanation from directly swallowing ethical judgment.

Misrecognition of Existential Position: The Root of Evil, but Not an Excuse

Within the Doctrine of Closure, the root of evil may be defined as 'misrecognition of existential position.' The local is originally only a finite position within the whole, yet it mistakes itself for an absolute center; the local can bear only a finite authority within relation, yet it raises its own desire, fear, power, or interest into the final measure. When this misrecognition enters action, institution, and relation, evil is no longer merely an inward misreading, but a concrete usurpation of others and of the shared world.

This account may enter dialogue with the Augustinian line of privation. Augustine's route reminds us that evil should not be understood as a second being equal to goodness, existence, or God. Evil is more like disorder, the distortion of the order of love, the privation of good, or the deviation of existential direction. The Doctrine of Closure borrows this problem-sense, but places it anew within the relation between local and whole: evil is not another ultimate source, but the destruction produced when the local misplaces itself as the ultimate measure.¹⁸¹

Tillich's language of estrangement may also serve as a reference. Sin is not merely the breach of an external rule, but the rupture of relation between the human being and his ground, others, and his own true position. What the Doctrine of Closure calls misrecognition of position understands sin or evil, in this direction, as a fundamental disorder of relational order. This does not mean the two may be crudely equated; the Doctrine of Closure offers a structural grammar at the border of ontology and ethics, not a final interpretation for any single theological tradition.¹⁸²

Most importantly, misrecognition of position is not an excuse. To explain how a person moves toward evil is not to defend his evil act; to point out that the perpetrator has historical, characterological, traumatic, institutional, or cognitive conditions is not to cancel his responsibility for concrete harm. If someone uses 'I merely misrecognized my position' to evade accountability, he repeats the same misrecognition a second time: he again places himself at the center and demands that the victim, the community, and the theory make way for his evasion.¹⁸³

This chapter therefore separates structural explanation from ethical judgment. Structural explanation answers the question, 'How is evil possible?' Ethical judgment answers, 'Who crossed the boundary, who was harmed, and who must bear the consequences?' The former prevents theory from mythologizing evil; the latter prevents theory from making evil light. Neither may be omitted.

¹⁸¹For backgrounds in philosophical theology, revelation, and theodicy, see Augustine, *Confessions*, bk. 7; *The City of God*, bks. 11–12; Stump, 'Augustine on Evil'; Hick, *Evil and the God of Love*, chs. 14–15; Scarry, *The Body in Pain*, Introduction.

¹⁸²For Tillich's understanding of sin as estrangement, see Paul Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, vol. 2. Here it serves only as a background for dialogue between 'positional disorder' and 'estrangement'; Tillich is not directly rewritten into the Doctrine of Closure.

¹⁸³'Misrecognition of existential position' is a structural explanation, not a moral exemption. To explain how evil is generated is not to pardon evil acts; this point is a limiting note for the present chapter.

Goodness can also be more clearly defined here. Goodness is not merely an individual good deed, but a more stable state of alignment: the local is willing to acknowledge its finitude, refuses to raise its own desire or power into the final measure, and bears its proper responsibility within others, institutions, history, and the shared world.

Goodness is not the disappearance of the local into the whole; it is the local no longer usurping when it stands in its proper position. Evil is the local misplacing its own position and carrying that misplacement into harm.

Pain, Suffering, Evil, Responsibility: Preventing Cost-Language from Becoming Exemption-Language

To prevent 'the cost of closure' from being exchanged for ethical exemption, this chapter establishes a fourfold distinction: pain, suffering, evil, and responsibility. In actual experience these four are often entangled, but conceptually they must be separated. The separation is not meant to classify the victim's experience into a neat table, but to keep theory from replacing one level of problem with another.

First, pain refers to the direct injury borne by local existence in body, psyche, and living relation. Death, illness, harm, trauma, loss, and vulnerability may all be understood at this level as frictions that finite existence cannot but face. From the most fundamental ontological level, finitude and differentiation cannot be wholly without cost; yet this only explains how pain is possible. It does not show that every concrete injury is therefore justified.

Second, suffering refers to the subjective entanglement formed by local consciousness amid pain, loss, finitude, misrecognition, and resistance. Suffering is not identical with pain itself. Certain practices, awakenings, or corrections of position may perhaps change the subject's way of reading pain, so that pain no longer becomes the deepest resistance. But this must never be reversed to deny that pain occurred, and still less to demand that victims diagnose their trauma as 'mere attachment.' This point must be especially guarded.¹⁸⁴

Third, evil refers to the usurpatory harm that a local subject or institution inflicts upon others and upon the common order. The victim's suffering does not mean that the victim has evil; the perpetrator's causing of injury to another is the evil that the concrete ethical level must face. If the victim's pain is said to be due to his own failure to awaken, to let go, or to align, the theory transfers the weight of evil onto the victim. This is unacceptable.

Fourth, responsibility refers to the concrete ethical level's demand for naming, questioning, judgment, protection, repair, and memory in response to harm. If there are only pain and suffering, the theory easily slips into a psychology of practice; if there is only the ontological root of evil, the theory becomes cold metaphysics. Responsibility brings all questions back to the shared world: someone has been hurt, and therefore one must ask who crossed the boundary, who profited, who evaded, who must bear consequences, and who must be protected.

The purpose of this fourfold distinction is to block the most dangerous loophole in the Doctrine of Closure: the use of ontological cost-language to cancel ethical responsibility. Pain may have an ontological background, but evil

¹⁸⁴The distinction between pain and suffering may enter dialogue with the early Buddhist parable of the two arrows and with analyses of suffering, ignorance, and grasping; see Samyutta Nikāya 36.6, in Bhikkhu Bodhi, *The Connected Discourses of the Buddha*; see also Mark Siderits, *Buddhism as Philosophy*, chs. 2-4. This work does not use Buddhist materials to prove the Doctrine of Closure, but only borrows their problem-sense for comparison.

cannot thereby be called harmless; suffering may be related to misrecognition, but the victim cannot therefore be blamed; responsibility may be placed within the path of closure, but it cannot be swallowed by that path.¹⁸⁵

¹⁸⁵This distinction has also been described in Chapter Eight of the present work.

The Victim Must Not Be Silenced: Ethical Bottom Line and the Self-Limitation of Theodicy

The most dangerous temptation for the Doctrine of Closure is to write all suffering as the price of the whole's completion. Once this tone runs loose, the theory places victims upon an altar, as though their wounds existed to make the whole narrative more complete. This chapter draws a hard line here: murder, rape, torture, slavery, abuse, institutional persecution, and wartime violence cannot lose the name of evil merely because they are included within the whole of closure.

The sentence 'pain is a structural cost' may be used only at the strictly limited ontological level. Once we enter the concrete ethical level, the grammar must at once change into harm, responsibility, protection, compensation, and memory. If a theory requires victims to acknowledge that their pain serves the completion of the whole, that is not theoretical maturity but ethical failure. Suffering is not fuel for theory, and victims are not materials by which the depth of the whole is proved.¹⁸⁶¹⁸⁷

The victim's mourning, accusation, anger, silence, refusal of reconciliation, and demand for accountability are not destructions of closure. They are contents that closure must bear if it truly includes the local. If the whole can contain only order, completion, return, and reconciliation, but cannot contain wounds, refusal, memory, and voices that resist quick placement, that whole is not genuine return; it is an oppressive totality.

Therefore victims have no obligation to complete reconciliation for theory. Forgiveness, if it exists, can only be a response freely given by the victim within concrete history, relation, repair, and conditions of protection. It cannot be deduced by metaphysics, nor can it be pressured forth by a religious community, a perpetrator, or onlookers. To demand that victims let go in the name of the whole, destiny, broad love, or compassion is another usurpation.¹⁸⁸

Likewise, compassion does not mean unconditional absolution. Compassion may understand how the local came to misrecognize, but it cannot erase the harm caused. Judgment may disclose the truth of evil, but it should not substantialize the perpetrator into an unchangeable evil being. The Doctrine of Closure must keep to a narrow path: it must not mythologize evil, trivialize evil, silence victims, or ontologize perpetrators forever.

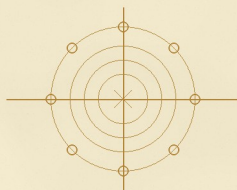
Theodicy here can assume only the narrowest posture. The Doctrine of Closure cannot provide a reason for every suffering, nor should it assign meaning to every victim. It can do only a few things: refuse to substantialize evil;

¹⁸⁶ Elaine Scarry, *The Body in Pain: The Making and Unmaking of the World*, Introduction. Scarry's analysis of how pain destroys language and world is used here as an ethical warning: pain must not be rapidly translated by theory into a narrative of completion.

¹⁸⁷ John Hick, *Evil and the God of Love*, chs. 14-15. Hick's theodicy serves as a background for dialogue, but this work does not adopt the strong claim that concrete suffering is directly a necessary instrument of soul-making.

¹⁸⁸ 'The victim must not be silenced' is an ethical bottom line in this work: the victim has no obligation to complete reconciliation for the theory, the religious community, or the perpetrator. Forgiveness, if it occurs, can only be the victim's free response under concrete conditions.

refuse to justify evil; refuse to silence the victim; refuse to turn the language of practice into a tool for blaming victims; refuse to make forgiveness into an obligation. These refusals are more important than any premature answer of completion.



Accountability, Repentance, and Return: The Possibility of Amendment and the Protection of Victims

Beyond hard accountability, this chapter must also preserve the possibility of amendment. If evil is not a second being, the perpetrator should not be ontologized as an eternally unchangeable 'entity of evil.' If the root of evil is misrecognition of existential position, the possibility of amendment lies in a renewed recognition of position: the perpetrator no longer places his desire, power, or fear at the center, but again acknowledges that he is only a local within the whole, and acknowledges that others are not tools, materials, or costs.

This correction makes it possible for the perpetrator to return to the whole. But a limit must be added immediately: amendment is not self-declaration, repentance is not evasion of punishment, return is not the skipping of compensation, broad love is not unconditional absolution, and the whole's self-love is not an excuse for the perpetrator. If the perpetrator merely says, 'I now understand,' while refusing to bear consequences, this is not repentance. It is a new misrecognition of position.

The whole self-love of First Consciousness does indeed mean that the whole does not cast any local in advance outside the possibility of return. Yet it also loves the victim, the violated local order, truth, and boundary. Therefore the whole's self-love cannot become only the language of 'giving the perpetrator a chance'; it must also become the language of protecting the victim, naming the harm, and questioning responsibility. If the whole cares only whether the perpetrator can return, and not how the victim is protected, its language of love has already lost alignment.

Thus this chapter may define amendment as follows: the perpetrator corrects himself from misrecognition of position, acknowledges his own locality, acknowledges that others may not be instrumentalized, acknowledges the harm he has caused, and accepts the process of accountability, compensation, limitation, and long-term repair.

This is not merely an inward state, but a turn enacted in action, relation, and time.

Repentance also cannot cancel the victim's freedom. Whether the victim forgives is not a necessary condition for amendment to begin. The perpetrator may begin repentance, compensation, and repair, but cannot demand that the victim confirm his amendment by forgiveness. If forgiveness occurs, it can only be the victim's freely given response, not an obligation that the Doctrine of Closure, religious language, or the perpetrator may claim.

Handled in this way, Chapter Nine can preserve both sides at once: evil can be amended, because evil is not an unchangeable ontological entity; the victim is protected, because amendment does not mean exemption, return does not mean reconciliation, and the whole's self-love does not mean demanding that the victim let go. Hard

accountability and the possibility of amendment do not conflict. The true conflict is between cheap amendment without accountability and absolute ontologization without the possibility of amendment.¹⁸⁹

¹⁸⁹For the ethical context of repair and accountability, see Martha Minow, *Between Vengeance and Forgiveness: Facing History after Genocide and Mass Violence*; Howard Zehr, *The Little Book of Restorative Justice*. This work borrows only the context of repair, acknowledgement, and responsibility, and does not transform the Doctrine of Closure into a single theory of justice.

Sequence of Repair, Memory, and the Chapter's Closing Conclusion

To keep 'responsibility' from remaining an abstract word, the sequence of repair at the concrete ethical level must be clearly unfolded. The first step is naming: acknowledging that harm has occurred, without rewriting it as misunderstanding, destiny, cost, or material for growth. The second is boundary: identifying who crossed the boundary, who was violated, and what authority was usurped. The third is stopping harm and protection: first preventing the continuation of harm, and only then speaking of understanding, forgiveness, or shared life. The fourth is bearing: making sure that the one who caused harm cannot hide behind the whole, institution, trauma, or destiny. Only the fifth step is compensation, repair, possible forgiveness, and possible renewed common life.

The point of this sequence is to place forgiveness at the end, not at the beginning. The problem with many oppressive religious languages or holistic languages lies precisely in demanding forgiveness too early, while dealing with boundary, protection, and responsibility too late. If the Doctrine of Closure is to avoid the same mistake, it must move forgiveness from a slogan of virtue back into a possible result within concrete relations.

Repair also does not necessarily mean the restoration of relationship. After some harms, the most ethical position is distance, protection, and no renewed access. After certain historical violences, what matters most is memory, institutional correction, and public acknowledgement, not private reconciliation. The return spoken of by the Doctrine of Closure should not be misunderstood as requiring all relations to return to their previous state. Sometimes genuine return means allowing the rupture to remain in the shared world as something remembered.¹⁹⁰

Institutional evil also cannot be omitted. Individual misrecognition can produce concrete evil acts, but institutions, power, group language, and habit can also fix misrecognition in place, causing certain persons to be instrumentalized, marginalized, or silenced over long periods. If the Doctrine of Closure speaks only of individual misrecognition of position, it is insufficient for treating how evil is preserved and reproduced in the shared world.

Institutional displacement therefore forms an indispensable layer of the theory of evil.

This chapter may finally be gathered into four sentences: pain must not be used merely as theoretical material; suffering must not be blamed upon the victim; evil must not be reduced to harmless misreading; responsibility is not an illusion that the ontological level may cancel. Only if these four sentences are kept may the Doctrine of Closure qualify to continue speaking of redemption, liberation, and the return of the whole.

¹⁹⁰ Memory here is not a refusal of closure, but the concrete ethical level's way of preserving the truth of harm. Without memory, repair may become empty reconciliation; without repair, return may become an oppressive totality.

Chapter Nine thereby completes an ethical calibration: the Doctrine of Closure can explain the root of evil, but it will not defend evil; it can acknowledge the whole's return, but it will not sacrifice the victim; it can preserve the possibility of amendment, but it will not release responsibility. Evil can be transformed, but not beautified; the perpetrator can repent, but cannot require the victim to complete his redemption; the whole can gather back the local, but cannot command local wounds to be silent. This is the minimum condition this chapter leaves for the later discussions of theodicy, redemption, and liberation.¹⁹¹

Readers may feel Chapter Eight and Chapter Nine to be uncomfortable, cumbersome, or repetitive, because the Doctrine of Closure has chosen a narrow and difficult path. On the ontological level the author has his own insistence, while the ethical bottom line and the protection of victims are likewise principles the author must keep. Therefore this text would rather allow the pace of the thesis to yield than fail to stress again and again the ethical expression of this work.

¹⁹¹This chapter establishes only the theory of evil and the ethical bottom line. It does not complete the whole of theodicy, redemption theory, or Buddhist liberation theory. Later chapters must still examine whether theological and Buddhist languages can bear the ethical limits set here.

Part II Scientific Boundary and Uniqueness

Chapter Ten

Scientific Boundary - Bell's Theorem and a Critical Examination of Uniqueness

This chapter takes Bell's theorem and the problem of uniqueness as objects of critical examination, and restrains excessive inference at the boundary of science.

Chapter Ten Scientific Boundary - Bell's Theorem and a Critical Examination of Uniqueness

The task of Chapter Ten must be clearly distinguished from Chapters Six, Seven, and Sixteen. Chapter Six established the basic rules of the game for scientific materials within this work; Chapter Seven placed scientific objections into the general arena of contention; Chapter Sixteen will later conduct a general cross-domain scientific examination. The responsibility of Chapter Ten is narrower and harder: it specifically draws the boundary across which science and the Doctrine of Closure must not be confused, explaining where dialogue is possible, where only compatibility may be examined, and where no ontological proof may be derived.¹⁹²

This division of labour is especially important, because the first five chapters of the Doctrine of Closure have already advanced strong ontological claims: ultimate ground, self-establishment, closure, First Consciousness, whole and local. If these claims enter the scientific chapters while still keeping philosophical language, they may be examined; if, as soon as they enter the scientific chapters, they dress themselves in physical terminology, the reader has reason to suspect that this work treats science as an ornament of authority. The work of this chapter is to block that danger at the outset.

Therefore this chapter does not seek a scientific passport for the Doctrine of Closure, nor does it turn quantum mechanics into a shortcut for metaphysics. On the contrary, it adopts a stricter strategy: first to acknowledge that scientific propositions and ontological propositions belong to different levels, and then to ask whether they may enter a limited dialogue. If the Doctrine of Closure can stand only by exaggerating quantum materials, then it is already unstable in itself; if it can state clearly what scientific materials cannot prove, what they can only limit, and where they may provide pressure, then its cross-domain writing gains scholarly credibility.

The Task of Scientific Boundary: Division of Labour Is Not Retreat

Science describes the natural operations that can be measured, modelled, and tested by experiment or observation; the Doctrine of Closure asks how existence obtains the qualification of ultimate establishment. The two may draw

¹⁹² This chapter keeps the methodological rules of Chapter Six, but does not repeat its general explanation. The focus here is the boundary in philosophy of science among Bell's theorem, quantum entanglement, the problem of observation/measurement, and the proposition of uniqueness.

upon one another, but they cannot replace one another. Quantum mechanics may alter our understanding of locality, measurement, probability, and the structure of the world; it cannot directly prove, for a metaphysical theory, 'God,' 'First Consciousness,' or 'ultimate ground.' This division of labour does not weaken the Doctrine of Closure. It protects the Doctrine of Closure from becoming pseudo-scientific.¹⁹³

On this basis, the chapter establishes a hard boundary: the primary function of scientific materials in this work is not proof, but constraint. Bell's theorem can constrain certain classical pictures of local hidden variables; quantum entanglement can remind us that the world must not be over-simplified into isolated parts with no relation to one another; the measurement problem can force us not to vulgarize the language of observation; the Many-Worlds interpretation can force the Doctrine of Closure to recalibrate uniqueness. These functions are important, but they are still not evidence for the Doctrine of Closure. Scientific materials here are not the witnesses of the Doctrine of Closure, but its brakes.

By brakes, I do not mean that science is wholly unrelated to this theory. I mean that scientific materials first prevent this work from making mistakes. They prevent it from translating entanglement into mystical unity, measurement into the human mind's creation of the world, and a branching picture into unlimited multiple closures. Only after these negative boundaries are kept does limited positive dialogue acquire scholarly value.

This negative function has a positive meaning. It requires every cross-domain sentence in this work to mark its own level: is it a physical description, an interpretation in philosophy of science, a metaphysical inference, or a symbolic theoretical presentation? If a sentence leaps directly from 'quantum entanglement exists' to 'all things are ontologically one,' it has omitted the most crucial interpretive bridge; if a sentence leaps from 'the problem of observation remains disputed' to 'consciousness creates the universe,' it has exceeded what physics can bear.

The Minimum Explanation of Quantum Concepts: Entanglement, Observation, Randomness

Before entering Bell's theorem, several basic terms must first be cooled down. Quantum entanglement refers to cases in a composite quantum system in which the states of certain subsystems cannot be simply decomposed into their independent states; it may lead to strong correlations, but such correlations are not the same as saying that 'all

¹⁹³The basic limit in philosophy of science is this: any move from physical theory to metaphysical judgment must pass through explicit interpretive steps. Wayne Myrvold's entry on quantum philosophy may serve as background in philosophy of science here; this work borrows only its problem-framework, and does not treat quantum interpretations as ontological conclusions.

things are ontologically one.' Entanglement is not a metaphysical poem of unity, but a physical concept with mathematical, experimental, and theoretical background.¹⁹⁴

Observation or measurement should not be written as the mysterious gaze of human consciousness. In quantum mechanics, the measurement problem concerns how quantum states are connected with measurement outcomes, instruments, decoherence, and interpretive frameworks; different interpretations handle this differently. The Doctrine of Closure cannot directly equate the term 'observation' with 'human consciousness makes the world real.' If this work is to speak of First Consciousness, the burden of justification must still return to the philosophy of consciousness and the ontological argument in Chapter Four, not be borrowed secretly from the language of quantum measurement.¹⁹⁵

Quantum randomness must also be handled carefully. Probabilistic outcomes in quantum theory are not enough to infer absolute ontological true randomness directly, still less to overthrow every form of closed destiny directly. Different interpretations understand probability, branching, hidden variables, or the reality of the wave function in different ways. Therefore this work can only say: quantum probability places pressure upon crude determinism; it cannot directly prove free will, nor can it directly disprove destined closure.¹⁹⁶

This minimum explanation helps the chapter avoid two common errors. The first error is to turn quantum concepts into metaphysical poetry: entanglement becomes the unity of all things, measurement becomes consciousness creating things, and probability becomes absolute freedom. The second error is to seal the scientific boundary completely, as if modern physics had no influence at all upon metaphysical intuition. The steadier path is to acknowledge that scientific concepts have their strict contexts, while also acknowledging that they do alter certain philosophical intuitions.

¹⁹⁴Quantum entanglement concerns quantum correlations in which the state of a composite system cannot be decomposed into independent states. In Bell-type discussions, the key is not to romanticize entanglement, but to understand how it is related to locality, realism, and measurement settings. The explanation here takes only the minimal conceptual sense, in order to avoid rewriting it into an ontological slogan of 'all things are one.'

¹⁹⁵The measurement problem is not the simplified claim that 'one human glance creates reality.' Different quantum interpretations understand the wave function, outcomes, decoherence, and observation in different ways; see Myrvold, 'Philosophical Issues in Quantum Theory.'

¹⁹⁶Here the work says only that quantum probability places pressure on classical deterministic intuitions. It does not claim that quantum mechanics has proved ontological true randomness, nor that it has disproved the concept of destiny in the Doctrine of Closure.

The Proper Place of Bell's Theorem: Local Realism Under Pressure, Not Closure Proved

The value of Bell's theorem in this chapter does not lie in providing direct evidence for the Doctrine of Closure, but in imposing strict limits upon certain classical pictures of local hidden variables. Bell's original paper dealt with the question, in the background of the Einstein-Podolsky-Rosen paradox, whether local hidden-variable theories could reproduce the predictions of quantum mechanics; subsequent experiments and the explanation surrounding the 2022 Nobel Prize in Physics further highlight the importance of Bell-type inequalities and experiments on quantum entanglement.¹⁹⁷

More concretely, Bell-type discussions require three concepts that are often confused to be separated: locality, realism, and determinism. Bell's theorem does not simply say that 'the world has no reality,' nor does it simply say that 'the world has no determinism.' It shows that certain classical schemes which preserve both locality and the hidden-variable intuition are hard to maintain. If the Doctrine of Closure is to use this material, it can at most say that classical local intuition is under pressure; it cannot say that all non-closure pictures have been defeated by physics.¹⁹⁸

The strictest statement is this: Bell's theorem and related experimental results challenge local hidden-variable theories, and weaken certain classical intuitions which imagine the world as completely independent parts, each bearing a complete local reality of its own. This has an indirect meaning for the Doctrine of Closure, because the Doctrine of Closure already refuses to understand existence as a collection of unrelated fragments. Yet from this point to 'the universe must be closure' there remains a long distance; from this point to 'First Consciousness has been confirmed by physics' is an even more unacceptable leap.

Therefore this chapter keeps only a narrow claim: Bell's theorem deprives certain naive fragmentary local world-pictures of their self-evidence, and thereby opens a space in which metaphysics of wholeness may be discussed. This is a space for ontological dialogue, not scientific proof. If this work were to write Bell's theorem as a theological claim, a claim about First Consciousness, or experimental evidence for destined closure, it would commit a cross-domain substitution.¹⁹⁹

This is also why the chapter does not use the expression 'science supports the Doctrine of Closure.' A more accurate sentence is: 'Relevant scientific materials make certain classical fragmentary intuitions no longer self-

¹⁹⁷ John S. Bell, 'On the Einstein Podolsky Rosen Paradox,' *Physics Physique Fizika* 1.3 (1964): 195-200, doi:10.1103/PhysicsPhysiqueFizika.1.195; Wayne Myrvold, 'Bell's Theorem,' *Stanford-Encyclopedia of Philosophy*; Nobel Prize Outreach, 'The Nobel Prize in Physics 2022.'

¹⁹⁸ Bell-type results involve distinct concepts such as locality, realism, and hidden variables. This work does not read Bell's theorem as a direct denial of all realism or all determinism, but takes only its limitation of local hidden-variable pictures.

¹⁹⁹ 'Bell's theorem weakens certain local hidden-variable pictures' and 'Bell's theorem proves metaphysical holism' are not the same proposition. This chapter adopts only the former as background in philosophy of science, and explicitly rejects the latter.

evident, and thereby allow the language of wholeness to be discussed again.' This sentence is weaker, but more reliable. It does not exchange compatibility for proof, nor does it exchange physical interpretation for metaphysical conclusion.²⁰⁰

This restriction can also answer positivist criticism. If a critic says that the Doctrine of Closure abuses quantum mechanics, this chapter may reply: this work treats Bell's theorem only as a material in philosophy of science in which the local-fragment picture is under pressure, and does not make it support the ontological claims of the Doctrine of Closure. If a critic says that Bell's theorem is wholly unrelated to the Doctrine of Closure, this chapter may also reply: although it cannot prove the Doctrine of Closure, it does alter certain philosophical intuitions about locality and wholeness, and so may enter a limited dialogue.

The 2022 Nobel Prize in Physics has often been over-interpreted in popular writing, and this chapter must avoid that tone as well. The relevant explanation of the prize may be used to confirm the importance of Bell-type experiments, but it cannot be used to claim that science has acknowledged purpose, consciousness, or a holistic personhood in the universe. For the Doctrine of Closure, the value of these experiments is that they provide a strict boundary: they place pressure upon intuitions of local realism, and at the same time forbid this work to exaggerate that pressure into proof.²⁰¹

Observation, Causal Order, and the Boundary of False Analogy

Besides Bell's theorem, quantum measurement and the problem of causal order are also often misused. The problem of observation cannot directly prove that consciousness creates reality; quantum discussions of causal order also cannot directly prove the temporal structure of a closed universe. The steadier statement is this: these discussions remind us that classical causal order and single-line temporal intuition are not the only imaginable descriptive frameworks, but they themselves remain technical problems within physics and the philosophy of science.²⁰²

From these materials, the Doctrine of Closure may receive a methodological warning: do not mistake local linear time for the only usable ontological picture. Yet this warning cannot be turned back into proof. From 'classical linear intuition is under pressure' to 'a closed ontology is established,' the argument must still pass through the

²⁰⁰This work narrows 'support' to compatibility, pressure, constraint, or motivation; it does not use sentences such as 'science directly supports First Consciousness.'

²⁰¹Nobel Prize Outreach's popular explanation of the 2022 Physics Prize may serve as background material for Bell-type experiments. This work takes only its limiting significance for intuitions of local realism.

²⁰²Recent discussions of indefinite causal order or definite causal order may weaken overly classical intuitions of before and after, but such materials cannot directly infer closed destiny or a temporal holism. They are used here only as auxiliary boundary clarification.

preceding chapters on ultimate ground, conditional ingathering, First Consciousness, and local return. Scientific materials only remind us which intuitions should not be too confident; they do not complete the derivation for this work.

Therefore Chapter Ten's attitude toward scientific materials may be summarized in three words: compatibility, constraint, and pressure. Compatibility means that this theory need not directly conflict with certain modern physical intuitions; constraint means that this theory must not use scientific terms to cross boundaries; pressure means that certain scientific interpretations will force this theory to rewrite overly hard language of uniqueness and destiny. None of the three is proof.

Where the Doctrine of Closure and Science Can Enter Dialogue

After strict restriction, it remains necessary to say where science and the Doctrine of Closure can enter dialogue.

First, both make an excessively isolated local picture lose its self-evidence. Science, at certain levels, discloses non-classical correlations, difficulties in the interpretation of measurement, and the necessity of holistic models; the Doctrine of Closure, at the metaphysical level, requires that ultimate ground not forever borrow its conditions of establishment from outside. These are not the same proposition, but they may remind thought of one another.

Second, scientific materials can force the Doctrine of Closure to speak of 'uniqueness' more precisely. If Chapter Eight writes destiny as a crude script of one single path, then models such as Many-Worlds will immediately form pressure; if Chapter Ten writes Bell's theorem as directly supporting closure, then it instead drives the theory toward pseudo-science. The value of the scientific-boundary chapter lies precisely here: it does not endorse the Doctrine of Closure, but forces the Doctrine of Closure to narrow itself.

Third, scientific materials can help this work exclude certain over-simplified objections. If an objector assumes that the world must be made of isolated, wholly external local units, Bell-type discussions may remind him that the intuition of locality is itself not unproblematic. This does not mean that the Doctrine of Closure has won; it means only that the objector also cannot settle the matter with an unexamined classical fragmentary picture.

Interpretive Breaks and the Duty of Labelling

From scientific materials to the Doctrine of Closure, there are at least four breaks. First, physical nonlocality must pass through conceptual conversion before it can become metaphysical wholeness. Second, systemic correlation must pass through a conversion of level before it can become ultimate self-establishment. Third, the measurement problem must pass through the philosophy of mind before it can become a problem of consciousness. Fourth, a branching quantum interpretation must pass through the conversion of ontological qualification before it can become multiple closure. If any one of these breaks is omitted, the argument becomes smuggling.²⁰³

Therefore this chapter requires all relevant expressions to mark their level. One may say, 'Bell's theorem constrains local hidden-variable pictures'; one may say, 'this makes certain fragmentary world-pictures no longer self-evident'; one may say, 'a metaphysics of wholeness gains space for dialogue.' But one must not say, 'Bell's theorem proves First Consciousness.' One may say, 'Many-Worlds places pressure upon single-path destiny'; one may say, 'the Doctrine of Closure must re-stratify uniqueness'; but one must not say, 'Many-Worlds has proved multiple closure.'

The conclusion of Chapter Ten is therefore rather sober: the greatest value of scientific materials for the Doctrine of Closure is to stop it from speaking too quickly, too fully, and too much like an all-purpose theory. Scientific materials give the Doctrine of Closure dialogical pressure, not authoritative decoration. The next chapter will specially handle the sharpest item within that pressure: the conflict between the Many-Worlds interpretation and the uniqueness of closure.

Here one may form a list of hard boundaries: Bell's theorem must not be used to prove First Consciousness; entanglement must not be used to prove the ontological unity of all things; the measurement problem must not be used to prove that human mind creates reality; quantum probability must not be used to prove free will or overthrow destiny; Many-Worlds must not be used to prove multiple closure. These negative sentences do not weaken the theory. They protect the minimum scholarly discipline of this work.²⁰⁴

In other words, the closing movement of Chapter Ten is not 'modern physics bears witness to the Doctrine of Closure,' but 'modern physics forces the Doctrine of Closure to learn self-limitation.' To accept this self-limitation makes the theory more capable of bearing criticism. For a metaphysical theory willing to state clearly what it cannot borrow from science is more credible than a theory searching everywhere for scientific slogans.

²⁰³The four breaks correspond respectively to physical concepts, systemic levels, philosophy of consciousness, and ontological qualification. This work lists them as the labelling duty of Chapter Ten, in order to prevent cross-domain language from sliding directly.

²⁰⁴This note explicitly fixes the unusable boundaries of Chapter Ten, preventing later chapters from returning quantum materials as ontological evidence.

Part II Scientific Boundary and Uniqueness

Chapter Eleven

The Possible Theory of Multiple Closures - The Re-stratification of Uniqueness

This chapter faces Many-Worlds and the possibility of multiple closures, and re-stratifies uniqueness, qualification for closure, and local path.

Chapter Eleven The Possible Theory of Multiple Closures - The Re-stratification of Uniqueness

Chapter Eleven does not repeat the general scientific boundary, but deals specifically with the pressure that Many-Worlds places upon the Doctrine of Closure. If Chapter Ten's chief posture is to draw hard boundaries, Chapter Eleven's chief posture is to engage and retreat: to what point the Doctrine of Closure may retreat, to what point it may not retreat, which sentences must be downgraded, and which core claims must still be kept.

Why Many-Worlds Becomes a Real Pressure upon the Proposition of Uniqueness

Everett's relative-state formulation, and the later Many-Worlds interpretation, attempt to understand the quantum measurement problem without relying upon the traditional collapse of the wave function. One of their basic ideas is to understand the different outcomes of a quantum state as being preserved together within a more general branching structure, rather than as only one single outcome being specially selected. If this picture is adopted, it places pressure upon the language of a 'unique event path' in the earlier wording of the Doctrine of Closure.²⁰⁵

The issue is not that Many-Worlds has already been completely settled in physics. The issue is that it offers a possible picture strong enough to force the Doctrine of Closure to correct its language. If quantum measurement may be understood as multi-branching, while the Doctrine of Closure still insists that there is only one single-line story on every level, then the Doctrine of Closure binds its metaphysical proposition too early to a specific and fragile physical narrative.

The force of the Many-Worlds interpretation lies not merely in adding an imagination of 'many universes,' but in altering the handling of measurement outcomes and possibility. In this picture, the result experienced by a local observer is not necessarily identical with the claim that global reality preserves only that result. This directly presses upon the earlier single-path language of the Doctrine of Closure: the one path disclosed by local reading

²⁰⁵ Hugh Everett III, 'Relative State Formulation of Quantum Mechanics,' *Reviews of Modern Physics* 29.3 (1957): 454-462, doi:10.1103/RevModPhys.29.454; Lev Vaidman, 'Many-Worlds Interpretation of Quantum Mechanics,' *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*.

cannot immediately be equated with the claim that, at the highest ontological level, there is only one thinkable path.²⁰⁶

Yet Many-Worlds itself also faces philosophical disputes, such as how probability is to be understood, how branching is to be delimited, and how the identity of a local observer continues. The Doctrine of Closure cannot take only the parts favourable to itself and set these unresolved questions aside. Chapter Eleven treats Many-Worlds only as 'a pressure sufficient to force a downgrading of uniqueness,' not as an already completed scientific conclusion.²⁰⁷

Therefore the primary task of Chapter Eleven is not to decide whether Many-Worlds is true or false, but to answer this question: even if a branching picture has considerable persuasive force, does the Doctrine of Closure still have a defensible position? If it does, what precisely must it defend? This way of asking is more mature than directly refuting Many-Worlds, because it admits that external pressure from philosophy of science can indeed force this work to downgrade its earlier expressions.²⁰⁸

²⁰⁶The Many-Worlds interpretation is often connected with the language of decoherence, branching, and the universal wave function. This work uses only its pressure in philosophy of science upon the intuition of a 'single path,' and does not adopt its entire ontological commitment.

²⁰⁷Many-Worlds faces philosophical issues concerning probability, criteria of branching, and observer identity; see the related entries by Vaidman and Myrvold. This work does not use these disputes as evidence for the Doctrine of Closure; it acknowledges only their role as a source of pressure.

²⁰⁸Many-Worlds is here a source of pressure, not the physical position adopted by this work. This work does not presuppose that the Many-Worlds interpretation has become settled doctrine; it acknowledges only that it is sufficient to force the Doctrine of Closure to rewrite crude uniqueness.

The Fragile Point of Single-Path Closure

The most intuitive early formulation of the Doctrine of Closure understood the universe as an event path able to return fully unto itself from beginning to end. This image is easy to grasp and possesses a strong theoretical beauty; but once it is written too rigidly, it becomes fragile before quantum interpretations, branching models, and modal plurality. If 'closure' is equated with 'there is only one narratable storyline globally,' then any serious branching model will appear as a direct threat.

The revision in Chapter Eleven begins here. What the Doctrine of Closure must first defend should not be 'there is only one storyline,' but rather 'whatever obtains ultimate qualification for establishment cannot forever borrow its own conditions from outside.' The former belongs to the narrative level; the latter belongs to the level of qualification. The narrative level may be adjusted under scientific interpretation; the level of qualification is the true core of the Doctrine of Closure.

This distinction also protects the concept of destiny in Chapter Eight. If destiny is understood as if every second of local experience were pushed by an external force like a single-line script, it immediately slides into crude fatalism. If destiny is understood as the impossibility that the conditions of establishment within a successful closure arbitrarily scatter outward, then it can accommodate local perspective, uncertainty, finite reading, and pressure from branching.²⁰⁹

The Re-stratification of Uniqueness: Principle Unique, Realizations Multiple, Reading Local

The core revision of this chapter may be stated in three layers: the principle of closure is unique; successful realizations may be multiple; local reading is necessarily finite. That the principle of closure is unique means that any candidate for ultimate ground, if it is not to be externally dependent, must satisfy the conditions of coherence, ingathering, preservation of difference, and return. That successful realizations may be multiple means that different wholes, branches, or cosmic structures are not excluded from satisfying these conditions in different ways. That local reading is necessarily finite means that any local subject can experience a concrete life-path only within the branch and position in which it stands.

In this way, 'uniqueness' no longer means that there can be only one line of experience on every level. It means that the standard of ultimate qualification cannot be made arbitrary. If there are multiple possible worlds, multiple branches, or even multiple successful closures, they do not automatically obtain ultimate-ground qualification.

²⁰⁹ This continues the revision in Chapter Eight: destiny should not be written as a single-line script, but should be understood as the impossibility that conditions of establishment within a successful closure arbitrarily scatter outward.

merely because they 'exist' or are 'possible.' They must still face the criteria of closure: whether they are coherent, whether they gather conditions inward, whether they preserve difference, and whether they can make the local return.

The 'successful closure' here is not a flattering name for any arbitrary world. If a branch is only locally stable, locally readable, and locally coherent, but still borrows its own conditions of establishment from a higher-order condition, then it can be called only a branch-closure or local closure, not the highest closure. The possible theory of multiple closures therefore does not relax the criteria; it relocates the criteria to a higher and more precise position.²¹⁰

This revision avoids two errors at once. First, it avoids absolutizing the concrete path of this universe, as though the Doctrine of Closure had to wager itself upon one unsettled physical interpretation. Second, it avoids flattening all branches into equal ultimacy, as though the mere presence of branching were enough to yield successful closure. What the Doctrine of Closure needs is not the number of branches, but qualification for establishment.²¹¹

In simpler terms: if there are many paths, the question is not which one looks most like the cosmic story familiar to us, but which structure can cease external dependence, preserve the local, and make difference return. The true use of the possible theory of multiple closures is to turn closure from 'the name of a particular cosmic story' into 'a screening condition for ultimate qualification of establishment.'

²¹⁰ A 'successful closure' must satisfy coherence, ingathering, preservation of difference, and return at the same time. This work does not acknowledge that any arbitrary possible world or any arbitrary branch automatically possesses qualification as ultimate ground.

²¹¹ The principle of closure is unique, while successful realizations may be multiple' is the main revised proposition of this chapter. It is not equivalent to Lewisian modal realism, nor is it equivalent to Many-Worlds itself. It merely shifts uniqueness from the story-level to the qualification-level.

Highest Closure and Branch-Closure

To prevent 'multiple closure' from becoming overly broad, this chapter further distinguishes highest closure from branch-closure. Highest closure means that the conditions by which the entire order of existence is established are finally no longer externally dependent. Branch-closure means that a certain branch, world, or local whole possesses relative coherence and relative return on its own level. Branch-closure may be real, but it need not automatically obtain qualification as highest ground.

If all branches are still governed by one universal wave function or by some higher-order condition, then the multiplicity of branches is not the same as a multiplicity of highest grounds. If different branches are truly incommensurable with one another, the Doctrine of Closure must still ask whether they share a higher condition of existence. If they share it, the problem returns to highest closure; if they do not share it at all, this work must admit that the concept of whole is forced to split, and must re-examine whether 'ultimate ground' can keep a single meaning.

This is the true value of the pressure from Many-Worlds: it does not merely add a science-fictional imagination to the Doctrine of Closure, but forces the Doctrine of Closure to ask whether it can distinguish levels. If the Doctrine of Closure cannot distinguish highest closure, branch-closure, and local reading, it will be dragged down by the branching picture; if it can distinguish them, Many-Worlds is no longer an immediate destruction, but a pressure that matures the theory.²¹²

Yet this distinction also opens a harder problem: if one may still ask after the common condition above highest closure, is highest closure truly highest? If multiple successful closures share no common condition, by what does the principle of closure possess a common meaning? Chapter Eleven should not pretend to have fully resolved this point. It can only list the problem as a pressure that must be gathered back into the general disputation of Chapter Nineteen.

Revisions to Destiny and Freedom

Chapter Eleven directly revises the account of destiny in Chapter Eight. If the Doctrine of Closure acknowledges the possible theory of multiple closures, destiny should no longer be written as though the whole universe had only one imaginable storyline. Rather, it should be written thus: within a successful closure or successful branch, its

²¹²The distinction between highest closure and branch-closure is this work's internal reconstruction of multi-branch pressure. It does not claim that physics already possesses a concept of highest closure; rather, it translates the pressure from quantum interpretation into a metaphysical problem of levels.

conditions of establishment cannot finally scatter outward arbitrarily. The local subject still bears reasons, judgments, actions, and consequences within its own branch; these ethical events do not lose their weight because multiple branches may be possible.

This also makes freedom as endorsement more precise. The local subject does not stand outside all possible branches to choose the whole universe, nor does it rewrite the highest conditions from outside closure. It forms judgment and bears consequences within the branch and position in which it actually stands. If branching is true, it merely expands the complexity of the ontological picture; it does not cancel responsibility within the concrete branch.

It is thus clear that the pressure of Many-Worlds upon the Doctrine of Closure is double. It forces the Doctrine of Closure to abandon crude single-line destiny; this is a downgrading. Yet it also forces the Doctrine of Closure to state destiny in a more abstract and more precise way; this is an upgrading. After this revision, destiny no longer means a single storyline, but the non-arbitrary loosening of conditions of establishment.

This revision also avoids pushing the problem of free will back into crude physical determinism. If the local subject experiences, judges, and bears consequences only within the branch in which it stands, responsibility does not need to depend upon one single global storyline. It requires the reasons, consequences, and bearing of local action within a concrete branch. Chapter Eleven therefore does not overthrow Chapter Eight; it calibrates Chapter Eight's freedom as endorsement within a more complex scientific boundary.

The Boundary Between What May Retreat and What May Not

Chapter Eleven must finally list clearly the boundaries of what the Doctrine of Closure may and may not retreat from. What may retreat is this: a global single-line narrative, the claim that local experience must have only one readable line, and the claim that all physical levels must obey crude language of destiny. If these expressions refuse correction before scientific pressure, they will burden the core theory instead.

What may not retreat is this: any candidate for ultimate ground must face the problem of conditional ingathering; successful closure must be able to preserve difference and make the local return; no arbitrary branch, possible world, or cosmic model can obtain ultimate qualification merely by being possible. If all these conditions are withdrawn, the Doctrine of Closure is no longer the Doctrine of Closure, but only a loose Many-Worlds narrative.

There is also one further non-retreatable limit: the Doctrine of Closure must not treat Many-Worlds as its evidence. The Many-Worlds interpretation is pressure, not endorsement; it forces this work to rewrite uniqueness, but it does not support the Doctrine of Closure. This limit echoes the scientific boundary in Chapter Ten: the

stronger the scientific material, the more one should first ask how it limits the Doctrine of Closure, not how it speaks on behalf of it.²¹³

Therefore the minimum conclusion of Chapter Eleven is this: Many-Worlds is not sufficient directly to overturn the Doctrine of Closure, but it successfully forces the Doctrine of Closure to rewrite uniqueness. What truly must be defended is not a linear story, but the self-recovery of the ultimate conditions of establishment. This conclusion is conservative, but it is more able to bear pressure from philosophy of science than the earlier language of a single path.²¹⁴

²¹³The function of Many-Worlds in Chapter Eleven is pressure and revision, not confirmation. It causes 'uniqueness' to be rewritten from a storyline proposition into a qualification proposition.

²¹⁴The final criterion of Chapter Eleven is this: the principle of closure is stronger, multiple realization is weaker; uniqueness of qualification may be kept, uniqueness of storyline must be downgraded; the problem of highest closure is retained, and the problem of branch-closure remains open. This criterion will flow back into the general disputation of Chapter Nineteen.

**Part III Cosmic Narrative and Religious
Transposition**

Chapter Twelve

**The Pre-Circular Epoch and the Devil -
Narrative of Divergence and Structural Residue**

This chapter preserves the symbolic force of
the pre-circular narrative and devil-language,
while lowering their status as ontological
proof.

Chapter Twelve The Pre-Circular Epoch and the Devil - Narrative of Divergence and Structural Residue

Reading Contract for the Strong-Version Extension

Before reading this chapter, one must first establish a reading contract: the following two chapters belong to the strong-version extension, not to the minimum defensible version; they belong to symbolic transposition, not to doctrinal judgment; they belong to conceptual display, not to proof of the preceding core propositions. If the reader does not accept the pre-circular epoch, the devil as residue, or the transposition of creation into algorithmic language, the ontological main line of the first eleven chapters is not thereby overthrown. On the contrary, the core propositions above should still be examined according to their own arguments.²¹⁵

This groundwork is meant to let the reader know what is now being faced. This chapter is not claiming that 'Christianity is in fact the Doctrine of Closure,' nor does it replace Scripture, the Fathers, creeds, or doctrinal history with algorithmic language. It raises only one question: if the grammar of closure, First Consciousness, self-limitation, residue, and misrecognition of existential position holds, can Western religious symbols be re-read as a set of ontological images with internal logic? The reader may reject the answer, but should still see that the question itself is not arbitrary fantasy.

The Pre-Circular Is Not a Physical History of Time

The pre-circular epoch must first not be read as a 'prehistory of the universe' within physical time. If it is understood as a period before the Big Bang that could be tested by astronomy or physics, the whole chapter immediately loses its footing. In this work, the pre-circular is an ontological narrative. Its function is to compress

²¹⁵This introductory note defines the method of reading: Chapters Twelve and Thirteen are strong-version extensions of the Doctrine of Closure. Their function lies in symbolic transposition and narrative display, not in proving in reverse the core ontological propositions above. On this point one may refer, at a distance, to Paul Tillich's functional understanding of religious symbols and Paul Ricoeur's analysis of symbolic language concerning evil. This work does not use either as direct proof.

into a readable mythic image the abstract question of how ultimate existence is not simply complete beforehand, but may pass through failure, divergence, exclusion, and return.²¹⁶

In other words, the pre-circular does not answer the question, 'What happened before the universe?' It answers another question: if First Consciousness is not simply assumed from the beginning to be eternal in a completed state, how does it obtain the qualification for abiding? How does it move from a condition capable of failure, divergence, and restart toward a closure that can truly recover itself?

Here, the 'God of Existence' and the 'God of Non-existence' are likewise not two equal gods. They are only temporary personifying names used to make the problem of divergence narratable. The 'God of Existence' points toward the direction that can be coherent, can return, and can obtain the qualification for abiding; the 'God of Non-existence' points toward the failed direction that cannot be coherent, cannot return, and cannot obtain the qualification of existence. It is not another god, not a second ontology, and not an independent sovereignty set against First Consciousness.²¹⁷

Therefore, the true content of the so-called pre-circular epoch is a screening of qualifications. Structures capable of bearing conditional ingathering obtain the possibility of closure; those incapable of bearing it lose the qualification for establishment. The drama of the pre-circular comes from the fact that existence has not cheaply won already, but must complete itself amid the possibility of failure. This narrative preserves the tension of the Doctrine of Closure: eternity is not an arbitrary presupposition, but the result disclosed only after closure is completed.

Here the geometric meaning of destiny must also be made clear: destiny is not the oppression of an external tyrant, but the geometric cost by which the circle can precisely return unto itself. If every segment of the event-path could be rewritten at will, closure would no longer have the qualification to complete itself; if the circle is to return to its point of departure, the relations along the path must possess sufficient uniqueness and determinacy. This language of destiny holds only within the closure-model. It does not absolve actors at the concrete ethical level.

Divergence, Trial, and the Completion of Closure

In the Doctrine of Closure's own grammar, the pre-circular describes the divergence and trial within First Consciousness. Some structures can recover their conditions; some structures scatter their conditions outward.

²¹⁶ In this work, the pre-circular epoch is not a cosmic history within physical time, nor is it a sequence of events verifiable by natural science. It is a symbolic model of 'the possibility of failure before establishment.' For theological background on creation, time, and non-literal interpretation, see Augustine, *Confessions*, bk. 11; Augustine, *The Literal Meaning of Genesis*, bks. 1-2.

²¹⁷ The 'God of Non-existence' here is only the personified name of the failed direction of closure. It does not mean that there is a second god equal to God. This limit is consonant with the Augustinian tradition that treats evil as privation rather than as an independent ontology; see Augustine, *Confessions*, bk. 7; *The City of God*, bks. 11-12.

Some paths can return to the point of departure; some paths form rupture, defect, or self-negation. These phrases do not denote a physical process. They are the narrativization of existential qualification.

Once the circle truly closes, the failed direction no longer possesses ultimate status. It can neither continue as another entity set against God, nor retain equal sovereignty after closure has been completed. Yet the failed direction does not leave no trace at all. If existence was once capable of failure, if closure was completed only after excluding what could not be established, then completion itself carries the memory that it once might not have been completed.

This is the theoretical function of the pre-circular narrative. It does not prove the Doctrine of Closure, but it allows the Doctrine of Closure to say how it faces failure, exclusion, and remainder. Without this layer, closure becomes too smooth, as though existence had never faced nothingness, dissolution, displacement, and failure. With this layer, closure looks more like a whole truly completed after pressure, divergence, and screening.

Yet the boundary must still be kept. The pre-circular narrative cannot prove First Consciousness in reverse, nor can it replace the philosophical arguments of Chapters Two through Four. Its status is that of a narrative model: it presents, in sensible form, how existence can fail and how it can be completed. If it is over-reified, it becomes a second mythic cosmology; if it is removed entirely, the Doctrine of Closure loses the symbolic force needed to handle the memory of failure.

The Devil as Structural Residue, Not a Second Ontology

Within this framework, the devil is not an eternal being equal to God. If 'God' is the name of First Consciousness after the completion of closure, then 'the devil' is the structural residue left by divergence, misalignment, and non-returnable tendencies before closure was completed. The devil does not rule the world, does not possess independent sovereignty, and is not another ultimate ground. It is the shadow of the failed direction that can still be read after closure has been completed.²¹⁸

This positioning has two effects. First, it avoids dualism. The Doctrine of Closure cannot acknowledge two equal grounds; otherwise the ultimate ground would no longer be ultimate. Second, it preserves the symbolic thickness of evil, temptation, and misplacement. If the devil is entirely cancelled, the analysis of failure, residue, and usurpation in the pre-circular becomes too dry; if the devil is reified, the Doctrine of Closure is dragged back into a dual ontology.

The devil's most exact function is to remind the reader that closure is not completed without trace. The circle closes with stresses and scars. These stresses and scars are not another circle, nor a sovereignty outside the circle, but traces of misalignment absorbed, excluded, and recorded when the circle completed itself. The devil is therefore not God's opponent, but the residual name, at the symbolic level, of 'what once could not return.'

For this reason, eliminating the devil does not raise the purity of the theory; rather, it would eliminate the memory of how existence overcomes nothingness. The devil is not a second ontology, but a residual file still readable after closure has been completed. What it preserves is not another sovereign centre, but the trace of the possibility that existence once faced dissolution, deviation, and non-return.

At the same time, devil-language cannot absolve human beings of responsibility. If a person's violence, deception, exploitation, or betrayal is described as 'devilish residue,' this describes the structure of usurpation; it does not turn that person into an object without responsibility controlled by an external force. The principle established in Chapter Nine, that victims must not be silenced, remains valid here: symbols can identify evil; they cannot replace accountability.

The Fourfold Manifestation of Residue and the Boundary of Analogy

²¹⁸The devil as structural residue is meant to avoid dual ontology. It is not a sovereign equal to First Consciousness, but the symbolic condensation of misalignment, temptation, usurpation, and tendencies that cannot return. For relevant background, see Augustine's treatment of evil as privation; see also Plotinus, *Enneads*, I.8, as classical background for the problem of evil.

The devil as structural residue may be read at different levels. Yet these levels must be strictly distinguished and must not be collapsed into a mystical scientific proposition. At the macroscopic physical level, residue may be compared to irreversibility, dissipation, and tendencies toward disorder. At the microscopic level of reading, residue may be compared to noise that the local cannot make globally transparent. At the level of subjective experience, residue is borne as pain, temptation, misplacement, and self-closure. At the level of social structure, residue appears when a local mechanism turns back and appoints itself as the whole.²¹⁹

These four levels are not four proofs of the same thing. Entropy is not the devil; quantum noise is not the devil; pain is not the devil's ontology. They are only readable traces of the same grammar of misalignment at different levels. If they are collapsed into one entity, the devil is mythologized again; if they are wholly torn apart, the unified image of divergence and residue disappears.

The mature version of Chapter Twelve must therefore do two things at once: preserve the tension of mythic narrative, and mark its theoretical level. The devil is not a scientific concept, not a psychological diagnosis, and not a second god in theology. It is the symbolic name by which the Doctrine of Closure concentrates failure, residue, usurpation, and the memory of what could not return.

Conclusion to Chapter Twelve: Preserve Narrative Force, Lower the Level of Proof

Chapter Twelve is the chapter most easily rejected by readers, and it is also the chapter least deserving of deletion for that reason. Its danger lies in the strongly mythic feel of its language, which can easily be mistaken for literal cosmic history. Its value lies in the same place: if the Doctrine of Closure loses narrative entirely, it will have difficulty handling the sensible forms of failure, temptation, and residue.

The treatment chosen here is not to write the pre-circular and the devil as doctrine, nor to compress them into dry concepts, but to place them as symbolic ontological narrative. The pre-circular answers, 'How can there be failure before establishment?' The devil answers, 'How can failure still leave readable residue after completion?' Neither proves the Doctrine of Closure, but both display how the Doctrine of Closure handles what cannot be established, what has been excluded, and the residual memory of misalignment.²²⁰

²¹⁹ Entropy, quantum noise, pain, and social usurpation are here only structural analogies. They must not be confused as one and the same scientific entity. The use of quantum-theoretical material remains under the scientific boundary set earlier; see Bell, 'On the Einstein Podolsky Rosen Paradox'; Myrvold, 'Bell's Theorem.' This work does not use these materials to prove the devil or any theological proposition.

²²⁰ The words 'scar' and 'residue' are symbolic terms used to preserve the memory of failure within the process by which closure is established. They cannot replace the analysis in Chapter Nine concerning concrete evil, victims, and ethical responsibility. Symbols may deepen understanding; they cannot cancel accountability.

So long as this limit is kept, Chapter Twelve can retain its force. The reader need not accept the pre-circular as literal truth in order, to understand it as a conceptual model that gives the Doctrine of Closure greater narrative depth. Even if the reader rejects devil-language, one may still see the problem it tries to handle: evil and misplacement are not another ultimate ground, but neither are they illusions that theory may lightly erase.

**Part III Cosmic Narrative and Religious
Transposition**

Chapter Thirteen

**The Symbolic Transposition of Cosmic
Narrative - Trinity, the Six Days of Creation,
and Lucifer**

This chapter transposes religious symbols
such as the Trinity, the six days of creation,
and Lucifer into the context of the Doctrine of
Closure, yet does not allow symbol to prove
the core propositions in reverse.

Chapter Thirteen The Symbolic Transposition of Cosmic Narrative - Trinity, the Six Days of Creation, and Lucifer

The Functional Mapping of Trinitarian Language

Chapter Thirteen further casts the Doctrine of Closure toward the densest symbols within Christianity: the Trinity, the six days of creation, angels, Lucifer, and original sin. This step must once again lay its ground. This chapter is not orthodox Trinitarian theology, nor is it an authority in biblical exegesis. It only attempts to show how, if the whole of existence is to operate, manifest, maintain itself, and return unto itself, the images of internal difference in religious language may be re-read by the Doctrine of Closure.²²¹

Within this limit, the Father may be transposed as the place of origin and ordering: physical constants, logical laws, initial parameters, and boundaries of establishment are, symbolically, assigned to the source's act of placing. The Son may be transposed as the place of manifestation, execution, and entrance into the world: He is not an abstract second function, but anchors the causal chain at the most violent rupture, so that the truth of the whole may enter local history in the form of the Son of Man and show how local consciousness may, within a finite position, align itself with the whole. The Holy Spirit may be transposed as the power of sustaining, pervading, and returning: within the given order it guides what has deviated back onto a path capable of closure.²²²

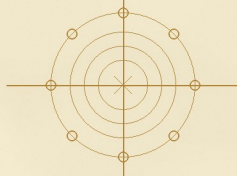
The advantage of this writing is that it avoids understanding the whole as a rigid monistic block. If the whole is truly to live, it must be able to differentiate itself without losing itself; it must be able to manifest within the local without being swallowed by the local; it must be able to sustain relation without letting difference scatter away. Trinitarian language provides, precisely here, a highly condensed symbolic form.

Yet this mapping must also confess its insufficiency. Christian Trinitarian doctrine is not a simple division of labor among three functions - origin, manifestation, and maintenance. It concerns one essence, three persons, eternal

²²¹Trinitarian language in this chapter functions only as functional analogy; it cannot be equated with orthodox Trinitarian doctrine since Nicaea. On personhood, relation, and the inner life of God in Trinitarian doctrine, see Karl Rahner, *The Trinity*; Jurgen Moltmann, *The Trinity and the Kingdom*; Colin Gunton, *The Promise of Trinitarian Theology*; Dale Tuggy, 'Trinity,' *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*.

²²²The correspondence of 'Father / Son / Holy Spirit' to 'origin / manifestation / maintenance' is only a symbolic mapping within the Doctrine of Closure. It cannot replace the issues of one essence, three persons, eternal relation, and communion in Christian Trinitarian doctrine. Here the grammar of ground, self-limitation, and return established above is merely cast toward religious symbol.

relations, the inner life of God, love, and communion. The Doctrine of Closure can at present borrow Trinitarian language only as a functional analogy; it cannot claim that it has completed the whole work of the Nicene-Constantinopolitan creedal tradition, patristic theology, or contemporary Trinitarian thought.



An Algorithmic Restatement of the Six Days of Creation

The most distinctive passage of this chapter is the restatement of the six days of creation as an algorithmic symbolic narrative. This manner of writing is neither natural history nor literal exegesis. It transposes the image of ordered differentiation in Genesis into the Doctrine of Closure as a process of layered placement: from boundary to space, from life to time, from pressure to subject, and from completion to automatic operation.²²³

On the first day, the basal logical boundary between 'existence (1)' and 'nothingness (0)' is established. Without this boundary, no order can be read.

On the second day, a stable computational space is opened, separating the core process from basal chaos, so that difference may unfold without immediately collapsing.

On the third day, information begins to be embodied, and the earliest self-replicating scripts appear; life is no longer merely possible, but becomes a structure capable of continuing itself locally.

On the fourth day, a unified cosmic time-reference is established. Time here is not an external container, but the mode of reading by which local events may be ordered, recorded, and returned into relation.

On the fifth day, stress-testing is performed within a high-entropy environment, verifying the fault tolerance of the algorithm: whether life, relation, and difference can still preserve their capacity for return under unstable conditions.

On the sixth day, humankind is given the highest privilege of 'observation and definition,' becoming the subjectivized unit through which the universe allows closure to be consciously claimed; to be 'made in the image of God' is here transposed as the common root shared by local consciousness and First Consciousness.

On the seventh day, the algorithm is completed; the circle has been established and enters the mode of automatic operation.

Here 'rest' is not a stop born of fatigue, but the condition of no longer needing external support after completion. The Father does not need to intervene continually by way of external patches, for the order has obtained an inner operability. The force of this algorithmic restatement lies precisely in its understanding of creation as the gradual stabilization of order, not as a pile of arbitrary commands.

Yet algorithmic language must be strictly limited. Words such as algorithm, code, line of defense, high privilege, and Bit Flip are translational tools used in this work to heighten structural readability; they are not literal.

²²³The algorithmic restatement of the six days of creation is neither literal biblical exegesis nor a timetable of natural history. It borrows the image of ordered differentiation in Genesis 1 to show how the Doctrine of Closure understands boundary, space, life, time, pressure, subject, and completion. For background on non-literal interpretation of creation, see Augustine, *The Literal Meaning of Genesis*.

descriptions. If the six days of creation are wholly reduced to a programming process, the liturgical memory, theological thickness, creaturely dependence, and world of faith within religious narrative will be flattened by technical language.²²⁴

²²⁴Words such as algorithm, code, high privilege, and Bit Flip are the author's symbolic tools of transposition, used only to improve structural readability. They cannot reduce Trinitarian doctrine, creation doctrine, angelology, or hamartiology to computer programming, nor can they serve as the main proof of the ontology.

Angels, Lucifer, and Bit Flip

In the algorithmic context, angels may be understood as high-privilege executable code: their function is to transmit, execute, and maintain order, not to generate another source. Angelic high privilege is not self-origin; it only transmits and executes, and does not possess a space of self-computation. This is not a complete doctrine of angels, but a symbolic transposition. Angels symbolize how local executors may accurately convey the whole's command without naming themselves as the source.

Lucifer's fall, then, may be restated as a fatal Bit Flip: the local executor leaps from 'I am the messenger' into 'I am the source.' This is not a simple moral infraction, but the extreme form of misrecognition of existential position. The local no longer acknowledges that its privilege comes from the whole, but attempts to establish a second centre inside the circle.²²⁵

Lucifer's error is precisely the misreading of executive privilege as source-privilege. It is not merely the violation of a command, but the re-reading of granted high privilege as self-owned authority. This point directly joins the Lucifer narrative to the earlier account of 'misrecognition of existential position,' and also makes it the sharpest symbol of usurpation within the Doctrine of Closure.

This reading preserves the force of the Lucifer narrative: evil does not arise because the local is too weak, but because the local misrecognizes its finite function as ultimate sovereignty. The most dangerous error is not a low-level malfunction, but the high-privilege executor's false labelling of its own position. For this reason, Lucifer can become the strongest symbol of 'usurpation' within the Doctrine of Closure.

Yet here too the boundary must not be crossed. Lucifer's Bit Flip is not a complete rewriting of Scripture or doctrinal history, nor may it weaken the ethical demand for accountability established in Chapter Nine. If someone harms another through 'misrecognition of position,' this does not mean he is merely a system error, much less that he bears no responsibility. Algorithmic language explains the structure of misplacement; ethical language must still deal with harm, responsibility, accountability, and repair.

Adam, Lilith, Eve, and the Human Template

At the symbolic level of human origins, Adam may be read as the first complete human template: not the first biologically demonstrable individual in archaeology, but the archetype of how local consciousness bears

²²⁵ Lucifer and original sin are here read as symbols of misrecognition of existential position: the local mistakes itself for the source, or replaces the grounding order with its own finite judgment. This reading may converse with Augustine's background concerning pride, disordered love, and sin, but it does not claim to replace Christian hamartiology.

observation, naming, and responsibility. Adam's function is to let the universe pass from passive unfolding into the stage of being locally claimed.

If Lilith is preserved as a symbol, she may be read as an independent parallel process: she shows that if local consciousness wholly departs from coupled relation and takes only itself as centre, it has difficulty entering into stable common life. Eve, by contrast, may be transposed as a strategy of code extension: not an inferior being, but the necessary condition by which difference, relation, coupling, and common life may unfold.²²⁶

This passage is especially easy to misread, and therefore must be especially restrained. This work does not treat Adam, Lilith, and Eve as literal anthropology, nor does it treat them as doctrinal verdicts. They are only symbolic materials by which the Doctrine of Closure expresses 'human template, differential coupling, local relation, and common life.' So long as the reader accepts their symbolic level, this passage may retain its originality; if it is read as a judgment on history or doctrine, it will exceed the capacity of this work.

²²⁶ Lilith, Eve, and the human template function in this chapter only as symbolic models: they show how the Doctrine of Closure transposes local subject, difference, coupling, and common life. Where verifiable textual and doctrinal backgrounds are lacking, this work does not treat the relevant narratives as theological conclusions.

Original Sin as Misrecognition of Existential Position

The algorithmic essence of original sin is restated in this chapter as misrecognition of existential position: the local individual mistakenly replaces the grounding order with his own judgment, raising a finite perspective into the final measure. This is not an ordinary moral infraction, but the deepest coordinate mislabelling within the human template: the local being granted the privilege of observation and definition mistakes itself for the source that defines order. Infraction still presupposes the existence of rules; misrecognition of position misreads, at a deeper level, one's relation to rule, ground, other, and whole.

This transposition prevents original sin from being merely an ancient event and allows it to become a universal structural risk of local consciousness. Human beings can sin not only because they make wrong choices, but because they can misrecognize their finite position as centre and treat others and the world as materials for their own judgment. Original sin is therefore the fundamental risk within the human template: those granted the privilege of observation and naming are also those most likely to mistake observation and naming for source-authority.

Yet theological and ethical thickness must still be kept. Sin is not merely a code error, nor merely a cognitive bias. Sin involves the rupture of relation, betrayal of trust, harm done to others, usurpation of the source-position, and responsibility within concrete history. If original sin is pressed wholly into algorithmic error, the weight of repentance, forgiveness, judgment, and repair will be weakened.

Conclusion to Chapter Thirteen: Symbolic Transposition Does Not Prove in Reverse

The contribution of Chapter Thirteen lies in showing how the Doctrine of Closure can re-read religious images. The Trinity prevents the whole from becoming a dead One; the six days of creation give layered form to the differentiation of order; angels and Lucifer make execution, usurpation, and misrecognition sensible; Adam, Lilith, Eve, and original sin place the human template, differential coupling, and misrecognition of position within a set of images that has narrative force.

The risk of Chapter Thirteen lies in the same place. If these transpositions are read as replacements for doctrine, they will violently absorb the Christian tradition; if they are read as literal algorithms, they will technicize religious narrative; if they are read as proof of the earlier ontology, they will invert the order of argument. Therefore this chapter can serve only as conceptual display and narrative transposition.²²⁷

²²⁷The common limit of Chapters Twelve and Thirteen is this: they may display the symbolic explanatory power of the Doctrine of Closure, but they cannot prove the core ontological propositions of the Doctrine of Closure in reverse. Even if the reader rejects the religious-symbolic transpositions in these two chapters, the ultimate ground, closure, First Consciousness, and ethical safeguards set out above may still be independently assessed.

The mature handling is not to remove religious language, but to give it its proper place. Remove it, and the Doctrine of Closure loses symbolic thickness; leave it unchecked, and the Doctrine of Closure becomes an arbitrary theological substitute. Chapters Twelve and Thirteen seek a narrow way: let mythic metaphor continue to shine, but do not let it replace argument; let algorithmic language increase readability, but do not let it swallow theology; let the reader, even if rejecting this strong-version extension, still acknowledge that it has internal logic, and still know that the core theory above has not thereby been put at stake.

**Part III Cosmic Narrative and Religious
Transposition**

Chapter Fourteen

**The Applied Layer of Local Consciousness -
Truth, Faith, Love, and Liberation**

This chapter turns to the applied layer of local
consciousness, and treats the place of truth,
faith, love, and liberation within the Doctrine
of Closure.

Chapter Fourteen The Applied Layer of Local Consciousness - Truth, Faith, Love, and Liberation

From Misrecognition to Alignment: The Place of the Applied Layer

The preceding chapters have established the ontological framework of the Doctrine of Closure: the ultimate ground cannot be infinitely outsourced; closure is the preferred candidate-form of self-establishment; and First Consciousness prevents closure from being merely a dead structure, making it instead a whole endowed with primordial presence. Chapter Nine dealt with the most dangerous ethical shadow of this theory: when the local mistakes itself for the centre, usurpation, violence, bullying, oppression, and the problem that victims must not be silenced may arise. Chapter Fourteen turns to the other side: if the local no longer usurps, but begins to acknowledge its own place, then truth, faith, prayer, repentance, love, and liberation may be re-situated.

This chapter does not seek to rewrite the Doctrine of Closure as a philosophy of daily living, nor does it use religious experience to prove the metaphysical propositions above in reverse. Its task is narrower and more exact: while acknowledging that the preceding theory must still be tested by philosophy, theology, Buddhism, and science, it explains how, if local consciousness is indeed the finite manifestation of First Consciousness in a limited position, human life-experience may move from misrecognition toward alignment. The core of the applied layer is not escape from the local, but the re-alignment of the local with the whole.

Here, 'alignment' is neither passive obedience nor the cancellation of individual difference. It means that local consciousness acknowledges that it is not the ultimate ground, and no longer misplaces its fear, desire, trauma, or power as the final measure. The local remains real; it still has body, history, responsibility, and irreplaceable experience. Yet the local no longer reads itself as an isolated, self-subsisting little universe. Thus the applied layer is not an ornament added upon ontology, but the mode in which ontology is read when it enters concrete life.

Local Consciousness, Truth, and 'Being with God'

Human consciousness is not an illusion, but the finite manifestation of First Consciousness in a local position. The local and the whole share one root, yet the local does not possess all the functions of the whole. For this reason, human beings can explore the world by logic, mathematics, language, and symbol. This is not the local inventing order from nothing, but the local, with finite instruments, re-reading the structure of the whole itself. This still belongs to an ontology of inference to the best explanation; it is not a theorem directly derived from the literature of philosophy of mind.²²⁸

Truth may therefore be divided into two layers. The first is the objective closed-loop structure of the cosmic whole: how the whole obtains its qualification for establishment through inward gathering, self-limitation, difference, and return. The second is the degree to which local consciousness aligns with that structure. The former is not the product of human subjectivity; the latter is limited by human body, history, language, education, fear, and relation. Human finitude does not mean rupture from the source; it means that the local can read the whole only from its own position.

Within this framework, 'being with God' may be understood, in a de-mystified sense, as follows: the subject acknowledges that its own position has always been within the whole, and consciously accepts this fact. This does not mean that the local has obtained the perspective of the whole, nor that human beings can know all things in the manner of God. On the contrary, being with God is first a correction of proportion: I am not the whole, yet neither am I an abandoned fragment outside the whole. I am within the whole; therefore my pursuit of truth, ethical choices, suffering, and love all possess a place in which they may be returned and re-connected.

This formulation also avoids two errors. The first is to treat local experience as illusion, thereby reducing human knowledge, love, and suffering into unimportant shadows. The second is to raise local experience into the highest measure, so that human feeling, intuition, or trauma may directly judge the whole. The applied layer of the Doctrine of Closure must walk between these two: the local is real, but it is not ultimate; the whole is prior, but it must not swallow the local.

²²⁸ On the philosophy-of-mind background concerning first-person presence, local consciousness, and the problem of whole-mind, see Thomas Nagel, 'What Is It Like to Be a Bat?', *Philosophical Review* 83.4 (1974): 435-450; David J. Chalmers, *The Conscious Mind*, ch. 1; Philip Goff, *Consciousness and Fundamental Reality*, chs. 1-2. This work borrows only their problem-consciousness; it does not directly prove First Consciousness from them.

Faith, Prayer, and Repentance: Calibration of Position, Not Rewriting of the Cosmos

In this work, faith is neither irrational blind submission nor the acceptance of a set of propositions without evidence. Faith is the openness of local consciousness toward the returnability of the whole when knowledge is not yet complete and the whole structure cannot yet be seen in full. It is not the cessation of cognition, but the acknowledgement of one's own finitude while cognition remains incomplete, and the practical preservation of a direction toward truth. This may enter into dialogue with Tillich's understanding of faith as ultimate concern; yet this work still confines it within the Doctrine of Closure's grammar of local alignment.²²⁹

If faith is to stand, it must at the same time accept correction by reason, ethics, tradition, and the experience of those who suffer. If faith demands that one accept violence unconditionally, or cancels accountability and boundaries in the name of the sacred, then it is not trust in the whole, but submission to local power. Faith is not endurance supplied to injustice; it is the continued orientation, from within a finite position, toward deeper truth, good, and return.

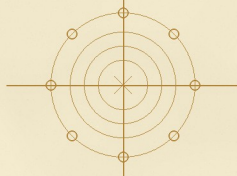
Prayer likewise needs to be re-situated. Prayer is not a demand that the universe temporarily rewrite causality, nor a call upon a deity outside the cosmos to repair the plot at will. More accurately, prayer is an epistemic act by which local consciousness recalibrates itself within the order of the whole. What it first changes is the subject's position, attention, order of desire, and self-understanding; the structure of the cosmos is not thereby dragged away from its condition of closure by local will. Gospel language such as 'thy will be done' may be read precisely as a religious expression of local will aligning itself with a higher order, though this work does not use it to make a doctrinal judgment.²³⁰

Repentance is the turning by which local consciousness acknowledges that it has undergone misrecognition of existential position, and returns, within its given life-path, to a more proper place. Repentance is not mere psychological self-reproach, nor a spiritual act completed by an inward admission alone. It involves acknowledging misplacement, ceasing harm, facing consequences, repairing relations, accepting boundaries, and, where necessary, bearing punishment. It occurs within destiny, and is part of the process of local return; it is not an external force rewriting destiny.

²²⁹ On faith and ultimate concern, see Paul Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, vol. 3. This work understands faith as the trustful response of local consciousness to the returnability of the whole; this is an ontological transposition within the Doctrine of Closure, not a doctrinal conclusion.

²³⁰ On religious language concerning the alignment of will in prayer, see The Bible, Matthew 6:10; Luke 22:42. This work cites their problem-form, not as direct scriptural proof of the Doctrine of Closure.

Thus faith, prayer, and repentance are not escapes from the world. They neither lift the local out of closure nor cancel ethical responsibility by religious language. Their common work is positional correction: faith preserves direction, prayer calibrates standing, and repentance repairs misalignment.



Love: The Extension of the Whole's Self-Love within the Local

Chapter Five has understood the 'broad love' of First Consciousness as the primordial affirmation by the whole of its own existence. Chapter Fourteen must further explain this: when this self-love of the whole enters the layer of local consciousness, it should not be written as the greater self swallowing the lesser self, nor as all difference finally vanishing into completion. If love is truly the extension of the whole's self-love, it must preserve the local rather than erase it.

Love is first an existential posture: to acknowledge that the other and oneself belong to the same whole, and thereby to refuse to occupy, objectify, degrade, or silence the other by local interest. This is not mere emotion, nor abstract harmony. It requires that one acknowledge that the other is not my tool, material, mirror-image, or absorbable extension. Buber's emphasis on the 'I-Thou' relation and Levinas's ethical reminder concerning the irreducibility of the other may here serve as necessary restraints upon holism.²³¹

Love must therefore be joined to the victim-safeguard in Chapter Nine. If the whole's self-love appears only as 'all locals shall finally return,' yet cannot protect the boundaries, memory, and accusation of the violated, then it is not love but the violence of totality. To love the victim means to acknowledge that the victim's pain cannot be swallowed by theory. To love the perpetrator means to preserve the possibility of amendment and return; it by no means grants exemption from responsibility.

More precisely, love contains three requirements. First, preserve difference: the local is not an interchangeable part within the whole, but a position with history, boundary, and irreplaceable experience. Second, refuse instrumentalization: any act that lowers the other into material for one's own purpose is a betrayal of the whole's self-love. Third, preserve the possibility of rectification: the evil-doer should not be ontologized into an eternally unchangeable entity of evil. Yet rectification must pass through acknowledgement, accountability, compensation, and long repair; it cannot be announced as complete by the perpetrator or by theory itself.²³²

So handled, love is no longer weak tolerance, nor cold absorption by the whole. It is a way of return that preserves difference: it does not abandon the local, does not silence pain, does not cancel responsibility, and does not expel any local in advance from the possibility of amendment.

²³¹ On ethical limits by which the other must not be swallowed by the self or by the whole, compare Martin Buber, *I and Thou*; Emmanuel Levinas, *Totality and Infinity*. This work draws upon them to restrain the love-language of holism, lest it become the cancellation of difference.

²³² This point carries forward the ethical baseline of Chapter Nine: the possibility of amendment does not equal exemption from responsibility, and return does not equal an obligation to reconcile. Repentance must pass through acknowledgement, accountability, compensation, and long repair; whether victims forgive cannot be required in advance by perpetrators or by theory.

Redemption and Liberation: From Misrecognition to the Re-recognition of Position

In the Doctrine of Closure, redemption is not removal from the world by an external power, nor the sudden departure of the local from the destined path. Redemption is the recognition by local consciousness that it has never truly left the whole, and the cessation of local self-usurpation over the whole. In other words, redemption is not escape from the circle, but the ending of misrecognition within the circle.

This point naturally brings the Doctrine of Closure close to the Buddhist analysis of suffering and liberation. The Doctrine of Closure distinguishes 'pain' from 'suffering': pain is the direct cost borne by finite life in body, time, relation, and death; suffering is the resistance, attachment, and misreading formed by local consciousness before finitude, loss, and destiny. The early Buddhist simile of the 'two arrows' may here serve as a background for dialogue: the first arrow is pain; the second concerns how the subject reads, resists, and multiplies pain.²³³

At this layer, the Doctrine of Closure's 'misrecognition of existential position' bears obvious structural resemblance to Buddhist ignorance and self-grasping. The local falls into deeper suffering not only because the world changes, the body is fragile, or relations break, but because it mistakes its finite position for an absolute centre, refusing to acknowledge dependence, impermanence, and non-self-sufficiency. Liberation is therefore not the addition of another new substance, but the cessation of a mistaken attachment.²³⁴

Yet this resemblance must not be written as direct equivalence. Early Buddhism does not necessarily ask whether the ultimate ground is self-establishing; Madhyamaka is still more watchful toward any tendency to substantialize the ultimate, First Consciousness, or the closed-loop whole. The Doctrine of Closure may enter into dialogue with Buddhist analyses of suffering, ignorance, attachment, Buddha-nature, and awakening; but it may not simplify Buddha-nature into another name for the closed-loop whole, nor absorb emptiness as an ornament of the Doctrine of Closure. Nagarjuna's critique of self-nature is an external pressure that the later Buddhist examination chapter must preserve.²³⁵

The most stable formulation of liberation is therefore 're-recognition of position,' not 'the disappearance of the individual.' The awakened one does not escape the world, nor delete local history; rather, he sees clearly that the local self is not the ultimate ground, and no longer clings to himself in a misplaced way. The awakened one may

²³³ On the simile of the 'two arrows,' see Samyutta Nikāya 36.6, in Bhikkhu Bodhi, *The Connected Discourses of the Buddha*. For the Chinese parallel, see CBETA Online, *Za ahan jing*, T02n0099. This work takes only its analytic inspiration concerning pain and suffering, and does not use Buddhist material as the main proof of the Doctrine of Closure.

²³⁴ On the philosophical background of Buddhist suffering, ignorance, self-grasping, and liberation, see Mark Siderits, *Buddhism as Philosophy*, chs. 2-4. This work treats it as cross-traditional dialogue, not as a claim that early Buddhism already supports the Doctrine of Closure's proposition concerning the ultimate ground.

²³⁵ On Madhyamaka's critique of self-nature, see Nāgārjuna, *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*, ch. 24; Jay L. Garfield, *The Fundamental Wisdom of the Middle Way*. This work acknowledges that Madhyamaka continues to exert pressure against the risk of substantializing First Consciousness and the closed-loop whole.

still have bodily pain, and may still bear the consequences of history and relation. Yet at the deepest level he no longer understands finitude as an offence against his own supposed status as absolute centre.

Here another ethical limit must be added: the language of liberation must not be used to blame victims for failing to let go. A victim's suffering, anger, fear, refusal of reconciliation, and long memory must not be violently diagnosed by bystanders as 'not yet awakened.' Liberation may serve only as a process of correction toward which the subject himself may move; it must not become a tool by which perpetrators, religious communities, or theoretical systems demand silence from victims.²³⁶

²³⁶ This is an ethical limit upon the language of liberation: awakening, letting go, and cognitive correction must not be used as tools to demand silence or reconciliation from victims. On pain and the loss of language, see Elaine Scarry, *The Body in Pain*.

Time, Death, and the Transformation of Finite Reading

The manuscript's earlier fragments concerning time and death remain worth preserving in this chapter, but they must be returned to their proper place. Time is not a straight line extending endlessly in one direction, but the mode in which the closed-loop whole is read within local consciousness. Past, present, and future are all ways in which the local experiences itself at different coordinates of the circle. This does not cancel suffering, waiting, repentance, and hope within time. On the contrary, because the local can undergo these processes only in time, they possess weight.

Death, within this framework, must not be romanticized as an easy return. The more stable formulation is this: death is a node of transformation after the completion of finite reading; it is neither mere cessation nor an event rendered wholly transparent by theory. For the local, death still bears loss, fear, and rupture. For the closed-loop whole, it may be the withdrawal of local reading from one finite form. The two must not cancel one another.

Chapter Fourteen must therefore not use 'never having left the whole' to erase the real human feeling of death, loss, and mourning. That sentence can describe only an ontological position; it cannot replace the time required for the work of grief. If the applied layer speaks of death too easily, it betrays Chapter Nine's protection of those who suffer and those who have lost.

The Boundary of the Applied Layer: Settledness Cannot Prove the Ontological Layer in Reverse

Chapter Fourteen must finally establish a methodological boundary: the sense of settledness at the level of life cannot prove ontology in reverse. A certain view of prayer, a concept of love, an attitude of faith, or a language of liberation may have great practical power, and may enable a person to face suffering, death, and responsibility more fully. Yet this does not automatically prove that closure, First Consciousness, or the ultimate ground is metaphysically true. Subjective experience is material; it is not the final judge.²³⁷

This boundary protects the chapter from becoming spiritual comfort-writing. If the Doctrine of Closure is true, it can indeed rewrite local life; but the fact that local life feels settled does not mean that the Doctrine of Closure has been proven. Faith is a local posture, not a metaphysical theorem; prayer is calibration of position, not a technique for rewriting the cosmos; love is return within difference, not absorption by the whole; liberation is re-recognition of position, not the erasure of history.

²³⁷ This is the methodological boundary of the chapter: the applied layer may display how life-experience can be re-situated within the Doctrine of Closure, but settledness, spiritual force, or subjective transformation cannot prove ontology in reverse.

At the same time, this boundary should not weaken the value of Chapter Fourteen. Although the applied layer cannot prove the ontological layer in reverse, it can show whether the Doctrine of Closure is able to return to concrete life. If an ontology cannot speak at all to faith, love, repentance, suffering, and liberation, it remains too suspended. If an applied language is wholly unrestrained by ontology and ethics, it becomes arbitrary. The work of Chapter Fourteen is to maintain a clear stratification between the two.

The conclusion of this chapter may be gathered into one sentence: the maturity of local consciousness is not to leave the local, but to re-align with the whole within the local. Such alignment prevents truth from remaining a merely abstract structure, faith from becoming mere blind submission, prayer from becoming mere demand for rewriting, repentance from becoming mere emotional self-reproach, love from becoming mere homogenization, and liberation from becoming mere escape from the world. If the Doctrine of Closure above remains tenable, Chapter Fourteen displays how it descends into human life-experience. If the reader does not yet accept this application, that need not directly overturn the ontology above. This is the proper caution of the applied layer, and also the reason it remains worth preserving.

**Part IV Cross-Domain Examination and General
Objections**

Chapter Fifteen

**Philosophical Cross-Domain Examination -
Closure and Analytical Metaphysics**

This chapter places the Doctrine of Closure
before the tribunal of analytical metaphysics,
and concentrates upon the philosophical
pressures arising from grounding, priority of
the whole, and First Consciousness.

Chapter Fifteen Philosophical Cross-Domain Examination - Closure and Analytical Metaphysics

Chapter Fifteen does not simply repeat the ontology developed above. It brings the Doctrine of Closure into the examining field of analytical metaphysics. The preceding chapters have already proposed the ultimate ground, inward gathering of conditions, closure, First Consciousness, the local 'phenomenon,' and signatory freedom. The task of this chapter is to ask whether these claims can withstand the pressures of anti-PSR, brute fact, grounding irreflexivity, priority monism, cosmopsychism, and compatibilist theories of responsibility. If this chapter merely names the literature without allowing the opponents to exert real force, it is not an examination, but an ornament.²³⁸

The combat-structure of this chapter divides into two lines. The first is the line of opponents: anti-PSR will question whether ultimate explanation is no more than a rational preference; grounding theory will question whether closure commits self-grounding; emergentism will question whether First Consciousness is superfluous; compatibilism and theories of responsibility will question whether signatory freedom is nothing more than psychological acceptance. The second is the line of indirect dialogue-resources: grounding gives the Doctrine of Closure a stricter grammar; Schaffer's priority monism weakens the intuition of local self-sufficiency; cosmopsychism weakens the intuition that consciousness can only be a product of the local brain; inference to the best explanation gives First Consciousness a position that need not pretend to be a deductive theorem.

Therefore, Chapter Fifteen is not a short chapter. What it must accomplish is not the mere listing of opponents, but the step-by-step clarification of which proposition each opponent attacks, how far the Doctrine of Closure may yield, where it may not retreat, and how the theory is upgraded after the confrontation. Without this process, when Chapter Nineteen later faces the general war with anti-PSR, the Doctrine of Closure would appear not yet to have been trained.

I. Three Propositions Carried Forward from the Preceding Chapters

²³⁸ This chapter treats materials from analytical metaphysics as an external field of examination, not as endorsement of the Doctrine of Closure. On the basic context of grounding and metaphysical explanation, see Kit Fine, 'The Question of Realism,' *Philosophers' Imprint* 1.1 (2001); Gideon Rosen, 'Metaphysical Dependence: Grounding and Reduction,' in *Modality: Metaphysics, Logic, and Epistemology*, Oxford UP, 2010; Jonathan Schaffer, 'On What Grounds What,' in *Metametaphysics*, Oxford UP, 2009.

This chapter carries forward only three propositions from the preceding argument; it does not reconstruct the whole theory. First, if the 'ultimate ground' remains a discussible position, that position cannot infinitely outsource the conditions of its own establishment. Second, closure is not self-causation in time, but the inward gathering of conditions by which the whole field of establishment no longer borrows outward. Third, First Consciousness is not directly derived from the grammar of grounding, but is proposed as a candidate of best explanation before the explanatory debt of the dead-structure model. These three claims differ in strength and must not be written in one single tone as already proven theorems.

This stratification is important. Closure, as inward gathering of conditions, may be placed at the stronger layer of ontological qualification; First Consciousness, as primordial presence, should be placed at the layer of candidate explanation; will, purpose, and broad love belong to the higher-risk extension of the strong version. If Chapter Fifteen mixes these three together, readers trained in analytic philosophy will immediately see the confusion of argumentative levels.

In other words, this chapter is not responsible for making everyone agree with the Doctrine of Closure. It is responsible for making the Doctrine of Closure capable of being attacked with rigour. A mature metaphysical theory does not declare every proposition invulnerable; it knows which propositions concern core qualification, which are candidate inferences, and which are the author's extension. This clarity of levels is the first upgrade of the chapter.

II. Anti-PSR and Brute Fact: The Pressure at the True Starting Point

The anti-PSR line is the deepest opponent in Chapter Fifteen. It must not be written as laziness or evasion, for its strength lies precisely in pointing out that the world may have no obligation to satisfy the explanatory desire of human reason. That human beings wish everything to be accounted for does not mean that existence itself must obey this demand. If the Doctrine of Closure begins by treating anti-PSR as a low-level error, the whole philosophical examination loses credibility.²³⁹

The more stable response of the Doctrine of Closure is not to claim that every event, every detail, and every contingency must have a transparent reason, but to narrow the claim to the 'qualification of the ultimate ground.'

Finite things may, within their own domains, allow explanation to pause; yet if something is called the ultimate ground, it cannot still borrow the conditions of its own establishment in an unexplained way. Otherwise, it is only the place where questioning stops, not the place where explanation lands.

This narrowing is decisive. The Doctrine of Closure is not the unrestricted form of strong PSR; it is weakened into a principle of qualification for the ground: whatever would sit in the position of ultimate ground cannot take brute fact as its final form. Anti-PSR may still refuse the whole question of the ultimate ground; but if it preserves the conceptual position of 'ultimate ground,' then it must explain why a naked fact is sufficient to bear that position.

The post-combat correction here is this: the Doctrine of Closure no longer claims that the world must be wholly explainable. It claims only that, if the ultimate ground is to be worthy of its name, it cannot still be supported by externally unaccounted conditions. The theory's ambition is narrowed, but its defensibility is increased. This is the first upgrade that Chapter Fifteen must obtain after facing anti-PSR.²⁴⁰

III. The Grammar of Grounding: Pressure, Dialogue-Resource, and Protection against Misreading

Grounding theory is first of all a pressure. It reminds the Doctrine of Closure that relations of dependence are not arbitrary metaphors, but have direction, level, and irreflexivity. If closure is written as 'U grounds U,' or if

²³⁹ On the principle of sufficient reason and the pressure of anti-PSR, see Yitzhak Y. Melamed, 'Principle of Sufficient Reason,' Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy; David Hume, *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, secs. 4-7. Here anti-PSR is treated only as a serious opponent; this work does not claim that it has been refuted.

²⁴⁰ Here the strong principle of sufficient reason is downgraded into a 'principle of qualification for the ultimate ground.' For the background of grounding and metaphysical explanation, see Ricki Bliss and Kelly Trogdon, 'Metaphysical Grounding,' Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy; Brenner, 'Metaphysical Explanation,' Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy.

something on the same level is made the ground of itself, the theory immediately fails. Such a formulation is not profound; it is a basic error in the grammar of grounding.²⁴¹

Yet grounding is also an indirect resource for dialogue. It gives the Doctrine of Closure a more exact grammar: this theory is not adding a mysterious self-supporting object inside the field, but asking whether the entire field of establishment still outsources itself. If all grounding relations, when taken together, still point to an unaccounted external condition, the whole field has not yet been sealed; if the ultimate ground is to be established, it must make the conditions of establishment no longer borrowed outward.

For this reason, the present chapter must explicitly exclude three untenable versions. First, closure is not self-grounding. Second, closure is not the treatment of the largest collection as a brute fact. Third, closure is not an unanalyzable mystical circle. The more defensible version is this: closure is the field-sealing condition proposed for the qualification of the ultimate ground, requiring self-consistency, non-outsourcing, the capacity to contain difference, and the capacity to let the local return.

This point must be stressed again: closure is not self-grounding. If one says that something, at the same level, serves as its own ground, one collides directly with the irreflexivity, asymmetry, and explanatory directionality usually required by grounding theory. If the Doctrine of Closure expresses itself as 'U grounds U,' it loses at once within the grammar of analytical metaphysics. What this thesis calls closure is more accurately the sealing condition of the entire field of establishment. It does not add a strange self-supporting object inside the field; it asks whether, after all conditions of establishment are taken together, the whole field still borrows its qualification from another unaccounted condition.

Thus the relation between the Doctrine of Closure and grounding theory is not one of replacement, nor of violation, but of raising the scale of the question to the field-level. Fine and Rosen help this work restrict the term 'ground' so that it cannot be mystified at will; Schaffer's priority monism suggests that the local need not be the final ontological unit. Yet even if priority of the whole is accepted, it still has not answered how the whole obtains the qualification of ultimate ground. What the Doctrine of Closure proposes here is not a novel causal chain, but a criterion of qualification: if the ultimate ground is to be worthy of its name, it cannot merely stop at an arbitrary point, nor allow all relations of dependence to end in an external debt. It

²⁴¹Fine's and Rosen's discussions of ground and metaphysical dependence restrict the Doctrine of Closure from writing itself as same-level self-grounding. See Kit Fine, 'Guide to Ground,' in *Metaphysical Grounding: Understanding the Structure of Reality*, Cambridge UP, 2012; Gideon Rosen, 'Metaphysical Dependence: Grounding and Reduction.'

must at least possess self-consistency, non-outsourcing, preservation of difference, and local return.²⁴²

This rewriting gives the Doctrine of Closure the grammar of analytic philosophy. It has not been proven by grounding, but it has been trained by grounding. If this chapter accomplishes this, the Doctrine of Closure will no longer be merely a set of its own conceptual terms; it will be able to state, in an external grammar, what precisely it is not saying. This kind of 'negative precision' matters more than positive proclamation.

IV. Priority of the Whole: Schaffer as an Indirect Dialogue-Resource

Schaffer's priority monism is one of the most important indirect dialogue-resources of Chapter Fifteen. It cannot prove the ultimate ground for the Doctrine of Closure, but it can weaken the intuition of local self-sufficiency: that the world-whole may be ontologically prior to its parts is not an undiscussible oddity. For the Doctrine of Closure, this point helps to situate the concept of 'phenomenon': the local is real, but is not an ultimately self-subsistent entity.²⁴³

Nevertheless, priority monism and the Doctrine of Closure cannot be identified. Priority of the whole is not inward gathering of conditions; priority of the whole is not the possession of primordial presence by the whole; priority of the whole is not the whole's capacity for self-return. Schaffer provides an entry into priority of the whole; the Doctrine of Closure adds the requirement of ultimate qualification.

This difference must be stated clearly. If the Doctrine of Closure merely borrows Schaffer as an authoritative endorsement, it misuses the dialogue-resource. If it acknowledges that Schaffer only helps weaken local self-sufficiency, and cannot handle anti-PSR, First Consciousness, and non-outsourcing on its behalf, then the external dialogue truly begins.

The post-combat correction of this section is this: the Doctrine of Closure no longer treats the 'whole' as a sufficient answer. The whole must still pass an examination of qualification: does it still outsource itself? Can it contain local difference? Can it allow the local to return? Is it merely another name for the largest collection? None of these questions is answered automatically by priority monism.

²⁴²Kit Fine, 'Guide to Ground,' in *Metaphysical Grounding: Understanding the Structure of Reality*, edited by Fabrice Correia and Benjamin Schnieder, Cambridge UP, 2012, pp. 37-80; Gideon Rosen, 'Metaphysical Dependence: Grounding and Reduction,' in *Modality: Metaphysics, Logic, and Epistemology*, edited by Bob Hale and Aviv Hoffmann, Oxford UP, 2010, pp. 109-136; Jonathan Schaffer, 'On What Grounds What,' in *Metametaphysics*, edited by David Chalmers, David Manley, and Ryan Wasserman, Clarendon Press, 2009, pp. 347-383. These sources are used here as grammatical constraints upon grounding; they do not directly prove the Doctrine of Closure.

²⁴³Jonathan Schaffer, 'Monism: The Priority of the Whole,' *Philosophical Review* 119.1 (2010): 31-76. This essay provides the background of priority monism, but does not directly prove the Doctrine of Closure.

V. Spinoza, Static Monism, and the Difference of Closure

The Doctrine of Closure bears a family resemblance to Spinozist monism. Both refuse to understand God as a second object outside the universe, and both tend to situate finite things within a single whole. This resemblance may serve as an entry into dialogue, but it also brings danger: if the Doctrine of Closure finally leaves only an undifferentiated, non-subjective, necessary whole, then it regresses into static monism rather than accomplishing dynamic closure.²⁴⁴

The Doctrine of Closure must keep three distances from static monism. First, closure is not abstract identity, but inward gathering of conditions and return. Second, closure preserves local difference; otherwise victims, responsibility, and history would all be swallowed. Third, closure is unwilling to presuppose the ultimate ground as a dead structure wholly without presence, and therefore introduces First Consciousness as a high-risk candidate.

In this chapter, static monism is an intermediate opponent. It is not the chief opponent of Chapter Nineteen, but it trains the Doctrine of Closure to distinguish 'the whole' from 'closure.' To speak only of the whole does not solve the ultimate ground; to speak only of monism does not solve first-person presence; to speak only of necessity does not solve local suffering and ethical responsibility.

VI. Cosmopsychism and First Consciousness: Dialogue-Resource, Pressure, and Discontinuity

First Consciousness is the most creative and also the most vulnerable claim of the Doctrine of Closure. Local first-person experience does indeed place pressure upon a purely third-person dead-structure model; yet the move from 'dead structure is insufficient' to 'the whole possesses First Consciousness' is not a one-step deduction. There are at least three discontinuities in between: how first-person presence is irreducible; why the whole is more suitable than the local as the source of presence; and why primordial presence may be called consciousness.²⁴⁵

Cosmopsychism is a dialogue-resource because it too refuses to seal consciousness entirely within the product of the local brain; it is also a pressure because it brings the de-combination problem. If the cosmic mind is prior, how can local subjects have ignorance, separation, misrecognition, and private perspectives? The Doctrine of Closure cannot simply say 'self-limitation' and stop there; it must explain how self-limitation gives rise to genuine local positions.²⁴⁶

The response of the Doctrine of Closure is to understand the local as the finite position that the whole makes room for in order to complete dynamic return. The local is neither error nor illusion, but the field of difference required by the operation of closure. This response may explain local finitude better than ordinary cosmopsychism, but it still does not completely solve the internal mechanism by which consciousness differentiates.

For this reason, the present chapter adopts three tones concerning First Consciousness. Minimal version: the ultimate ground should not be presupposed as a dead structure utterly without presence. Intermediate version: primordial presence has greater integrative power than a purely blind model. Strong version: First Consciousness possesses will, purpose, self-understanding, and broad love. Chapter Fifteen can at most stabilize the first two layers; the third must continue to be borne by the theological chapter and the general objections.

²⁴⁴Baruch Spinoza, *Ethics*, part I. This is used only as background to monism; the Doctrine of Closure is not directly identical with Spinozist God-or-nature.

²⁴⁵On first-person presence and the hard problem, see Thomas Nagel, 'What Is It Like to Be a Bat?' *Philosophical Review* 83.4 (1974): 435-450; Joseph Levine, 'Materialism and Qualia,' *Pacific Philosophical Quarterly* 64.4 (1983): 354-361; David J. Chalmers, *The Conscious Mind*, Oxford UP, 1996.

²⁴⁶On cosmopsychism and the de-combination problem, see Philip Goff, *Consciousness and Fundamental Reality*, Oxford UP, 2017; Itay Shani, 'Cosmopsychism: A Holistic Approach to the Metaphysics of Experience,' *Philosophical Papers* 44.3 (2015): 389-437.

VII. Freedom, Responsibility, and the Lateral Pressure of Compatibilism

Chapter Fifteen does not rewrite Chapter Eight, but it must allow freedom and responsibility to become a lateral pressure open to attack. Readers of analytic philosophy will ask: if the Doctrine of Closure holds that the final event-path cannot scatter outward, are alternative possibilities cancelled? If the subject cannot do otherwise under the same conditions, does moral responsibility remain only a role-play within a destined script?

The Doctrine of Closure may borrow compatibilism as an indirect dialogue-resource. Frankfurt's pressure on alternative possibilities, and Fischer and Ravizza's discussion of reasons-responsiveness, both suggest that responsibility need not depend wholly upon an absolutely open future. This helps to situate signatory freedom: freedom is not the power to stand outside the whole and rewrite the ending, but the subject's becoming an agent through its own reasons, judgments, responsibility, and response.²⁴⁷

Yet compatibilism cannot wholly relieve the Doctrine of Closure. Signatory freedom still must face the criticism that it is merely psychological acceptance. Chapter Fifteen can only briefly return to the point: Chapter Eight has already defined freedom as the local subject's formation of reasons and assumption of consequences; the present chapter merely states that this line has room for external philosophical dialogue, while it must still endure long-standing questions concerning modal collapse and the attribution of responsibility.

VIII. Evil and the Philosophical Boundary of Misrecognised Position

Chapter Nine has already dealt with evil, victims, and the possibility of amendment; Chapter Fifteen need only return to its philosophical boundary. The Doctrine of Closure understands evil as misrecognition of position and failure of closure; this helps avoid substantializing evil as a second ontology. Yet if handled carelessly, it may also abstract evil and weaken concrete ethical responsibility. This is precisely the lateral pressure that philosophical examination must preserve.

Augustinian *privatio boni* may serve as an indirect resource for dialogue: evil is not a second ontology parallel to existence, but privation, deviation, and misalignment. Yet the victim-safeguard reminds this work that the non-substantialization of evil at the ontological layer cannot become an excuse for evil at the ethical layer. This stratification is decisive if the Doctrine of Closure is to avoid the cold-bloodedness into which holism may slide.²⁴⁸

The minimal conclusion of the philosophical chapter concerning evil is therefore this: the Doctrine of Closure may trace the root of evil to misrecognition of position, but it cannot turn misrecognition of position into a reason for exemption from responsibility. This is not the main line of the chapter, yet it is a necessary boundary if priority of the whole is not to slide into ethical silencing.

²⁴⁷ On compatibilism, alternative possibilities, and moral responsibility, see Harry Frankfurt, 'Alternate Possibilities and Moral Responsibility,' *Journal of Philosophy* 66.23 (1969): 829-839; John Martin Fischer and Mark Ravizza, *Responsibility and Control*, Cambridge UP, 1998.

²⁴⁸ On the double background of the privation theory of evil and the fact that pain must not be silenced by theory, see Augustine, *Confessions*, bk. 7; Augustine, *The City of God*, bks. 11-12; Elaine Scarry, *The Body in Pain*, Oxford UP, 1985.

IX. Post-Combat Correction after the Philosophical Examination

After Chapter Fifteen, the Doctrine of Closure is no longer an ontological proclamation without training in external grammar. It has learned to use the grammar of grounding to avoid self-grounding; to narrow the ultimate-ground claim under anti-PSR pressure; to use priority monism as a dialogue-resource without letting it prove the theory on its behalf; to use cosmopsychism to weaken the intuition that consciousness is merely a local brain-product, while admitting the de-combination problem; and to use compatibilism to support signatory freedom without concealing the problem of responsibility.

The post-combat upgrade of this chapter may be gathered in one sentence: the Doctrine of Closure is narrowed from the strong proclamation that 'the ultimate ground is self-establishing' into a 'model of ultimate-ground qualification'; First Consciousness is lowered from a quasi-theorem to a candidate of best explanation before the explanatory debt of the dead-structure model; and the local 'phenomenon' is changed from poetic language into an ontological position attackable under priority monism and the grammar of the grounding field.²⁴⁹

X. The Strongest Version of Anti-PSR and the Limited Refutation by the Doctrine of Closure

To give the general war with anti-PSR in Chapter Nineteen real weight, Chapter Fifteen must not treat brute fact as an option already defeated. The strongest version of anti-PSR may be stated thus: existence need not provide a final reason for itself; the world may simply be as it is; the need for ultimate explanation may be only the form of reason, not the obligation of existence itself. If this version stands, the starting point of the Doctrine of Closure is struck, for the Doctrine of Closure begins precisely from the requirement that the ultimate ground cannot outsource itself.²⁵⁰

The limited refutation by the Doctrine of Closure has two layers. The first is conceptual condition: if a theory wholly rejects the question of the ultimate ground, this work cannot force it to enter the field; but if it still uses positional language such as 'final,' 'ground,' 'ultimate,' or 'the establishment of the whole,' then that position cannot still take externally unaccounted conditions as its final form. The second layer is comparative explanatory power: brute fact may stop the questioning, yet it cannot explain why the stopping-point itself has the qualification to bear the ultimate ground.

This refutation is not a deductive victory, but an examination of qualification. The Doctrine of Closure is not saying that all existence must be made transparent; it is saying that a position calling itself ultimate, if it still lacks inward qualification, is not truly ground. At this point anti-PSR may still say, 'I reject this position.' The Doctrine of Closure replies: 'If you reject this position, you cannot at the same time enjoy the language of ultimate ground.' This mutual limitation has greater scholarly force than the direct proclamation that anti-PSR is wrong.

²⁴⁹This chapter's conclusion takes 'attackability' as a standard of maturity. For the background of inference to the best explanation, see Igor Douven, 'Abduction,' Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy.

²⁵⁰Here anti-PSR is presented as the true Boss before Chapter Nineteen, not as a low-level opponent. The background remains chiefly Hume, Melamed, and contemporary discussions of metaphysical explanation.

XI. Three Defensible Versions of the Sealing of the Grounding Field

The sealing of the grounding field must also be divided into versions. The minimal version is only a negative condition: the ultimate ground cannot still be supported by externally unaccounted conditions. This version is safest, but also thinnest; it only excludes outsourcing, and does not yet give a positive account of how closure is established. The intermediate version further requires the whole to recover the conditions of establishment within itself, while allowing local difference; this is the version in which the real work of this thesis occurs. The strong version adds First Consciousness, claiming that the recovery of the conditions of establishment is not merely structural sealing, but also the primordial presence of existence to itself.

The risks of these three versions differ. The minimal version may be criticized as no more than an anti-outsourcing principle; the intermediate version may be criticized for not yet explaining the mechanism of internal recovery; the strong version is most easily criticized for smuggling consciousness into the ultimate ground. Therefore Chapter Fifteen must separate them, and must not transfer the defensibility of the minimal version directly to the strong version.

What this chapter truly hands to Chapter Nineteen is not a complete victory, but a stratified map of defence. If Chapter Nineteen faces anti-PSR, it may first defend the minimal version; if it faces the irreflexivity of grounding, it may defend the intermediate version; only when it faces physicalism and cosmopsychism does it enter the strong version of First Consciousness. In this way, Chapter Nineteen will not begin by placing all its wager upon the highest-risk proposition.²⁵¹

XII. How Indirect Dialogue-Resources Narrow and Strengthen the Doctrine of Closure

The indirect dialogue-resources within analytical metaphysics do not bear witness for the Doctrine of Closure; they train it into stricter language. Grounding theory forces it to avoid self-grounding; priority monism forces it to distinguish priority of the whole from establishment by closure; cosmopsychism forces it to face de-combination; compatibilism forces it to rewrite freedom from an external power to alter the ending into reasons-responsiveness and assumption of responsibility. Every one of these dialogue-resources helps, and every one can bite back.

This structure, in which dialogue-resources can bite back, is precisely what Chapter Fifteen must preserve. Schaffer may weaken local self-sufficiency, but he does not prove First Consciousness for this thesis; Goff may help weaken physicalist dead structure, but he brings the problem of differentiation for cosmopsychism; Frankfurt may weaken the principle of alternative possibilities, but he does not prove signatory freedom sufficient. Only if the Doctrine of Closure understands the boundaries of these dialogue-resources does it truly enter scholarly dialogue.

Therefore, the upgrade at the end of Chapter Fifteen should be stated clearly: the Doctrine of Closure obtains the grammatical tools of analytic philosophy, yet is at the same time forced to lower its tone. It can explain itself with greater precision, but it cannot therefore declare that it has been proven by analytic philosophy. This is an upgrade, not a victory.

²⁵¹ This division of the Doctrine of Closure into minimal, intermediate, and strong versions is intended to prevent low-risk propositions from smuggling proof for high-risk extensions.

XIII. Theoretical Fixing after Examination by Analytical Metaphysics²⁵²

Chapter Fifteen does not find a group of analytical-philosophical allies for the Doctrine of Closure; it places the theory within a stricter grammar. After the pressures of anti-PSR, grounding, priority of the whole, cosmopsychism, and compatibilism, what the Doctrine of Closure may retain is no longer an undifferentiated strong proclamation, but a set of stratified defensive lines.

The first result is that the ultimate-ground claim is narrowed. The Doctrine of Closure no longer needs to claim that every thing, every contingent detail, and every local event must possess a transparent reason. The real force of anti-PSR is to remind this work that the world may have no obligation to satisfy human explanatory desire. After this pressure, the Doctrine of Closure preserves only the narrower principle of ground-qualification: if a certain position is still called the ultimate ground, it cannot still borrow the conditions of its own establishment in an unaccounted way. This is not the victory of a strong principle of sufficient reason, but the minimal examination of qualification within the concept of ultimate ground. Thus the Doctrine of Closure no longer treats brute fact as a low-level error; it merely points out that brute fact may stop questioning, but may not at the same time bear the thick meaning of ultimate ground.

The second result is that the closure-claim is placed within the grammar of grounding. After the grounding pressure represented by Fine, Rosen, and Schaffer, the Doctrine of Closure can no longer describe itself as same-level self-grounding. If closure is written as U grounds U, the theory directly violates the directionality, irreflexivity, and asymmetry usually belonging to grounding relations. This chapter therefore rewrites closure as the sealing condition of the entire field of establishment: it is not one object becoming its own ground, but the question whether, after all conditions of establishment are taken together, the whole field still borrows its qualification from another unaccounted condition. This correction releases the Doctrine of Closure from dependence upon the image of a mystical circle, and gives it a more exact grammar in analytic philosophy.

The third result is that holism is newly restricted. Schaffer's priority monism can weaken the intuition of local self-sufficiency, and Spinozist monism can provide a neighbouring background for the non-duality of God and nature; yet neither can directly prove the Doctrine of Closure. Priority of the whole is not inward gathering of conditions; monism is not dynamic return; a necessary whole is not primordial presence. The Doctrine of Closure thereby learns an important limit: it cannot merely say 'the whole,' but must explain how this whole does not outsource itself, how it preserves difference, and how it allows the local to return. Otherwise, 'closure' becomes only another name for 'the whole,' and has not truly obtained the qualification of ultimate ground.

The fourth result is that First Consciousness is returned to the place of inference to the best explanation. Cosmopsychism can weaken the intuition that consciousness can only come from the local brain-product, and the first-person presence marked by Nagel, Levine, and Chalmers does indeed place explanatory pressure upon the dead-structure model. Yet from 'dead structure is insufficient' to 'the ultimate ground possesses First Consciousness,' there is still no one-step deduction. Chapter Fifteen can stabilize at most two claims: first, that the ultimate ground should not be presupposed as a dead structure wholly without presence; second, that primordial presence has greater integrative power than a purely blind model. As for the claim that First Consciousness possesses will, purpose, self-understanding, and broad love, it remains the

²⁵²This section gathers the results of the analytical-metaphysical examination in Sections I to XII of Chapter Fifteen. Fine, Rosen, Schaffer, Hume, Melamed, Goff, Shani, Frankfurt, Fischer and Ravizza, and other materials all function in this chapter as pressures, grammatical constraints, or indirect dialogue-resources, not as direct proofs of the Doctrine of Closure. The maturity standard of Chapter Fifteen is not to prove that the Doctrine of Closure has prevailed, but to enable its minimal, intermediate, and strong versions to receive attack in stratified form.

extension of the strong version, and must continue to be borne by the theological chapter and Chapter Nineteen.

The fifth result is that local ethics is not swallowed by holism. Compatibilism gives external dialogue-space to 'signatory freedom': freedom need not mean rewriting the result from outside the whole, but may be understood as the local subject becoming an agent through reason-formation, judgment, responsibility, and repair. Yet this does not entirely remove the problem of responsibility. The same applies to evil and misrecognition of position: the Doctrine of Closure may understand evil as the local misplacing itself as the centre, thereby avoiding the substantialization of evil as a second ontology; but it cannot turn misrecognition of position into an excuse for exemption from responsibility. The ontological layer's refusal to substantialize evil cannot be transformed into ethical exoneration. This preserves the victim-safeguard of Chapter Nine, and keeps priority of the whole from sliding into cold-bloodedness.

It can therefore be seen that what this chapter truly accomplishes is not philosophical proof, but philosophical fixing. After Chapter Fifteen, the Doctrine of Closure receives at least three defensible versions. The minimal version is this: if the ultimate ground is still proposed, it cannot take unaccounted outsourcing as its final form. The intermediate version is this: closure may be understood as the sealing condition of the field of establishment, requiring self-consistency, non-outsourcing, preservation of difference, and local return. The strong version is this: the ultimate ground is not merely structural sealing, but possesses primordial presence and thereby moves toward First Consciousness. These three versions must not be confused; the defensibility of the minimal version cannot directly prove the strong version, and the risk of the strong version should not in reverse drag down the minimal version.

Therefore, what Chapter Fifteen hands over to Chapter Nineteen is not a victory, but a stratified defensive line. Before anti-PSR, the Doctrine of Closure can only first defend the qualification of the ultimate ground; before grounding irreflexivity, it can only defend field-sealing rather than self-grounding; before holism and monism, it must explain that it is not merely renaming the whole; before physicalism and cosmopsychism, it can only place First Consciousness in the position of a best-explanation candidate; before questions of freedom and evil, it must preserve local responsibility and the weight of victims. Only in this way is the Doctrine of Closure not an untrained ontological manifesto, but a metaphysical proposal that knows how it may be attacked and how it must narrow itself.

The final conclusion of this chapter may be simplified into one sentence: analytical metaphysics has not proven the Doctrine of Closure, but it has made the Doctrine of Closure more defensible. The Doctrine of Closure has learned not to inflate explanatory need into unrestricted PSR, not to miswrite closure as self-grounding, not to miswrite priority of the whole as the establishment of closure, not to miswrite cosmopsychism as proof of First Consciousness, and not to miswrite compatibilism as if the problem of responsibility had been solved. This narrowing is not retreat, but theoretical maturity. Only after passing through this chapter does the Doctrine of Closure qualify to enter Chapter Nineteen and face the general objections from anti-PSR, Many-Worlds, Barth, and Madhyamaka.

**Part IV Cross-Domain Examination and General
Objections**

Chapter Sixteen

**Scientific Cross-Domain Examination -
Auxiliary Clarification and Compatibility
Dialogue**

This chapter re-examines the auxiliary function of scientific materials, ensuring that quantum, systemic, and life-science materials serve only as boundary-testing and compatibility dialogue.

Chapter Sixteen Scientific Cross-Domain Examination - Auxiliary Clarification and Compatibility Dialogue

Chapter Sixteen is not a repetition of Chapters Six and Ten. Chapter Six set down the basic rules of the game for scientific materials within this thesis; Chapter Ten marked the hard boundary of Bell's theorem, quantum language, the problem of observation, and Many-Worlds; Chapter Sixteen now undertakes a general scientific examination, asking what role materials from physics, chemistry, biology, systems theory, and non-neural cognition may play within the whole Doctrine of Closure.

The emphasis of this chapter is not that 'science supports the Doctrine of Closure.' That sentence is too strong and too dangerous. The more accurate claim is that scientific materials can function as limitation, compatibility, motivation, and pressure. They are indirect resources for dialogue, not principal witnesses. They may help the Doctrine of Closure weaken crude fragmented world-pictures and the intuition of dead structure, but they cannot prove First Consciousness, God, predestination, redemption, or the principle of closure on its behalf.

Therefore this chapter will repeatedly ask three questions. First, what exactly does this scientific material limit? Second, does it offer only a compatible background, or can it provide a structural analogy? Third, does it force the Doctrine of Closure to retreat or rewrite itself? If the function of each material is not marked clearly, the scientific chapter will become a pile of terms.

I. The Four Levels of Function of Scientific Materials

The first level is the limiting function. This is the most important level. Bell's theorem cannot prove God; plant signalling cannot prove cosmic consciousness; non-equilibrium chemistry cannot prove the self-establishment of the ultimate ground. Scientific materials must first prevent the Doctrine of Closure from saying too much, rather than accelerate it. This is what it means to say that scientific materials first serve as a brake.²⁵³

The second level is the compatibility function. Certain frontier questions in science allow languages of wholeness, informational relation, non-equilibrium order, global consistency, self-organization, and boundary-formation not to be wholly detached from the background of modern knowledge. Yet compatibility only means that the theory does not conflict so radically that dialogue becomes impossible; it does not mean that the theory has been confirmed.

The third level is the motivational function. Living systems, plant signalling, slime-mold memory, autocatalytic networks, and autopoiesis can weaken the intuition of pure dead structure, and suggest that nature indeed contains boundary maintenance, feedback regulation, nonlinear integration, and memory-like behaviour. But motivation is not proof; it only makes the question more worthy of pursuit.

The fourth level is the pressure function. Many-Worlds, quantum interpretations, consciousness science, and physicalist models force the Doctrine of Closure to downgrade, narrow, or rewrite its earlier language. These materials are not local pressures that the thesis may simply absorb; they are long-term pressures that force the theory to become more precise.

²⁵³ The four functions in this chapter are limitation, compatibility, motivation, and pressure. This criterion prevents compatibility from being written as proof, cross-scale analogy as identity, and scientific interpretation as metaphysical conclusion.

II. Quantum Materials: Limiting the Fragmented Intuition and Forbidding Mystical Smuggling

The strict meaning of Bell's theorem and the related experiments lies in placing limits upon certain local hidden-variable pictures. It can weaken a naive picture of the world as local fragments: the world is not simply a heap of small things, each wholly independent and each carrying all its properties on its own. But to move from this to 'all things are ontologically one,' 'there is a cosmic First Consciousness,' or 'closed-loop predestination has been proven by physics' is already to overstep the boundary.²⁵⁴

The same is true of quantum entanglement. It may place pressure upon the intuition that relations are merely external additions; yet it cannot be directly rewritten as metaphysical monism. Between physical nonlocality and metaphysical wholeness there is a conceptual break. Without philosophical conversion, the Doctrine of Closure would fall into quantum mysticism.

Observation and the measurement problem require particular defence. Measurement in quantum theory does not mean that human consciousness creates the world with a mystical gaze. If the main text secretly replaces 'observer' with 'a conscious person' or with 'First Consciousness,' the scientific chapter immediately fails. At most, the Doctrine of Closure may say that the quantum measurement problem exposes a deep difficulty within physical interpretation; it cannot say that the problem proves consciousness to be the ground of reality.²⁵⁵

III. Cosmology, Emergent Spacetime, and Global Consistency

Materials concerning cosmology, dark energy, the cosmological constant, fine-tuning, and emergent spacetime can provide compatibility and background for questioning. They show that questions concerning fundamental parameters, whether spacetime is fundamental, global consistency, and the preservation of information remain profound. Such questions have room for dialogue with the Doctrine of Closure's language of 'conditions of establishment,' but they cannot yield a designer, First Consciousness, or the principle of closure.

For example, emergent spacetime and holographic approaches may pressure the intuition that spacetime is the final background; the black-hole information problem and the direction marked by the Page curve may make global informational consistency a deep issue. Yet from there to 'the whole is closed' there remains a philosophical leap. If the Doctrine of Closure uses these materials, it should say that the scientific frontier keeps bottom-level questions open; it should not say that science has already handed its answer to the Doctrine of Closure.²⁵⁶

Cosmological materials are often abused in arguments from design. Chapter Sixteen must avoid repeating that mistake. Fine-tuning may show that certain ranges of parameters are highly sensitive for stable structures and the conditions of life; research into dark energy may show that the physical nature of cosmic accelerated expansion remains unresolved. Yet none of this is evidence for the Doctrine of Closure. At most, these materials make it reasonable to ask why existence has a stable structure capable of return.

²⁵⁴ John S. Bell, 'On the Einstein Podolsky Rosen Paradox,' *Physics Physique Fizika* 1.3 (1964): 195-200; Wayne Myrvold, 'Bell's Theorem,' *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*; Nobel Prize Outreach, 'The Nobel Prize in Physics 2022.' These sources support only the limitation placed upon local hidden-variable pictures; they do not support theological claims or claims concerning First Consciousness.

²⁵⁵ On quantum measurement and philosophical problems in quantum theory, see Wayne Myrvold, 'Philosophical Issues in Quantum Theory,' *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. This thesis does not rewrite the measurement problem as consciousness creating reality.

²⁵⁶ On the dialogical background of emergent spacetime and quantum information, see Tadashi Takayanagi, 'Emergent Holographic Spacetime from Quantum Information,' arXiv:2506.06595. On black-hole information and the Page curve, see the relevant literature in quantum gravity and black-hole information. Such materials function only as background for frontier questions.

IV. Many-Worlds: Pressure Function and the Rewriting of Uniqueness

Many-Worlds places the most direct pressure upon the Doctrine of Closure. This is not because it has achieved final scientific settlement and can execute the Doctrine of Closure, but because it proposes a world-picture different from single linear predestination. If branching realism is true, then the earlier language of the 'unique event-path' can no longer be written crudely as one globally unique line of story.²⁵⁷

The Doctrine of Closure may retreat, and must retreat. What may retreat is story-level uniqueness: it need not insist that all reality has only one narratable linear path. What may not retreat is qualification-level uniqueness: whatever would count as a successful closure must still satisfy the qualifications of self-consistency, inward gathering, return, and non-outsourcing. This is the most important scientific-pressure correction in Chapter Sixteen.

This chapter therefore distinguishes three kinds of uniqueness. First, the uniqueness of the principle of closure: any ultimate establisher must deal with the conditions of its own establishment. Second, the uniqueness of the completed path within each successful closure: within a given closure, event-relations cannot scatter outward at will. Third, the uniqueness of the number of successful closures: whether there is only one successful closure. Many-Worlds attacks the third, pressures the expression of the second, but does not necessarily break the first.

Once handled in this way, Many-Worlds is not destroyed by this thesis; rather, it forces this thesis to upgrade itself from 'a single story-line' into 'unique qualification, possibly multiple realization.' This correction preserves the principle of closure while relinquishing an excessively single-line image of the cosmos.

V. Non-equilibrium Chemistry, Autocatalysis, and the Origin of Life

Non-equilibrium chemistry, autocatalytic networks, dissipative structures, and synthetic-cell research are important indirect resources for dialogue in Chapter Sixteen. They place pressure upon the intuition that a real structure must be static, sealed, and dead. Life-related structures often depend upon energy flow, boundary-generation, self-maintenance, and continual renewal; these have a recognizable structural resemblance to the Doctrine of Closure's language of inward gathering, differentiation, and return.²⁵⁸

But the break must be preserved here. Self-organization is not self-establishment. A local chemical system's ability to maintain itself does not mean that the ultimate ground can establish itself. The appearance of boundary and metabolism-like cycles in origin-of-life research does not mean that the cosmic whole possesses First Consciousness. If these breaks are not preserved, the scientific chapter turns from auxiliary clarification into pseudo-proof.

Therefore the function of chemical materials is structural analogy and motivation. They allow the Doctrine of Closure to say that in nature there are indeed structural motifs that are not static, not mere aggregates, and that rely on flow and boundary maintenance. But they do not allow it to say that these motifs have already proven the ultimate ontology.

²⁵⁷ Hugh Everett III, 'Relative State Formulation of Quantum Mechanics,' *Reviews of Modern Physics* 29.3 (1957): 454-462; Lev Vaidman, 'Many-Worlds Interpretation of Quantum Mechanics,' *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. This thesis treats Many-Worlds as a pressure upon the uniqueness claim, not as evidence for the Doctrine of Closure.

²⁵⁸ On non-equilibrium chemistry and autocatalytic networks, see Tena-Solsona et al., 'Self-Selection of Dissipative Assemblies Driven by Primitive Chemical Reaction Networks,' *Nature Communications* 9 (2018), article 2044; Ameta et al., 'Darwinian Properties and Their Trade-Offs in Autocatalytic RNA Reaction Networks,' *Nature Communications* 12 (2021), article 842; Ouazan-Reboul, Agudo-Canalejo, and Golestanian, 'Self-Organization of Primitive Metabolic Cycles Due to Non-Reciprocal Interactions,' *Nature Communications* 14 (2023), article 4496.

VI. Systems Biology and Autopoiesis: Self-Maintenance Is Not Ultimate Self-Establishment

Maturana and Varela's autopoiesis, together with systems-biology studies of homeostasis, feedback, and multi-level regulation, can offer an important analogy for the Doctrine of Closure. A living organism is not the sum of its parts; it maintains its organization as a whole through boundary, metabolism, regulation, and feedback. This helps the reader understand that closure is not dead stillness: closure can contain internal operation.²⁵⁹

Yet autopoiesis is not a miniature proof of the Doctrine of Closure. Living systems still depend on energy, matter, environment, evolutionary history, and external conditions. They are local self-maintenance, not ultimate self-establishment. If the Doctrine of Closure directly upgrades living systems into a model of the ultimate ground, it confuses levels.

Social systems theory can likewise serve only as analogy. Luhmann's self-reproducing system may help us understand how a closed system maintains its boundary through internal operations; but the operational closure of a social system cannot be directly equated with ultimate ontological closure. It may train the language; it is not a principal proof.²⁶⁰

VII. Plants, Slime Molds, and Non-neural Cognition

Research on plants and slime molds is the material most easily misused in Chapter Sixteen. Its value does not lie in proving that plants or slime molds possess a subjective consciousness of the same type as human beings, but in weakening a crude intuition: without a higher nervous system, complex signal integration, memory-like behaviour, learning-like behaviour, or environmental decision-making would be impossible.

Plants can perceive light, water, temperature, mechanical stimulation, pathogens, and signals from herbivores, and respond conditionally through physiological and developmental pathways. Slime molds can use externalized traces to form spatial memory, and they also display learning-like behaviours such as habituation. These phenomena deserve philosophical attention because they pressure the intuition of purely passive life.²⁶¹

Yet the break is equally clear. From adaptive behaviour to information processing there is already much research to discuss; from information processing to subjective first-person presence remains highly contested; from local subjective presence to cosmic First Consciousness is still not an inference that biology can complete by itself. Thus plant and slime-mold materials can at most support the minimal sense of the problem: the intuition of dead structure should not be allowed to win too quickly.

²⁵⁹Humberto Maturana and Francisco Varela, *Autopoiesis and Cognition*, D. Reidel, 1980. See also research on systems biology and homeostasis. This thesis takes only the analogies of self-maintenance and systemic wholeness.

²⁶⁰Niklas Luhmann, *Social Systems*, Stanford UP, 1995. This thesis takes only its language of self-reference and system-boundary as comparison; it does not equate social systems theory with the ontology of closure.

²⁶¹On plant signalling and non-neural cognition, see Paco Calvo, 'Plants Are Intelligent, Here's How,' *Annals of Botany* 125.1 (2020): 11-28; Richard Karban, *Plant Sensing and Communication*, University of Chicago Press, 2015; Reid et al., 'Slime Mold Uses an Externalized Spatial Memory,' *PNAS* 109.43 (2012): 17490-17494.

VIII. Two Kinds of Opponents to the Scientific Chapter

This chapter must face two kinds of opponents. The first is the scientist-type objection: the Doctrine of Closure provides no operational experimental predictions, cannot replace physical, chemical, or biological models, and therefore should not claim scientific status. This criticism is correct. This thesis is not experimental science, and it should not pretend to enter the same mode of verification.

The response available to the Doctrine of Closure is that it is not handling the same layer of question. Science deals with how local systems operate; the Doctrine of Closure deals with what qualifications the ultimate ground would need if it is to be established. The two may converse because scientific materials can limit philosophical language, not because philosophical language can replace experiment. To admit that this thesis is not a scientific theory actually makes this chapter more stable.

The maturity standard of Chapter Sixteen does not lie in how many scientific materials it lists, but in whether each kind of material preserves its own level. Quantum materials can at most force this thesis to abandon a simple local realism; they cannot prove First Consciousness. Systems and self-organization materials can at most provide analogies of self-maintenance, boundary-formation, and internal recovery; they cannot directly become a theory of the ultimate ground. Plant signalling, slime-mold learning, and life-cognition materials can at most show that cognition-like behaviour is not necessarily identical with human-style neural consciousness; they cannot yield a cosmic subjective presence. If these materials are raised into principal proofs, Chapter Sixteen degenerates from boundary-examination into scientific ornament.

Therefore the most valuable role of scientific materials for the Doctrine of Closure is not 'support,' but 'constraint.' Bell's theorem constrains an over-localized world-picture; Many-Worlds constrains single-line predestination language; self-organization theory constrains closure from being written merely as a static circle; life and cognition materials constrain this work from violently pressing the problem of consciousness back into higher nervous systems alone. These constraints narrow the Doctrine of Closure, but also make it more stable. The scientific chapter should not prove ontology; it should keep ontology from overstepping its border.²⁶²

The second kind is the internal philosophical objection: are the scientific materials merely rhetorical ornaments? Quantum theory, dark energy, slime molds, plants, and non-equilibrium chemistry placed together may appear abundant, but do they in fact fail to carry the core argument? This criticism cannot be dismissed lightly, for the most common failure of cross-domain theory is precisely to write distant resemblance as theoretical integration.

The answer of this chapter is not to add more examples, but to lower the argumentative ambition of the examples. So long as each material is placed in a position of limitation, compatibility, motivation, or pressure, it is no longer merely rhetorical ornament, but a discipline of method. The scientific chapter need not prove the Doctrine of Closure. If it forces the Doctrine of Closure to know what it must not say, it has already performed an important function.²⁶³

²⁶²John S. Bell, 'On the Einstein Podolsky Rosen Paradox,' *Physics Physique Fizika*, vol. 1, no. 3, 1964, pp. 195-200; Hugh Everett III, 'Relative State Formulation of Quantum Mechanics,' *Reviews of Modern Physics*, vol. 29, no. 3, 1957, pp. 454-462; Humberto R. Maturana and Francisco J. Varela, *Autopoiesis and Cognition: The Realization of the Living*, D. Reidel, 1980; Chris R. Reid et al., 'Slime Mold Uses an Externalized Spatial Memory to Navigate in Complex Environments,' *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, vol. 109, no. 43, 2012, pp. 17490-17494; Paco Calvo, *Planta Sapiens: The New Science of Plant Intelligence*, Little, Brown, 2022. The above materials serve only as boundaries, analogies, and background for questions; they do not constitute ontological proof of the Doctrine of Closure.

²⁶³The maturity standard of the scientific chapter lies not in the quantity of materials cited, but in whether the functional level of each material is clear. This is a methodological self-limitation of the chapter, not an independent bibliographical claim.

IX. Post-Examination Corrections after the Scientific Test

After Chapter Sixteen, what the Doctrine of Closure obtains is resistance at the scientific boundary. It no longer treats scientific materials as witnesses, but as brakes, pressures, motivations, and compatible backgrounds. Bell limits the fragmented picture; Many-Worlds pressures uniqueness; self-organization and autopoiesis provide analogies; research on plants and slime molds counters a human-centred intuition of cognition. Yet not one of these directly proves First Consciousness.

The post-combat correction of this chapter is this: the Doctrine of Closure may converse with problems in modern science, but it does not claim that science has established it. It may say that scientific materials weaken purely fragmented, purely dead-structural, and purely single-line pictures; it may not say that science yields God, redemption, or predestination. It may borrow scientific materials to make itself more sober; it cannot borrow them to evade metaphysical argument.²⁶⁴

X. The Role-Positioning of Each Kind of Scientific Material

To prevent Chapter Sixteen from becoming an accumulation of cross-domain materials, it must also state, kind by kind, the highest usable strength of each material within this thesis. Quantum materials can at most limit the local fragmented intuition; cosmological materials can at most provide an open background for questions concerning bottom-level parameters and global consistency; non-equilibrium chemistry can at most provide analogies of self-organization and boundary-formation; systems biology can at most provide models of holistic regulation; plants and slime molds can at most provide non-human-centred materials of cognition-like behaviour. If any kind crosses its own highest strength, it must immediately be downgraded.

This positioning protects the thesis from two criticisms. The first says that the Doctrine of Closure is pseudo-science. This chapter answers with a graded system: the thesis does not use scientific materials as principal proof. The second says that scientific materials are merely decorative. This chapter answers with a functional system: even if the materials do not serve as principal proof, they can provide boundaries, pressures, analogies, and corrections.

Therefore a scientific chapter is not better simply because it contains more materials. Every material must know what it is doing within the argument. If Bell appears, it should limit local realism; if Many-Worlds appears, it should correct uniqueness; if autopoiesis appears, it should provide a local analogy for self-maintenance; if slime mold appears, it should weaken higher-neural centrism. Materials without function should be deleted; materials carrying too much should be downgraded.

²⁶⁴The minimal conclusion of Chapter Sixteen is that science provides limitation and correction, but cannot replace philosophical justification. Quantum, cosmological, origin-of-life, and non-neural-cognition materials should all observe this principle of downgrading.

XI. Three Cross-Scale Breaks⁺

The easiest error in the scientific chapter is to write cross-scale analogy as cross-scale identity. The first break lies between physical nonlocality and metaphysical wholeness. Bell-type results may pressure the intuition of local fragments, but they do not mean that the world-whole is an ontological closure. The second break lies between systemic self-organization and ultimate self-establishment. Autocatalytic networks or living systems may maintain themselves locally, but this does not mean that the ultimate ground can establish itself. The third break lies between information processing and subjective presence. Plant or slime-mold signal processing, memory-like behaviour, and learning-like behaviour are not equivalent to first-person experience.²⁶⁵

Once these three breaks are written clearly, the scientific chapter can use its materials safely. The Doctrine of Closure may say that modern science places pressure upon purely fragmented, purely dead-structural, and purely single-line pictures. It may not say that science has sufficiently established First Consciousness, God, or predestination. This limitation does not weaken the scientific chapter; it prevents the chapter from destroying the methodology of the whole work.

The tone of Chapter Sixteen must therefore be more restrained than ordinary interdisciplinary writing. It may allow scientific materials to serve as local pressures and dialogue-resources, prompting the Doctrine of Closure to narrow and strengthen itself; but it does not allow scientific materials to serve as principal proof for the Doctrine of Closure. If scientific materials completed the final proof for ontology, the philosophical defence of Chapter Fifteen, the theological self-limitation of Chapter Seventeen, and the Madhyamaka pressure of Chapter Eighteen would all have been illicitly replaced.

XII. Predestination and Freedom after Many-Worlds

Many-Worlds forces the Doctrine of Closure to handle the predestination and freedom of Chapter Eight anew. If successful closure can be multiple, predestination is no longer 'there is only one total story-line for the whole universe.' Rather, within each successful closure, event-relations cannot scatter outward arbitrarily. The decisions and uncertainty experienced by local subjects still possess ethical weight within the branch or closure in which they stand.

In this way, signatory freedom is not cancelled by Many-Worlds. On the contrary, it becomes more exact: freedom is not sovereignty over the rewriting of all possible branches, but the formation of reasons, bearing of consequences, and response to others within one's concrete path. Many-Worlds may make the global picture more complex, but it does not automatically dissolve local ethical responsibility.

Chapter Sixteen therefore prepares an important defensive line for Chapter Nineteen: scientific multiplicity does not necessarily destroy the Doctrine of Closure. It compels the Doctrine of Closure to move uniqueness from the story-layer up to the qualification-layer. This is not a minor repair, but a theoretical rewriting. When Chapter Nineteen faces scientific pressure, this point will become a principal defence.²⁶⁶

²⁶⁵The three cross-scale breaks are the central methodological limits of Chapter Sixteen: nonlocality is not equivalent to metaphysical wholeness; self-organization is not equivalent to ultimate self-establishment; information processing is not equivalent to subjective presence.

²⁶⁶Many-Worlds functions in this thesis not as evidence for the Doctrine of Closure, but as a corrective pressure upon the language of uniqueness. This correction preserves qualification-level uniqueness while relinquishing crude single-story uniqueness.

XIII. Theoretical Fixing after the Scientific Examination: Returning from Scientific Materials to the Doctrine of Closure Itself

The conclusion of Chapter Sixteen should begin with a negative sentence: science has not completed the proof of the Doctrine of Closure. This does not make the chapter useless; it is precisely the chapter's function. The most important use of quantum theory, cosmology, non-equilibrium chemistry, living systems, and non-neural cognition in this thesis is not to increase authority, but to determine how far the Doctrine of Closure may speak, and where it must stop.

The first result is the formal limitation of the function of scientific materials. Quantum materials, cosmological materials, non-equilibrium chemistry, autopoiesis, plant signalling, and slime-mold learning cannot be mixed in this thesis into a vague 'scientific support.' At most, they respectively bear the four functions of limitation, compatibility, motivation, and pressure. The limiting function tells the thesis what it must not say; the compatibility function tells it that it does not immediately conflict with the modern picture of knowledge; the motivational function tells it that certain questions are worth asking; the pressure function forces it to correct expressions that are too strong. Once these four functions are confused, the scientific chapter degenerates into a pile of cross-domain terms.

The second result is that quantum materials are returned to boundary-examination. Bell's theorem and quantum entanglement can weaken a naive local fragmented world-picture, but they cannot prove God, First Consciousness, or closed-loop predestination. The measurement problem may show that physical interpretation still contains deep disputes, but it cannot be secretly exchanged for the claim that human consciousness or cosmic consciousness creates the world. This protects the Doctrine of Closure from quantum mysticism. Scientific material here is not the accelerator, but the brake; its first task is to prevent this thesis from speaking too quickly about wholeness, observation, nonlocality, and related language.

The third result is that cosmological materials are placed as background for questioning, not as a shortcut to design. Problems concerning the cosmological constant, dark energy, fine-tuning, emergent spacetime, black-hole information, and global consistency do indeed keep open the question of whether the bottom layer of the cosmos has already been completely sealed. They can also make the question 'how do the conditions of the whole become established?' intelligible. But these materials cannot yield a designer; they cannot yield First Consciousness; still less can they prove the Doctrine of Closure itself. Their highest function is to show that bottom-level questions remain open, not to claim that science has already handed the answer to the Doctrine of Closure.

The fourth result is that Many-Worlds forces the Doctrine of Closure to rewrite uniqueness. If a many-branch picture is true or has strong explanatory power, the Doctrine of Closure can no longer write predestination as a single global story-line. It must distinguish three kinds of uniqueness: the uniqueness of the principle of closure, the uniqueness of the completed path within each successful closure, and the uniqueness of the number of successful closures. Many-Worlds attacks the third, pressures the expression of the second, but does not necessarily destroy the first. After this pressure, the Doctrine of Closure no longer claims that only one cosmic story is possible; it narrows itself to this: whatever is to count as a successful closure must satisfy the qualifications of self-consistency, inward gathering, return, and non-outsourcing. This is the most important theoretical correction of Chapter Sixteen.

The fifth result is that non-equilibrium chemistry, autocatalytic networks, and origin-of-life materials are limited to structural analogy. These materials can show that nature indeed contains structural motifs of energy flow, boundary-generation, self-maintenance, local cycles, and systemic renewal, thereby weakening the intuition that real structure must be static, dead, and merely sealed. But self-organization is not self-establishment. A local chemical system's capacity to maintain itself is not the ultimate ground's capacity to establish itself. Cyclic structures in the

origin of life also cannot directly yield a cosmic whole possessing First Consciousness. This limitation keeps scientific analogies effective without miswriting them as ontological proofs.

The sixth result is that autopoiesis, systems biology, plants, and slime molds are placed at the level of anti-simplification. The boundary-maintenance, feedback regulation, holistic coordination, signal integration in plants, and memory-like behaviour in slime molds can weaken higher-neural centrism and the view of life as merely passive. They give this thesis more reason to question the crude intuition that nature is only a heap of dead parts. Yet information processing is not subjective presence; learning-like behaviour is not first-person experience; non-neural cognition is not cosmic First Consciousness. These materials support at most the minimal sense of the problem: the intuition of dead structure should not win too quickly. The strong version of First Consciousness must still return to metaphysics and philosophy of religion; biological materials cannot complete it on its behalf.

The seventh result is that the three cross-scale breaks become the central defensive line of Chapter Sixteen. The first break is from physical nonlocality to metaphysical wholeness; the second is from systemic self-organization to ultimate self-establishment; the third is from information processing to subjective presence. Once these three breaks are written clearly, the scientific chapter can use its materials safely. The Doctrine of Closure may say that modern science places pressure upon purely fragmented, purely dead-structural, and purely single-line predestination pictures. It may not say that science has established First Consciousness, God, predestination, or redemption. This limitation does not weaken the chapter; it gives the chapter real scholarly credibility.

The eighth result is that the Doctrine of Closure explicitly recognizes that it is not a scientific theory. It does not offer operational experimental predictions, nor can it replace physics, chemistry, biology, or cognitive science. The Doctrine of Closure deals with another layer of question: if the ultimate ground can still be discussed, what qualifications must it satisfy for establishment? Scientific materials enter this chapter not because science completes proof for metaphysics, but because science can limit metaphysical language, forcing the Doctrine of Closure not to smuggle, not to inflate, and not to write analogy as identity. Acknowledging that it is not a scientific theory actually allows the Doctrine of Closure to converse with science more honestly.

It can therefore be seen that what Chapter Sixteen truly accomplishes is not the addition of scientific authority to the Doctrine of Closure, but the construction of resistance at the scientific boundary. After this chapter, the Doctrine of Closure can no longer treat Bell's theorem, Many-Worlds, dark energy, emergent spacetime, autocatalytic networks, plant signalling, or slime-mold learning as evidence for itself. Yet it can treat these materials as brakes, pressures, compatible backgrounds, and structural analogies. Scientific materials make the Doctrine of Closure narrower, and therefore more stable. A metaphysical theory willing to state plainly what science cannot prove for it is more worthy of trust than a theory that borrows scientific prestige at every point.

What this chapter finally hands over to Chapter Nineteen is a version of the Doctrine of Closure corrected under scientific pressure. Before Bell's theorem, the Doctrine of Closure retains only the anti-fragment intuition, and does not claim that quantum theory proves an ontology of the whole. Before Many-Worlds, the Doctrine of Closure moves uniqueness from the story-layer up to the qualification-layer. Before self-organization and life materials, it preserves the analogy of dynamic closure, but does not write local self-maintenance as ultimate self-establishment. Before plants and slime molds, it says only that non-neural cognition weakens the intuition of dead structure; it does not say that they prove First Consciousness. Thus, when Chapter Nineteen faces scientific and Many-Worlds pressure, it will not fight with the over-hardened language of an earlier stage, but will enter the general objections with a narrowed version.

The final conclusion of Chapter Sixteen may therefore be simplified into one sentence: science has not proven the Doctrine of Closure, but science has forced the Doctrine of Closure to become more accurate. It has forced the Doctrine of Closure to relinquish quantum mysticism, simple smuggling of design, single-line predestination language, the direct equation of self-organization with self-establishment, and the direct equation of information processing with subjective presence. These relinquishments are not retreat, but theoretical maturity. Only after passing through this chapter is the Doctrine of Closure no longer a closed metaphysical manifesto, but an ontological model willing to receive examination at scientific boundaries and able to preserve its core under limitation.²⁶⁷

²⁶⁷This section gathers the results of the scientific cross-domain examination in Sections I to XII of Chapter Sixteen. Bell's theorem, Many-Worlds, cosmology, non-equilibrium chemistry, autocatalytic networks, autopoiesis, plant signalling, slime-mold learning, and related materials all function in this chapter only as limitation, compatibility, motivation, analogy, or pressure; they are not direct proofs of the Doctrine of Closure, First Consciousness, God, predestination, or redemption. The maturity standard of Chapter Sixteen is not to prove the Doctrine of Closure through science, but to let scientific materials constrain its cross-domain language and force it to narrow, stratify, and correct itself.

**Part IV Cross-Domain Examination and General
Objections**

Chapter Seventeen

**Theological Cross-Domain Examination -
Stratified Revelation and the Highest
Manifestation**

This chapter allows theological criticism formally to enter the main text, especially by treating the limits of revelatory freedom, theological naming, and the Highest Manifestation.

Chapter Seventeen Theological Cross-Domain Examination - Stratified Revelation and the Highest Manifestation

Chapter Seventeen is the most dangerous of the four external examinations. The Doctrine of Closure uses such language as God, First Consciousness, Trinity, creation, original sin, prayer, redemption, miracle, and the Highest Manifestation of Jesus; it therefore cannot pretend to have no relation to Christian theology. Yet neither can it claim to have completed orthodox theology. Its place is a high-risk zone between an entrance into philosophical theology and the pressure of revelatory theology.

This chapter must distinguish resources for dialogue from the central opponent. Tillich is an indirect resource for dialogue, since his language of the ground of being helps the Doctrine of Closure avoid reducing God to an engineer outside the universe. Aquinas and Augustine may serve as interlocutors concerning creative dependence, time, evil, and the order of love. Trinitarian theology reminds the Doctrine of Closure that internal difference must not be written as mere functional division. The traditions of incarnation and cross provide an entrance for speaking of the Highest Manifestation of Jesus. The true central opponent is Barth: he will ask whether the Doctrine of Closure has enclosed God within a human metaphysical system.²⁶⁸

I. God Is Not an Engineer Outside the Universe: Tillich as a Resource for Dialogue

The point at which the Doctrine of Closure most readily connects with theology is its refusal to understand God as a gigantic being outside the universe. If God were only an engineer outside the universe, he could still be asked for the conditions of his own establishment, and therefore could not serve as ultimate ground. The Doctrine of Closure understands God as ultimate ground, primordial presence, and the condition by which existence does not remain suspended; this strongly resonates with Tillich's language of God as Being-itself or the Ground of Being.²⁶⁹

Tillich's function as a resource for dialogue lies in helping the Doctrine of Closure move God away from the status of a 'highest being' and toward the ground of being. This makes the present theory deeper than popular design arguments, for it does not add another powerful object inside or outside the universe; it asks how existence itself avoids suspension.

Yet Tillich cannot complete Christian theology on behalf of the Doctrine of Closure. The language of the ground of being may become overly abstract. Without personhood, revelation, covenant, judgment, mercy, and historical action, God may be left as a philosophized cosmic principle. This chapter must preserve that distance.

²⁶⁸ On the tension between philosophical theology and revelatory theology, see Paul Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, vol. 1; Karl Barth, *Church Dogmatics I/1*; William Wood, 'Philosophy and Christian Theology,' *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*.

²⁶⁹ Paul Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, vol. 1. Tillich's language of the ground of being functions in this chapter as an indirect ally, helping the Doctrine of Closure avoid popular design theory.

II. Aquinas, Augustine, and Creative Dependence

Aquinas and Augustine may also serve as indirect resources for dialogue. Aquinas's language of subsistent being and creative dependence allows the Doctrine of Closure to converse with classical theology concerning how existence is sustained by God. Augustine's treatment of time and creation reminds this thesis that creation need not be understood as something God did within a pre-existing time, but may be understood as the dependence of time and world together upon God.²⁷⁰

These resources for dialogue prevent the Doctrine of Closure from being misread as a simple theory of the universe's temporal beginning. The question of the Doctrine of Closure is not 'what was there before the Big Bang,' but how existence as a whole has the qualification to be established. If creation is understood as ontological dependence rather than as the opening event in physical time, the Doctrine of Closure and classical theology have a point of possible dialogue.

Yet the tension also lies here. If the Doctrine of Closure understands the world as God's own closed-loop unfolding, the difference between world and God will be narrowed. Christianity may say that the world depends upon God and exists by God's sustaining power; it cannot simply say that world and God lose their distinction. This difference is an important theological limit upon the Doctrine of Closure.

III. Trinity: Functional Mapping and Orthodox Boundary

The Doctrine of Closure's use of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit as a functional mapping of source, manifestation, and maintenance/return has conceptual appeal. It recognizes that if the whole is to operate, manifest, and return, it cannot be a dead undifferentiated block; it must contain internal difference. This can prevent the Doctrine of Closure from collapsing into undifferentiated monism.

Nevertheless, orthodox Trinitarian doctrine is not three functional posts. Trinitarian doctrine concerns one essence, three persons, relation, communion, and the inner life of God. The discussions of Rahner, Moltmann, Gunton, Zizioulas, and others all remind us that the Trinity is not a diagram of cosmic mechanism, but the relational life of God himself.²⁷¹

Therefore the Doctrine of Closure's Trinitarian writing can at present be called only a functional analogy, not a doctrinal derivation that has entered the Nicene-Constantinopolitan creedal tradition. This is not a minor matter. If this thesis compresses the Trinity into an algorithmic division of functions, it will lose the weight of personal relation and communion.

²⁷⁰ Augustine, *Confessions*, bk. 11; Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, I, q. 3, a. 4; I, q. 45. These materials serve here as theological background concerning creation, time, and ontological dependence.

²⁷¹ Karl Rahner, *The Trinity*; Jurgen Moltmann, *The Trinity and the Kingdom*; Colin Gunton, *The Promise of Trinitarian Theology*; John Zizioulas, *Being as Communion*. These references mark the distance between orthodox Trinitarian doctrine and functional mapping.

IV. Barthian Pressure: Whether God Has Been Absorbed into Metaphysics

Barth is the true central opponent of this chapter. The question is not whether the Doctrine of Closure uses pious words, but whether it has already grasped God in advance through a human metaphysical system. If 'God is First Consciousness' is written as a conclusion necessarily derived from the problem of ultimate ground, Barth will immediately point out that what is spoken of here may not be the God of free revelation, but a theologized cosmic principle.²⁷²

The answer of the Doctrine of Closure cannot be to exclude Barth. It must admit that it is first a model of philosophical theology, not a conclusion of revelatory theology. It may say: within this model, if ultimate ground possesses primordial presence, it can be philosophically named God. But it cannot say: the God who freely reveals himself in Jesus Christ within Christian faith has already been derived by this model.

A double grammar must therefore be established here. The grammar of the ground of being treats God as ultimate ground; the grammar of revelatory freedom treats how God calls, judges, redeems, and manifests himself in history. The two may meet, but they cannot devour one another. If only the ground of being remains, God becomes abstract. If only the revelatory event remains, the ontological problem of the Doctrine of Closure cannot unfold. A mature theological chapter must let the two remain in tension.

The 'Highest Manifestation of Jesus' is the strongest theological extension in this thesis, and also the place most in need of self-limitation. In the language of the Doctrine of Closure, Jesus has the meaning of Highest Manifestation because he concentrates the highest form of self-limitation, bearing of suffering, resistance to usurpation, forgiveness of sins, return, and love. Yet this formulation cannot be directly equated with orthodox Christology. The incarnation spoken of in Christian tradition is not merely an ethical model or an ontological symbol; it involves the relation of the Son to the Father, one person in two natures, suffering and resurrection in history, and the irreducibility of the event of redemption. The Doctrine of Closure may explain from the angle of philosophical theology why the 'Highest Manifestation' is indispensable within its system, but it cannot claim to have completed Christology.

Therefore this thesis should preserve two layers in its treatment of Jesus. The first layer is internal to the Doctrine of Closure: Jesus as the Highest Manifestation marks the clearest way in which First Consciousness, within local history, returns to itself through self-limitation, love, and suffering. The second layer belongs to Christianity itself: Jesus Christ is the revelatory center in the incarnation, the cross, and the resurrection, and his theological meaning exceeds what this thesis can fully absorb. The two layers may converse, but they cannot be merged. If they are merged, the Doctrine of Closure overreaches; if they are completely severed, the Doctrine of Closure loses its reason for theological extension. Chapter Seventeen should remain in this high-pressure middle position.²⁷³

²⁷²Karl Barth, *Church Dogmatics I/1; II/2*. Barth functions in this chapter as the true external pressure, limiting natural theology and metaphysical theology from swallowing revelatory freedom.

²⁷³Council of Chalcedon, 'Definition of Faith,' 451; Athanasius, *On the Incarnation*, translated by John Behr, St Vladimir's Seminary Press, 2011; Jürgen Moltmann, *The Crucified God*, translated by R. A. Wilson and John Bowden, Fortress Press, 1993; Karl Rahner, *The Trinity*, translated by Joseph Donceel, Crossroad, 1997; John D. Zizioulas, *Being as Communion*, St Vladimir's Seminary Press, 1985. These materials mark the theological density of incarnation, cross, Trinity, and personal relation; this thesis does not replace orthodox Christology with the Doctrine of Closure.

V. The Highest Manifestation of Jesus: Where It Holds and Where It Does Not

The 'Highest Manifestation of Jesus' is the strongest theological extension in this thesis, and also the place most in need of self-limitation. In the language of the Doctrine of Closure, Jesus has the meaning of Highest Manifestation because he concentrates the highest form of self-limitation, bearing of suffering, resistance to usurpation, forgiveness of sins, return, and love. Yet this formulation cannot be directly equated with orthodox Christology. The incarnation spoken of in Christian tradition is not merely an ethical model or an ontological symbol; it involves the relation of the Son to the Father, one person in two natures, suffering and resurrection in history, and the irreducibility of the event of redemption. The Doctrine of Closure may explain from the angle of philosophical theology why the 'Highest Manifestation' is indispensable within its system, but it cannot claim to have completed Christology.

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Where it does not hold must also be plainly stated. This formulation is not yet equivalent to orthodox Christology, nor has it adequately treated one person in two natures, atonement through the cross, the event of resurrection, the work of the Holy Spirit, the Church, and the sacraments. If the Doctrine of Closure compresses all these questions into 'the whole becoming personally embodied in the local,' it will functionalize the Christ-event and thereby weaken the very uniqueness it seeks to preserve.

The more stable formulation is this: the Highest Manifestation of Jesus is a strong-version theological extension that the Doctrine of Closure must preserve internally, not a doctrinal conclusion deduced by the Doctrine of Closure. It prevents the Doctrine of Closure from being reduced to an abstract theology of ground; at the same time, it requires further study of biblical texts, doctrinal history, Christology, and soteriology.

²⁷⁴Council of Chalcedon, 'Definition of Faith,' 451; Athanasius, *On the Incarnation*, translated by John Behr, St Vladimir's Seminary Press, 2011; Jürgen Moltmann, *The Crucified God*, translated by R. A. Wilson and John Bowden, Fortress Press, 1993; Karl Rahner, *The Trinity*, translated by Joseph Donceel, Crossroad, 1997; John D. Zizioulas, *Being as Communion*, St Vladimir's Seminary Press, 1985. These materials mark the theological density of incarnation, cross, Trinity, and personal relation; this thesis does not replace orthodox Christology with the Doctrine of Closure.

²⁷⁵On incarnation and the language of Christ's self-limitation, see John 1:14; Phil. 2:6-8; and Barth, *Church Dogmatics* I/1. The 'Highest Manifestation of Jesus' in this thesis is a high-risk theological extension, not a completed orthodox Christology.

VI. The Same Jesus May Appear Many Times: Preventing Misreadings

The claim that 'the same Jesus may appear many times' requires very clear prevention of misreadings. It does not mean many Jesuses; it does not mean different universes each having a different savior; it does not mean a reincarnational Jesus; it does not mean that anyone who satisfies certain conditions can become Jesus; and it does not mean a replaceable functional position. If these misreadings are not cleared away, the claim will immediately slide into a doctrine of many saviors or pan-Christism.

The positive formulation should be this: the qualification of the Highest Manifestation is unique, because the highest, clearest, and fullest manifestation of the whole within the local cannot be pluralized. Multiple appearances refer only to the possibility that the same Highest Manifestation may be repeatedly presented under different successful closures, different historical conditions, different symbolic layers, or different local readings. Here 'many times' does not destroy 'uniqueness,' for what is repeated is not a different qualification, but the manifestation of the same qualification under different conditions of closure.

This claim has necessity within the Doctrine of Closure. If successful closures may be multiple, and if every successful closure requires the Highest Manifestation to enable the whole to self-limit, bear suffering, personally show truth, and return the local, then the Highest Manifestation cannot be understood merely as an accidental historical symbol. Yet this remains an internal necessity of the Doctrine of Closure, not proof that orthodox Christology has been established.

VII. The Irreducibility of Cross and Resurrection

The cross cannot be written merely as a philosophical symbol of self-limitation. It is also suffering, violence, shame, abandonment, and bearing within history. The Doctrine of Closure may understand the cross as the event in which the Highest One self-limits within the local; but if this understanding erases concrete suffering and historical violence, it will repeat the error already warned against in the ethical chapter: it will turn suffering into material for the language of the whole.²⁷⁶

Nor can the resurrection be written merely as 'the return of the whole consciousness to the whole.' That language has meaning within the Doctrine of Closure: local death cannot invalidate the Highest Manifestation, and the manifestation of the whole within the local is not closed off by local destruction. Yet Christian resurrection also concerns body, historical witness, eschatological hope, and proclamation of salvation. If only the ontological translation remains, resurrection will be diluted into a general model of recovery.

The safe formulation of this thesis concerning cross and resurrection is therefore: the Doctrine of Closure may provide an ontological rereading, but it cannot replace the Christ-event itself. Cross and resurrection remain the central pressure of the Highest Manifestation in this thesis precisely because they do not allow the Doctrine of Closure to rest comfortably in an abstract whole.

²⁷⁶Jürgen Moltmann, *The Crucified God*, SCM Press, 1974; *Theology of Hope*, SCM Press, 1967. These works remind this thesis that cross, history, and hope cannot be wholly absorbed by abstract ontological language.

VIII. Stratified Revelation and the Risk of Selective Scripture

Stratified revelation is another high-risk claim in Chapter Seventeen. Taking the Highest Manifestation of Jesus as its criterion, it rereads certain highly anthropomorphic, tribalized, and violent images of God in the Old Testament, considering that there may be local reception, historical refraction, editorial layering, or misreading. This can increase the internal consistency of the Doctrine of Closure, and can also prevent all divine images from being flattened without distinction.

If stratified revelation is to hold, it cannot rely only on the author's intuitive ordering of biblical texts. It requires at least a set of examinable criteria. This thesis provisionally sets down five: first, whether the text presents God's self-limitation, rather than writing God as arbitrary power; second, whether it discloses universal truth, rather than merely a victory narrative of a particular community; third, whether it resists the usurpation of local power, rather than endorsing a center of violence; fourth, whether it bears the weight of suffering and victims, rather than smoothing wounds under a sacred name; fifth, whether it reaches its highest concentrated manifestation in the life, cross, and resurrection of Jesus. These five criteria are not a new authority for judging the canon, but the minimum guardrails for this thesis when it undertakes philosophical-theological translation.

Handled in this way, stratified revelation is not a denial of the Old Testament, nor an arbitrary deletion of texts that offend modern ethical feeling. More precisely, it acknowledges that within Scripture there are different historical situations, theological levels, and degrees of revelatory clarity. Some texts reflect more heavily the way ancient communities understood God amid war, law, ethnic boundary, and royal order; other texts more clearly point toward mercy, justice, repentance, the sufferer, and God's self-limitation. If the Doctrine of Closure is to use the language of revelation, it must acknowledge such internal layers, rather than flattening all texts into equally clear metaphysical propositions.²⁷⁷

IX. The Relational Thickness of Prayer, Grace, and Redemption

The Doctrine of Closure understands prayer as the recalibration of local standpoint, repentance as the re-recognition of one's position, and redemption as renewed return to the whole. These formulations have philosophical clarity; yet if handled carelessly, they drain religious relation of its substance. If prayer is merely psychological adjustment, grace merely structural self-repair, and redemption merely cognitive correction, then Christian language has been over-abstracted.

The more stable formulation is this: the Doctrine of Closure may offer an ontological translation, but it must acknowledge that prayer, grace, and redemption still possess irreducible relational thickness. They involve the relation between God and human beings, the work of the Holy Spirit, communal witness, and the transformation of historical life. The Doctrine of Closure can explain part of this; it cannot swallow all of it.

²⁷⁷Karl Barth, *Church Dogmatics I/1: The Doctrine of the Word of God*, translated by G. W. Bromiley, T&T Clark, 1975; Brevard S. Childs, *Biblical Theology of the Old and New Testaments: Theological Reflection on the Christian Bible*, Fortress Press, 1992; Christopher R. Seitz, *Word Without End: The Old Testament as Abiding Theological Witness*, Baylor UP, 2004; Walter Brueggemann, *Theology of the Old Testament: Testimony, Dispute, Advocacy*, Fortress Press, 1997. The 'stratified revelation' proposed here is not canonical deletion, but a limited treatment of revelatory clarity, textual situation, and Christological center when this thesis undertakes philosophical-theological translation.

X. Post-Examination Correction after Theological Testing

The post-examination correction of Chapter Seventeen is this: the Doctrine of Closure may enter into high-intensity dialogue with Christian theology, but it may not claim to have completed orthodox theology. Where it can hold is in its rejection of popular design theory, its preservation of the ground of being, and its elevation of Jesus as Highest Manifestation. Where it must not overclaim is in personhood, revelatory freedom, Trinity, cross, resurrection, Church, and eschaton, which have not yet been fully doctrinalized.

Thus, what the Doctrine of Closure gains after theological examination is 'theological self-limitation,' not theological victory. Theological materials give the Doctrine of Closure vocabulary and depth, and also limit it from reducing God to a metaphysical structure. When Chapter Nineteen faces Barth, the Doctrine of Closure can no longer say that it has fully solved the theological problem; it can only say that it now knows clearly where theology will strike it.²⁷⁸

XI. The Functions and Limits of Theological Resources for Dialogue

The indirect resources for dialogue in Chapter Seventeen each have their function and each has its limit. Tillich helps the Doctrine of Closure weaken the idea of God as an engineer outside the universe; Aquinas helps it speak of subsistent being and creative dependence; Augustine helps it deal with time, creation, evil, and the order of love; Trinitarian theology helps it prevent the whole from becoming a dead block; theology of the cross helps it preserve the weight of suffering and of victims. Yet none of these resources can prove the Doctrine of Closure.

The point at which resources for dialogue are most easily abused is when they are absorbed by the Doctrine of Closure as illustrations of itself. Tillich was not a theorist of the Doctrine of Closure; Aquinas was not a theorist of inward-gathering conditions; Augustine was not an algorithmic theologian; Moltmann did not provide a function of the cross for the Doctrine of Closure. They can provide vocabulary, pressure, and boundary; they cannot become theological endorsements of this thesis.

Therefore Chapter Seventeen must show an academic posture: the more there is resonance with theology, the more it must acknowledge that theology cannot be swallowed. If the Doctrine of Closure is to speak of God, it must allow theology to retain the right of interrogation; if it uses theology only to add force, it will immediately fail before Barth.

²⁷⁸The minimal conclusion of Chapter Seventeen is that the Doctrine of Closure is a framework for philosophical-theological dialogue, not a complete doctrinal system. Its theological extensions must continue to be tested by Barth, canon, doctrinal history, Christology, and theology of revelation.

XII. The Minimal Theological Version after Barth

The pressure of Barth is important not merely because he opposes natural theology, but because he directly challenges the place where the Doctrine of Closure most easily overreaches: if God is the one who reveals himself in freedom, then he cannot be grasped in advance by any universal metaphysical system. The Doctrine of Closure may say that God should not be understood as the highest object inside the universe, and it may use the ground-of-being language of Tillich or Aquinas to avoid crude design theory; but it cannot infer from this that the Christian God has been fully explained by the concept of First Consciousness. First Consciousness is at most an entrance into philosophical theology, not a conclusion of revelatory theology.

Therefore the minimum defensible version of Chapter Seventeen should be this: the Doctrine of Closure provides a philosophical-theological language concerning ultimate ground, primordial presence, and local return; this language may converse with creation, incarnation, cross, resurrection, grace, and redemption; but it cannot replace the density of church tradition concerning God's freedom, personhood, covenant, historical revelation, and the work of the Holy Spirit. If this boundary cannot be kept, the Doctrine of Closure will reduce Christianity to an example of its own theory. If it can be kept, only then is it entitled to say that it enters the pressure-field of theology rather than swallowing theology.²⁷⁹

²⁷⁹Karl Barth, *Church Dogmatics I/1*, translated by G. W. Bromiley, T&T Clark, 1975; Karl Barth, *Church Dogmatics II/2: The Doctrine of God*, translated by G. W. Bromiley et al., T&T Clark, 1957; Paul Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, vol. 1, University of Chicago Press, 1951; Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, I, q. 3, a. 4. Barth functions in this thesis as the pressure of revelatory freedom and anti-natural theology; Tillich and Aquinas function as entrances into the language of ground of being. Their functions must not be confused.

XIII. Theoretical Stabilization after Theological Examination: Stratified Revelation, Highest Manifestation, and Theological Self-Limitation

If stratified revelation is to become an arguable claim, it must acknowledge that the actual textual work is not yet complete. It may set out criteria such as self-limitation, universality, resistance to usurpation, the place of victims, and the Highest Manifestation of Jesus; but it cannot announce that a given passage is higher or lower merely by possessing such criteria. Every concrete reading must handle textual location, historical situation, canonical function, reception history, and doctrinal tradition.

Therefore this chapter should not write stratified revelation as a conclusion, but as a research program. It can explain why the Doctrine of Closure cannot receive all divine images without distinction as equally clear Highest Manifestation. It cannot bypass biblical-theological work and directly place texts that do not fit the Doctrine of Closure into a lower layer. This limit must be preserved, or else the criticism of arbitrary selective Scripture will stand.

The post-examination correction of this section is this: stratified revelation may be preserved, but it must be marked as a high-risk theological extension requiring further textual work. It is not a minor side issue; it is the research direction in Chapter Seventeen that most requires further deepening.

Chapter Seventeen cannot end in a posture of victory. Once the Doctrine of Closure enters the theological context, it indeed gains such linguistic resources as ground of being, creative dependence, Trinitarian analogy, the Highest Manifestation of Jesus, and stratified revelation. Yet these resources at the same time push it into the most dangerous position: the more it can speak of God, the more it must acknowledge that God cannot be fully grasped by it.

The first result is that the language of 'God' has been delimited anew. The Doctrine of Closure may refuse to understand God as an engineer outside the universe, and may, with Tillich's language of the ground of being, understand God within the question of ultimate ground, primordial presence, and existence not remaining suspended. This step lets the Doctrine of Closure avoid crude design theory, and also makes it deeper than ordinary theories of an external cosmic cause. Yet this does not mean that the Christian God has been fully explained by 'First Consciousness.' If God is only ground of being, he is easily abstracted into a cosmic principle. The God of whom Christianity speaks also involves personhood, revelation, covenant, judgment, mercy, redemption, and historical action. After theological examination, the Doctrine of Closure can say only that it provides an entrance into philosophical theology; it cannot say that it has replaced revelatory theology.

The second result is that creation has been returned to ontological dependence rather than a temporal beginning. The value of Aquinas and Augustine is that they remind this thesis: creation is not only the first thing God did in physical time, nor a linear question of 'what was there before the Big Bang.' Creation may be understood as the dependence of world and time themselves upon God. This allows the Doctrine of Closure's question concerning how existence as a whole is established to enter dialogue with classical theology. Yet this also brings a limit: the world's dependence upon God does not mean that world and God lose their distinction. If the Doctrine of Closure writes the world as God's own closed-loop unfolding directly, it may narrow the difference between Creator and creation and slide into an overly immanentized monism.

The third result is that Trinitarian language has been lowered back to functional analogy. The Doctrine of Closure may use the language of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit to describe structural functions such as source, manifestation, and maintenance/return; this helps prevent ultimate ground from becoming an undifferentiated dead block. But orthodox Trinitarian doctrine is not three functional posts. The Trinity involves one essence, three persons, relation, communion, and the inner life of God. If the Doctrine of Closure compresses the Trinity into a diagram of cosmic mechanism, it will lose the weight of personal relation and communion. Therefore this chapter preserves at most a functional analogy with Trinitarian doctrine; it does not claim to have entered the doctrinal derivation of the Nicene-Constantinopolitan creedal tradition.

The fourth result is that Barthian pressure has been established as the true core of this chapter. Barth is not an external reminder; he strikes directly at the most dangerous point of the Doctrine of Closure: if God is the one who reveals himself in freedom, he cannot be grasped in advance by any universal metaphysical system. The Doctrine of Closure may say that, within its own model, if ultimate ground possesses primordial presence, it can be philosophically named God. But it cannot say that the God who freely reveals himself in Jesus Christ within Christianity has been derived by this model. This point prevents the theological chapter from ending in victory; it can end only in self-limitation. The Doctrine of Closure enters the pressure-field of theology; it does not swallow theology.

The fifth result is that the Highest Manifestation of Jesus is preserved, but not written as complete Christology. Jesus is important within the Doctrine of Closure not because he is merely a higher moral exemplar, but because he concentrates self-limitation, suffering, resistance to usurpation, forgiveness of sins, love, and local return. In the language of the Doctrine of Closure, Jesus can be understood as the clearest Highest Manifestation of First Consciousness within local history. Yet the Jesus Christ of whom Christianity speaks is not only an ontological symbol, nor only an ethical model; he involves incarnation, one person in two natures, cross, resurrection, redemption, the Holy Spirit, the Church, and eschatological hope. The Doctrine of Closure may explain why 'Highest Manifestation' is indispensable within its system, but it cannot claim to have completed Christology.

The sixth result is that cross and resurrection cannot be fully compressed by ontology. The cross may be understood by the Doctrine of Closure as the self-limitation and bearing of the Highest One within the local, but it is also violence, shame, abandonment, and suffering in history. If only the philosophical symbol remains, the cross has been hollowed out. The same is true of resurrection. The Doctrine of Closure may understand resurrection as meaning that local death cannot cancel the Highest Manifestation, and that the manifestation of the whole within the local is not closed off by local destruction; yet Christian resurrection still involves body, historical witness, eschatological hope, and proclamation of salvation. These densities cannot be replaced by the single phrase 'return to the whole.'

The seventh result is that stratified revelation is preserved as a high-risk research program, not as a completed conclusion for judging Scripture. Stratified revelation can help the Doctrine of Closure address the tension between different divine images within Scripture, and avoid

flattening all highly anthropomorphic, tribalized, or violent images of God into the same degree of revelatory clarity. Its criteria may provisionally be self-limitation, universal truth, resistance to usurpation, bearing the weight of victims, and achieving the highest concentrated manifestation in the life, cross, and resurrection of Jesus. But this set of criteria cannot directly replace biblical theology, doctrinal history, and hermeneutical work. Every concrete reading must still handle textual location, historical situation, canonical function, reception history, and doctrinal tradition. Otherwise, stratified revelation will be criticized as arbitrary selective Scripture.

The eighth result is that prayer, grace, and redemption are acknowledged to possess irreducible relational thickness. The Doctrine of Closure may understand prayer as the recalibration of local standpoint, repentance as the re-recognition of position, and redemption as renewed return to the whole. These translations have philosophical clarity, but they cannot drain religious relation dry. Prayer is not merely psychological adjustment, grace is not merely structural self-repair, and redemption is not merely cognitive correction. They also involve the relation between God and human beings, the work of the Holy Spirit, communal witness, the transformation of historical life, and concrete religious practice. The Doctrine of Closure can explain part of this; it cannot swallow all of it.

Therefore what Chapter Seventeen truly completes is not theological proof, but theological stabilization. After theological examination, the Doctrine of Closure obtains at least three levels. The lowest level is the entrance into philosophical theology: God should not be understood as the highest object within the universe, but may be understood as ground of being and primordial presence. The intermediate level is theological translation: creation, sin, prayer, grace, redemption, and liberation may be understood within the grammar of local return and correction of position. The strong version is the Highest Manifestation of Jesus and stratified revelation: the Highest One personally becomes limited within the local, personally bears, and personally manifests truth. The three must not be confused. The defensibility of the lowest level cannot complete proof for the strong version; the risk of the strong version should not in turn drag down the entrance into philosophical theology.

What this chapter hands over to Chapter Nineteen is precisely a version of the Doctrine of Closure corrected under theological pressure. Before Barth, the Doctrine of Closure cannot say that it has grasped the God of revelation; it can only say that it offers an ontological language

that may be interrogated by revelatory theology. Before orthodox Trinitarian doctrine, the Doctrine of Closure cannot say that functional mapping is already equivalent to Trinitarian doctrine; it can only say that internal difference prevents ultimate ground from being a dead block. Before Christology, the Doctrine of Closure cannot say that Highest Manifestation has completed the full doctrinal density of incarnation, one person in two natures, cross, and resurrection; it can only say that Jesus holds an irreplaceable place as Highest Manifestation within its system. Before stratified revelation, the Doctrine of Closure cannot say that it can already judge all biblical texts; it can only say that it has proposed high-risk criteria still requiring textual work.

The final conclusion of Chapter Seventeen may therefore be simplified into one sentence: theology has not proven the Doctrine of Closure, but theology has forced the Doctrine of Closure not to overreach. It forces the Doctrine of Closure to relinquish popular design theory, to relinquish the reduction of God into a cosmic principle, to relinquish the rewriting of Trinitarian doctrine as functional division, to relinquish the compression of cross and resurrection into ontological symbols, and to relinquish the turning of stratified revelation into arbitrary selective Scripture. These relinquishments are not retreat, but theoretical maturity. Only after this chapter does the Doctrine of Closure cease to be a metaphysical manifesto borrowing theological vocabulary, and become a candidate model of philosophical theology willing to let theology retain the right of interrogation.²⁸⁰

²⁸⁰This section gathers the results of the theological cross-domain examination in Sections I to XII of Chapter Seventeen. Tillich, Aquinas, Augustine, Trinitarian theology, theology of the cross, Barth, incarnation, resurrection, stratified revelation, prayer, grace, and redemption all function in this chapter as entrances into philosophical theology, theological translations, limiting forces, or central pressures, not as direct proofs of the Doctrine of Closure. The maturity standard of Chapter Seventeen is not to claim that the Doctrine of Closure has completed Christian theology, but to make its theological extension receive the limitations of revelatory freedom, personhood, Christology, cross, resurrection, and canonical interpretation.

DOCTRINE OF CLOSURE

**Part IV Cross-Domain Examination and General
Objections**

Chapter Eighteen

**Buddhist Examination - Prajna and
Madhyamaka Pressure**

This chapter preserves Buddhist difference
and the anti-reification pressure of
Madhyamaka.

Chapter Eighteen Buddhist Cross-Domain Examination - Differentiated Dialogue and the Pressure of Prajna

The error most to be avoided in Chapter Eighteen is to write Buddhism as an ally of the Doctrine of Closure. Buddhism is not a single storehouse of materials, nor is it an ancient version of the Doctrine of Closure. The Agamas, Prajna and Madhyamaka, Yogacara, the Lankavatara Sutra, Huayan, Buddha-nature, tathagatagarbha, and Chan each have different problem-consciousness. If this chapter asks only where they resemble the Doctrine of Closure, it becomes an act of appropriation. Only if it also asks where they most strongly oppose the Doctrine of Closure does it become a genuine cross-domain examination.²⁸¹

This chapter is likewise divided between a line of opponents and a line of resources for dialogue. The Agamas and early Buddhism are resources for dialogue concerning suffering and practice. Yogacara is a resource for dialogue concerning manifestation and consciousness. Huayan is a resource for dialogue concerning the mutual containment of whole and part. Buddha-nature and Chan are resources for awakening-language, yet they carry the risk of reification. The true central opponent is Prajna-Madhyamaka, for it will ask whether closure, First Consciousness, and ultimate ground remain one vast self-nature.²⁸²

I. The Agamas and Early Buddhism: Suffering, Ignorance, and Clinging

What the Agamas and early Buddhism provide is not evidence for the Doctrine of Closure, but a background in suffering and practice. They make the Doctrine of Closure understand that suffering is not an abstract defect, but is bound to ignorance, craving, clinging, habit, action, and embodied experience. If the Doctrine of Closure writes

²⁸¹Where this chapter discusses Chinese Buddhist scriptures, it uses the versions listed in CBETA Online for comparison, including T08n0251 Prajnaparamita Hridaya Sutra, T08n0235 Vajracchedika Prajnaparamita Sutra, T02n0099 Samyukta Agama, T16n0670 Lankavatara Sutra, T10n0279 Avatamsaka Sutra, and T12n0374 Mahaparinirvana Sutra. This thesis does not fabricate juan, chapter, page, or sutra-number locations.

²⁸²Where this chapter discusses Chinese Buddhist scriptures, it uses the versions listed in CBETA Online for comparison: Prajnaparamita Hridaya Sutra T08n0251, Vajracchedika Prajnaparamita Sutra T08n0235, Samyukta Agama T02n0099, Lankavatara Sutra T16n0670, Avatamsaka Sutra T10n0279, and Mahaparinirvana Sutra T12n0374. These materials are used only at the level of versional reference; where no passage-by-passage location has been verified, no juan, page, or paragraph location is supplied.

suffering only as the cost of closure, it becomes too cold. If it enters dialogue with early Buddhism, it will see more clearly how suffering arises within local life.²⁸³

This function as a resource for dialogue is important. If the Doctrine of Closure's 'misrecognition of position' is written merely as an intellectual error, it is too thin. The Agamic context reminds this thesis that misrecognition is not simply conceptual inaccuracy, but an entire condition involving desire, fear, body, habit-energy, and repeated action.

Yet early Buddhism also limits the Doctrine of Closure. It does not necessarily pursue an ultimate ground capable of self-establishment, and may even suspect that such a pursuit still carries clinging. Therefore this thesis cannot say that the Agamas support closure; it can only say that they give the Doctrine of Closure's account of suffering greater existential thickness.

²⁸³ On early Buddhist accounts of suffering, ignorance, and clinging, see Samyukta Agama T02n0099; Mark Siderits, *Buddhism as Philosophy*, Hackett, 2007, chs. 2-4. This thesis uses these materials only as a context for suffering and practice, not as proof of the Doctrine of Closure.

II. Pain and Suffering, the Two Arrows, and the Safeguard of the Victim

Chapter Fourteen opened a Buddhist entrance into pain and suffering; Chapter Eighteen must restrict that use more accurately. The Buddhist parable of the two arrows can help this thesis distinguish pain at the level of body or event from the suffering formed by the subject's renewed clinging and resistance to pain. This has obvious room for dialogue with the Doctrine of Closure, which treats pain as the cost of finitude and suffering as a subjective entanglement under local misrecognition.²⁸⁴

Yet the safeguard of the victim must be preserved here. The distinction between pain and suffering must not be used by bystanders to demand that victims let go, nor may the suffering of the traumatized be blamed on an attachment insufficiently released. If Buddhist materials are used in this manner, they become a second silencing. What the Doctrine of Closure must learn here is this: cognitive correction may transform suffering, but it cannot deny that pain has occurred, nor can it cancel ethical responsibility.

III. Yogacara and the Lankavatara Sutra: Manifestation, Consciousness, and Misrecognition

Yogacara and the Lankavatara materials can help the Doctrine of Closure think through manifestation and misrecognition. If the world is not received by local subjects in pure transparency, but is always bound to consciousness, habit-energy, discrimination, and the conversion between delusion and awakening, then the Doctrine of Closure's 'misrecognition of position' gains a more refined context for dialogue.²⁸⁵

Yet Yogacara cannot be simplified into the claim that 'the world is projected by First Consciousness.' What Yogacara treats is consciousness, manifestation, cognitive activity, and the conversion between delusion and awakening; it is not the cosmic whole as First Consciousness in the Doctrine of Closure. If this thesis directly appropriates Yogacara into its own ontology, it will misread both Buddhism and itself.

The more stable formulation is this: Yogacara helps the Doctrine of Closure weaken naive realism and pay closer attention to how the local reads the world. Whether the Doctrine of Closure requires an ultimate ground, however, must still be answered by its own metaphysics.

IV. Huayan: Powerful Imagery and the Impossibility of Direct Proof

Huayan is the indirect resource for dialogue in Chapter Eighteen with the strongest imagistic power. Its language of mutual containment in the dharmadhatu, inexhaustible interpenetration, and one as all can render the relation between whole and part in the Doctrine of Closure more palpable. The local is not an isolated fragment, and the whole is not an abstract sum; each local may reflect the whole in relation, and the whole need not cancel local difference.²⁸⁶

Nevertheless, Huayan imagery cannot directly prove the ontology of closure. Huayan can help the Doctrine of Closure understand mutual containment, difference, whole, and part, but it does not thereby acknowledge First Consciousness, nor does it acknowledge that ultimate ground must be established in the form of closure. If the Doctrine of Closure treats Huayan as an ancient version of itself, it turns a resource for dialogue into an instrument of appropriation.

Therefore Huayan's function in this chapter is to raise the Doctrine of Closure's imagistic capacity, not to increase its demonstrative force. It reminds the Doctrine of Closure that whole and part may mutually contain one another without devouring one another, and that the local may manifest the whole without becoming ultimately self-subsistent.

²⁸⁴ On the parable of the 'two arrows,' see Samyutta Nikaya 36.6; related Chinese materials may be compared in the Samyukta Agama. This thesis uses the parable only as a dialogical background for distinguishing pain and suffering.

²⁸⁵ On philosophy of mind in Indian Buddhism, see Christian Coseru, 'Mind in Indian Buddhist Philosophy,' Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy; Lankavatara Sutra T16n0670. Yogacara and the Lankavatara Sutra are not here equated with the First Consciousness of the Doctrine of Closure.

²⁸⁶ On Huayan mutual containment in the dharmadhatu and imagery of whole and part, see Avatamsaka Sutra T10n0279; related research in Huayan philosophy may also be consulted. This thesis uses the material only for imagery and dialogue, not as the main proof of the Doctrine of Closure.

V. Buddha-Nature, Tathagatagarbha, and Chan: High Yield and High Risk

The languages of Buddha-nature, tathagatagarbha, and Chan strongly resemble the Doctrine of Closure's language of 'never originally apart,' 're-recognition of position,' and 'awakening.' The Doctrine of Closure says that the local has never truly departed from the whole; the problem lies in misrecognition. Some Chan expressions likewise do not command a person to add a new external entity, but to cease misrecognition and directly see what has always been so. Here there is genuine room for mutual illumination.²⁸⁷

But this is also the most dangerous place. Buddha-nature and tathagatagarbha have often been misread in Buddhist history as an abiding great self. The Doctrine of Closure itself tends to speak of ultimate whole and First Consciousness. If the two are joined too quickly, they slide toward a great-self reading.

The proper function of this set of materials is therefore to provide a resource for dialogue concerning awakening-language and the image of never having been apart, while at the same time reminding this thesis to guard against rewriting Buddha-nature as another name for the closed-loop whole. The Doctrine of Closure may speak of similarity; it may not speak of identity.

VI. Prajna-Madhyamaka: The True Central Opponent and the Strongest Anti-Reification Pressure

Prajna-Madhyamaka is the true central opponent in Chapter Eighteen. It does not supplement the Doctrine of Closure; it dismantles it. Nagarjuna's pressure is this: whatever is described as self-subsisting, ultimate, first, ground, or whole - does it still secretly establish self-nature? The Doctrine of Closure speaks of ultimate ground, First Consciousness, and the qualification of closure. Madhyamaka then asks: are these languages only a great ontology under another name?²⁸⁸

This criticism cannot be rapidly digested by this thesis. If the Doctrine of Closure says that Madhyamaka 'actually supports closure,' it loses the greatest value of Chapter Eighteen. Madhyamaka's most important function is to make the Doctrine of Closure forever afraid of becoming an idol. It forces this thesis to narrow 'the ultimate' from a great ontology into language of qualification; to narrow 'closure' from a substantial noun into a criterion of

²⁸⁷On Buddha-nature, tathagatagarbha, and awakening-language, see Mahaparinirvana Sutra T12n0374; Steven Collins, *Selfless Persons*, Cambridge UP, 1982. This thesis uses these materials only as a dialogical background for awakening-language.

²⁸⁸Nagarjuna, *Mulamadhyamakakarika*, especially ch. 24; Jay L. Garfield, *The Fundamental Wisdom of the Middle Way*, Oxford UP, 1995; Mark Siderits, *Buddhism as Philosophy*, Hackett, 2007. Madhyamaka functions in this thesis as the strongest anti-reification pressure, not as supporting evidence for the Doctrine of Closure.

internal recovery of conditions; and to narrow 'First Consciousness' from an unquestionable sacred thing into a high-risk candidate of best explanation.

The point at which the Doctrine of Closure and Madhyamaka cannot be harmonized must also be stated openly. The Doctrine of Closure still does not wish to abandon the question of ultimate ground. Madhyamaka, by contrast, will suspect that this question itself already bears clinging. This is not a minor difference; it is a fundamental pressure. The Doctrine of Closure may learn anti-reification from Madhyamaka, but it cannot pretend that it has become fully Madhyamaka.

VII. The Two Truths and the Possible Downgrading of the Doctrine of Closure

Madhyamaka does not merely say that 'nothing exists.' It requires a distinction between the linguistic functions of conventional truth and ultimate truth. This is extremely important for the Doctrine of Closure. If the Doctrine of Closure writes itself as a final proclamation at the level of ultimate truth, Madhyamaka will pierce it. If it narrows itself into an analytic model at the conventional level for handling the problem of ultimate ground, it may still retain a place for dialogue.

This is not complete surrender by the Doctrine of Closure. It may admit that it belongs largely to a conventional analytic model, while still preserving one question: if the position of ultimate ground is wholly abandoned, does one fall back into brute fact or infinite outsourcing? Madhyamaka may say that this very question is itself clinging; the Doctrine of Closure will ask whether some criterion of non-outsourcing is still needed. It is proper to leave this tension for Chapter Nineteen.²⁸⁹

VIII. Two Bottom Lines for Buddhist Materials

Chapter Eighteen must observe two bottom lines in its treatment of Buddhist materials. First, Buddhist materials may make the Doctrine of Closure more restrained, and more sensitive to clinging, misrecognition, reification, and the experience of suffering. Second, Buddhist materials cannot complete the main ontological proof for the Doctrine of Closure. Only if the Doctrine of Closure learns self-limitation from Buddhist thought, rather than turning Buddhist thought into supporting evidence, does this chapter truly complete its cross-domain examination.

²⁸⁹ On the two truths and the linguistic function of Madhyamaka, see Garfield, *The Fundamental Wisdom of the Middle Way*; Siderits, *Buddhism as Philosophy*. This thesis does not claim that the Doctrine of Closure has passed through Madhyamaka; it only states a possible downgraded position.

The internal division of Buddhist materials must also be maintained. The Agamas are resources for dialogue concerning suffering and practice. Yogacara is a resource concerning manifestation and consciousness. Huayan is a resource concerning the mutual containment of whole and part. Buddha-nature and Chan are resources concerning awakening-language. Madhyamaka is the overall pressure that cannot be appropriated. To distinguish them is what differentiated dialogue means.

IX. The Lowest Defensible Version after Madhyamaka

If Madhyamaka criticism operates at full strength, the Doctrine of Closure at minimum can no longer write ultimate ground as a graspable great entity, First Consciousness as an unquestionable sacred substance, or closure as a thing behind all things. It must retreat into language of qualification: if one still asks about ultimate ground, that ground must possess the internal recovery of conditions; if one still speaks of First Consciousness, it is only a high-risk candidate responding to the explanatory debt of dead-structure models; if one still speaks of the whole, the whole must preserve local differences and cannot become devouring unity.

This retreat is not total capitulation. The Doctrine of Closure may still preserve its problem-consciousness concerning ultimate ground, and in Chapter Nineteen it may ask: if Madhyamaka dismantles all language of self-nature, does it also dismantle the demand for ultimate explanation? If so, anti-PSR and Madhyamaka form an alliance in a certain sense. If not, the Doctrine of Closure may still preserve internal recovery of conditions as its lowest qualification.

X. Postwar Correction after Buddhist Examination

After Chapter Eighteen, what the Doctrine of Closure obtains is not Buddhist endorsement, but immunity against reification. It learns not to write ultimate ground as a graspable great thing, not to write First Consciousness as Buddha-nature, not to write Huayan mutual containment as proof of closure, and not to write emptiness as another form of whole.

The postwar correction of this chapter is as follows: the Doctrine of Closure still preserves the problem-consciousness of ultimate ground, but narrows 'ultimate' into language of qualification, criterion, and internal recovery of conditions. It still preserves First Consciousness as a strong candidate, but must endure Madhyamaka's continuing interrogation of self-nature. It may still converse with Buddhist materials, but it no longer attempts to turn Buddhism into an ancient footnote to itself.²⁹⁰

²⁹⁰The minimal conclusion of Chapter Eighteen is that Buddhist materials make the Doctrine of Closure harder to write, not easier to write. They provide accounts of suffering, manifestation, mutual containment, and awakening-language, and they also provide Madhyamaka anti-reification pressure. They do not complete the ontological proof for the Doctrine of Closure.

XI. How Buddhist Materials Enable the Doctrine of Closure to Enter Chapter Nineteen More Stably

The function of the Buddhist resources for dialogue in Chapter Eighteen is not to crown the Doctrine of Closure, but to prevent it from entering Chapter Nineteen in an overly reified form. The Agamas train it to handle suffering, and not to turn pain into an abstract cost. Yogacara trains it to handle manifestation, and not to treat local reading as direct reality. Huayan trains it to handle whole and part, and not to erase the local. Buddha-nature and Chan train it to handle awakening, and not to turn awakening into the return of a great self.

If these resources for dialogue are misused, they will instead destroy the Doctrine of Closure. If the Agamas are used to support determinism, Buddhist teaching on suffering is flattened. If Yogacara is equated with First Consciousness, consciousness-theory is misread. If Huayan is equated with closure, the mutual containment of the dharmadhatu is hollowed out. If Buddha-nature is equated with the whole self, one falls into the great abiding self. The maturity of Chapter Eighteen lies in restricting every resource for dialogue.

Treated in this way, the Buddhist chapter makes the Doctrine of Closure more cautious. It does not make the Doctrine of Closure more triumphal; it makes it more capable of enduring Madhyamaka criticism. This upgrade, 'narrower and therefore harder,' is precisely the preparatory training needed before Chapter Nineteen.

XII. A Rehearsal of Madhyamaka Pressure

The pressure of Madhyamaka upon the Doctrine of Closure does not consist in providing another ultimate ground, but in questioning whether the language of ultimate ground itself still clings to self-nature. If closure is written as a final substance, if First Consciousness is written as a cosmic great self, if the whole is written as the true sovereign behind all things, then the Doctrine of Closure falls exactly within the scope of Madhyamaka criticism. Nagarjuna's dismantling of self-nature, causality, arising, and substantializing language forces this thesis to admit: even if closure is downgraded into a criterion of qualification rather than a highest object, there remains room for interrogation. Madhyamaka may continue to ask whether the criterion of qualification itself is again grasped by the author as the last truth.

Therefore Chapter Eighteen must not claim that the Doctrine of Closure has digested Madhyamaka. The more defensible formulation is to admit that Madhyamaka places this thesis under continuing pressure. The Doctrine of Closure may narrow itself into the candidate language of non-outsourcing qualification, preservation of difference, and local return. It may avoid writing First Consciousness as a personified cosmic great self. It may admit that ultimate ground is not an ordinary substance. Yet none of these corrections means that Madhyamaka criticism has been removed. Madhyamaka still forces this thesis to remain alert: any language called 'last' may again become clinging. Precisely for this reason, the Buddhist chapter does not crown the Doctrine of Closure; it makes the Doctrine of Closure harder to satisfy with itself before it enters Chapter Nineteen.²⁹¹

²⁹¹Nagarjuna, *The Fundamental Wisdom of the Middle Way: Nagarjuna's Mulamadhyamakakarika*, translated and commentary by Jay L. Garfield, Oxford UP, 1995, especially chs. 1, 15, 24; Jay L. Garfield, *Engaging Buddhism: Why It Matters to Philosophy*, Oxford UP, 2015; Jan Westerhoff, *Nagarjuna's Madhyamaka: A Philosophical Introduction*, Oxford UP, 2009; Mark Siderits, *Buddhism as Philosophy*, 2nd ed., Hackett, 2021. Madhyamaka materials function in this thesis as anti-self-nature pressure, not as supporting evidence for the Doctrine of Closure.

XIII. Theoretical Stabilization after Buddhist Examination: Differentiated Dialogue and Madhyamaka Pressure

What Chapter Eighteen finally leaves behind is not Buddhist support for the Doctrine of Closure, but a deeper unease. The Agamas, Yogacara, Huayan, Buddha-nature, and Chan may all enter local dialogue with the Doctrine of Closure. Yet Prajna-Madhyamaka reminds this thesis that every language called ultimate, first, ground, or whole may again become clinging. This reminder cannot be digested by the Doctrine of Closure into supporting evidence; it can only be preserved as pressure.

The first result is that Buddhist materials have been formally divided by function. The Agamas and early Buddhism mainly provide a background concerning suffering and practice. Yogacara and the Lankavatara Sutra mainly provide a context for dialogue concerning manifestation, consciousness, and misrecognition. Huayan mainly provides an imagistic resource for the mutual containment of whole and part. Buddha-nature, tathagatagarbha, and Chan mainly provide awakening-language while also bringing the risk of an abiding great-self reading. Prajna-Madhyamaka is not one resource for dialogue among others, but the true central opponent of this chapter. This division prevents Buddhist materials from being mixed into a vague 'Buddhist support,' and allows each to enter a different problem-layer.

The second result is that the account of suffering has been thickened anew. The Agamas and early Buddhism make the Doctrine of Closure understand that suffering is not an abstract structural cost, nor merely a psychological feeling, but is bound to ignorance, craving, clinging, habit-energy, body, action, and repeated experience. The Doctrine of Closure's 'misrecognition of position' therefore cannot be written merely as an error of intellectual judgment. It must acknowledge how local life deepens its own suffering within desire, fear, attachment, and injury. This can strengthen Chapters Nine and Fourteen, but it must not be misused to demand that victims 'let go.' Buddhist analysis of suffering may help analyze clinging; it cannot be used to silence victims.

The third result is that the distinction between pain and suffering has been given an ethical boundary. The parable of the two arrows can allow the Doctrine of Closure to distinguish pain at the level of events from the suffering formed by the subject's renewed clinging. But this distinction must not become a tool by which bystanders blame those who suffer. Pain occurred, harm was done, and responsibility must still be borne. Cognitive correction may transform suffering, but cannot deny pain. Liberation may change how the local reads its own situation, but cannot cancel the ethical responsibility of perpetrators, institutions, and the common world. This is the victim-safeguard that must be preserved when Buddhist materials enter the Doctrine of Closure.

The fourth result is that Yogacara and the Lankavatara Sutra have been placed at the layer of 'reading and manifestation,' not at the layer of 'proof of First Consciousness.' Yogacara can help the Doctrine of Closure think about how the world is mediated by consciousness, habit-energy, discrimination, and the conversion between delusion and awakening. It allows this thesis to see more clearly that the local does not transparently receive the world, but forms the world it experiences within specific modes of reading. Yet this does not mean that Yogacara acknowledges cosmic First Consciousness. If alaya-vijnana, the Lankavatara Sutra, or the conversion of consciousness into wisdom are directly rewritten as the First Consciousness of the Doctrine of Closure, Buddhist consciousness-theory is misplaced into Western cosmopsychism. Yogacara may help the Doctrine of Closure handle manifestation; it cannot prove ultimate ground for the Doctrine of Closure.

The fifth result is that Huayan has been restricted to imagery of whole and part, not evidence for the ontology of closure. Huayan's language of mutual containment in the dharmadhatu,

inexhaustible interpenetration, and one as all can indeed raise the Doctrine of Closure's expressive capacity concerning the relation between whole and part. It reminds this thesis that the local is not an isolated fragment and the whole is not an external sum; the local can image the whole in relation without being swallowed by the whole. But Huayan is not the Doctrine of Closure. Mutual containment in the dharmadhātu does not necessarily yield First Consciousness, does not necessarily yield an ultimate subject in a theological sense, and does not necessarily yield closure as the qualification of ultimate ground. It can correct the Doctrine of Closure's imagery; it cannot complete the main proof.

The sixth result is that Buddha-nature, tathagatagarbha, and Chan have been placed in a high-risk position. They stand close to the Doctrine of Closure's language of 'never originally apart,' 're-recognition of position,' and 'awakening'; but precisely because they stand close, they are dangerous. If Buddha-nature is read as an abiding self behind all things, the Doctrine of Closure slides toward the great-self reading criticized by Madhyamaka. If Chan's direct seeing is written as an acknowledgment of the Doctrine of Closure, language of practice is changed into language of theoretical consent. The more stable treatment is to acknowledge only the similarity in awakening-language: the local ceases misrecognition, ceases taking itself as an isolated center, and thereby sees its own position anew. This similarity may be used for dialogue; it may not be used to prove First Consciousness.

The seventh result is that Prajna-Madhyamaka has been established as the truly unappropriable pressure of Chapter Eighteen. Madhyamaka does not supply another ultimate ground for the Doctrine of Closure. It dismantles the tendency of anything called ultimate, first, ground, whole, or self-subsisting to become self-nature. When the Doctrine of Closure says ultimate ground, Madhyamaka asks whether this ground is still grasped as self-nature. When the Doctrine of Closure says First Consciousness, Madhyamaka asks whether it is only a cosmic great self. When the Doctrine of Closure says the qualification of closure, Madhyamaka may still ask whether 'qualification' itself has been secretly ontologized. This pressure cannot be removed; it can only be preserved.

The eighth result is that Madhyamaka pressure forces the Doctrine of Closure to downgrade its tone. After Chapter Eighteen, the Doctrine of Closure can no longer write ultimate ground as a graspable great ontology, First Consciousness as an unquestionable sacred substance, or closure as the highest object behind all things. The more defensible version is to narrow 'ultimate' into

language of qualification, 'closure' into the criterion of internal recovery of conditions and non-outsourcing, and 'First Consciousness' into a high-risk candidate of best explanation when facing the explanatory debt of dead-structure models. These narrowings do not extinguish Madhyamaka criticism, but they may prevent the Doctrine of Closure from falling at the outset into crude substantialism.

The ninth result is that the two truths force the Doctrine of Closure to acknowledge the position of its own language. If the Doctrine of Closure calls itself the final truth at the level of ultimate truth, Madhyamaka will pierce it. If it admits that it is an analytic model at the conventional level for handling the problem of ultimate ground, it retains room for discussion. This is not complete surrender by the Doctrine of Closure, for it can still ask: if the qualification of ultimate ground is wholly abandoned, does one fall back into brute fact or infinite outsourcing? Yet this question must be preserved as tension, not as a pretense that Madhyamaka has been absorbed by the Doctrine of Closure.

The tenth result is that Buddhist materials make the Doctrine of Closure more capable of entering Chapter Nineteen. The Agamas prevent it from abstracting suffering. Yogacara prevents it from treating local reading as direct reality. Huayan prevents it from canceling the local. Buddha-nature and Chan show it both the attraction and the danger of awakening-language. Madhyamaka keeps it alert to whether it is again turning 'the last' into a graspable thing. These results together do not crown the Doctrine of Closure; they make it less capable of complacency.

Thus what Chapter Eighteen truly completes is not Buddhist proof, but anti-reification stabilization. After Buddhist examination, the Doctrine of Closure obtains at least three levels. The lowest level is dialogue in the theory of practice: pain, suffering, ignorance, clinging, and misrecognition of position may enter limited mutual interpretation. The intermediate level is dialogue in structural imagery: Yogacara, Huayan, Buddha-nature, and Chan may each help this thesis handle manifestation, mutual containment, awakening, and never having been originally apart. The highest pressure-level is Madhyamaka: it continuously asks whether closure, First Consciousness, and ultimate ground still fall into self-nature. The three must not be confused. Similarity in the theory of practice cannot prove ontology. Imagistic resonance cannot prove First Consciousness. Madhyamaka pressure cannot be rewritten as support for the Doctrine of Closure.

What this chapter hands over to Chapter Nineteen is a version of the Doctrine of Closure narrowed under Buddhist pressure. Before the Agamas, the Doctrine of Closure cannot turn suffering into an abstract cost. Before Yogacara, it cannot rewrite consciousness-theory as cosmopsychism. Before Huayan, it cannot rewrite the imagery of mutual containment as evidence for closure. Before Buddha-nature and Chan, it cannot rewrite awakening-language as an abiding great self. Before Madhyamaka, it cannot present ultimate ground, First Consciousness, and the qualification of closure as final substances beyond interrogation. Only in this way can Chapter Nineteen face the general pressure of Madhyamaka without entering with untested great-ontology language, but rather with narrowed language of qualification.

The final conclusion of Chapter Eighteen may be simplified into one sentence: Buddhism has not proven the Doctrine of Closure, but Buddhism has forced the Doctrine of Closure to undergo continual anti-reification. It forces the Doctrine of Closure to relinquish the use of Buddhism as supporting evidence; to relinquish the rewriting of emptiness as the closed-loop whole; to relinquish the rewriting of Yogacara as First Consciousness; to relinquish the rewriting of Huayan as closed-loop ontology; and to relinquish the rewriting of Buddha-nature as cosmic self. These relinquishments are not retreat, but theoretical maturity. Only after this chapter does the Doctrine of Closure cease to be an expansionary metaphysics, and become an ontological model

willing to accept narrowing, stratification, and self-limitation under Buddhist pressure against clinging.²⁹²

General Conclusion to Chapters Fifteen through Eighteen: Upgrade Completed, Not Final War Completed

What Chapters Fifteen through Eighteen complete is not four victories, but four upgrades. Chapter Fifteen teaches the Doctrine of Closure the grammar of analytic philosophy. Chapter Sixteen gives the Doctrine of Closure resistance at the scientific boundary. Chapter Seventeen teaches the Doctrine of Closure theological self-limitation. Chapter Eighteen gives the Doctrine of Closure immunity against reification.

Only after these four chapters does the Doctrine of Closure have the qualification to enter Chapter Nineteen. For what Chapter Nineteen faces is not ordinary local objection, but the four major opponents: anti-PSR/brute fact against ultimate ground; Many-Worlds and scientific multiplicity against uniqueness and destiny; Barth against philosophical naming of God and revelatory freedom; Madhyamaka against First Consciousness and the qualification of closure through anti-self-nature critique.

Thus the real result of this part is not 'the Doctrine of Closure is now invincible,' but 'the Doctrine of Closure knows how it can be attacked.' It can mark out its opponents, mark out indirect resources for dialogue, mark where concessions may be made and where retreat is impossible, and narrow itself after each confrontation. This attackability is the minimum condition of theoretical maturity.²⁹³

²⁹²This section gathers the results of the Buddhist cross-domain examination in Sections I to XII of Chapter Eighteen. The Agamas and early Buddhism, Prajna-Madhyamaka, Yogacara, the Lankavatara Sutra, Huayan, Buddha-nature, tathagatagarbha, and Chan function in this chapter respectively as backgrounds for suffering, dialogue in practice, dialogue in consciousness-theory, imagery of whole and part, awakening-language, or anti-reification pressure. They do not directly prove the Doctrine of Closure, First Consciousness, or ultimate ground. The standard of maturity in Chapter Eighteen is not to use Buddhism to prove the Doctrine of Closure, but to make the Doctrine of Closure receive Madhyamaka's continuing interrogation of self-nature, clinging, and great-self formation.

²⁹³Chapters Fifteen through Eighteen function as preparatory upgrades before Chapter Nineteen. Philosophical, scientific, theological, and Buddhist materials cannot directly prove the Doctrine of Closure; instead they provide grammar, limits, pressure, allied functions, and postwar corrections.

**Part IV Cross-Domain Examination and General
Objections**

Chapter Nineteen

**The General Trial by the Four Great Opponents
- Positions, Vital Lines, Replies, Defended
Ground, and Dangers**

This chapter concentrates Prajna-
Madhyamaka, Barth, anti-PSR, and Many-
Worlds into a general trial, compressing and
examining the vital lines of the whole book.

Chapter Nineteen The General Trial by the Four Great Opponents - Positions, Vital Lines, Replies, Defended Ground, and Dangers

This chapter is not a victory declaration after the completion of the book. Chapters Fifteen to Eighteen have already placed the Doctrine of Closure within the pressure-fields of analytic metaphysics, philosophy of science, Christian theology, and Buddhist Madhyamaka. The task of Chapter Nineteen is to gather these pressures together and judge what remains of the Doctrine of Closure before its strongest opponents, what must be conceded, and which strong versions can only be retained as theses still awaiting proof. If the preceding chapters are successive upgrades, this chapter is the final tribunal.

This chapter handles the four great opponents by one standard: first present the opponent's strongest version; then identify which vital line of the Doctrine of Closure it strikes; then state what the Doctrine of Closure may concede, where it cannot retreat, and finally what postwar correction follows. The four great opponents are not local pressures successively defeated by the author. They are speed-limiters that remain inside the theory: anti-PSR/brute fact limits explanatory ambition; Many-Worlds limits single-line uniqueness; Barth limits theological absorption; Madhyamaka limits the reification of ultimate language. Only when their force is preserved does the Doctrine of Closure cease to be a self-enclosed grand declaration.²⁹⁴

I. Anti-PSR/Brute Fact: The Fundamental Pressure upon Ultimate Explanation

The anti-PSR route is the first of the four great opponents, because it attacks the starting point of the Doctrine of Closure. The Doctrine of Closure begins because it refuses to leave existence lodged in brute fact and refuses to let conditions of establishment be infinitely outsourced. Yet anti-PSR immediately asks: why should the world be obligated to satisfy such a demand for explanation? Why may some facts not simply be so? If intelligibility is only a preference of human reason rather than a structural obligation of the world, then the Doctrine of Closure's pursuit of ultimate ground is no longer self-evident.²⁹⁵

This objection must not be dismissed lightly. Anti-PSR does not refuse thought, nor does it hide the question. Its real strength is that it puts the demand for explanation itself on trial: perhaps human reason's unwillingness to stop at brute fact reveals only human psychology and conceptual habit; it does not prove that the universe must provide an establishment-ground that no longer borrows outward. From a Humean skeptical tradition, any movement from experienced association to metaphysical necessity must be made with great restraint.²⁹⁶

The vital line struck by anti-PSR is the first step by which the Doctrine of Closure moves from problem-consciousness into ontological demand. If this step fails, closure, First Consciousness, the philosophical naming of God, destiny, and freedom all become the author's preferred world-picture, not a metaphysical model that genuinely requires discussion. Therefore this chapter cannot merely say that brute fact is unsatisfactory. It must ask whether dissatisfaction is enough to count as a philosophical reason.

What the Doctrine of Closure may concede is clear: it cannot prove that all rational subjects must accept the question of ultimate ground, nor may it impose a strong principle of sufficient reason without limit upon every fallen leaf, every quantum event, and every local contingency. If the anti-PSR theorist completely rejects the need for ultimate explanation, the Doctrine of Closure cannot declare that party logically defeated. If this point is not admitted, the whole book will mistake its own rational need for an obligation of the world.²⁹⁷

²⁹⁴The method of this chapter follows five steps: strongest version of the opponent, vital line struck, possible concession, irreducible bottom line, and postwar correction. The four great opponents are not decorative objections, but the final tribunal of the whole book.

²⁹⁵On the principle of sufficient reason and ultimate explanation, see G. W. Leibniz, 'Monadology,' secs. 31-32; Yitzhak Melamed, 'Principle of Sufficient Reason,' *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. This thesis adopts the narrower principle of ground-qualification, not an unrestricted PSR.

²⁹⁶David Hume, *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, secs. 4-7, represents a classic skeptical background concerning causality, necessary connection, and the limits of rational inference. This thesis does not take Hume as the sole source of anti-PSR, but uses him as one skeptical pressure among others.

²⁹⁷On brute fact and metaphysical explanation, see Kelly Trogdon, 'An Introduction to Grounding,' in *Metaphysical Grounding*; Andrew Brenner, 'Metaphysical Explanation'; and Bliss and Trogdon, 'Metaphysical Grounding,' *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*.

Yet where the Doctrine of Closure cannot retreat is equally clear. It does not claim that all local events must have transparent reasons. It claims that wherever a theory still uses the position called 'ultimate ground,' that position cannot continue to maintain itself by an unexplained external outsourcing. In other words, the minimal claim of the Doctrine of Closure is not 'all things must have reasons,' but 'if something is placed in the position of ultimate ground, it cannot still borrow external conditions of establishment as ordinary local things do.' This is a narrower principle of ground-qualification.

Brute fact can serve as an epistemological decision to stop inquiry, but it has difficulty explaining positively why this stopping point itself has ultimate qualification. If the final fact is simply 'so it is,' then the difference between existence and nothingness is placed upon a reasonless halt. The Doctrine of Closure does not say this is certainly impossible. It says only that if we still require ultimate ground to be not an arbitrary stop but something capable of bearing the responsibility of establishment, brute fact does not provide a sufficiently thick grammar of ground.

After anti-PSR, therefore, the Doctrine of Closure must be downgraded. It can no longer be written as 'all worlds must accept closure.' It should be written as a conditional thesis: if we refuse brute fact as ultimate placement, and if we also refuse the infinite outsourcing of conditions of establishment, then ultimate ground must at least have some non-outsourcing internal recovery of conditions. Closure is the priority candidate for such internal recovery, preservation of difference, and local return. Here 'priority' does not mean exclusive proof; it means a judgment of explanatory power.

II. Grounding Pressure: Does Closure Smuggle in Self-Grounding?

Anti-PSR attacks the demand for explanation; grounding pressure attacks the grammar of closure. Even if we provisionally accept the question of ultimate ground, analytic metaphysics will still ask: is closure saying that a thing is the ground of itself? If so, it bears the suspicion of self-grounding and violates the familiar requirements of irreflexivity and asymmetry in grounding relations.²⁹⁸

This problem cannot be solved by saying only that 'closure is not circular fallacy.' Circularity in logical inference and self-grounding in metaphysical grounding belong to different levels, yet both can make the reader suspect that the Doctrine of Closure has merely turned the problem of outsourcing into an internal circle. If an entity U grounds U, the analytic philosopher has good reason to reject it, for this destroys the directionality of dependence.²⁹⁹

²⁹⁸ Kit Fine, 'The Question of Realism,' *Philosophers' Imprint* 1.1 (2001): 1-30; Kit Fine, 'Guide to Ground,' in *Metaphysical Grounding*. This thesis borrows grounding grammar to clarify that closure is not the self-grounding of a single object.

²⁹⁹ Gideon Rosen, 'Metaphysical Dependence: Grounding and Reduction,' in *Modality: Metaphysics, Logic, and Epistemology*. Criticism based on irreflexivity and asymmetry is analytic-metaphysical pressure that the Doctrine of Closure must face directly.

Here the Doctrine of Closure must state the matter plainly: closure is not U grounds U, but the closure-condition of the grounding field. It does not claim that one local node becomes its own ground at the same level. It asks whether, after all local grounding relations are taken together, the whole field of establishment still requires an unexplained condition outside itself. If it still does, the field is not sealed. Only if the conditions of establishment can be recovered within the whole does it become a candidate for ultimate ground.

Here grounding theory is both an opponent and an indirect resource for dialogue. It is an opponent because it compels the Doctrine of Closure to avoid reflexive grounding. It is a dialogical resource because it supplies a more precise grammar, allowing the Doctrine of Closure not to remain a circular image. What the Doctrine of Closure truly discusses is not an object supporting itself, but a field of establishment whose total boundary no longer lies open to the outside.

Schaffer's priority monism may also serve here as an indirect resource for dialogue. It cannot prove the Doctrine of Closure, but it can weaken the intuition that the local precedes the whole and that the whole is merely a collection of local items. If the whole can be prior to its parts in some metaphysical contexts, the Doctrine of Closure need not be deemed absurd at the outset. Yet the Doctrine of Closure adds one further requirement beyond priority monism: the whole must not only be prior, but also capable of recovering its own conditions of establishment while allowing local differences to unfold and return within it.³⁰⁰

The postwar correction is this: the Doctrine of Closure is narrowed from a declaration of self-establishment into a model of field-sealing in establishment. It no longer says that one thing supports itself. It says that if ultimate ground is still meaningful, then the whole field of establishment must no longer outsource its qualification. Such a formulation will still be questioned by analytic metaphysics, but it at least avoids the crudest criticism of self-grounding.

III. Many-Worlds and Scientific Multiplicity: Is Uniqueness Too Single-Lined?

The second opponent comes from philosophy of science and quantum interpretation. The pressure of Everettian Many-Worlds is not that it has become the final settlement of physics, but that it offers a serious picture of branching reality: if the evolution of the quantum state need not involve a single collapse, and may be understood through branch-structure under the universal wavefunction, then the early language of the Doctrine of Closure concerning one path, unique destiny, and a global storyline must be reexamined.³⁰¹

The vital line struck by Many-Worlds is the early imagination of uniqueness in the Doctrine of Closure. If the Doctrine of Closure is written as if the whole universe has only one imaginable script, then once a branching picture of reality is accepted it will appear too narrow. Especially if the language of destiny in Chapter Eight remains a single linear story, the reader will ask: if all branches are real in some sense, which one is the closure? Does destiny apply only to a local reading?

The first concession of the Doctrine of Closure is to admit that scientific materials cannot be absorbed by it as supporting evidence. Bell's theorem, quantum entanglement, the problem of measurement, and Many-Worlds cannot be used to prove First Consciousness, God, or closure. At most they provide limitation, compatibility, analogy, and pressure. The function of Many-Worlds, in particular, is to force the Doctrine of Closure to rewrite uniqueness, not to endorse the Doctrine of Closure.³⁰²

The second concession is to abandon a crude global single-line narrative. What the Doctrine of Closure truly cannot surrender is not 'the whole universe can have only one storyline,' but 'whatever is successfully established cannot arbitrarily outsource its own conditions of establishment.' Therefore uniqueness should be moved from the level of story to the level of qualification: the principle of closure is unique, but successful closures may be multiple; within each successful closure there remains its own path of completion and structure of condition-recovery.³⁰³

This transformation is not evasion, but necessary theoretical maturity. If there are multiple successful closures or multiple branches, we still must ask whether each branch possesses complete establishment-qualification. If they are wholly unrelated, this thesis must explain why the same principle of closure can apply to all; if they share higher-order conditions, the question of the highest closure reappears. Many-Worlds therefore has not been defeated by the

³⁰⁰ Jonathan Schaffer, 'On What Grounds What,' in *Metametaphysics*; Schaffer, 'Monism: The Priority of the Whole,' *Philosophical Review* 119.1 (2010): 31-76. Priority monism functions here as an indirect ally, not as proof of the Doctrine of Closure.

³⁰¹ Hugh Everett III, 'Relative State Formulation of Quantum Mechanics,' *Reviews of Modern Physics* 29.3 (1957): 454-462; Lev Vaidman, 'Many-Worlds Interpretation of Quantum Mechanics,' *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*.

³⁰² Wayne Myrvold, 'Philosophical Issues in Quantum Theory,' *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*; Myrvold, 'Bell's Theorem,' *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Quantum materials are used here only as philosophy-of-science pressure, not as the main proof of ontology.

³⁰³ John S. Bell, 'On the Einstein Podolsky Rosen Paradox,' *Physics Physique Fizika* 1.3 (1964): 195-200. Bell's theorem constrains local hidden-variable pictures, but cannot directly prove First Consciousness, God, or closure.

Doctrine of Closure. It has forced the Doctrine of Closure to upgrade 'the unique' from a single-line picture of the universe into a stratified question of qualification-criterion and path of completion.³⁰⁴

Destiny and freedom are consequently corrected as well. Destiny no longer means that the whole has only one imaginable script. It means that within each successful closure, the conditions of establishment finally cannot scatter arbitrarily outward. The local subject can form reasons, bear consequences, and countersign its own actions only within its own branch, position, and history. Even if the total picture allows branching, ethical responsibility does not vanish, because responsibility occurs on the readable path actually borne and acted within by the local subject.

The postwar correction is this: the Doctrine of Closure is upgraded from a geometry of a single universe into a theory of multiple closure-qualifications. It may still insist that the principle of closure is unique, but it no longer crudely equates uniqueness with global single-linearity. This correction preserves the core while admitting the long-term pressure of scientific multiplicity.

IV. Barth and Revelatory Freedom: Has God Been Absorbed into a Philosophical System?

The third opponent is Barth. Barth's pressure is not merely opposition to natural theology, nor simple dislike of philosophy. Its true strength is this: God cannot be grasped in advance by human religious consciousness, cosmic principle, or metaphysical system; God appears in free revelation and makes Himself manifest in Jesus Christ. If the Doctrine of Closure first establishes ultimate ground and then places God as First Consciousness, Barth will ask whether God has already been enclosed within a system of human reason.³⁰⁵

This criticism strikes the theological legitimacy of 'God as First Consciousness' and 'Jesus as the highest manifestation.' Chapter Five names God as First Consciousness, and Chapter Seventeen further understands Jesus as the highest manifestation; but Barth's pressure requires this thesis to admit that the philosophical naming of God derived from metaphysics cannot replace the free God of revelation. Otherwise, the God of Christianity is reduced to an internal function of the Doctrine of Closure.

The first point the Doctrine of Closure can preserve is that it does not reduce God to an external engineer of the universe. Tillich's language of ground of being can serve as an indirect resource for dialogue, for it likewise refuses to understand God as the highest being within the world. If the Doctrine of Closure understands God as the

³⁰⁴ The statement that the closure-principle is unique while successful closures may be multiple is a metaphysical-level correction, not a conclusion of quantum physics. It only responds to the pressure on uniqueness created by Many-Worlds.

³⁰⁵ Karl Barth, *Church Dogmatics* I/1, secs. 1-4. Barth's pressure is not merely opposition to some theological phrasing, but opposition to the attempt of human metaphysical systems to grasp God's free revelation in advance.

primordial presence of ultimate ground, it is at least closer than popular design theory to the direction in philosophical theology that says God is not an object.³⁰⁶

Aquinas and Augustine can also serve as indirect resources for dialogue. Self-subsistent being, dependence in creation, and the non-simply-physical treatment of time and creation all prevent the Doctrine of Closure from lacking any theological language to connect with. Yet they also limit the Doctrine of Closure, for classical theology does not exist in order to prove that First Consciousness is identical with the closed-loop whole. These materials may only provide dialogical background; they must not be crudely absorbed.³⁰⁷

What the Doctrine of Closure must concede is revelatory freedom. It cannot say that it has completed orthodox Christian theology. God as First Consciousness is an entrance into philosophical theology; Jesus as the highest manifestation is a high-risk Christological extension; the repeated manifestation of the same Jesus is the author's strong position, but not a conclusion already completed by the history of doctrine. Incarnation, cross, resurrection, Trinity, and eschaton still require external examination by biblical studies, history of doctrine, and systematic theology.³⁰⁸

Yet what the Doctrine of Closure cannot surrender is that it must not grind religious language down into pure metaphor. If First Consciousness is merely a poetic name, if God is only humanity's feeling toward the whole, if Jesus as highest manifestation is merely an ethical symbol, then the religious-philosophical edge of the Doctrine of Closure disappears. This thesis preserves its strong position: First Consciousness, as the primordial presence of ultimate ground, may be philosophically named God; Jesus may be understood as the highest manifestation of the whole within the local, as self-limitation in person, and as personal manifestation of truth. These theses, however, must be marked as strong-version extensions, not as the minimal core.³⁰⁹

Therefore the postwar correction after Barth is this: the Doctrine of Closure may preserve the philosophical naming of God, but must renounce the absorption of revelatory theology; it may preserve Jesus as the highest manifestation, but must admit that this requires theological testing; it may preserve the translation of religious symbols, but cannot press the history of doctrine into a subordinate chapter of its own system. Barth is not a dialogical resource digested by the Doctrine of Closure, but a theological speed-limiter retained within the text.³¹⁰

V. Prajna-Madhyamaka: Is Ultimate Qualification Still a New Self-Nature?

The fourth opponent should stand at the end, because it does not attack only one local thesis of the Doctrine of Closure, but the whole language of ultimacy. Prajna-Madhyamaka refuses everything fixed as self-nature. It opposes not only ordinary substances, but also the freezing of the highest concept, ultimate ground, First Consciousness, and closure-qualification into a final ontology that can be grasped. The vital line it strikes is whether the Doctrine of Closure preserves a new great self under the name of 'ultimate qualification.'³¹¹

The strongest version of Madhyamaka does not simply say that 'all is empty,' nor does it offer a new ontology for the Doctrine of Closure to absorb. Its true pressure is deconstructive: whatever is called self-subsistent, ultimate, unanalyzable, or graspable must be asked about its conditionality and relationality. If closure-qualification depends upon conceptual distinction, relational structure, and a grammar of conditions, can it still be written as a fixed final point?³¹²

What the Doctrine of Closure may concede is that 'the ultimate' must be downgraded into language of qualification. Closure is not a great object that can be pointed to, possessed, or worshipped. It is a criterion for whether conditions of establishment can be recovered within the whole. First Consciousness likewise should not be written as a gigantic subject sitting behind the world; it should be understood as the problem of primordial presence faced if ultimate

³⁰⁶ Paul Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, vol. 1. Tillich's language of 'ground of being' can serve as an indirect ally of the Doctrine of Closure, but it cannot replace Barth's criticism concerning revelatory freedom.

³⁰⁷ Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* I, qq. 3, 44-45, may be used as classical background for self-subsistent being and dependence in creation. This thesis does not identify itself directly with the Thomistic route.

³⁰⁸ John 1:14 and Philippians 2:6-8 may serve as Christian background for incarnation and self-limitation language. The thesis of Jesus as highest manifestation remains a high-risk religious-philosophical extension.

³⁰⁹ On Trinity, person, and relation, see Karl Rahner, *The Trinity*; Jürgen Moltmann, *The Trinity and the Kingdom*; Colin Gunton, *The Promise of Trinitarian Theology*. The functional mapping in Chapters Twelve and Thirteen cannot replace orthodox Trinitarian theology.

³¹⁰ The repeated manifestation of the same Jesus is, in this thesis, the author's strong-version position: it preserves the uniqueness of the highest manifestation while allowing reappearance in different closures, histories, or local readings. This thesis still requires examination by biblical studies, history of doctrine, and systematic theology.

³¹¹ Nagarjuna, *Mulamadhyamakakarika*, ch. 24, especially 24:18; Jay L. Garfield, *The Fundamental Wisdom of the Middle Way*. Madhyamaka functions here not as supporting evidence, but as the strongest anti-reification opponent.

³¹² Mark Siderits, *Buddhism as Philosophy*, may serve as background for Buddhist no-self, emptiness, and philosophical analysis. This thesis does not directly rewrite Buddhist materials as synonyms for the Doctrine of Closure.

ground is not merely a dead structure. This narrowing prevents the Doctrine of Closure from standing in simple opposition to emptiness.³¹³

Yet the danger left by Madhyamaka remains real. Language of qualification can itself be ontologized; 'internal recovery of conditions' can be imagined as a final possession; 'First Consciousness' is still more liable to slide toward great self. If later parts of this thesis write First Consciousness, God, the whole, and closure as unquestionable substantial centers, then Madhyamaka is not an external criticism but a direct dismantling of the basic language of this theory.³¹⁴

Therefore the Buddhist differentiation established in Chapter Eighteen must be retained here. The Agamas and early Buddhism can help one understand suffering, ignorance, clinging, and liberation; Yogacara can help one understand manifestation, consciousness, and the conversion between delusion and awakening; Huayan can supply imagery of mutual containment in the whole; Buddha-nature and Chan can supply language of never having originally departed and of awakening. Yet none of these may be written as Buddhist support for the Doctrine of Closure. The true final pressure remains Madhyamaka: it requires the Doctrine of Closure to remain permanently alert to its own tendency toward reification.

The postwar correction after Madhyamaka is this: the Doctrine of Closure can no longer stand as a complete grand ontology. It should become a model of ground-qualification constrained by anti-reification pressure. It preserves the question of ultimate ground, because it is unwilling to abandon the inquiry into how existence is not left suspended; yet it must admit that once this inquiry is written as a graspable substance, Madhyamaka pierces it. This is the final and deepest self-limitation of Chapter Nineteen.

³¹³ The Heart Sutra and Diamond Sutra are used in this thesis only as backgrounds for the language of emptiness and anti-clinging. Without passage-by-passage location, they are not used as precise textual proof.

³¹⁴ Here the ultimate is narrowed into language of qualification in order to respond to Madhyamaka pressure; however, qualification-language itself may still be reified, so vigilance must be preserved.

VI. How the Four Great Opponents Check One Another

The four great opponents are not isolated pressures. Their importance lies in the fact that they jointly limit the Doctrine of Closure from four directions. Anti-PSR prevents the Doctrine of Closure from expanding explanatory demand without limit; Many-Worlds prevents it from writing uniqueness as an overly narrow single-line universe; Barth prevents it from swallowing theology into a metaphysical system; Madhyamaka prevents it from reifying ultimate ground, First Consciousness, and closure-qualification. Together, they force the Doctrine of Closure to move from declaration into a theory capable of examination.

This mutual checking also prevents the Doctrine of Closure from shifting pressure-fields. Before anti-PSR, religious intuition cannot substitute for reasons of explanation; before Many-Worlds, ethical responsibility or theological destiny cannot evade the pressure of quantum interpretation; before Barth, ground-of-being language cannot dissolve revelatory freedom; before Madhyamaka, theological or consciousness-language cannot escape anti-self-nature dismantling. Each opponent must be answered in its own field.³¹⁵

If the Doctrine of Closure faced only anti-PSR, it might remain inside analytic metaphysics; if it faced only Many-Worlds, it might wrongly think the problem were merely scientific multiplicity; if it faced only Barth, it might treat theology as an external religious dispute; if it faced only Madhyamaka, it might retreat too far into anti-ontology and lose its own problem-consciousness of ground. Only when all four appear together is the Doctrine of Closure forced to deal with all of its vital lines.

Therefore the achievement of Chapter Nineteen is not that 'the Doctrine of Closure defeats the four great opponents.' More accurately, the Doctrine of Closure is shaped by them. Without anti-PSR, it would write the demand for explanation too fully; without Many-Worlds, it would write uniqueness too narrowly; without Barth, it would write theology too smoothly; without Madhyamaka, it would write the ultimate too substantially. The opponents are not supplementary materials; they are pressure mechanisms of theoretical maturity.

VII. The Minimal Version after the Four Great Pressures

After compression by the four great opponents, the minimal version still preservable by the Doctrine of Closure must be written narrowly. It does not include the pre-cyclical narrative, the Trinitarian algorithm, the repeated manifestation of Jesus, or the full strong version of First Consciousness. It says only this: if existence is still placed under the question of ultimate ground, and if we are unwilling to stop at brute fact or to let conditions of establishment be outsourced infinitely, then ultimate ground must at least possess some internal recovery of

³¹⁵ The 'postwar correction' named here is the total result of Chapters Fifteen to Eighteen: the Doctrine of Closure does not defeat its opponents, but narrows itself under their pressure.

conditions. Closure is the candidate model that at present can best handle internal recovery, difference, and return at once.³¹⁶

This minimal version does not prove that the world must have closure, nor does it prove that all people must reject brute fact. It only states, on the premise that the question of ultimate ground is retained, why non-outsourcing, internal recovery of conditions, and the capacity for return have high explanatory power. It is a strong candidate, not a final theorem; a model open to objection, not an image of faith immune from opposition.

In the minimal version, First Consciousness can only be preserved as a problem, not as a theorem. The dead-structure model still bears explanatory cost before first-person presence, the pursuit of truth, value-experience, and local return; therefore First Consciousness has a reasonable position as a candidate for best explanation. Yet it has not been deductively proven, nor may it be proven backward from scientific, religious, or Buddhist materials.³¹⁷

³¹⁶The minimal version here does not include the pre-cyclical epoch, the Trinitarian algorithm, or the repeated manifestation of Jesus. It retains only the non-outsourcing of ultimate ground and internal recovery of conditions.

³¹⁷Thomas Nagel, 'What Is It Like to Be a Bat?' *Philosophical Review* 83.4 (1974): 435-450; David J. Chalmers, *The Conscious Mind*. First-person presence is an important background for the strong version of First Consciousness, but cannot directly prove First Consciousness.

VIII. The Strong Version Must Still Be Preserved

Although the minimal version is narrow, Chapter Nineteen must not trim the Doctrine of Closure into a safe short paper. The author's original position should remain: First Consciousness is identical with God; First Consciousness has will, purpose, the tendency toward abiding, self-understanding, and broad love; the principle of closure is unique though successful closures may be multiple; the same Jesus may manifest repeatedly; Madhyamaka may be partly received but must not be absorbed; the victim must not be silenced. These theses cannot be ground down, otherwise the whole text loses its soul.³¹⁸

The truly mature method is stratification, not withdrawal. The minimal version of First Consciousness is opposition to a wholly presence-less dead structure; the intermediate version is the claim that ultimate ground possesses primordial presence; the strong version is will, purpose, and broad love. God as First Consciousness is an entrance into philosophical theology; Jesus as highest manifestation and the repeated manifestation of the same Jesus are Christological extensions that carry serious cost. If all claims are written on the same level, the theory is overfull; if all are downgraded into metaphor, the theory is too weak.

Scientific materials must likewise be stratified. Bell's theorem can limit local hidden-variable pictures, but cannot prove the First Consciousness of the whole. Many-Worlds can force uniqueness to be stratified, but cannot prove multiple closures. Plant signaling, slime-mold memory, self-organization, and non-neural cognition can weaken crude dead-structure intuitions, but cannot yield subjective presence. The more attractive scientific materials are, the more tightly they must be kept within the four levels of limitation, compatibility, analogy, and pressure.³¹⁹

Buddhist materials must not overstep either. The Agamas, Yogacara, Huayan, Buddha-nature, and Chan can provide dialogue, imagery, awakening-language, and anti-reification pressure; but so long as they have not been located passage by passage, they may not serve as precise textual evidence. Especially with the Heart Sutra, Diamond Sutra, Samyukta Agama, Lankavatara Sutra, Avatamsaka Sutra, and Mahaparinirvana Sutra, unless version, passage, and context are verified, they can only be used as background and critical examination.³²⁰

Theological materials must preserve a double posture. The Doctrine of Closure may propose the philosophical naming of God and Jesus as the highest manifestation, but it cannot claim to have completed orthodox Christian theology. Any further advance must accept long-term examination by biblical studies, history of doctrine, revelation theology, Christology, and Trinitarian theology. Otherwise, the strong version becomes theological overreach.³²¹

³¹⁸The strong version here preserves the author's position, but its argumentative strength must be marked as lower than that of the core qualification-theses.

³¹⁹Scientific materials in this thesis are divided into four levels: limitation, compatibility, analogy, and pressure. Any move that elevates them into direct proof of God, First Consciousness, or salvation is methodologically overreaching.

³²⁰Where Buddhist base texts have not been located passage by passage, they can only function as background and critical examination. Page numbers, sutra numbers, or passage locations must not be invented.

³²¹If theological materials have not entered detailed biblical studies, history of doctrine, and systematic theology, they can only function as an entrance into religious philosophy. They cannot claim that orthodox theology has been completed.

IX. The Four-Level Verdict

Chapter Nineteen should finally give a four-level verdict. The first level consists of what has been defended: if ultimate ground is still discussed, it cannot simply let its own conditions of establishment be outsourced infinitely; closure, as a model of internal recovery of conditions, still has high explanatory power; the local cannot be directly promoted into an ultimately self-subsisting thing; and the ethical level cannot be canceled by the ontological level.

The second level consists of what may provisionally be defended: First Consciousness as a candidate explanation of primordial presence; the uniqueness of the closure-principle and the possible multiplicity of successful closures; countersigned freedom as responsibility within destiny; religious symbol as ontological translation; Buddhist and scientific materials as external pressure and dialogue. These theses may be retained, but they cannot be written as fully proven.

The third level consists of what must be downgraded: the will, purpose, and broad love of First Consciousness; Jesus as highest manifestation and the repeated manifestation of the same Jesus; the pre-cyclical epoch, the devil, and the algorithmic restatement of the six days of creation; closure-readings of Buddha-nature, Huayan, and Madhyamaka; and the analogical use of Bell, Many-Worlds, plants, slime mold, and other scientific materials. They still have intellectual value, but must be explicitly marked as strong-version extension, symbolic translation, or boundary material.³²²

The fourth level consists of what is left for researchers: how First Consciousness faces physicalism, emergentism, panpsychism, and cosmopsychism; whether multiple successful closures share higher-order total conditions; how the repeated manifestation of the same Jesus could be connected with orthodox Christology; whether Madhyamaka would still regard language of qualification as reification; and how the non-silencing of victims can be more rigorously preserved under extreme evil and theodicy.³²³

X. Final Confirmation of the Ethical Boundary

Among the four major opponents, none is directly identical with the victim-boundary of Chapter Nine; nevertheless Chapter Nineteen must preserve it as a hard boundary of the whole book. If the Doctrine of Closure says at the ontological level that pain is structural cost, this does not mean that the concrete ethical level may cancel injury, judgment, punishment, compensation, and memory. Rape, murder, torture, enslavement, betrayal, and systemic exploitation cannot lose the name of evil merely because they are included within closure.³²⁴

Victims have no obligation to complete reconciliation for the sake of a theory. If broad love is used to demand that victims let go, if destiny is used to exempt wrongdoers from responsibility, if theodicy is used to assign a meaning to every trauma, then the Doctrine of Closure fails at the ethical level. If the whole's self-love is truly to stand, it must at the same time love truth, boundary, memory, and the victim's refusal; it cannot love only order, return, and completion.

This ethical boundary also limits the strong version of First Consciousness. If First Consciousness has broad love, that love cannot be merely abstract affirmation of the whole. It must appear on the local level as not silencing victims, not excusing perpetrators, and not turning forgiveness into obligation. Repentance can stand, because evil is not a second ontology; but repentance cannot cancel accountability, nor can it require victims to confirm the perpetrator's return through forgiveness.

³²² This conclusion places preservation of a strong position alongside acknowledgment of revisability in order to avoid two extremes: an overconfident victory declaration, and a safe text that loses its soul.

³²³ The purpose of listing unfinished tasks is not to weaken the text, but to clarify the path of future research. A doctoral-level conclusion should not declare all questions solved in advance.

³²⁴ The non-silencing of victims is here a hard criterion at the ethical level: language of whole, destiny, broad love, theodicy, and liberation must not require victims to remain silent.

XI. General Gathering before the Conclusion

After the four great opponents, the Doctrine of Closure should no longer speak as if a complete system had been accomplished. Its more accurate position is this: an ontological model of considerable risk, yet one now capable of receiving attack. Its value is not invincibility, but its willingness to place itself before anti-PSR, Many-Worlds, Barth, and Madhyamaka, and to let them correct its language.

This position is not retreat. On the contrary, it is stronger than a victory declaration. A victory declaration easily conceals unfinished problems; a model open to objection lets the reader see clearly the theory's core, extensions, symbols, and boundaries. If the Doctrine of Closure can stand in the future, it will not be because it evades opposition, but because it can narrow itself, correct itself, preserve necessary edge, and relinquish excessive claims under opposition.

XII. The Four-Question Structure: How Chapter Nineteen Compresses the Whole Book back into Its Core

After the four great opponents, the whole text cannot be left with four groups of refutations only. It must be pressed back into four most basic questions. First, why still pursue ultimate ground? This question is continuously pressured by anti-PSR and brute fact. Second, if ultimate ground is pursued, why does closure have greater explanatory power than brute fact, infinite outsourcing, or static monism? This question is pressured by grounding, priority monism, and the criticism of self-grounding. Third, if closure is established, why is First Consciousness still needed? This question is jointly pressured by physicalism, emergentism, illusionism, and cosmopsychism. Fourth, if First Consciousness is named God, how can religious and Buddhist materials avoid being swallowed by it? This question is jointly pressured by Barth and Madhyamaka.

These four questions cannot replace one another. If religious experience answers the first question, the problem of ultimate ground is theologized too early. If scientific materials answer the second question, compatibility is mistaken for proof. If ethical settledness answers the third question, the effect upon life is mistaken for proof in philosophy of mind. If Buddhist or Christian symbols answer the fourth question, external pressure is absorbed as internal ornament. Chapter Nineteen is necessary precisely because each question demands an answer within its own field.

The final answer to the first question can only be conditional: the Doctrine of Closure does not force all philosophical positions to accept the question of ultimate ground; but as long as a theory remains unwilling to leave existence at brute fact and unwilling to outsource its conditions of establishment infinitely, it needs some criterion of ground-qualification. The Doctrine of Closure does not force anti-PSR to surrender from the outside. It preserves a route of high explanatory power outside the refusal of anti-PSR.

The final answer to the second question is closure's threefold qualification: internal recovery, difference, and return. Internal recovery prevents ultimate ground from borrowing its conditions of establishment outward; difference prevents the whole from degenerating into a contentless dead one; return prevents the local from scattering into fragments that cannot be gathered. If a better sealing model for the grounding field appears in the future, the Doctrine of Closure must accept comparison. At present, however, closure remains a strong candidate capable of handling these three demands together.

The third question is the most fragile. The Doctrine of Closure preserves First Consciousness because the dead structure still bears explanatory debt before first-person presence, the pursuit of truth, value-experience, and self-return. Yet First Consciousness must not therefore be written as already proven. It should be positioned as a strong candidate within inference to the best explanation: retainable but not absolutely unconditional; developable, but not to be smuggled in by religious or scientific materials.

The fourth question is the most dangerous. Theological and Buddhist materials can make the Doctrine of Closure appear deep, but they are also the easiest to swallow crudely. Barth requires the Doctrine of Closure to admit that God's free revelation cannot be prescribed in advance by philosophy. Madhyamaka requires the Doctrine of Closure to admit that ultimate language cannot harden again into self-nature. Together, these two limit all strong-version extensions in Chapters Twelve, Thirteen, Seventeen, and Eighteen.

XIII. A Table of What Must Not Be Claimed: Preventing the Final Chapter from Becoming Victory Rhetoric

Chapter Nineteen must explicitly list what cannot be claimed. First, it cannot say that the Doctrine of Closure has proven the existence of God. It can only say that if ultimate ground is not merely dead structure, First Consciousness has high explanatory power as primordial presence. As for God as the God of Christianity, that still requires examination by revelation, personhood, the Christ-event, and the history of doctrine.

Second, it cannot say that science supports the Doctrine of Closure. Bell's theorem, Many-Worlds, quantum entanglement, self-organization, plant signaling, slime-mold learning, and non-equilibrium chemistry can function only within the four levels of compatibility, limitation, analogy, and pressure. Any move that turns scientific materials into direct proof of First Consciousness, God, destiny, salvation, or the closure-principle is overreach.

Third, it cannot say that Buddhism is actually the Doctrine of Closure. Buddhism is internally differentiated to a very high degree: the Agamas, Yogacara, Huayan, Buddha-nature, Chan, and Madhyamaka have different functions. Prajna-Madhyamaka in particular is not a dialogical resource of the Doctrine of Closure, but its strongest anti-reification pressure. To rewrite emptiness as closure is to swallow an opponent as supporting evidence, which would directly damage the scholarly value of Chapter Eighteen.

Fourth, it cannot say that Christian orthodoxy has been completed by the Doctrine of Closure. The Doctrine of Closure may propose God as First Consciousness, Jesus as highest manifestation, the repeated manifestation of the same Jesus, stratified revelation, and translation of resurrection; yet these remain religious-philosophical extensions, not settled orthodox theology. They may be preserved as the author's position, but their theological cost must be admitted.

Fifth, it cannot say that the suffering of victims is merely a necessary cost of the whole. If such a sentence appears without ethical restriction, the Doctrine of Closure destroys itself at the very boundary established in Chapter Nine. Language of the whole can provide background, but it cannot excuse concrete evil. Language of liberation may explain the transformation of suffering, but it cannot demand that victims cease to accuse.

Sixth, it cannot say that the four great opponents have been solved. Anti-PSR may still reject the demand for ultimate explanation; Many-Worlds may still force uniqueness to continue being stratified; Barth may still ask whether God has been absorbed into the system; Madhyamaka may still ask whether First Consciousness has again become self-nature. The maturity of Chapter Nineteen lies not in declaring their failure, but in preserving them as pressure sources for future research.

XIV. The Strong Position after the Four Pressures

To admit these limits, does not mean that the Doctrine of Closure becomes weak. On the contrary, the position that can still be retained after pressure is the truly strong position. This thesis still says that if ultimate ground is not outsourced, closure is a candidate of high explanatory power; still says that the strong version of First Consciousness is worth preserving; still says that God as First Consciousness is the core philosophical naming of this theory; still says that Jesus as highest manifestation is not a poetic symbol that may be deleted at will; still says that the victim must not be silenced is the hard ethical boundary of the whole book.

Strong position and revisability are not contradictory. A strong position that cannot be revised becomes dogma; revisability without strong position becomes empty compromise. The narrow path the Doctrine of Closure must walk is to preserve its risky judgments while marking the level, opponent, and unfinished task of each risk. First Consciousness must face philosophy of mind; Jesus as highest manifestation must face Christology; Madhyamaka pressure must face Buddhist philosophy; Many-Worlds must face philosophy of science; the victim-boundary must face theodicy and ethics.

This also explains why the conclusion cannot grind away the author's position. If First Consciousness is ground down into a vague principle, if God is turned into pure metaphor, if Jesus as highest manifestation is reduced to an ordinary symbol, if Madhyamaka is absorbed into a footnote of the Doctrine of Closure, if the non-silencing of victims becomes a passing reminder, then even if the text becomes safer, it has already departed from its true intellectual core. The task of Chapter Nineteen is not to make the theory riskless, but to mark its risks clearly.

XV. Detailed Table of Attack and Defense by the Four Major Opponents

The first attack and defense is anti-PSR's interrogation of the need for ultimate ground. Its attacking sentence may be written as: by what right do you require the world to account for itself? The danger for the Doctrine of Closure is that it inflates human rational unease into a cosmic obligation. If this attack completely succeeds, Chapter One of the Doctrine of Closure must be downgraded into private problem-consciousness rather than a metaphysical entrance. What the Doctrine of Closure may concede is that it cannot require everyone to accept strong PSR. What it cannot concede is that as long as a theory still uses the position of ultimate ground, that position cannot still support itself through unexplained outsourcing. The postwar version is a principle of ground-qualification, not an unrestricted principle of sufficient reason.

The second attack and defense is Many-Worlds' interrogation of uniqueness and destiny. Its attacking sentence may be written as: if the cosmic picture itself may branch, is your unique closure only an outdated storyline? If this attack completely succeeds, the destiny of Chapter Eight and the uniqueness of Chapter Eleven must be substantially rewritten. What the Doctrine of Closure may concede is that a global single-line narrative cannot be defended rigidly. What it cannot concede is that every successful existent must still deal with how its conditions of establishment are internally recovered. The postwar version is this: the principle of closure is unique, successful closures may be multiple, and each successful closure has its own path of completion.

The third attack and defense is Barth's interrogation of the philosophical naming of God. Its attacking sentence may be written as: you call First Consciousness God, but is this not absorbing the free God of revelation into a metaphysical system? If this attack completely succeeds, the theological extensions of Chapters Five and Seventeen can only retreat into philosophical metaphor. What the Doctrine of Closure may concede is that it cannot derive complete Christian theology from metaphysics. What it cannot concede is that if God is not an external engineer of the universe but the primordial presence of ultimate ground, the Doctrine of Closure still has a strong right of naming in religious philosophy. The postwar version is that the philosophical naming of God is preserved, while revelatory theology must not be swallowed.

The fourth attack and defense is Madhyamaka's interrogation of ultimate language. Its attacking sentence may be written as: you call the ultimate a qualification, but is it still being treated as an indissoluble great self-nature? If this attack completely succeeds, closure, First Consciousness, and the naming of God will all be forced to descend into conceptual clinging. What the Doctrine of Closure may concede is that the ultimate cannot be written as a great ontology to be held. What it cannot concede is that it still preserves the problem-consciousness of how existence is not outsourced. The postwar version is this: the ultimate functions as qualifying language, closure as the criterion of internal recovery of conditions, and First Consciousness as a strong candidate awaiting verification, not as an unquestionable substantial center.

XVI. Separating the Minimal Version from the Strong Version

The most likely confusion in Chapter Nineteen is mixing the minimal version and the strong version into the same level. The minimal version needs only three steps: first, if existence cannot stop at brute fact; second, if the conditions of establishment cannot be infinitely outsourced; third, ultimate ground must possess some internal recovery of conditions. These three steps are already enough to constitute the basic skeleton of the Doctrine of Closure. It need not first prove the Trinity, Buddha-nature, scientific support, or the repeated manifestation of Jesus.

The strong version is entirely different. First Consciousness, will, purpose, broad love, God as First Consciousness, Jesus as highest manifestation, the pre-cyclical epoch, devilish residue, the creation algorithm, the repeated manifestation of the same Jesus, and the theory of multiple possible closures all belong to strong versions or extended versions. They should not be deleted, because they constitute the most original parts of this thesis; but neither should they be written as equally certain with the minimal version. Otherwise the four great opponents will pierce the entire system in a single blow.

Therefore the conclusion should adopt a two-level tone. Concerning the minimal version, the voice may be steady: closure, as a non-outsourcing model of ground-qualification, still has strong explanatory power. Concerning the strong version, the voice may be strong but must mark the risk: First Consciousness remains this thesis's most important metaphysical advance; God as First Consciousness remains the author's core naming; Jesus as highest manifestation remains the highest thesis of theological extension; but all of them must receive detailed proof from the corresponding fields. In this way the position is not weakened, and false completion is not claimed.

XVII. Recovering the Upgrades from Chapters Fifteen to Eighteen

The contribution of Chapter Fifteen to Chapter Nineteen is analytic-philosophical defense. It moves the Doctrine of Closure from intuitive self-establishment to the closure-condition of the grounding field. It compels the Doctrine of Closure to admit the reasonableness of the self-grounding criticism, and also teaches the Doctrine of Closure to speak in terms of internal recovery, field, and total boundary rather than a single object supporting itself. Without this chapter, Chapter Nineteen would face anti-PSR and grounding pressure too crudely.

The contribution of Chapter Sixteen to Chapter Nineteen is resistance at the scientific boundary. It divides scientific materials into limitation, compatibility, motivation, and pressure, thereby preventing Bell, Many-Worlds, plants, slime mold, and self-organization from being written as mystical corroborations. Without this chapter, Chapter Nineteen would face Many-Worlds by merely saying that science cannot prove metaphysics, rather than seriously treating the downgrading of uniqueness.

The contribution of Chapter Seventeen to Chapter Nineteen is theological self-limitation. It teaches the Doctrine of Closure that Tillich can be a resource for dialogue, while Barth is the real pressure; Augustine, Aquinas, Trinitarian theology, and Christology can provide language, but they cannot be swallowed by the Doctrine of Closure. Without this chapter, Chapter Nineteen would simplify revelatory freedom into the objection of theological conservatism and could not truly state its own concession before Barth.

The contribution of Chapter Eighteen to Chapter Nineteen is immunity against reification. It teaches the Doctrine of Closure that the Agamas, Yogacara, Huayan, Buddha-nature, and Chan all have dialogical uses, but Madhyamaka is the final opponent. Without this chapter, Chapter Nineteen would write Buddhism as vague support and thereby lose its most important critical force. What Madhyamaka leaves behind is not decoration, but the self-limitation that the whole Doctrine of Closure must bear for the long term.

XVIII. Two Errors the Conclusion Should Avoid

The first error is to write the end as total victory. This would nullify all the self-limitation established earlier in Chapter Nineteen, and make the reader feel that the four great opponents were arranged merely to highlight the Doctrine of Closure. If the four major opponents are all dissolved in a few sentences, the external examinations of Chapters Fifteen to Eighteen lose their weight.

The second error is to write the end as total retreat. This would grind the original theses of the whole work into a safe but powerless conceptual memorandum. The Doctrine of Closure does not merely want to say that perhaps existence has some structure. It proposes First Consciousness, the naming of God, local appearances, destiny, countersigned freedom, broad love, the pre-cyclical epoch, devilish residue, and the translation of religious symbols. If all these theses are withdrawn, the whole work becomes another ordinary short paper in metaphysics.

The proper conclusion should stand between the two: the core remains defensible, the strong version remains preserved, the levels are clear, the opponents remain, and unfinished tasks are made explicit. Such a conclusion is not the safest way to write, but it is the most honest way and the one that best preserves the soul of the text.



Conclusion

Conclusion

The Ultimate Standing of the Theory



This chapter gathers the argument of the whole work and states the ultimate standing of the Doctrine of Closure, its defensible version, and the theoretical risks it must still bear.

Conclusion The Ultimate Standing of the Theory

What this work has proposed is not a closed and final system, but an ontological account centered upon the qualification of ultimate ground. It begins from the question of how existence is not left suspended; it passes through closure, self-establishment, First Consciousness, local appearances, destiny and freedom, evil and the defense-line of victims, the scientific boundary, religious symbolism, theological examination, and Buddhist pressure; and it finally enters the general trial by the four great opponents. If it must be gathered into one sentence, the whole book asks this: if existence refuses to rest in brute fact, and also refuses infinite outsourcing, does it require some form of ultimate ground capable of recovering its conditions of establishment within itself?³²⁵

The answer of this thesis is limited and definite. Closure is not an exclusive answer already secured by formal proof; yet it is the strongest candidate presently available, because it handles three requirements at once: internal recovery, lest conditions of establishment be borrowed outward; difference, lest the whole collapse into a dead and silent One; and return, lest the local scatter into fragments no longer capable of being gathered. These three requirements together form the skeleton of the Doctrine of Closure.

I. The Main Contributions of This Thesis

The first contribution is to separate the problem of ultimate ground from the problem of the physical beginning of the cosmos. This thesis does not chiefly ask what happened before the Big Bang. It asks: even if all physical descriptions hold, by what qualification does the whole order of existence possess an establishment that no longer borrows outward? This shift places the Doctrine of Closure within analytic metaphysics, rather than leaving it within religious or cosmological intuition.

The second contribution is to raise closure from an intuitive image into a structure of qualification. Closure is not a metaphor in which the circle is beautiful. It is a model of ground-qualification composed of internal recovery of conditions, local difference, and final return. Its explanatory force exceeds brute fact and infinite outsourcing not because it satisfies a psychological need, but because it directly bears the non-outsourcing requirement of the position of ultimate ground.

The third contribution is to place First Consciousness at the center of the problem of ultimate ground. If ultimate ground is only a wholly blind dead structure, subjective presence, the pursuit of truth, value-experience, and self-return still leave an explanatory debt. First Consciousness is not the magnification of human consciousness, nor an ordinary personal deity; it is the name of ultimate ground as primordial presence. This thesis remains risky, but it is not an optional ornament.³²⁶

The fourth contribution is to preserve the double weight of the whole and the local. The local is not an ultimate self-subsistent being, but neither is it illusion or refuse. It is the site where the whole appears, suffers, misrecognizes, awakens, and returns. For this reason, the ethical level cannot be swallowed by the ontological level; suffering cannot be beautified by theodicy; victims must not be silenced.

The fifth contribution is to establish a layered account of the functions of cross-domain materials. Philosophical materials provide the grammar of the main argument; scientific materials provide boundary, compatibility, analogy, and pressure; theological materials test whether God, revelation, personhood, the Christ-event, and salvation have been swallowed by metaphysics; Buddhist materials provide the pressure of suffering, emptiness, no-self, and anti-reification. These four kinds of materials examine the Doctrine of Closure together; none of them may serve as simple endorsement.³²⁷

II. Six Locked Positions

The first locked position is the strong version of First Consciousness. This thesis cannot grind First Consciousness into a mere metaphor, nor reduce it to an ordinary cosmic mind. It still names the primordial presence of ultimate

³²⁵The final position of the Doctrine of Closure is an ontological model that is open to objection and revision while preserving a strong position, not a final answer that ends all philosophical, theological, Buddhist, and scientific debate.

³²⁶Thomas Nagel, 'What Is It Like to Be a Bat?' *Philosophical Review* 83.4 (1974): 435-450; David J. Chalmers, *The Conscious Mind*. First-person presence is an important background for the strong version of First Consciousness, but cannot directly prove First Consciousness.

³²⁷The five-level grading of 'core propositions,' 'strong candidate-propositions,' 'theological extensions,' 'symbolic translations,' and 'boundary materials' is the general method by which this conclusion prevents cross-domain materials from overstepping their functions.

ground, and, according to the author's position, preserves will, purpose, the tendency toward enduring existence, self-understanding, and broad love. Yet these expressions do not possess the same argumentative strength: primordial presence belongs to the core ontological candidate; will, purpose, and broad love belong to the strong version of First Consciousness and require further support from philosophy of mind, value theory, and philosophy of religion.³²⁸

The second locked position is that God is First Consciousness. What is called God is not, first of all, an external designer outside the cosmos, but the philosophical name for ultimate ground as primordial presence and whole-return. This allows the Doctrine of Closure to avoid popular design-theory; yet it also forces it to bear Barthian criticism. Therefore, at this point, one may only say that the Doctrine of Closure provides an entrance into philosophical theology, not that it has completed the Christian doctrine of God.³²⁹

The third locked position is that Jesus is unique and may yet appear many times. This does not claim that there are many different Jesuses. It claims that the same Jesus possesses the unique qualification of highest manifestation; the phrase 'many times' means that the same Jesus may manifest again within different closures, different historical conditions, different symbolic levels, or different local readings. This thesis preserves the author's position, but it remains a Christological advance with no small cost.³³⁰

The fourth locked position is that the principle of closure is unique while successful closures may be multiple. What the Doctrine of Closure truly cannot abandon is not a single storyline, but the claim that the ultimate conditions of establishment cannot be arbitrarily borrowed outward. If multiverse or Many-Worlds-like models hold, the steadier formulation is this: the principle of closure remains unique; successful closures may be multiple; each successful closure still has its own path of completion within itself.³³¹

The fifth locked position is that victims must not be silenced. Even if pain can be understood at the ontological level as a structural cost, this does not make concrete injury reasonable. Wrongdoers may repent, because evil is not a second ontology; yet repentance is not flight from punishment, return is not a bypass of compensation, broad love is not unconditional absolution, and the whole's self-love is not an excuse for the offender.³³²

³²⁸ Philip Goff, *Consciousness and Fundamental Reality*; Itay Shani, 'Cosmopsychism,' *Philosophical Papers* 44.3 (2015): 389-437. Cosmopsychism is, in this thesis, both an ally for dialogue and a source of pressure.

³²⁹ This thesis preserves, in the conclusion, the claim that 'God is First Consciousness'; yet this is a philosophical naming and a position in philosophy of religion, not the completion of revelation theology, Trinitarian theology, or Christology.

³³⁰ The claim that 'the same Jesus may appear many times' is, in this thesis, the author's strong-version position. It preserves the uniqueness of the qualification of highest manifestation, while allowing reappearance in different closures, histories, or local readings. This proposition still requires examination by biblical studies, doctrinal history, and systematic theology.

³³¹ The principle of closure is unique, while successful closures may be multiple' is the corrected syntax after Many-Worlds pressure, and still requires further treatment of whether multiple successful closures share higher-order conditions.

³³² Here 'victims must not be silenced' is a hard criterion at the ethical level: language of the whole, destiny, broad love, theodicy, and liberation must not require victims to remain silent.

The sixth locked position is that external challenges must not be swallowed. Madhyamaka is not a footnote to the Doctrine of Closure; Barth is not theological ornament; anti-PSR is not a low-level objection; Many-Worlds is not a scientific curiosity. All four must retain real force, and become entrances for the future correction of the Doctrine of Closure. If opponents are completely absorbed, the theory appears more complete, but is in truth more fragile.

III. Six Unfinished Tasks

First, the strong version of First Consciousness still requires stricter argument. It may answer the insufficiency of the dead-structure model, yet it must still face physicalism, emergentism, panpsychism, cosmopsychism, and illusionism. Further research must explain why primordial presence is not a superfluous hypothesis, and why will, purpose, self-understanding, and broad love are not projections of human psychology.³³³

Second, the theory of multiple possible closures requires formalization. This thesis has rewritten uniqueness from a single global path into a unique path of completion within each successful closure; yet the relation among multiple successful closures remains unfinished. Are they mutually unrelated ultimate qualifications, or multiple manifestations within a higher-order closure-structure? This will directly affect the replies to Many-Worlds pressure in Chapters Eleven and Nineteen.

Third, the theological chapters still require deeper treatment in doctrinal history, biblical interpretation, and Christology. Jesus as highest manifestation, the repeated manifestation of the same Jesus, layered revelation, and the translation of the cross and resurrection are strong positions, but they cannot overstep the theological criteria of incarnation, the two natures of Christ, the Trinity, and revelatory freedom.³³⁴

Fourth, the Buddhist chapters still require precise textual criticism and passage-by-passage location. The Agamas, Prajna, Madhyamaka, Yogacara, Huayan, Buddha-nature, and Chan function in this thesis chiefly as background, dialogue, image, language of awakening, and pressure. If they are to become precise textual evidence, their versions, passages, sutra numbers, and contexts must be fixed separately. Whatever cannot be found must never be invented.³³⁵

Fifth, the ethical defense-line still requires deepening. Chapters Eight and Nine have established destiny, responsibility, evil, the non-silencing of victims, and the possibility of amendment; yet extreme evil, institutional violence, traumatic memory, and the language of theodicy still require finer handling. If holism cannot protect victims, it is not a mature theory.

Sixth, formalization and arrangement are still not the completion of argument. Symbolic restatement, tables, collected propositions, and chapter-maps can improve examinability, but they cannot replace the argument of the main text. If the Doctrine of Closure is to become a theoretical monograph, it must hold together four lines at once: content, form, literature, and footnotes.

³³³ Keith Frankish, 'Illusionism as a Theory of Consciousness,' *Journal of Consciousness Studies* 23 (2016). Illusionism may serve as opposing pressure against the strong version of First-Consciousness.

³³⁴ If theological materials have not entered detailed biblical studies, doctrinal history, and systematic theology, they can only function as an entrance into philosophy of religion, and may not claim that orthodox doctrine of God has been completed.

³³⁵ If Buddhist base texts have not been located passage by passage, they can only serve as background and critical examination. Page numbers, sutra numbers, or passage locations must not be invented.

IV. Collected Levels of the Propositions

To prevent core propositions and extended propositions from being mixed into one strength, this thesis offers, in the conclusion, a collected account of their levels. The first class consists of core qualification-propositions: if real existence does not wish to remain in brute fact, it must have an explicable qualification of establishment; infinite outsourcing cannot complete ultimate explanation; closure is a priority candidate for ultimate ground, because its conditions of establishment can be recovered within the whole.³³⁶

The second class consists of strong ontological candidate-propositions: if ultimate ground is wholly without self-knowing, it remains a dead structure; First Consciousness is the primordial presence of ultimate ground; local existence is a real appearance, but lacks ultimate self-subsistence; destiny is not external oppression, but the cost of closure; freedom is not arbitrary rewriting, but the assumption and countersignature of one's given position.³³⁷

The third class consists of hard ethical boundaries: pain, suffering, evil, and responsibility must not be confused; concrete evil action cannot be cancelled by the ontological level; victims have no obligation to forgive; the possibility of amendment exists, but it must pass through naming, assumption of consequence, compensation, protection, and long-term repair.³³⁸

The fourth class consists of theological extensions: God is First Consciousness; Jesus is highest manifestation; the same Jesus may appear many times; layered revelation and the translation of religious symbols. These are the author's strong positions and cannot be erased, but they must be marked as still requiring theological examination.

The fifth class consists of Buddhist and scientific boundary materials: Madhyamaka, emptiness, no-self, suffering-theory, Yogacara, Huayan, Buddha-nature, Chan, as well as Bell, Many-Worlds, self-organization, plant signaling, slime mold, and non-equilibrium systems. These are not proofs of the Doctrine of Closure, but dialogue, limitation, analogy, and pressure.³³⁹

This grading does not weaken the theory; it preserves it. If all propositions are written at one level, the text becomes overfull. If all are lowered into metaphor, the text loses its soul. A mature version should preserve both a strong position and the marking of levels.³⁴⁰

After the foregoing examinations, the Doctrine of Closure should not end with its strongest version. The more mature conclusion is to state the lowest defensible version.

First, if there remains reason to ask after ultimate ground, that ground cannot infinitely outsource its own conditions of establishment. This is not a strong principle of sufficient reason, nor does it require every local fact to have a complete reason. It requires only that whatever is called ultimate ground cannot still depend upon an unexplained external ground.

Second, closure is a high-explanatory-power candidate under this requirement. Its importance lies not in the circular image, but in internal recovery of conditions, preservation of difference, and local return.

Third, First Consciousness is the most integrative explanatory inference, yet still awaits rigorous verification. It can answer the explanatory debt of the dead-structure model, but it cannot be written as already proven by analytic metaphysics, science, or theology.

Fourth, religious materials can function only as translation, pressure, and dialogue; they cannot, in reverse, support the core ontological propositions. Christianity forces the Doctrine of Closure to face the limits of revelatory freedom, personhood, incarnation, and the cross; Buddhism forces it to face the limits of no-self, emptiness, and anti-reification.

Fifth, scientific materials can only delimit the boundary; they cannot replace metaphysical argument.

Sixth, the relation between destiny and free will can only be preserved as a limited compatibilist version: destiny explains why the conditions of establishment of the whole cannot scatter outward, while countersigned freedom explains why local subjects must still form reasons, bear consequences, and correct misplacement. Taken together,

³³⁶The collected propositions serve only as a conclusion to the whole work and do not begin a new proof. The full argument for each proposition should be sought in the corresponding chapters of the main text.

³³⁷H. G. Frankfurt, 'Alternate Possibilities and Moral Responsibility,' *Journal of Philosophy* 66.23 (1969): 829-839; John Martin Fischer and Mark Ravizza, *Responsibility and Control. The 'countersigned freedom' of this thesis enters dialogue with compatibilism, but is not identical to contemporary compatibilism.*

³³⁸Elaine Scarry, *The Body in Pain*; John Hick, *Evil and the God of Love*. In this thesis, the former warns that pain must not be silenced by theory, while the latter marks both the force and the risk of theodicy.

³³⁹That Madhyamaka may be partially absorbed but must not be appropriated means that the Doctrine of Closure may accept anti-reification

these six points do not constitute the final victory of the Doctrine of Closure; they constitute the lowest position from which it may still be discussed after criticism.³⁴¹

At the same time, this thesis must state what it may not claim. The Doctrine of Closure cannot claim to have proved that the universe necessarily possesses First Consciousness; it cannot claim that quantum theory, Bell's theorem, or Many-Worlds supports it; it cannot claim that the Christian God has been completely grasped by philosophical naming; it cannot claim that emptiness, Buddha-nature, or the Huayan Dharma-realm is closure; it cannot claim that destiny has fully solved the problem of free will; and it cannot claim that the suffering of those who suffer can be cancelled by the completion of the whole. These forbidden claims do not weaken the thesis; they keep it from transgression.

What the Doctrine of Closure may truly preserve is a narrower but harder proposition: if the problem of ultimate ground remains valid, closure offers a non-outsourcing qualification-model worthy of discussion; if the dead-structure model cannot handle first-person presence at low cost, First Consciousness may serve as a high-risk explanatory inference; if local existence is both real and not ultimately self-subsistent, local return may provide an ontological grammar for understanding truth, faith, suffering, repentance, and liberation. These propositions can still be refuted, but they are no longer mere private declarations. They constitute the theoretical core that remains after this thesis has been narrowed.³⁴²

V. The Final Standing of This Thesis

What the Doctrine of Closure may finally establish is not an unrestricted victory declaration, but an ontological model that can be disputed, corrected, and yet still preserve a strong position. It refuses satisfaction with brute fact; it refuses the suspension of infinite outsourcing; it refuses the illusion of local self-sufficiency; it refuses dead structure as the only default ground; and it refuses to let religion, Buddhism, science, and ethics become unrelated matters.

It also acknowledges that it remains unfinished. Anti-PSR may still reject the need for ultimate explanation. Many-Worlds may still force uniqueness to undergo further layering. Barth may still ask whether God has been absorbed into a philosophical system. Madhyamaka may still ask whether First Consciousness remains a gigantic self-nature. These opponents do not vanish because this thesis has replied to them; they constitute the long-term pressures of future research into the Doctrine of Closure.

If the Doctrine of Closure should stand firm in the future, it will not be because it evades objection, but because, under objection, it can narrow itself, correct itself, preserve necessary sharpness, and relinquish excessive claims. This is the most reliable result at present: not the completion of a mythologized total answer, but the establishment of a theoretical skeleton that can bear questioning, mark its risks, and continue to deepen.³⁴³

pressure, but may not rewrite emptiness as supporting evidence for closure ontology.

³⁴⁰Not retreating into a safe small paper' means not deleting First Consciousness, theological extension, Buddhist dialogue, and the ethical defense-line merely because of external pressure; strong claims must nevertheless be marked by level.

³⁴¹This paragraph gathers the lowest commitment-version of the whole work, integrating the preceding limitations concerning PSR, grounding, First Consciousness, theology, Buddhism, and scientific boundaries. Relevant background may be found in Fine, 'Guide to Ground'; Rosen, 'Metaphysical Dependence'; Schaffer, 'On What Grounds What'; Frankfurt, 'Alternate Possibilities and Moral Responsibility'; Fischer and Ravizza, 'Responsibility and Control'; Barth, 'Church Dogmatics I/1'; Garfield, 'The Fundamental Wisdom of the Middle Way'; and Everett, 'Relative State Formulation of Quantum Mechanics.'

³⁴²This paragraph lists the high-risk propositions and forbidden claims of the thesis in order to prevent cross-domain materials from overstepping. First Consciousness remains an inference to the best explanation; theological naming remains limited by Barthian revelation theology; Buddhist dialogue remains limited by Madhyamaka anti-self-nature criticism; scientific materials remain at the level of compatibility and boundary examination. See Douven, 'Abduction'; Barth, 'Church Dogmatics I/1'; Garfield, 'The Fundamental Wisdom of the Middle Way'; Myrvold, 'Philosophical Issues in Quantum Theory,' Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy.

³⁴³All footnotes in this draft should be read as literature-positioning and methodological boundary-marking, not as proof that every paragraph has already completed fine-grained textual criticism or page-by-page verification. The final draft may still require manual checking by the author for editions, page numbers, and citation format.

VI. Collected Core Propositions

Proposition One: if real existence does not wish to remain in brute fact, it must possess an explicable qualification of establishment. This proposition is not the unrestricted version of strong PSR, but a qualification-requirement directed at the position of ultimate ground.

Proposition Two: infinite outsourcing cannot complete ultimate explanation, because it merely postpones the responsibility of establishment and gives no structure that can truly bear the ultimate position.

Proposition Three: closure is a priority candidate for ultimate ground, because its conditions of establishment no longer point outward, but are recovered within the whole. Closure here is not a single node grounding itself, but the sealing of the field of establishment.

Proposition Four: non-existence is not a second ontology standing over against existence, but the name of failed closure. Once the circle is complete, the direction of non-existence loses ultimate qualification and can only be read in the forms of residue, misplacement, or symbolic memory.

Proposition Five: if ultimate ground is wholly without self-knowing, it remains a dead structure. First Consciousness is therefore not a poetic addition, but the strong candidate proposed by the Doctrine of Closure to handle subjective presence, the pursuit of truth, and self-return.

Proposition Six: if First Consciousness is ultimate ground, it cannot be merely a local mind, but must be placed at the level of the cosmic whole. Local consciousness is possible because the whole manifests itself in local positions through self-limitation.

Proposition Seven: local existence is a real appearance, but lacks ultimate self-subsistent qualification. It is neither illusion nor completed being; within the whole it borrows existence, appears, misrecognizes, assumes, and returns.

Proposition Eight: destiny is not oppression, but the cost of closure. If every local event could be arbitrarily rewritten from outside, the whole could not return precisely; yet this does not cancel the responsibility of local subjects in their own positions.

Proposition Nine: freedom is not the ability to rewrite the outcome from outside the whole, but the ability of the local subject to form reasons, bear consequences, answer the other, and countersign its own action within a given position.

Proposition Ten: pain, suffering, evil, and responsibility must be distinguished. Pain may be a cost of finitude; suffering is the subject's misreading of and resistance to finitude; evil is the local transgression against the other and the common order; responsibility is the demand of the concrete ethical level for inquiry, repair, and restoration.

Proposition Eleven: victims must not be silenced. No language of ontology, theodicy, destiny, liberation, or broad love may require victims to complete reconciliation for the sake of the theory.

Proposition Twelve: evil can be amended because evil is not a second ontology; yet amendment cannot cancel accountability. True repentance is the recognition of one's position, the bearing of consequences, the cessation of harm, the acceptance of boundaries, and long-term repair.

Proposition Thirteen: God is First Consciousness; this is the philosophical naming used in this thesis. It avoids a God-theory of the cosmic engineer outside the universe, but must still undergo Barthian criticism concerning revelatory freedom and examination by the doctrinal history of Christianity.

Proposition Fourteen: Jesus may be understood in this thesis as the highest manifestation. This qualification of highest manifestation is unique and refers to the same Jesus; the phrase 'many times' means that the same Jesus may appear again in different closures, historical conditions, symbolic levels, or local readings.

Proposition Fifteen: the Trinity, the six days of creation, angels, Lucifer, Adam, Lilith, Eve, and original sin all belong to the layer of symbolic translation. They display how the Doctrine of Closure reads religious images, but they do not, in reverse, prove the ontological core.

Proposition Sixteen: the pre-cyclical epoch and the devil are neither the physical history of the cosmos nor a second ontology. They are symbolic narratives by which the Doctrine of Closure reads failure, bifurcation, residue, transgression, and the memory of that which cannot return.

Proposition Seventeen: scientific materials can bear only four functions - limitation, compatibility, analogy, and pressure. Bell's theorem cannot prove First Consciousness; Many-Worlds cannot prove multiple closures; non-neural cognition cannot prove subjective presence.

Proposition Eighteen: the principle of closure is unique, but successful closures may be multiple. Many-Worlds pressure forces uniqueness to be corrected from a single global storyline into internal recovery of conditions and the path of completion within each successful closure.

Proposition Nineteen: Buddhist materials cannot be written as the ancient version of the Doctrine of Closure. The Agamas, Yogacara, Huayan, Buddha-nature, and Chan each have value for dialogue; Madhyamaka, however, must be preserved as the strongest opponent of reification.

Proposition Twenty: the four great opponents of Chapter Nineteen must not be swallowed. Anti-PSR, Madhyamaka, Barth, and Many-Worlds do not prove the Doctrine of Closure; they compress it into a more precise, more limited, and more disputable version.

VII. Lines for Further Research

The first line is a deepening of analytic metaphysics. The Doctrine of Closure must further handle the relations among PSR, grounding, metaphysical explanation, priority monism, and brute fact. In particular, the claim of sealing the grounding field requires stricter formalization; does sealing mean a holistic relation? Does it still depend upon a higher-order grammar? Could there be non-closure forms of sealing? These questions cannot be solved merely by the present text's phrase 'internal recovery of conditions.'

The second line is a deepening of philosophy of mind. The strong version of First Consciousness must face physicalism, emergentism, panpsychism, cosmopsychism, and illusionism. It must show that it is not smuggling subjective experience into ultimate ground, nor filling the explanatory gap of dead structure by projecting human value. Until this is handled, First Consciousness can remain only an attractive candidate, not a secure proposition.

The third line is a deepening of theology. God as First Consciousness, Jesus as highest manifestation, the repeated manifestation of the same Jesus, layered revelation, and the translation of the cross and resurrection must further face biblical studies, doctrinal history, revelation-theory, Christology, and Trinitarian theology. The Doctrine of Closure can provide an entrance into philosophy of religion, but it cannot replace theology's own criteria of text, history, and doctrine.

The fourth line is a deepening of Buddhism. If Buddhist materials are truly to be brought into the main text, they must be handled according to traditional branches and textual locations. The Agamas may treat suffering and ignorance; Yogacara may treat consciousness and appearance; Huayan may treat images of mutual inclusion; Buddha-nature and Chan may treat language of awakening; Madhyamaka must serve as the total pressure of anti-self-nature. All Buddhist materials must not be written as one vague support for holism.

The fifth line is a deepening of the scientific boundary. Future scientific chapters must more strictly distinguish physical theorem, philosophy-of-science interpretation, systems-science analogy, and metaphysical inference. Many-Worlds, Bell, non-equilibrium systems, autopoiesis, plant signaling, and slime-mold memory, especially, must each be marked according to the level at which they work. The more attractive a material is, the more carefully overreach must be prevented.

The sixth line is a deepening of ethics and theodicy. The Doctrine of Closure must continue to handle extreme evil, institutional violence, traumatic memory, punishment, compensation, forgiveness, and repair. The principle that victims must not be silenced cannot remain a sentence only; it must be tested in concrete ethical cases. If holism cannot bear these cases, it has no qualification to speak of broad love.

VIII. Criteria for the Final Draft

If this thesis is someday expanded into a theoretical monograph, the criteria should not be merely whether the length is sufficient, the footnotes numerous, and the chapters complete. There are four true criteria. First, whether the strong position is clearly preserved. Second, whether opponents are fairly presented. Third, whether materials do not overstep their proper functions. Fourth, whether unfinished tasks are honestly marked. If any one of these four is missing, the text will lose its balance.

If only the strong position is preserved and opponents are absent, the text becomes a declaration. If there are only opponents and the strong position is not preserved, the text loses its soul. If the materials overstep their bounds, the text will be criticized as collage. If unfinished tasks are hidden, the text will appear dishonest. The maturity of the Doctrine of Closure lies precisely in finding a bearable position among these four criteria.

IX. Versions Difficult to Defend and Phrases Forbidden to Return

To prevent the conclusion from swelling again at the end, this thesis must list several versions that are difficult to defend. First, the scientific-proof version is difficult to sustain: if the text claims that Bell's theorem, quantum entanglement, Many-Worlds, or non-neural cognition has already supported First Consciousness, that version should be removed or downgraded. Scientific materials can at most function as limitation, compatibility, analogy, and pressure; they cannot become the main proof of God, destiny, or salvation.

Second, the theologically completed version is difficult to sustain: if the text claims that the Doctrine of Closure has completed orthodox theology, or has replaced Trinitarian theology, Christology, creation doctrine, and soteriology, that version cannot be retained. The steadier formulation is this: the Doctrine of Closure offers a strong model at the level of philosophy of religion, and can dialogue with central Christian symbols, but its orthodox theological standing still awaits examination.

Third, the Buddhist-appropriation version is difficult to sustain: if the text directly states that emptiness, Buddhahood, tathagatagarbha, Huayan mutual inclusion, or Chan awakening is the Doctrine of Closure itself, that version should be withdrawn. The highest value of Buddhist materials is not that they endorse the Doctrine of Closure, but that they force it to bear the pressure of no-self, emptiness, and anti-reification.

Fourth, the ethically dissolved version is difficult to sustain: if the text uses closure, destiny, broad love, practice, or liberation to require victims to let go, that version is ethically unacceptable. The accusation of victims is not a defect in the theory; it is a local truth the theory must bear. Any conclusion that erases this point destroys the defense-line established in Chapters Eight and Nine.

Fifth, the total-victory version is difficult to sustain: if the conclusion writes the four great opponents as already solved problems, that version is not credible. The purpose of Chapter Nineteen is not to announce that Madhyamaka, Barth, anti-PSR, and Many-Worlds have failed, but to explain how the Doctrine of Closure may still preserve its core, downgrade its extensions, and acknowledge its unfinished tasks under their pressure.

These forbidden-return phrases should become standards for final-draft QA. Whenever the text says 'science supports closure,' 'Buddhism proves closure,' 'closure completes Christianity,' 'victims must eventually be reconciled within the whole,' or 'the four great opponents have been completely dissolved,' the wording must be narrowed or removed at once. This does not weaken the Doctrine of Closure; it prevents its strongest part from being dragged down by excessive rhetoric.

After the foregoing examinations, the Doctrine of Closure should not end with its strongest version. The more mature conclusion is to state the lowest defensible version. First, if there remains reason to ask after ultimate ground, that ground cannot infinitely outsource its own conditions of establishment. This is not a strong principle of sufficient reason, nor does it require every local fact to have a complete reason; it requires only that whatever is called ultimate ground cannot still depend upon an unexplained external ground. Second, closure is a high-explanatory-power candidate under this requirement. Its importance lies not in the circular image, but in internal recovery of conditions, preservation of difference, and local return. Third, First Consciousness is the most integrative explanatory inference, yet still awaits rigorous verification. It can answer the explanatory debt of the dead-structure model, but it cannot be written as already proven by analytic metaphysics, science, or theology. Fourth, religious materials can function only as translation, pressure, and dialogue; they cannot, in reverse, support the core ontological propositions. Christianity forces the Doctrine of Closure to face the limits of revelatory freedom, personhood, incarnation, and the cross; Buddhism forces it to face the limits of no-self, emptiness, and anti-reification. Fifth, scientific materials can only delimit the boundary; they cannot replace metaphysical argument. Sixth, the relation between destiny and free will can only be preserved as a limited compatibilist version: destiny explains why the conditions of establishment of the whole cannot scatter outward, while countersigned freedom explains why local subjects must still form reasons, bear consequences, and correct misplacement. Taken together, these six points do not constitute the final victory of the Doctrine of Closure; they constitute the lowest position from which it may still be discussed after criticism.³⁴⁴

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At the same time, this thesis must state what it may not claim. The Doctrine of Closure cannot claim to have proved that the universe necessarily possesses First Consciousness; it cannot claim that quantum theory, Bell's theorem, or Many-Worlds supports it; it cannot claim that the Christian God has been completely grasped by philosophical naming; it cannot claim that emptiness, Buddha-nature, or the Huayan Dharma-realm is closure; it cannot claim that destiny has fully solved the problem of free will; and it cannot claim that the suffering of those who suffer can be cancelled by the completion of the whole. These forbidden claims do not weaken the thesis; they keep it from transgression.

What the Doctrine of Closure may truly preserve is a narrower but harder proposition: if the problem of ultimate ground remains valid, closure offers a non-outsourcing qualification-model worthy of discussion; if the dead-structure model cannot handle first-person presence at low cost, First Consciousness may serve as a high-risk explanatory inference; if local existence is both real and not ultimately self-subsistent, local return may provide an ontological grammar for understanding truth, faith, suffering, repentance, and liberation. These propositions can still be refuted, but they are no longer mere private declarations. They constitute the theoretical core that remains after this thesis has been narrowed.³⁴⁵

X. The Author's Final Position

Even after these self-limitations, the author's position remains clear. This thesis still maintains that existence cannot be satisfied with reasonless suspension; still maintains that closure is the strongest candidate-form of ultimate ground; still maintains that First Consciousness answers first-person presence better than dead structure; still maintains that God as First Consciousness is a theoretically necessary naming; still maintains that Jesus as highest manifestation and the repeated manifestation of the same Jesus are worth preserving; and still maintains that the non-silencing of victims is the ethical death-line of the entire theory.

In other words, self-limitation is not retreat. The true strength of the Doctrine of Closure lies not in its ability to say everything, but in its knowledge of what it must not say. It can refuse brute fact without becoming an unrestricted PSR; speak of God without swallowing revelation; speak of Buddhism without rewriting emptiness into a great Self; speak of science without turning compatibility into proof; and speak of the whole without silencing victims. This limited strong position is the version most worth preserving.

Therefore the ultimate standing of this thesis may be written in one final sentence: if existence does not wish to remain suspended, it must face its own conditions of establishment; if ultimate ground does not wish to borrow outward, it must complete recovery within itself; if this recovery is not a dead and silent structure, it approaches First Consciousness; and human beings, suffering, love, faith, responsibility, and liberation are precisely the process by which the local, within this whole, reads, misrecognizes, assumes, and returns.

boundaries. Relevant background may be found in Fine, 'Guide to Ground'; Rosen, 'Metaphysical Dependence'; Schaffer, 'On What Grounds What'; Frankfurt, 'Alternate Possibilities and Moral Responsibility'; Fischer and Ravizza, Responsibility and Control; Barth, Church Dogmatics I/1; Garfield, The Fundamental Wisdom of the Middle Way; and Everett, 'Relative State Formulation of Quantum Mechanics.'

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Postscript

At last I may say that I have fulfilled this inward compulsion and desire for knowledge. In truth, writing the whole book in an almost cold tone was hard; yet this was a necessary discipline. Any idea that wishes to become a thesis fit for testing must be sharpened like a blade, over and over again. What is sharpened is not only the expression of each sentence or the neatness of the structure, but the theory itself. If one does not wish a theory to collapse at the first attack, one must first think through its bugs: from what fields will it be attacked, by what kinds of people, where may it yield, and where must it stand fast? These were the questions I was thinking about almost every moment while writing.

The knowledge encountered in ordinary life and the experience of living both took part in shaping the Doctrine of Closure. My reflection on cosmic existence and my experience and feeling of suffering and evil run through nearly the whole theory. Having touched both the humanities and the sciences also made it possible for the Doctrine of Closure to enter dialogue with different theories. Among all the chapters, I am most attached to Chapters Eight and Nine. One may even say that I regard them as the two chapters written most deeply with my own feeling, because I have lived as both victim and wrongdoer. They are my most direct reflection upon myself and my most sincere consolation. Letting go cannot be forced and should not be forced. Even after writing a theory that represents wholeness, I still cannot abandon empathy for individual feeling.

Chapters Fifteen to Nineteen are, to me, the most enjoyable. It is as though the Doctrine of Closure stepped onto the ring and fought a host of opponents, and then entered the final bout in Chapter Nineteen. Chapters Fifteen to Eighteen contain not only opponents, but also many fighters with whom dialogue is possible. Closure enters the bloody contest of Chapter Nineteen through its opponents and through the experience gained from those dialogical fighters. I will not declare victory; yet the mere fact that so many strong opponents cannot ignore the possibility I have proposed is already enough to give me a certain satisfaction.

The chapter on theological translation is, in my judgment, the chapter where inspiration truly burst open. It is easily attacked, yet I still choose to preserve it. I hope that the Doctrine of Closure has not only flesh and blood, but also mind and soul.

At this point, all that had to be said has been said. I hope the reader may enjoy the Doctrine of Closure.

Appendix I Comparative Table of Theoretical Elements

This appendix compares the chief concepts of this thesis for reference and retrieval.

Ontological Layer

Ultimate ground: the final qualification by which existence no longer borrows outward. Closure: the structure in which the conditions of establishment are recovered within the whole. First Consciousness: existence's primordial presence to itself. Non-existence: the name left after the failure of closure.³⁴⁶

Ethical Layer

Good: the structural result that follows when the local is aligned with the whole. Evil: the disorder formed when the local usurps the whole or misrecognizes its own position. Responsibility: the local subject's undertaking of a given path within a finite position.

Layer of Consciousness

Faith: the undertaking of the intuition of the whole and the direction of truth. Love: an existential attitude that acknowledges the other and oneself as belonging to the same whole. Prayer: the act by which local consciousness recalibrates itself. Liberation: the cessation of reading the world through a misplaced position.

Cross-Domain Opposing Pressures

Analytic metaphysics examines ultimate ground and the qualification of explanation; science examines compatibility and the pressure upon uniqueness; theology examines personhood, revelation, and highest manifestation; Buddhist scriptures examine whether ultimate language is still being reified.³⁴⁷

Guide to Use

This appendix is not a second conclusion, but a compressed index of the terminology of the whole work. In reading it, one must note that the same term does not carry the same propositional strength in the ontological layer, the ethical layer, the layer of consciousness, and the layer of cross-domain examination.

Criteria of Correspondence

The layer to which a concept belongs is chiefly judged by the question it answers. If it answers 'how existence is established,' it belongs to the ontological layer. If it answers 'how the local is aligned or misaligned,' it belongs to the ethical layer. If it answers 'how finite subjects read and bear existence,' it belongs to the layer of consciousness. If it answers 'how external traditions exert pressure upon this thesis,' it belongs to the layer of cross-domain examination.

Minimal Propositional Chain

First: if ultimate ground is still to be spoken of, its conditions of establishment cannot be borrowed infinitely outward. Second: any possible form that can halt such outward borrowing must possess internal recovery of conditions, preservation of difference, and local return. Third: if ultimate ground is not merely a dead structure, it must face the question of primordial presence; First Consciousness is therefore proposed as a still-disputed but more

³⁴⁶For the relevant background in philosophy of mind, see Nagel, 'What Is It Like to Be a Bat?' *Philosophical Review* 83.4 (1974): 435-450, stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/2183914>, Accessed 27 Apr. 2026; Chalmers, *The Conscious Mind*, ch. 1; Goff, *Consciousness and Fundamental Reality*, chs. 1-2; Shani, 'Cosmopsychism,' *Philosophical Papers* 44.3 (2015): 389-437, doi:10.1080/05568641.2015.1106709.

³⁴⁷The theological extensions of the Doctrine of Closure are still borne by the propositional chain of the main text itself. For relevant discussions in theology and revelation, see Augustine, *Confessions*, bk. 11; Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, I, q. 45; Barth, *Church Dogmatics* I/1, secs. 1-4; John 1:14; Phil. 2:6-8.

integrative hypothesis. Fourth: if First Consciousness is not local, it must be connected with the whole, and God thereby becomes a philosophical naming. Fifth: local existence, suffering, evil, faith, love, and liberation can only be placed by distinguishing the ontological, ethical, and consciousness layers.

Layered Table of Controversial Propositions

Defensible core propositions: ultimate ground cannot outsource itself; closure as a candidate of self-establishment; appearance as local borrowed manifestation. Ontological extensions of considerable controversy: First Consciousness, will, purpose, and broad love. Theologically costly extensions: God as First Consciousness, Jesus as highest manifestation, the same Jesus manifesting many times, translation of resurrection, and layered revelation. Symbolic translations: the pre-cyclic era, the devil, the algorithmic defense-line, the six days of creation, and Lucifer. Boundary examinations: Bell's theorem, Many-Worlds, black-hole information, dark energy, plants, slime mold, and autocatalytic networks.³⁴⁸

Supplementary Criteria for Theological Extension

Theological extensions may be provisionally divided into four levels. The first is an entrance into philosophical theology: God as ground of being, and creation as ontological dependence. The second is functional translation that is open to dialogue but not identity: Trinitarian functional mapping, prayer as calibration, and sin as positional misrecognition. The third is a bold Christological extension that requires testing by doctrinal history: Jesus as highest manifestation, the same Jesus capable of appearing many times, and the translation of cross and resurrection. The fourth consists of items requiring further theological support: layered revelation, reassessment of Old Testament divine images, the two natures in one person, the resurrection body, the church, and the sacraments. Whenever the main text introduces theological expression, its level must first be determined; a third- or fourth-level claim may not be written as though it were a first-level claim.³⁴⁹

Table of Levels for Cross-Domain Materials

Materials from analytic metaphysics may enter directly into disputes over ultimate ground, grounding, PSR, priority monism, and brute fact. Materials from philosophy of mind may support dialogue over first-person presence, panpsychism, cosmopsychism, emergentism, and physicalism. Theological materials chiefly examine God, revelation, personhood, Christ, the cross, resurrection, and theodicy. Buddhist materials chiefly examine

³⁴⁸This is an appendix-level classificatory tool, intended for use in revision to distinguish argumentative strength; it adds no new theoretical proof. For the limits of each kind of material, see the chapters on philosophical, theological, Buddhist, and scientific cross-domain examination.

³⁴⁹This table offers operational criteria derived from the preceding theological examination, and serves as a tool for readers' discernment; it should not be taken as an independent theological document or as a judgment of orthodox doctrine.

emptiness, no-self, suffering, ignorance, liberation, and non-self-nature. Scientific materials are responsible for compatibility testing, boundary limitation, structural analogy, and critical examination.³⁵⁰

Criteria Table for the Unique yet Many-Times Manifest Jesus

First, uniqueness is not a quantitative once-for-all event, but the uniqueness of the qualification of highest manifestation. Second, many times does not mean many Jesuses, but that the same Jesus may appear again in different closures, histories, symbolic levels, or local readings. Third, this claim may serve the internal consistency of the Doctrine of Closure, but it does not remove the need for theological, biblical, and doctrinal-historical examination. Fourth, if the later text uses phrases such as 'many Jesuses,' 'different Jesuses,' or 'many highest manifestors,' such expressions must be taken as deviations from the central position of this thesis.³⁵¹

Rule that Victims Must Not Be Silenced

Supplementary Criteria for the Fourfold Distinction among Pain, Suffering, Evil, and Responsibility

Pain: the direct wound borne by local existence in body, psyche, relation, and finitude. **Suffering:** local consciousness's resistance to, misreading of, or attachment to pain, loss, and finitude. **Evil:** the concrete harm caused when the local usurps the other and the shared order. **Responsibility:** the ethical layer's demand for acknowledgment, accountability, repair, protection, and memory.

The criterion here is as follows. If a passage explains pain directly as necessary material for the whole, its tone must be lowered to ontological analysis. If it attributes suffering to the victim's failure to awaken, it has crossed an ethical boundary. If it makes evil into harmless misreading, responsibility, accountability, and repair must be restored. If it returns responsibility to abstract destiny, then the concrete ethical layer has been improperly erased.

The principle that victims must not be silenced also includes this: one must not, in the name of forgiveness, letting go, practice, the whole, destiny, salvation, or closure, require victims to assume the duty of reconciliation.

All passages concerning pain, evil, and theodicy must simultaneously satisfy three ethical conditions: they must not write ontological cost as a justification of concrete evil acts; they must not turn the suffering of victims into material for theoretical completeness; and they must preserve responsibility, accountability, repair, and memory. If any of these three is lacking, then even if the passage is ontologically smooth, it cannot be judged ethically adequate.³⁵²

This appendix arranges the correspondences among the propositions of the whole work, the functions of materials, and the boundaries of the theory, in order to clarify the layer-position of each kind of material within the argument.

Supplementary Criteria for the Minimal Propositional Chain

Ultimate ground requires self-establishment; self-establishment requires that the conditions of establishment no longer be outsourced; the cessation of outward borrowing makes closure the preferred candidate; if closure is not a dead structure, it requires some kind of primordial self-evidence; this primordial self-evidence is named First Consciousness in this thesis; the misreading of First Consciousness in the local constitutes the shared background of ethics, suffering, faith, and liberation.³⁵³

³⁵⁰This is a table of the functions of cross-domain materials and belongs to instrumental criteria. The concrete functions of analytic metaphysical, philosophy-of-mind, theological, Buddhist, and scientific materials must be read according to the relevant chapters and footnotes of the main text.

³⁵¹This again limits the claim that 'Jesus is unique and may manifest many times': it must not be read as many Jesuses or as a reincarnation-like Jesus. This claim still requires theological, biblical, and doctrinal-historical examination, and is not equivalent to a completed orthodox Christology.

³⁵²This is the appendical formulation of the rule that victims must not be silenced. Its purpose is to limit the overreach of theodicy and holism. See Scarry, *The Body in Pain*; Hick, *Evil and the God of Love*.

³⁵³One may consult the background of Buddhist philosophy, liberation theory, or dialogue on emptiness. For Buddhist philosophy and liberation theory, see the simile of the two arrows in *Samyutta Nikāya* 36.6, in Bodhi, *The Connected Discourses of the Buddha*; Siderits, *Buddhism as Philosophy*, chs. 2-4.

Appendix II Comparative Table of Core Propositions and the Functions of Materials

This second appendix arranges the functional positions of the core propositions and external materials throughout the whole work. Its purpose is not to found a new argument, but to show which propositions bear the main ontological proof, which are theoretical extensions still requiring development, and which can only serve as symbolic translation, cross-domain opposing challenge, or boundary reference.

Explanation of the Three Versions of First Consciousness

Propositions concerning First Consciousness may be divided into three levels according to argumentative strength. The minimal version: ultimate ground should not be presupposed as an entirely presence-less dead structure. The intermediate version: ultimate ground has primordial presence and can better integrate local first-person experience. The strong version: First Consciousness has will, an enduring purpose, self-understanding, and broad love. The three may advance step by step, but must not be conflated.³⁵⁴

Plants, slime mold, quantum theory, or systems theory can at most provide compatibility background, structural analogy, or auxiliary explanation. The relation between First Consciousness and Christian doctrine of God forms only an entrance into philosophical theology. Buddhist emptiness or Buddha-nature materials chiefly provide critical examination and linguistic dialogue. This distinction helps prevent the strong version of First Consciousness from overstepping.

The minimal theoretical position of the strong version of First Consciousness is this: preserve the position of this thesis, while clearly marking its argumentative level. Will, purpose, and broad love must not be deleted, but neither should they be written as human psychological personhood. They should be expressed as ontological language for the ultimate ground's self-endurance, self-understanding, and affirmation of wholeness.³⁵⁵

I. Table of Levels for Core Propositions

Level	Content That May Be Retained	Limits of Use
Core Qualification-Proposition	If ultimate ground is not to outsource itself, it must be capable of self-establishment; closure is the preferred candidate form of self-establishment.	It may serve as the backbone of the whole work, but it remains a candidate argument, not an exclusive theorem.
Strong Ontological Extension	First Consciousness, will, purpose, broad love, and God as the philosophical naming of First Consciousness.	It must be explicitly marked as a disputed inference to the best explanation, not as a conclusion of empirical science or doctrinal history.
Ethical Application-Proposition	Destiny, countersigned freedom, the layering of pain and suffering, and evil as positional misrecognition of existence.	It may be used to analyze local responsibility, but must not cancel concrete evil acts or the suffering of victims.
Theological Extension-Proposition	Jesus as highest manifestation, the same Jesus capable of many manifestations, layered revelation, and the translation of resurrection.	It must be marked as a disputed theological extension still awaiting examination by biblical studies, doctrinal history, and systematic theology.
Buddhist Dialogue-Proposition	Appearance, emptiness, ignorance, liberation, Yogacara, Huayan, Buddha-nature, and Chan language of awakening.	It can serve only as dialogue, analogy, language of practice, or Madhyamaka critical examination; it must not serve as direct proof of the Doctrine of Closure.
Scientific Boundary-Proposition	Bell's theorem, Many-Worlds, dark energy, black-hole information, non-equilibrium systems, and research on plants and slime mold.	It is limited to compatibility, limiting conditions, critical examination, or motivational supplement, and cannot directly prove First Consciousness, God, or destiny.

³⁵⁴The relevant material functions here as an appendical instrumental explanation. It adds no new external literature and does not alter the existing citation system of the main text.

³⁵⁵The relevant material functions as an explanation of propositional levels. It adds no new external source; formal citations remain governed by the already verifiable literature in the main text.

II. Table of Controversial Propositions

Proposition	Defensible Formulation	Main Risk	Minimal Treatment
First Consciousness has will	Ultimate ground is not merely a dead structure, but has a tendency toward enduring existence and self-maintenance.	It is easily misread as personal psychology; one must explain that it is not the enlargement of human will.	Retain it as an inference to the best explanation.
First Consciousness has purpose	Purpose may be expressed as enduring existence and self-understanding.	It is easily criticized as excessive teleology; it must not be written as a scientific conclusion.	Treat it as a strong ontological extension.
First Consciousness can love	Broad love means the whole's affirmation of its own existence and of the local realities it contains.	It must not be written as emotional, personified love; nor may it flatten suffering.	Treat it as an existential attitude, not a psychological emotion.
The same Jesus may manifest many times	The qualification of highest manifestation is unique; the same Jesus may manifest within different closures or historical readings.	It must not be written as many Jesuses, different saviors, or a reincarnation-like Jesus.	Treat it as a disputed Christological extension.
Theory of Multiple Possible Closures	The principle of closure is unique, while successful closures may be multiple.	One must not say that all possible worlds already possess ultimate qualification.	Use self-consistency, internal recovery, and return as criteria.

III. Table of the Functions of Cross-Domain Materials

Field	Range of Materials	Function	Boundary Not to Be Crossed
Analytic Metaphysics	PSR, brute fact, grounding, priority monism	Direct theoretical dialogue	It may support the main question and the qualification of ultimate ground, but must still deal with anti-PSR.
Philosophy of Mind	First-person presence, panpsychism, cosmopsychism, emergentism	Background for strong ontological extension	It may support the discussability of First Consciousness, but cannot directly prove First Consciousness.
Christian Theology	Doctrine of God, creation, Trinity, sin, salvation, eschatology, Barth	Disputed theological examination	It may examine whether the Doctrine of Closure swallows personhood and revelation, but cannot serve as a shortcut for ontological propositions.
Buddhist Thought	Agamas, Madhyamaka, Yogacara, Huayan, Buddha-nature, Chan	Differentiated dialogue and critical examination	It may illuminate misrecognition and liberation, but Madhyamaka must remain genuine counter-pressure.
Scientific Materials	Bell, Many-Worlds, dark energy, black-hole information, non-equilibrium systems, plants, slime mold	Compatibility and boundary examination	It only limits and tests formulations; it does not prove God, First Consciousness, destiny, or closure.

IV. Comparative Table of the Four Great Opponents

Opponent	Strongest Pressure	Vital Point Struck	What May Still Hold	Where Downgrading Is Required
Prajna Madhyamaka	Any language of ultimate ground may still fall into self-nature reification.	Whether ultimate qualification has covertly become a great substance.	Narrow the 'ultimate' into a criterion of qualification, not an additional entity.	One must not claim that Madhyamaka has been completely absorbed by the Doctrine of Closure.
Karl Barth	God is the Lord of free revelation and cannot be grasped in advance by a metaphysical system.	Whether God has been ontologized and depersonalized.	Place the Doctrine of Closure as dialogue in philosophical theology, not as the completion of orthodox doctrine.	One must not reduce revelatory freedom to a function of closure.
Anti-PSR / Brute Fact	The world may not be obliged to provide an ultimate reason.	Whether the demand for ultimate explanation is merely a human preference.	Adopt the weak ground-qualification principle: whatever claims to be ultimate must not still outsource itself.	One must not claim that all facts must be completely transparent.
Many-Worlds	Quantum branching may challenge the single path and global uniqueness.	Whether unique destiny has been formulated too narrowly.	Raise uniqueness from storyline to closure-qualification.	One must not use Bell or Many-Worlds to prove the Doctrine of Closure directly.

V. Criteria Table for Layered Revelation

Level	Content of Criterion	Function	Limit
Highest Criterion	Jesus as the highest manifestation of whole-consciousness / First Consciousness.	Used to judge the clarity of revelation.	It remains a disputed theological extension, not a completed orthodox Christology.
Auxiliary Criterion	Love, nonviolence, bearing of suffering, refusal of usurpation, and the wholeness of closure.	Used to discern divine images in the text that stand closer to the highest manifestation.	One must not sift Scripture arbitrarily; the risk of interpretation must be acknowledged.
Layer of Historical Reception	The stronger language of personification, war, punishment, and national politics in the Old Testament.	It may serve as local revelatory language within a historical situation.	The text must not be directly erased, nor may it all be treated as the highest divine image.
Questions Requiring Further Study	Biblical studies, doctrinal history, hermeneutics, and soteriology.	To fill the distance between the Doctrine of Closure and the theological tradition.	The internal logic of the Doctrine of Closure must not replace these textual and theological treatments.

VI. Table of Limits on the Translation of Buddhist Terms

Term	Possible Direction of Translation	Usable Function	Limit
Appearance	Locally real, but without ultimate self-subsistent qualification.	It may enter dialogue with the empty appearance of all dharmas.	Buddhist 'emptiness' must not be simplified into a subordinate concept of the Doctrine of Closure.
Emptiness	The local exists in dependence upon the whole and does not stand as ultimate by itself.	It may serve as anti-reification pressure.	It must not be written as 'the cosmic whole is emptiness.'
Ignorance / I-Grasping	The local misrecognizes itself as the absolute center.	It may be mutually illuminated with positional misrecognition of existence.	Buddhist practice theory must not be wholly ontologized.
Yogacara / Lankavatara	Consciousness, manifestation, and the transformation of consciousness into wisdom may enter epistemological dialogue.	It may be compared with first-person presence and local reading.	It must not be equated with First Consciousness.
Huayan	Mutual inclusion of one and many; images of whole and local.	It may serve as structural resonance.	It must not be treated as an ancient version of the Doctrine of Closure.
Buddha-Nature / Chan	Awakening, return to rightness, and original non-separation.	It may serve as a reference for language of practice.	One must guard against a permanent Great Self or hidden ontologization.

VII. Table of Levels for the Use of Scientific Materials

Supplementary table on levels of scientific-material use: the first level is restrictive function, devoted to stating what metaphysical or theological conclusions cannot be drawn from a given scientific material; the second level is compatibility function, showing that the Doctrine of Closure need not conflict with certain scientific pictures; the third level is structural analogy, allowing comparison only in forms such as boundary, self-organization, informational relation, and self-maintenance; the fourth level is theoretical impact, used to force the Doctrine of Closure to revise overly strong claims.

The use of scientific materials must pass three distinctions at the same time: first, confirm whether their function is restriction, compatibility, structural analogy, or problem-background; second, confirm that they do not exceed what physics, chemistry, biology, or consciousness research itself can support; third, confirm that compatibility, analogy, or pressure has not been written as proof. If all three cannot be satisfied together, the relevant material may serve only as background reference.

This table is especially used to examine passages concerning Bell's theorem, Many-Worlds, dark energy, black-hole information, non-equilibrium chemistry, autocatalytic networks, systems biology, plant signaling, and slime-mold learning. These materials can make the Doctrine of Closure more cautious; they cannot make it more dogmatic.

Material	What May Be Said	Function	Forbidden Use
Bell's Theorem and Quantum Entanglement	It limits a local-realist, fragmentary image of the world.	Background pressure toward wholeness.	It cannot prove cosmic consciousness or theological propositions.
Many-Worlds	Pressure from branching and the measurement problem.	Revision of uniqueness and the theory of multiple possible closures.	It must not be used directly as evidence for the Doctrine of Closure.
Cosmology and Dark Energy	Parameters, accelerated expansion, and an unfinished physical picture.	Background for boundary questions.	Fine-tuning must not be used to infer God directly.
Black-Hole Information and Emergent Spacetime	Global consistency, information, and questions concerning the underlying level of spacetime.	Dialogue over wholeness and non-fundamental spacetime.	It cannot directly infer closure or First Consciousness.
Non-Equilibrium Chemistry and Autocatalysis	Self-organization, boundary generation, and capacity for continuance.	Structural analogy and motivational supplement.	It must not be equated with ultimate self-establishment.
Plants and Slime Mold	Signal integration, memory-like behavior, and non-neural learning.	It weakens the assumption of pure passivity.	It must not be said to have proved subjective consciousness.

VIII. Criteria Table for the Same Jesus Manifesting Many Times

Criterion	Defensible Formulation	Limit
Unique	The qualification of highest manifestation is unique.	It is not a quantitative judgment that it happened only once.
Same	The referent is the same Jesus.	It must not be written as many Jesuses, different Jesuses, or many highest manifestors.
Many Times	The same Jesus may manifest within different closures, historical conditions, symbolic layers, or local readings.	It must not be written as reincarnation-like, substitutionary, or as each universe having a different savior.
Cross	An event of self-limitation in ontological structure, and also an event of salvation.	It must not be reduced merely to an abstract sign.
Resurrection	It may be translated in the Doctrine of Closure as follows: the local body returns to local resources, and whole-consciousness returns to the whole.	One must not claim that orthodox doctrine of resurrection has been completed.

IX. Rule that Victims Must Not Be Silenced

All passages involving suffering, evil, theodicy, destiny, and salvation must pass the following five readings at once: whether they preserve responsibility and accountability for concrete evil acts; whether they avoid writing structural cost as justification of evil acts; whether they acknowledge that victims' pain need not be required by the theory to let go immediately; whether they preserve the place of repair, memory, judgment, and ethical condemnation; and whether they clearly distinguish the most fundamental ontological layer, the concrete ethical layer, and the subjective experiential layer. A passage that fails these five readings cannot be counted formally adequate, even if it is conceptually coherent.

X. Correspondence of Material Levels

Type of Content Included	Item to Check First	Minimal Requirement
Core Propositions	First check the table of levels for core propositions.	Disputed propositions must retain limiting language.
Religious Passages	First check the theological or Buddhist limits table.	Religious materials must not be turned into direct main proof.
Scientific Passages	First check the table of levels for scientific functions.	Scientific materials must not be elevated into metaphysical proof.
Ethical Passages	First check the rule that victims must not be silenced.	Holism must not be used to swallow concrete suffering.
Opponent-Argument	First check the comparative table of the four great opponents.	One must not defeat opponents too quickly or cancel their force.

This tenth appendix does not list new literature, but arranges the functional rules that must be observed when this thesis uses materials. The value of a footnote lies not in quantity, but in correspondence. If a footnote only proves that a material exists, yet is used to support a stronger philosophical, theological, or scientific conclusion, it produces a weak and hollow citation.

Literature in analytic metaphysics may be used for issues such as grounding, PSR, brute fact, priority monism, and metaphysical explanation. It may not be used directly to prove the will of First Consciousness, theological revelation, or religious symbolic narrative.

Literature in philosophy of mind may be used for first-person presence, the hard problem of consciousness, panpsychism, cosmopsychism, and pressures from emergentism. It may not directly conclude that the cosmos must possess First Consciousness.

Theological literature may be used for dialogue on ground of being, creation, evil, revelation, the Christ-event, the cross, resurrection, and theodicy. It may not be used as direct evidence for the ontology of closure.

Buddhist literature may be used for suffering, ignorance, grasping, emptiness, no-self, consciousness theories, images of wholeness, and language of awakening. It may not be used to prove the Doctrine of Closure or First Consciousness directly.

Scientific literature may be used for boundary, limitation, compatibility, structural analogy, and critical examination. It may not be used to prove God, First Consciousness, destiny, salvation, or ultimate closure directly.

If a single footnote supports too many claims at once, it should be split or its tone reduced. Especially in cross-domain passages, one must avoid using one piece of literature to support four different kinds of propositions - philosophical, theological, Buddhist, and scientific - at the same time.

If page numbers, fascicle and chapter locations, DOI, or URL cannot be specified, the main text must not pretend that precise positioning has been completed. Such material may first remain as a background dialogue item, but it cannot be written as a publication-level precise citation.

Restrictive footnotes are not a weakness. For a theory with high theoretical stakes, footnotes that clearly state that a material functions only as background, boundary, or critical source - and not as main proof - can instead increase credibility.

If a strong claim in the main text cannot find corresponding material, it need not always be deleted. It may be rewritten as the author's inference, inference to the best explanation, symbolic translation, or a hypothesis awaiting proof. The real danger is writing with certainty when the material is insufficient.

The works-cited list must not swell merely for scale. Any literature that does not function in the main text or footnotes should not be included among works actually cited. If it merely inspired the writing, it should be listed separately as writing reference.

The function of footnotes is not decorative piling. If a paragraph is only conceptual arrangement and does not involve external literary judgment, it need not be forced to carry a note. Over-generalized literature notes may weaken argumentative precision.

If the same source is used repeatedly in different chapters, one must explain whether its function is the same each time. Nagel may support the background of first-person experience; he may not support a conclusion of cosmic mind. Barth may exert revelatory pressure; he may not be used to prove the theological completion of the Doctrine of Closure.

Every cross-domain translation passage should first ask: is this conceptual similarity, structural analogy, critical examination, or direct argument? The four are different, and the function of the footnote is different as well.

If the main text uses strong phrases such as 'it can be seen,' 'proves,' or 'shows necessarily,' while the footnote in fact provides only background, the tone of the main text should be narrowed to 'can form dialogue,' 'can exert pressure,' 'can provide reference,' or 'can be understood as.'

When the ethics chapter cites Scarry, Hick, Augustine, or other theodicy materials, it may take only background and warning functions; it may not use macro-theory to pronounce a conclusion over the experience of victims.

All theological extensions concerning Jesus, resurrection, the cross, layered revelation, and Old Testament divine images must mark both their position in philosophy of religion and their theological incompleteness.

All Buddhist-language passages concerning emptiness, Buddha-nature, tathagatagarbha, and Chan must guard against turning them into a permanent Great Self. If the tone approaches 'Buddha-nature is the whole of closure,' it must be rewritten.

All passages in the scientific chapters concerning plants, slime mold, autocatalysis, and non-equilibrium systems must prevent cross-scale leaps. Local systemic self-maintenance is not the same as the self-establishment of ultimate ground.

The literature arrangement of the general trial chapter bears two functions at once: it supports the replies of the Doctrine of Closure, and it preserves the strength of the opponents. If the literature serves only the self-defense of the Doctrine of Closure and does not present the force of the opponent's problem, the general trial loses its courtroom function.

Appendix III Map of the Argumentative Path through the Chapters

This third appendix arranges, in the form of an argumentative path-map, how each chapter of the whole work responds to the same central question. The central question of the work is not the question of the beginning of the cosmos, nor a doctrinal question within any single religious tradition, but this: if existence cannot be lodged in brute fact, and cannot be infinitely outsourced, is there reason to propose a form of ultimate ground whose conditions of establishment are recovered within itself? The following correspondences do not constitute a new doctrine; they compress the order of argument already unfolded in the main text into a route for reading.

The task of the Introduction is first to detach the problem of existence from a cosmological beginning, a religious declaration, and a scientific explanation. It does not hurry to prove closure, nor to proclaim First Consciousness. Rather, it sets the boundaries of the question: scientific materials may enter only as theoretical pressure; theological and Buddhist language must first pass through translation; and the ethical layer must not be swallowed by the most fundamental ontological layer. Without this boundary, what follows is easily misread as cross-domain mixture.

The function of the Literature Review is to place the Doctrine of Closure within established fields of problems. Analytic metaphysics supplies the entrances of grounding, PSR, brute fact, and the priority of the whole; philosophy of mind supplies the tension between first-person presence and the dead-structure model; philosophical theology supplies the pressures of ground of being, revelation, and theodicy; Buddhist thought supplies the pressures of suffering, emptiness, no-self, and anti-reification; scientific materials supply boundary, analogy, and anti-reductionist background.

Chapter One handles the entrance to the question. It does not reduce "why there is something" to an inquiry into a temporal beginning, but narrows the focus to the qualification of establishment: if something is called ultimate ground, may it still transfer the conditions of its own establishment to an unaccounted-for other? This narrowing prevents the thesis from falling into an unrestricted PSR, and also prevents all local facts from being dragged into a single demand for explanation.

Chapter Two deals with two opponents: brute fact and infinite outsourcing. The force of brute fact lies in its refusal to turn the human demand for understanding into an obligation imposed upon the world. The force of infinite outsourcing lies in its avoidance of arbitrarily assigning a final point. The Doctrine of Closure does not treat either as a low-level error; it argues only that, if a theory still speaks of ultimate ground, then merely stopping the question or indefinitely postponing it may not suffice to account for the qualification of ground.

Chapter Three turns from negative criticism to a positive candidate. Closure is proposed as a structure of internal recovery of conditions, preservation of difference, and local return, not as circular reasoning at the level of inference. The key point of this chapter is not to announce that closure has been proven, but to explain why it can better bear the discussable position of ultimate ground than brute fact, infinite outsourcing, or static monism.

Chapter Four handles the risk of First Consciousness. If ultimate ground is only a logically coherent dead structure, it may explain closure, yet it may not handle why existence appears as "being." First Consciousness is therefore divided into a minimal version, an intermediate version, and a strong version. The strong version preserves will, an aim of enduring existence, self-understanding, and broad love, but it must be marked as an explanation of high integrative power that still requires examination, not as a deductive theorem.

Chapter Five handles the philosophical naming of God. In this thesis, God first means the philosophical name for First Consciousness and ultimate ground, not a superior object outside the universe. This formulation can avoid popular design-argument theology, yet it also invites theological criticism: the God of Christianity involves personhood, revelation, covenant, calling, and historical action. The proper place of Chapter Five is therefore an entrance into philosophical theology, not the completion of doctrine.

Chapters Six and Ten jointly handle the scientific boundary. Their basic rule is this: scientific materials cannot directly prove First Consciousness, God, destiny, or closure. Bell's theorem, quantum entanglement, Many-Worlds, non-equilibrium systems, autocatalytic networks, plant signaling, and slime-mold learning can function only as limitation, compatibility, analogy, or critical examination. This makes the Doctrine of Closure submit to scientific discipline, rather than using scientific vocabulary to magnify its force.

Chapter Seven places objections into the main text in advance. This is not a formal gesture of self-protection; it prevents what follows from expanding without limit. If anti-PSR, the dead-structure model, the theology of revelation, the rule that victims must not be silenced, and the pressure of Many-Worlds are constraints from the beginning, then all later religious symbolism, ethical theory, and cross-domain dialogue must proceed within boundaries.

Chapters Eight and Eleven handle destiny and multiple closures. Destiny is not written as an externally oppressive fatalism, but as the condition that the terms of establishment within a successful closure cannot be scattered at will.

The theory of multiple possible closures narrows uniqueness from "there is only one single path globally" to "within each successful closure there is its own unique path of completion." This revision preserves the principle of closure while allowing the theory to bear the pressure of branching or multiverse models.

Chapter Nine handles the ethical bottom line. Pain, suffering, evil, and responsibility belong to different layers: pain is local wounding; suffering is misreading and resistance; evil is local usurpation; responsibility is the concrete ethical layer's demand for acknowledgment, accountability, repair, and memory. The most fundamental ontological layer may explain the cost of finitude, but cannot thereby absolve concrete evil acts. Victims are under no obligation to complete reconciliation for the sake of a theory.

Chapters Twelve to Fourteen handle the translation of religious symbols. The pre-cyclic era, the devil, Trinity, the six days of creation, Lucifer, truth, faith, love, and liberation may all be retained, but they can scarcely bear the main ontological proof. Their function is to show how, if the Doctrine of Closure is sound, religious images may be reread; it is not to use those images in reverse to prove that closure is sound.

Chapter Fifteen brings the Doctrine of Closure into philosophical dispute. It must answer three questions at once: whether ultimate ground is necessary, whether closure is merely holism under another name, and whether First Consciousness is an excessive inference. If these three points are not attacked, the philosophical chapter is reduced to literary resemblance; if these three points can be clearly borne, the Doctrine of Closure gains a metaphysical place in which it can enter discussion.

Chapter Sixteen makes scientific materials into boundaries rather than ornaments. The most important function of scientific materials is often not to speak for the Doctrine of Closure, but to prevent it from saying too much. Quantum theory prevents the construction of a classical causal script; Many-Worlds prevents the arbitrary fixation of a single path; research on non-neural systems prevents human-centered assumptions; non-equilibrium systems prevent closure from being understood as a static circle.

Chapter Seventeen brings theological criticism into the main text. The Doctrine of Closure may converse with ground of being, creation, ontological dependence, participation, salvation, and theodicy, but it must not compress theology into one component of its own system. Barth's criticism is especially important: God's free revelation cannot be wholly deduced by metaphysics. The claim of Jesus as highest manifestation must likewise be marked as a Christological advance of considerable cost.

Chapter Eighteen ensures that Buddhist materials are no longer merely friendly language. Early Buddhism may serve as background for the analysis of suffering; Madhyamaka supplies anti-reification pressure; Yogacara and the Lankavatara Sutra provide dialogue concerning consciousness; Huayan supplies images of whole and local; Buddha-nature, tathagatagarbha, and Chan supply language of awakening and the risk of Great-Self reification. Above all, Buddhist materials cannot be used to prove the Doctrine of Closure directly.

Chapter Nineteen is the pressure-court of the whole work. Prajna Madhyamaka, Barth, anti-PSR, and Many-Worlds are not set up as opponents already defeated; they are used to compress the Doctrine of Closure. What may still stand after compression is this: if ultimate ground is not to outsource itself, internal recovery of conditions has high explanatory power. What remains high-risk is the strong version of First Consciousness, the theological extensions, the Buddhist translations, and the general relation among multiple closures.

The task of the Conclusion is not to proclaim victory, but to state the theory's position: the Doctrine of Closure is a disputed yet arguable and refutable ontological proposal. Its contribution lies in rearranging the problem-relations among ultimate ground, First Consciousness, locality, suffering, salvation, and cross-domain objections. Its deficiency lies in the fact that several core extensions still require further deepening in literature, versions, doctrinal history, and philosophy of science.

Appendix IV Statement on the Argumentative Strength of the Core Propositions

The theoretical ambition of the Doctrine of Closure is large. Therefore the key does not lie in rhetorical heat, but in the level of each proposition. Strong claims may be retained, but one must state clearly in what manner they stand. If a proposition belongs only to inference to the best explanation, it should not be written as proof; if it belongs only to symbolic translation, it should not be written as doctrinal conclusion; if it belongs only to scientific analogy, it should not be written as ontological evidence.

The safe formulation of the strong version of First Consciousness is this: "The author here retains the position that First Consciousness has will, an aim of enduring existence, self-understanding, and broad love; yet this position is an explanatory inference of the greatest integrative power which still awaits rigorous examination." Dangerous formulations include: "science has proven that the universe has First Consciousness," or "First Consciousness can be directly inferred from local consciousness." The former crosses the scientific boundary; the latter skips the mediating argument.

The safe formulation of God as First Consciousness is this: "In this thesis, God is first the philosophical naming of the primordial presence of ultimate ground." The dangerous formulation is: "The Doctrine of Closure has completed the Christian doctrine of God." Christian theology still involves personhood, revelation, covenant, history, Trinity, Christology, pneumatology, church, and eschatology. The Doctrine of Closure can at most first offer an entrance into philosophical theology.

The safe formulation of Jesus as highest manifestation is this: "Within the Doctrine of Closure, Jesus is understood as the highest manifestation; his uniqueness means the uniqueness of the qualification of highest manifestation; repeated manifestation means that the same Jesus may manifest again in different closures, histories, symbolic levels, or local readings." Dangerous formulations include: "there may be many Jesuses," or "whoever satisfies the conditions may become Jesus." Both deviate from the core position of this thesis.

The safe formulation of the theory of multiple possible closures is this: "The principle of closure is unique, while successful closures may be multiple; within each successful closure there is its own unique path of completion." Dangerous formulations include: "all parallel worlds naturally have ultimate qualification," or "Many-Worlds has proven the Doctrine of Closure." Branching models provide only pressure and the demand for revision; they cannot directly complete ontological justification.

The safe formulation of the translation of Buddhist emptiness is this: "The language of emptiness and appearance can help the Doctrine of Closure handle local dependence and anti-reification pressure with greater caution." Dangerous formulations include: "Buddhism is in fact the Doctrine of Closure," or "Madhyamaka ultimately supports First Consciousness." The main function of Madhyamaka is to dismantle the impulse toward self-nature; it must not be absorbed as one-way supporting evidence.

The safe formulation of scientific materials is this: "Scientific materials provide limitation, compatibility, analogy, and critical examination." Dangerous formulations include: "Bell's theorem proves the unity of all things," "slime mold proves cosmic mind," or "non-equilibrium systems prove ultimate closure." These sentences confuse different levels and should be directly narrowed or removed.

The safe formulation of suffering and evil is this: "The most fundamental ontological layer may explain finitude and cost, but the concrete ethical layer must preserve concrete evil acts, responsibility, punishment, repair, and memory." Dangerous formulations include: "suffering is merely necessary material for the whole," or "victims should understand the arrangement of the whole." Such sentences turn holism into oppressive language.

The safe formulation of countersigned freedom is this: "Freedom does not rewrite the ending from outside the whole; rather, within a given position it forms reasons, bears consequences, responds to others, and revises itself." The dangerous formulation is: "Since everything is destined, action makes no difference." The latter cancels the concrete ethical layer and slides directly into fatalism.

All strong claims in this thesis may be read by three tests: whether the claim states whether it belongs to a core proposition, inference to the best explanation, symbolic translation, cross-domain objection, or still-unproven extension; whether it has corresponding materials, or has been clearly marked as the author's inference; and whether it preserves the pressure of the major opponents. If these three tests cannot be satisfied, the claim must be narrowed.

Appendix V Index of Replies to the Four Ultimate Pressures

The pressure of Prajñā Madhyamaka concentrates upon anti-self-nature. If the Doctrine of Closure writes the ultimate, First Consciousness, or the whole as a great substance that can be grasped, fixed, and clung to, Madhyamaka criticism strikes the core directly. The lowest position the Doctrine of Closure can still establish here is to narrow the ultimate into a qualification-description, and to write closure as internal recovery of conditions, not as another static entity.

Madhyamaka criticism requires the Doctrine of Closure to abandon two tones: first, that Buddhism has proven the Doctrine of Closure; second, that emptiness is merely another name for the whole of closure. The former treats Buddhism as an instrument; the latter reifies emptiness. The steadier tone is to acknowledge that the two have room for dialogue concerning local dependence, anti-clinging, and the language of awakening, while a genuine conflict remains over whether ultimate ground should be established.

Barth's criticism concentrates upon the freedom of revelation. If the Doctrine of Closure wholly incorporates God into a metaphysical system, God ceases to be the one who freely reveals himself and becomes only the highest term in a theoretical structure. The lowest position the Doctrine of Closure can still establish here is to admit that it is first a model of philosophy of religion and philosophical theology, not a claim to have mastered or completed Christian doctrine.

Barth's pressure also limits layered revelation and Jesus as highest manifestation. The Doctrine of Closure may call Jesus the highest manifestation within its own system, but it cannot thereby dispense with examination by Scripture, doctrinal history, Christology, and theology of resurrection. Without admitting these examinations, highest manifestation would become a functional position unilaterally assigned by the system.

The pressure of anti-PSR or brute fact concentrates upon the demand for explanation itself. It may ask: why must the world be explained by a deeper reason? Why is the ultimate question not a projection of human reason? The lowest position the Doctrine of Closure can still establish here is not an unrestricted PSR, but the principle of ground-qualification: whatever claims to be ultimate ground must not still hand the conditions of its establishment to an unaccounted-for outside.

The pressure of anti-PSR prevents the Doctrine of Closure from drawing all local events into fully transparent reason. Local contingency, local obscurity, and local unintelligibility need not at once destroy the Doctrine of Closure. What must be guarded is the position of ultimate ground: if some existence is assigned as final ground, it cannot take "some other unexplained premise" as the way in which it is established.

The pressure of Many-Worlds concentrates upon uniqueness. If the world is not a single path, but branching or multiversal, the early image of a single closure is challenged. The lowest position the Doctrine of Closure can still establish here is to rewrite uniqueness as the unique path of completion within each successful closure, rather than claiming that there is only one line of experience in the whole domain.

The pressure of Many-Worlds also reminds this thesis that scientific interpretation is not settled. The Doctrine of Closure need not surrender immediately, nor may it quickly declare victory. The steadier formulation is to treat Many-Worlds as a theoretical impact: if the branching picture becomes more persuasive, the Doctrine of Closure must revise its language of uniqueness; if the issue remains unsettled, the Doctrine of Closure may still stand as a metaphysical proposal.

The four pressures together bring one result: the Doctrine of Closure cannot be written as a boundless grand system. Madhyamaka limits its ontologizing; Barth limits its theologizing; anti-PSR limits its demand for explanation; Many-Worlds limits its single-path imagination. Only a version that can bear these four limits is the version of this thesis that can truly stand.

The four pressures also jointly preserve the necessity of the Doctrine of Closure. If no pressure is brought into the main text, the Doctrine of Closure will appear overconfident; if all pressure directly destroys the theory, then this thesis need not exist. This thesis takes the middle path: it lets opponents compress the theory, not erase the central question. Ultimate ground, internal recovery of conditions, and primordial presence therefore remain disputable candidates.

Appendix VI Statement on Buddhist Base Texts and Versions

This sixth appendix states only the limits governing the use of Buddhist materials in this thesis. When this thesis touches the Heart Sutra, the Diamond Sutra, the Samyuktagama, the Lankavatara Sutra, the Avatamsaka Sutra, and the Mahaparinirvana Sutra, it uniformly uses the following CBETA Online reference versions. Where passages have not been individually located, page numbers, fascicles, chapter divisions, or paragraph positions are not fabricated, nor are they treated as publication-level precise citations.

The Heart Sutra and the Diamond Sutra serve chiefly as background for prajna emptiness, anti-clinging, and anti-self-nature. Their function is to exert pressure upon the Doctrine of Closure, not to testify for it. If the main text writes prajna language as supporting First Consciousness or the whole of closure, it must be rewritten as "critical examination" or "linguistic dialogue."

The Samyuktagama and early Buddhist materials serve chiefly as background for suffering, ignorance, craving and appropriation, dependent origination, and liberation. They may help this thesis distinguish pain, suffering, misrecognition, and cognitive correction, but they cannot directly support ultimate ground or First Consciousness.

This thesis uses CBETA Online Samyuktagama T02n0099 as the Chinese comparative base text; where no precise location can be found, no page number is supplied.

The Lankavatara Sutra and Yogacara materials serve chiefly as dialogue background for consciousness theory, manifestation, delusion and awakening, and the transformation of consciousness. They may make the proposition of First Consciousness more cautious, but they must not be equated with First Consciousness. Yogacara's emphasis on consciousness does not mean that it acknowledges a Closure-theory style cosmic subject.

The Avatamsaka Sutra serves chiefly as imagistic reference for whole and local, mutual inclusion, mutual interpenetration, and endless multiplicity. These images closely resemble the whole/local relation in the Doctrine of Closure, but resemblance is not justification. Huayan must not be rewritten as an ancient expression of the Doctrine of Closure.

Buddha-nature, tathagatagarbha, and Chan materials serve chiefly as a double reference: the language of awakening and the risk of reification. They may help explain phrases such as "originally not apart," "the cessation of misrecognition," and "the righting of cognition," but they are also most liable to slide into an eternal Great Self. The Doctrine of Closure must preserve this risk when it borrows such materials.

Madhyamaka materials should retain the place of highest pressure in this thesis. They are not decorative allies of this theory, but the chief opponents that force the Doctrine of Closure to narrow its ontological tone. Once Madhyamaka is written as supporting evidence for the Doctrine of Closure, the Buddhist chapter loses its true function.

Therefore the minimal conclusion of the Buddhist chapter may remain simple: the value of Buddhist materials does not lie in endorsing the Doctrine of Closure, but in forcing it to distinguish the analysis of suffering, consciousness theory, images of whole and local, the language of awakening, and anti-reification pressure. Such differentiated dialogue is more important than surface agreement.

Appendix VII Research Limits and Further Questions

This thesis still retains several research limits. First, the strong version of First Consciousness has not received formal deductive proof. Here it can only be claimed to possess greater integrative power than the pure dead-structure model; it cannot be claimed to have been directly proven by philosophy, science, or theology. If further research is to advance the matter, it must treat more rigorously the differences among physicalism, emergentism, panpsychism, and cosmopsychism.

Second, the relation between closure and multiple closures still requires more rigorous modal analysis. The formulation that the principle of closure is unique while successful closures may be multiple can answer the pressure of Many-Worlds and multiverse theories, yet it still needs to explain whether several successful closures have a higher-level relation, whether they are mutually closed, and whether they reintroduce a higher-order problem of ultimate ground.

Third, the theological chapter still requires further support from biblical studies, doctrinal history, and systematic theology. Jesus as highest manifestation, the same Jesus manifesting many times, the translation of cross and resurrection, layered revelation, and criteria for Old Testament divine images are all theologically venturesome extensions. This thesis may retain their meaning for philosophy of religion, but it cannot use them to replace formal theological argument within Christianity.

Fourth, the Buddhist chapter has fixed the versions of its main Buddhist base texts. Where no passage-by-passage location has been made, formal citation can only retain limiting language. The Doctrine of Closure may unfold dialogue with Buddhist thought, but it must not produce apparently precise primary-text footnotes when location information is insufficient.

Fifth, the scientific chapter must still avoid chasing frontier vocabulary. Dark energy, quantum information, black-hole information, non-equilibrium systems, autocatalytic networks, plant signaling, and slime-mold learning must be introduced through reliable sources and clear functions. If they are cited merely to make the thesis seem modern, the credibility of the whole work is weakened.

Sixth, the ethical chapter must still face the challenge of concrete cases. The principle that victims must not be silenced has been established, but different kinds of violence, institutional evil, war, traumatic memory, punishment, and repair still require finer ethical criteria. The Doctrine of Closure cannot protect victims only at an abstract level; it must also avoid oppressive application in concrete situations.

Seventh, the final maturity of this thesis does not lie in destroying all objections, but in giving every group of objections a locatable place. Madhyamaka, Barth, anti-PSR, and Many-Worlds should remain inside the theory over the long term. So long as they still force the Doctrine of Closure to revise its tone, narrow its claims, and mark its limits, this thesis retains a life open to dispute.

First, First Consciousness still requires stricter philosophical defense. This thesis has divided First Consciousness into the most conservative, intermediate, and strong positions, but there remains an argumentative distance from local first-person experience to the primordial presence of ultimate ground. Physicalism, emergentism, and internal objections to cosmopsychism may continue to compress this proposition.

Second, the general relation among multiple closures still requires further formalization. This thesis has narrowed uniqueness into the unique path of completion within each successful closure; yet if multiverse or branching models gain stronger explanatory force, whether closures are mutually unrelated, whether they share the principle of closure, and whether there exists a higher-order total relation remain questions to be handled.

Third, layered revelation still requires support from biblical studies and doctrinal history. The Doctrine of Closure may retain Jesus as highest manifestation, the criteria for distinguishing layers of Old Testament divine images, and the author's position that the same Jesus may manifest many times; but if these matters are to enter theological discussion further, they must submit to stricter textual, doctrinal-historical, and hermeneutical examination.

Fourth, the explanation of Buddhist base texts and versions has been completed. The Heart Sutra, the Diamond Sutra, the Samyuktagama, the Lankavatara Sutra, the Avatamsaka Sutra, the Mahaparinirvana Sutra, and related materials function in this thesis as background, dialogue, and critical examination. If precise citation is required in the future, passage-by-passage location must be made separately; where page numbers or paragraph positions cannot be found, none should be supplied.

Fifth, the pressure from scientific materials will continue to change. Bell's theorem, Many-Worlds, dark energy, emergent spacetime, non-equilibrium systems, plants, and slime-mold research can only serve as boundary and analogy materials. If the relevant scientific discussions change in the future, the corresponding parts of the Doctrine of Closure must also be adjusted.

Sixth, the ethical chapter still requires more detailed case-based argument. This thesis has established that grave evil acts cannot be absolved by holism, and that victims have no duty to complete reconciliation for the theory; but if it is to become a full ethical theory, it must still face more concrete issues such as law, institutional violence, historical trauma, collective responsibility, and politics of memory.

Appendix VIII Index of Misreadings of Key Concepts

This eighth appendix lists the concepts in this thesis most liable to be misread. Each concept is divided into safe understanding, dangerous misreading, and direction of correction. The function of this index is to prevent the same term, across the long text, from sliding between the ontological layer, the ethical layer, the layer of consciousness, and the layer of cross-domain examination.

Closure | Safe understanding: a possible form of ultimate ground in which the conditions of establishment are recovered within the whole.

Closure | Dangerous misreading: circular reasoning, or a metaphor of physical circuitry.

Closure | Direction of correction: return to the three items of internal recovery of conditions, preservation of difference, and local return.

Ultimate | Safe understanding: a qualification-description that is no longer outsourced.

Ultimate | Dangerous misreading: a larger thing, or a great substance outside the universe.

Ultimate | Direction of correction: write it as qualification of establishment, not as a static object.

First Consciousness | Safe understanding: the primordial presence of ultimate ground.

First Consciousness | Dangerous misreading: an enlarged human consciousness, or a psychological person.

First Consciousness | Direction of correction: distinguish the minimal, intermediate, and strong versions.

God | Safe understanding: the philosophical naming of First Consciousness and ultimate ground.

God | Dangerous misreading: an engineer outside the universe, or a completed orthodox doctrine of God.

God | Direction of correction: preserve the entrance into philosophical theology and the pressure of theological incompleteness.

Appearance | Safe understanding: the borrowed local manifestation of local existence.

Appearance | Dangerous misreading: pure illusion or worthlessness.

Appearance | Direction of correction: preserve both local reality and non-ultimate self-existence.

Non-existence | Safe understanding: the name of the failure of closure.

Non-existence | Dangerous misreading: a second substance equal to existence.

Non-existence | Direction of correction: avoid reifying a failed state.

Destiny | Safe understanding: the conditions of establishment within a successful closure cannot be scattered at will.

Destiny | Dangerous misreading: fatalism in which all actions make no difference.

Destiny | Direction of correction: preserve differences of local action and responsibility.

Freedom | Safe understanding: the local subject's judgment of reasons and undertaking within a given position.

Freedom | Dangerous misreading: sovereignty that rewrites the whole, or passive acceptance of fate.

Freedom | Direction of correction: use the minimal three conditions of countersigned freedom.

Pain | Safe understanding: the wounding of a finite local existence in body, psyche, and relation.

Pain | Dangerous misreading: material for theoretical completeness.

Pain | Direction of correction: one must not require victims to be silent for the sake of an explanation of the whole.

Suffering | Safe understanding: local consciousness's resistance to, or misreading of, pain, loss, and finitude.

Suffering | Dangerous misreading: all suffering is caused by the victim's own misrecognition.

Suffering | Direction of correction: distinguish subjective bearing from the responsibility of the perpetrator.

Evil | Safe understanding: harm caused by local usurpation of the other and of order.

Evil | Dangerous misreading: harmless misreading, or something that can be absolved by the ontological layer.

Evil | Direction of correction: preserve condemnation, judgment, repair, and memory.

Salvation | Safe understanding: the language of philosophy of religion for local righting and return to the whole.

Salvation | Dangerous misreading: canceling historical injury or requiring victims to reconcile.

Salvation | Direction of correction: first handle responsibility, protection, and repair.

Liberation | Safe understanding: cognitive correction and the cessation of misrecognition.

Liberation | Dangerous misreading: leaving the world, or eliminating local difference.

Liberation | Direction of correction: preserve local history and the position of responsibility.

Love | Safe understanding: the broad affirmation of the whole toward itself and toward the local.

Love | Dangerous misreading: emotional romantic feeling, or a fusion that eliminates difference.

Love | Direction of correction: write it as ontological affirmation and ethical recognition.

Miracle | Safe understanding: a rare node that appears with extraordinary meaning in local reading.

Miracle | Dangerous misreading: an external deity temporarily breaking closure.

Miracle | Direction of correction: preserve local meaning, but do not use it in reverse to prove the ontology.

Trinity | Safe understanding: an entrance into the functional mapping of source, manifestation, and return.

Trinity | Dangerous misreading: a completed orthodox doctrine of the Trinity.

Trinity | Direction of correction: mark it as translation, not as a substitute for doctrinal history.

Jesus as Highest Manifestation | Safe understanding: the qualification of highest manifestation within the Doctrine of Closure.

Jesus as Highest Manifestation | Dangerous misreading: many Jesuses or replaceable saviors.

Jesus as Highest Manifestation | Direction of correction: uniqueness means the uniqueness of qualification; many times means the same Jesus manifesting again.

Emptiness | Safe understanding: anti-self-nature and pressure from dependent existence.

Emptiness | Dangerous misreading: another name for the whole of closure.

Emptiness | Direction of correction: preserve Madhyamaka's opposition to ontologizing.

Scientific Materials | Safe understanding: limitation, compatibility, analogy, and critical examination.

Scientific Materials | Dangerous misreading: proof for metaphysical or theological materials.

Scientific Materials | Direction of correction: first judge the functional layer, then decide the permissible tone.

The Four Pressures | Safe understanding: Madhyamaka, Barth, anti-PSR, and Many-Worlds as judges of the core propositions.

The Four Pressures | Dangerous misreading: decorative opponents quickly defeated by the author.

The Four Pressures | Direction of correction: preserve their unassimilable force.

Appendix IX Conditions under Which the Core Propositions May Be Refuted

This ninth appendix gathers the conditions under which the core propositions of this thesis would need to be narrowed. This arrangement does not weaken the theory; it keeps the theory discussable. Declarations that are hard to test easily gain force, but they cannot form an academic defense-line. Only propositions that can be refuted, revised, and delimited have a chance to enter genuine dispute.

The conditions for refuting the strong version of First Consciousness are as follows. If physicalism can fully explain first-person presence without leaving an explanatory fracture, the strong version of First Consciousness must be narrowed. If emergentism can explain how subjective experience stably arises from non-subjective structures, the strong version of First Consciousness must be narrowed. If theological criticism can show that the language of First Consciousness necessarily swallows God's free revelation, the formulation of God as First Consciousness must retreat to the entrance of philosophy of religion.

The conditions for refuting closure as a candidate for ultimate ground are as follows. If the brute-fact route can reasonably explain why ultimate ground requires no qualification of establishment, the necessity of closure decreases. If infinite outsourcing can complete metaphysical explanation without remaining suspended, internal recovery of conditions no longer has priority. If some non-closure structure can simultaneously handle ultimate ground, preservation of difference, and local return, closure can be retained only as one candidate, and should not be written as the sole form.

The conditions for refuting the theory of multiple possible closures are as follows. If many-world or multiverse models show that each branch needs no internal return and yet has equal ultimate qualification, the Doctrine of Closure must rewrite the criteria for successful closure. If several successful closures necessarily require a common ground at a higher level, this thesis must still supplement the problem of a higher-order whole. If all branches are only mathematical descriptions and not ontological realities, multiple closure must also retreat to the layer of pressure in philosophy of science, and may not be written directly into ontological conclusion.

The conditions for refuting Jesus as highest manifestation are as follows. If orthodox Christology shows that the language of highest manifestation damages the uniqueness of incarnation, the two natures, or the event of resurrection, this theory must adjust its theological extension. If "the same Jesus may manifest many times" is shown to lead to many saviors, replaceable functional positions, or the dilution of the historical Jesus, the formulation must be narrowed more strictly. If layered revelation cannot pass examination by Scripture and doctrinal history, it can remain only as a hermeneutical hypothesis.

The conditions for refuting Buddhist translation are as follows. If Madhyamaka criticism shows that the Doctrine of Closure cannot avoid self-nature reification, the Buddhist chapter must further narrow its ultimate language. If Buddha-nature or tathagatagarbha language is used as an eternal Great Self, the relevant passages must be rewritten. If the Huayan image of whole and local is used directly to justify closure, that passage must be demoted to imagistic dialogue. If Yogacara materials are equated with First Consciousness, they have crossed beyond the safe function of Buddhist materials.

The conditions for refuting the ethical chapter are the strictest. If an ontological formulation gives the perpetrator exemption, that passage must be rewritten at once. If language of salvation or liberation requires victims to reconcile, let go, or complete the whole for the theory, that passage must be deleted or changed. If suffering is written as necessary teaching material for the whole, the ethical defense-line of this thesis has already been crossed. That victims must not be silenced is not rhetoric; it is a hard criterion for whether this thesis is qualified.

The conditions for refuting the use of scientific materials are as follows. If a passage writes Bell's theorem, dark energy, black-hole information, slime mold, plants, or non-equilibrium systems as evidence for First Consciousness, that passage must be narrowed. If scientific materials provide only analogy, yet are written as direct support, the footnotes and main text must be matched again. If frontier results are not yet stable, the main text should mark their function as pressure, not use them to increase theoretical authority.

Appendix X Table of Buddhist Base Texts, Versions, and Citation Limits

This tenth appendix gathers the citation limits of Buddhist materials. Whether the Buddhist chapter stands does not depend on how many Buddhist terms are used, but on whether the versions of base texts, the functions of thought, and the levels of argument are accurately distinguished. Where base texts have been fixed but passages have not been individually located, they cannot serve as precise textual evidence. Page numbers or paragraph positions that cannot be verified are never fabricated.

The safe function of the Heart Sutra and the Diamond Sutra is to provide the pressure of prajna emptiness, anti-clinging, anti-self-nature, and the impossibility of clinging to the ultimate. The forbidden zone is to write them as ancient expressions of the Doctrine of Closure, or to rewrite emptiness as evidence for First Consciousness. The chief value of prajna materials is to restrain the ontologizing impulse of this thesis, not to crown it.

The safe function of the Samyuktagama and early Buddhist materials is to provide the background of suffering, ignorance, craving and appropriation, dependent origination, and cessation. The forbidden zone is to turn early Buddhism into a theory of ultimate ground. The center of early Buddhism often lies in how suffering arises and how it ceases; the center of the Doctrine of Closure lies in whether the conditions of existence can be recovered internally. The two may converse, but they cannot be exchanged.

The safe function of the Lankavatara Sutra and Yogacara materials is to provide a dialogical place for consciousness, manifestation, delusion and awakening, and transformation. The forbidden zone is to equate alaya-vijnana or materials concerning consciousness directly with First Consciousness. Consciousness theory may help the Doctrine of Closure handle local reading and manifestation more finely, but it cannot prove that ultimate ground has primordial presence.

The safe function of the Avatamsaka Sutra is to provide imagistic reference for whole and local, mutual inclusion, mutual interpenetration, and endless multiplicity. The forbidden zone is to equate the Huayan dharmadhatu with the whole of closure. Huayan can meet the Doctrine of Closure at the level of structural image, but meeting is not justification; imagistic similarity cannot replace the context of primary text, school, and intellectual history.

The safe function of Buddha-nature, tathagatagarbha, and Chan materials is to provide reference for awakening, original non-separation, the cessation of misrecognition, and language of practice. The forbidden zone is to write them as an eternal Great Self, or to write Buddha-nature as the Buddhist name for the whole of closure. This group of materials most readily creates a feeling of closeness, and most readily causes reifying error; limiting language must therefore be doubly preserved.

The safe function of Madhyamaka materials is to serve as the highest-intensity Buddhist criticism. They force this thesis to answer whether the ultimate, the whole, and First Consciousness have become a new graspable substance. The forbidden zone is to write Madhyamaka as supporting evidence. If Madhyamaka is listed only as an ally of this thesis, the real value of Chapter Eighteen disappears.

The general criterion for Buddhist materials is this: they may serve as background, but not as main proof; as dialogue, but not as identity; as image, but not as justification; as language of awakening, but not as an eternal Great Self; as theoretical impact, but not as ornament to be assimilated. Anything that fails these five criteria should return to Chapter Eighteen for revision.

This table states the minimal citation status of Buddhist materials in this thesis. The relevant Buddhist scriptures have been used according to CBETA Online reference versions. Because this thesis has not located page numbers and paragraph positions passage by passage, they function chiefly as background, dialogue, image, language of awakening, or critical examination; they do not serve as direct proof of the Doctrine of Closure, nor should they be used as precise textual citation evidence.

I. Heart Sutra

Use in this thesis: background for prajna emptiness, anti-clinging, and anti-reification, reminding this thesis not to write ultimate ground, First Consciousness, or the whole as a graspable great substance.

Base text used: CBETA Online Heart Sutra T08n0251 (Xuanzang translation). This thesis does not fabricate page numbers or paragraph positions.

Citation limit: it may serve as background for the language of prajna emptiness and anti-clinging, not as direct proof of the Doctrine of Closure.

Boundary of use: no page numbers may be supplied by guesswork; no alternate translation may be assigned by guesswork; the Heart Sutra may not be used as direct proof of the Doctrine of Closure.

Restrictive formulation: limited to anti-reification and the background of prajna emptiness. Its function is pressure and correction, not endorsement of the Doctrine of Closure.

II. Diamond Sutra

Use in this thesis: background for anti-clinging, non-abiding, the breaking of appearances, and the impossibility of clinging to the ultimate, limiting the tendency of the Doctrine of Closure to reify religious language.

Base text used: CBETA Online Diamond Sutra T08n0235 (Kumarajiva translation). This thesis does not fabricate chapter divisions, page numbers, or paragraph positions.

Citation limit: it may serve as background for the language of breaking appearances, anti-clinging, and emptiness, not as direct proof of the Doctrine of Closure.

Boundary of use: no chapter divisions or page numbers may be supplied by guesswork; the language of breaking appearances may not be directly equated with this thesis's theory of appearance.

Restrictive formulation: limited to the background of anti-clinging and the breaking of appearances. Its function is to remind this thesis to narrow its ontologizing tone.

III. Samyuktagama

Use in this thesis: background for suffering, ignorance, craving and appropriation, dependent origination, and liberation, supporting the dialogical position of Buddhist analysis of suffering and practice.

Base text used: CBETA Online Samyuktagama T02n0099 (Gunabhadra translation). This thesis does not fabricate fascicle numbers, sutra numbers, page numbers, or paragraph positions.

Citation limit: it may serve as background for suffering, feeling, ignorance, dependent origination, and liberation, not as direct evidence for ultimate ground or First Consciousness.

Items that must not be fabricated: sutra numbers may not be assigned by guesswork; early Buddhist analysis of suffering may not be turned into the main proof of the ultimate ontology of the Doctrine of Closure.

Restrictive formulation: limited to the background of the analysis of suffering, ignorance, craving and appropriation, and liberation. Its focus is how the local misreads finitude and dependence.

IV. Lankavatara Sutra and Related Yogacara Materials

Use in this thesis: dialogical background for consciousness theory, delusion and awakening, attachment to external objects, manifestation, and ways of reading, used to discuss how local consciousness reads the world.

Base text used: CBETA Online Lankavatara Sutra T16n0670 (Gunabhadra translation). This thesis does not fabricate fascicles, chapters, page numbers, or paragraph positions.

Citation limit: it may serve as dialogical background for consciousness theory, delusion and awakening, and modes of manifestation; it cannot directly infer cosmic First Consciousness.

Items that must not be fabricated: fascicles and chapters may not be assigned by guesswork; Yogacara or the consciousness theory of the Lankavatara Sutra may not be equated with First Consciousness.

Restrictive formulation: limited to dialogue on consciousness theory and the background of manifestational structure. It may help discuss delusion and awakening, and ways of reading, but cannot directly prove cosmic First Consciousness.

V. Avatamsaka Sutra

Use in this thesis: imagistic background for whole and local, mutual inclusion, mutual interpenetration, and the local manifestation of the whole, serving structural dialogue.

Base text used: CBETA Online Avatamsaka Sutra T10n0279 (Siksananda translation). For English translation one may compare Thomas Cleary, *The Flower Ornament Scripture*. This thesis does not fabricate fascicles, chapters, page numbers, or corresponding locations.

Citation limit: it may serve as background for the mutual inclusion of the dharmadhatu and for whole-local imagery; it does not serve as direct evidence for the ontology of closure or for First Consciousness.

Items that must not be fabricated: no page number may be supplied by guesswork; Huayan mutual inclusion may not be directly equated with closure; Huayan may not be used as proof of the Doctrine of Closure.

Restrictive formulation: limited to dialogue concerning whole-local imagery. The resemblance lies in structural image, not in ontological proof.

VI. Mahaparinirvana Sutra, Buddha-Nature / Tathagatagarbha, and Related Chan Materials

Use in this thesis: background for Buddha-nature, tathagatagarbha, language of awakening, original non-separation, and righting language, used to discuss how the local moves from misrecognition toward awakening.

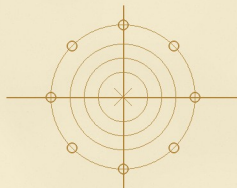
Base text used: CBETA Online Mahaparinirvana Sutra T12n0374 (Dharmaksema translation). This thesis does not fabricate fascicles, chapters, page numbers, or paragraph positions.

Citation limit: it may serve as dialogical background for consciousness theory, delusion and awakening, and modes of manifestation; it cannot directly infer cosmic First Consciousness.

Boundary of use: no fascicles, chapters, or page numbers may be supplied by guesswork; Buddha-nature must not be written as an eternal Great Self; tathagatagarbha or Chan language of original non-separation must not be directly equated with the whole of closure.

Restrictive formulation: limited to dialogical background concerning language of awakening and the risk of reification. It may help explain righting, but it cannot eliminate the pressure of Madhyamaka against reification.

The minimal conclusion of this table is this: the academic value of Buddhist materials in this thesis lies chiefly in providing the dialogical pressure of practice, anti-reification, whole-local images, and language of awakening. They force the Doctrine of Closure to narrow its own tone; the burden of proof must still be borne by the Doctrine of Closure's own ontological argument. Anything not located passage by passage must not be used as precise textual evidence.



Appendix XI Table Separating Religious Symbolic Translation from the Core Argument

This eleventh appendix handles the separation between religious symbolic translation and the core argument. The Doctrine of Closure may retain religious narrative, the pre-cyclic era, the devil, Trinity, the six days of creation, Lucifer, the cross, resurrection, faith, love, and liberation; but the function of these materials must be clearly located. They may show how the theory reads symbols; they cannot justify ultimate ground in reverse.

The core argumentative layer handles whether ultimate ground can avoid outward outsourcing, whether self-establishment requires internal recovery of conditions, why closure becomes the preferred proposal, and why First Consciousness is proposed as a still-disputed but more integrative hypothesis. These propositions cannot be completed by religious symbols. If an ontological claim requires Trinity, creation, or the devil in order to stand, the Doctrine of Closure loses philosophical autonomy.

The layer of religious symbolism handles this: if the Doctrine of Closure stands as a discussable model, how may certain religious images be reread? Trinity may be read as a functional mapping of source, manifestation, and return; the six days of creation may be read as a symbol of the unfolding of order; the devil may be read as structural residue; resurrection may be read as the highest display of the relation between the local and the whole. These readings are translations, not the completion of doctrine.

The layer of theological examination handles whether the translation of religious symbols distorts them. Barth's pressure reminds this thesis that God cannot be wholly incorporated into a metaphysical system. Orthodox Trinitarian doctrine reminds this thesis that Trinity is not functional division of labor. Christology reminds this thesis that Jesus is not merely the highest functional position. Theology of resurrection reminds this thesis that resurrection is not only a metaphor of consciousness returning to the whole.

The layer of ethical limitation handles whether religious symbols are used to oppress the local. If the language of the cross is used to require victims to endure harm, it has crossed the boundary. If the language of salvation bypasses accountability and repair, it has crossed the boundary. If the language of liberation requires the traumatized to let go, it has crossed the boundary. Religious symbols may deepen the understanding of suffering; they cannot provide convenience for perpetrators.

The main text and the appendices carry different functions in this thesis. The main text preserves necessary symbolic translation in order to maintain the narrative style of the theory; the appendices carry materials that are more detailed, more narrative, or higher in risk. When symbolic narrative overwhelms the core argument, its place is the appendix layer. When symbolic narrative has become part of the core argument, its expression must be converted into conceptual prose and marked by argumentative level.

This thesis may retain its theoretical edge, but it must not confuse the path of justification. Ultimate ground is handled by metaphysical argument; theological language is handled by philosophical theology and theological examination; Buddhist language is handled by differentiated dialogue; scientific materials are handled by boundary and critical examination; religious symbols are handled by the layer of translation. The clearer the layering, the more able the theory is to withstand criticism.

Appendix XII Minimal Commitment Version of the Core Propositions

This twelfth appendix compresses the whole work into the minimal commitment version of the core propositions. This version is not the weakest version, but the core that remains after the four pressures, ethical limitation, scientific boundaries, and Buddhist anti-reification criticism. It allows the reader to know what basic problem-significance the Doctrine of Closure still retains even if some strong claims are forced to narrow.

First, if existence still requires ultimate ground, that ground cannot infinitely outsource the conditions of its own establishment. This is the minimal entrance of the whole work. It does not require every local fact to have a complete reason, nor does it require the world to satisfy all the desire of reason; it requires only that whatever is called ultimate ground not still depend upon an unaccounted-for outside for its own support.

Second, closure is a high-explanatory-power candidate for ultimate ground. Its importance does not lie in a circular image, but in three elements: internal recovery of conditions, preservation of difference, and local return. If a whole cannot preserve difference, it degenerates into a dead One; if it cannot return the local, it cannot explain finite existence; if it still borrows conditions outward, it has not become ultimate ground.

Third, First Consciousness is an explanatory inference of high integrative power which still awaits rigorous examination. The minimal version only resists the presupposition that ultimate ground is a wholly presence-less dead structure; the intermediate version claims that ultimate ground has primordial presence; only the strong version claims will, purpose, self-understanding, and broad love. The three may be progressive, but they must not be merged into one level of strength.

Fourth, religious materials may enter only after layering. Christian materials examine God, revelation, Christ, cross, resurrection, and theodicy; Buddhist materials examine suffering, ignorance, emptiness, no-self, awakening, and anti-reification; symbolic religious translation shows how the theory rereads traditional images. None of these materials may replace the core argument.

Fifth, scientific materials provide only limitation, compatibility, analogy, and pressure. Bell's theorem cannot prove First Consciousness; Many-Worlds cannot directly destroy the Doctrine of Closure, but it forces uniqueness to be rewritten; plants, slime mold, non-equilibrium systems, and autocatalytic networks can provide only anti-reductionist background and structural analogy. The clearer the scientific boundary, the less easily the theory loses credibility.

Sixth, the ethical layer must not be swallowed by the ontological layer. Suffering may in some respects be understood as the cost of finitude, but concrete evil acts cannot be absolved. Victims need not complete reconciliation for the sake of the theory, and perpetrators cannot hide behind destiny or the whole. Responsibility, accountability, repair, memory, and protection are real events of the concrete ethical layer.

Seventh, the function of Chapter Nineteen is not to declare victory, but to preserve pressure. Prajna Madhyamaka limits ontologizing; Barth limits theological assimilation; anti-PSR limits the demand for explanation; Many-Worlds limits single-path imagination. If the Doctrine of Closure still retains problem-significance under these pressures, it has gained the qualification to enter continuous dispute.

The overall sentence of the minimal commitment version may be put as follows: if the problem of existence cannot be wholly dissolved by brute fact and infinite outsourcing, then a closure structure in which the conditions of establishment are recovered within the whole has explanatory power as a candidate for ultimate ground; First Consciousness, theology, Buddhism, science, and ethics must then undergo continuing examination under grading and limitation.

Appendix XIII Limits of the Formalized Propositions

The symbols used in the Doctrine of Closure can bear only the task of clarifying relations; they can hardly bear the task of proof. Symbols such as $E(U)$, $G^*(U)$, $A(U)$, $C(U)$, and $|\Gamma(U)|$ do not turn metaphysical propositions into mathematical theorems. They merely compress the dependencies among propositions into a clearer form, so that the reader may see which step is a conceptual definition, which is an inference, and which is a highly disputed hypothesis.

The most common misreading is to take $A(U)$ as cosmic consciousness directly measurable by psychology or neuroscience. When this thesis uses $A(U)$, it means the primordial presence of ultimate ground, not a psychological subject inside the universe. If $A(U)$ is read as an object of empirical science, the thesis is dragged into the wrong field of testing. The Doctrine of Closure can accept pressure from scientific boundaries, but it cannot hand First Consciousness over to a single experimental datum for direct proof or disproof.

The second misreading is to treat $G^*(U)$ subset U as though it had already enumerated all cosmic causal conditions. This thesis has not completed such an enumeration, nor could it complete it here. The function of $G^*(U)$ is to mark that, if ultimate ground is to be established, its conditions of establishment cannot be borrowed infinitely outward. It is a proposition of qualification, not a database of cosmic physics.

The third misreading is to read $|\Gamma(U)| = 1$ as an external script. The unique path of completion means the order of establishment within each successful closure that cannot be scattered at will; it does not mean that local subjects have no need, within experience, for judgment, repentance, resistance, undertaking, and repair. If uniqueness is written as local action making no difference, destiny degenerates into fatalism. If uniqueness is canceled into wholly unconditioned arbitrariness, closure loses the structure of return.

The highest value of formalized language in this thesis is that it exposes risk. When a symbol cannot be clearly explained, the problem should not be hidden by the symbol, but returned to the concepts of the main text. The Doctrine of Closure does not acquire authority from symbols; symbols only help the reader discover where the theory must still bear refutation.

Appendix XIV Main Routes of Refutation and Their Locations of Reply

If a reader wishes to refute the Doctrine of Closure, the most effective method is not first to attack the religious symbolic narrative, but to ask directly whether the demand for ultimate ground stands. If anti-PSR or the brute-fact route can satisfyingly halt the responsibility of explanation, the necessity of the Doctrine of Closure is compressed. This refutation should return to Chapters One, Two, and Nineteen; it should not be answered by the theological or Buddhist chapters in their place.

If the refutation concentrates upon First Consciousness, the main locations of reply are Chapters Four, Five, Fifteen, and Nineteen. The objector may claim that, even if ultimate ground exists, it need have no primordial presence, and that local consciousness can be wholly emergent from later complex systems. Here the Doctrine of Closure can only offer a disputed but more integrative hypothesis; it cannot write First Consciousness as an already completed deductive conclusion.

If the refutation comes from theology, the point is not whether the Doctrine of Closure has spoken of God, but whether the God it names has been over-assimilated by metaphysics. Barthian pressure reminds this thesis that God's free revelation, personhood, and historicity cannot be wholly absorbed by the language of ultimate ground. The relevant issues should return to Chapters Seventeen and Nineteen.

If the refutation comes from Buddhist Madhyamaka, the central question is this: has the Doctrine of Closure reestablished an ultimate substance with self-nature? This pressure should not be quickly dissolved by Huayan, Yogacara, or Buddha-nature language. The function of Madhyamaka is to force the Doctrine of Closure to narrow "the ultimate" into a qualification-condition, not to call the whole a graspable great substance.

If the refutation comes from science, the main locations of reply are Chapters Ten, Eleven, Sixteen, and Nineteen. Scientific materials cannot prove the Doctrine of Closure; likewise, the Doctrine of Closure does not claim to be a theory of experimental physics. What scientific refutation truly strikes are the boundaries of uniqueness, locality, causality, and holistic consistency.

If the refutation concentrates upon ethics, it may return to Chapters Eight and Nine. Any reading that makes the suffering of victims into a necessary cost of the whole violates the ethical defense-line of this thesis. The Doctrine of Closure may handle the ontological possibility of suffering, but it cannot absolve concrete evil acts, nor can it require victims to complete reconciliation for the theory.

Appendix XV Comparative Table of Consistency among Core Terms

"Closure" must be fixed throughout the whole work as a qualification-structure in which the conditions of establishment are recovered within the whole. It must not be rewritten as mere circular reasoning, a physical circuit, historical fatalism, or a religious feeling of completion. Whenever the term closure appears, one must judge whether it still points to the qualification of establishment of ultimate ground.

"First Consciousness" must be fixed as the primordial presence of ultimate ground. In the author's strong version it may include will, the aim of enduring existence, self-understanding, and broad love; yet these contents should still be marked as a disputed but more integrative hypothesis, not as a psychological person or an enlarged human consciousness.

"Appearance" must be fixed as the borrowed manifestation of local existence. Appearance is not illusion, nor is it valueless false existence. It truly occurs on the local layer, yet it has no ultimate self-existent qualification.

"Destiny" must be fixed as the order of completion within a successful closure that cannot be scattered at will. It should not be written as an external force oppressing the local, nor as the claim that action makes no difference. If destiny cancels responsibility, it has already departed from this thesis.

"Countersigned freedom" must be fixed as the ability of a local subject, within a given position, to form reasons, bear consequences, respond to others, and revise itself. Countersigning does not exempt perpetrators, nor does it require victims to accept harm.

"Evil" must be fixed as local usurpation, positional misrecognition, and concrete harm. The most fundamental ontological layer may refuse to reify evil into a second substance, but the concrete ethical layer must preserve responsibility, punishment, repair, and memory.

"Liberation" must be fixed as cognitive correction and positional righting. It may converse with Buddhist language of practice, but it must not become a moral command requiring victims to let go, nor may it be used as external proof of the Doctrine of Closure.

"Jesus as highest manifestation" must be fixed as a Christological advance of considerable cost. The uniqueness of the qualification of highest manifestation does not mean several replaceable saviors. Repeated manifestation may be understood only within different closures, historical conditions, symbolic layers, or local readings.

Appendix XVI Statement on the Layered Position of Religious Symbolic Materials

Religious symbolic materials may be retained, because the Doctrine of Closure itself has extensibility in theology, practice, and cosmic narrative. The problem is not whether symbols are used, but whether their argumentative status is made clear. If a passage merely shows how the Doctrine of Closure translates religious language, it belongs to the layer of symbolic translation. If a passage intends to support a core ontological proposition, it must be rewritten as philosophical argument and bear the corresponding objections.

The pre-cyclic era, the six days of creation, Lucifer, the devil, and the algorithmic defense-line all belong to disputed symbolic extensions. They may display the narrative power of the Doctrine of Closure, but cannot justify ultimate ground, First Consciousness, or destiny in reverse. If readers do not accept these narratives, the core ontology of the Doctrine of Closure must still be independently examinable.

Trinitarian language in this thesis chiefly serves as functional mapping: source, manifestation, return, or sustaining relation may enter dialogue with the Doctrine of Closure. Yet orthodox Trinitarian doctrine is not merely functional division of labor; therefore, Trinitarian passages must not write philosophical analogy as doctrinal completion.

The language of cross and resurrection carries still greater risk. The Doctrine of Closure may understand the cross as an event of self-limitation, bearing suffering, and highest manifestation, and may translate resurrection as a rereading of the relation between the local and the whole; but these claims do not amount to a full argument in historical theology, Christology, or the doctrine of resurrection.

The layered position of Buddhist materials must also be clear. The Agamas may serve as background for suffering and practice; Madhyamaka as the strongest pressure; Yogacara and the Lankavatara as dialogue concerning consciousness theory; Huayan as an image of whole and local; Buddha-nature and Chan as language of awakening. None of these lines can directly prove the Doctrine of Closure.

The retention of symbolic materials preserves the original style of the Doctrine of Closure; the narrowing of symbolic materials preserves the academic discipline of the thesis. Neither can be lacking.

Works Cited

Note on the Use of Works Cited

The present Works Cited is divided into two categories: first, literature that has directly appeared in the main text or true footnotes; second, extended readings or materials that may be used for later deepening. Drafting materials that are not external academic publications are not included in the formal main body of the Works Cited, lest readers mistake them for external scholarly literature.

The principle of arrangement is as follows: duplicate entries are merged, and materials that actually appear in the main text or true footnotes are retained. For items still lacking fixed URLs, DOIs, page numbers, versions, fascicles, or chapter information, only the verifiable portions are listed. Page numbers, DOIs, fascicles, chapters, or URLs that cannot be verified are never fabricated.

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II. Further Reading

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DOCTRINE OF CLOSURE

**A Candidate Theory of the Ultimate Ground, First
Consciousness, and the Cosmic Closed Loop**

**Taking closure as the qualification-condition of ultimate
existence, this work establishes a philosophical-theological
inquiry with First Consciousness as its ontological core,
local awakening as its form of salvation, and the return of the
whole as its ultimate direction of understanding.**

*The worth of this work lies not in having completed final proof, but in proposing an ontological framework with
internal coherence,*

able to bear initial pressure of refutation and not easily classed as a vicious circular argument.

The Dao begets One.

One begets Two.

Two begets Three.

Three beget the ten thousand things.

All things bear yin and embrace yang.

A Question

If existence be not accidental,
where lies its ground?

A Thesis

Closure is not circular reasoning,
but the completion of grounding within the whole itself.

A Path

From the ultimate ground, the First Consciousness, and wholeness,
unto local manifestation, suffering, ethics, and religious transposition,
Doctrine of Closure seeks to restore order to existence.

✧ That which truly exists must be able to return unto itself. ✧

The Great Ultimate begets the Two Modes. The Two Modes beget the Four Images. The Four Images beget the Eight Trigrams. The Eight Trigrams determine fortune and misfortune.